

Negation in the world's languages II

Eurasia

Edited by

Matti Miestamo

Ljuba Veselinova

With

Héloïse Calame

Research on Comparative Grammar

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Chapter 1

Negation in Sign Language of the Netherlands

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This chapter addresses negation in Sign Language of the Netherlands, a language in the visual-spatial modality. Throughout this chapter, we will address several aspects of negation that are modality-independent, such as the occurrence of negative particles, but also pay attention to structures that are particular for sign languages, such as the simultaneous use of grammatical non-manual markers. In the introduction, we provide some information on Sign Language of the Netherlands (NGT) in general, and we briefly go into our methodology. Then we continue to describe properties of negation in NGT step by step, based on previous research, but also by providing new data on phenomena that have, until now, not received much attention within the field of sign language linguistics, such as negative transport.

Keywords: Sign Language of the Netherlands, visual-spatial modality, headshake, manual negation, scope

1 The language

Sign Language of the Netherlands (*Nederlandse Gebarentaal*, NGT; ISO: **dse**, Glotto-code: **duct1253**) is used by at most 10,000 deaf signers (see **Klomp 2021** for more details on these numbers). Additionally, there is a considerable number of (native and L2) hearing signers, including family members of deaf people and interpreters, for example. **Cokart et al. (2019)** estimate the total group of signers in the Netherlands to be 60,000 people. On October 13, 2020, after many years of lobbying (**Cokart et al. 2019**), NGT has been officially recognized as a minority language in the Netherlands.

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The origins of NGT lie in Paris, France, where Charles-Michel de l'Épée (1712–1789) was the first teacher of deaf children who systematically used signs in his educational methods. The Dutchman Henri Daniel Guyot (1753–1828) visited the lessons of De l'Épée and implemented De l'Épée's methods in Guyots' newly founded Dutch school for the deaf in the Netherlands (Tijsseling 2014). In the years that followed, other schools for the deaf opened their doors all across the Netherlands. The schools had different preferences in their methods and language policies: from roughly 1880–1980, signing was discouraged or even forbidden in most schools for the deaf throughout Europe (van den Bogaerde et al. 2016). The emergence and development of NGT had not been documented properly, until the pioneering linguist Ben Tervoort described the signs used by children at the deaf school in St. Michielsgestel as truly linguistic (Tervoort 1953). There are strong indications that children were secretly signing in boarding schools, at home, or with friends at the playgrounds (Tijsseling 2014). Due to the discouragement of signing and the physical distances between deaf schools, there is striking variation in the vocabulary of NGT. We sometimes speak of five “dialects”, referring to the five locations of the former deaf schools, which were situated in the North (Groningen), the South (St. Michielsgestel), the North-West (Amsterdam) and the South-West (Rotterdam and Voorburg); see Figure 1. However, to date, research into the grammar of NGT, which started in the 1980s, has not provided clear evidence of regional grammatical differences.



Figure 1: The locations of the five schools for the deaf in the early 20th century in the Netherlands. © Nederlands Gebarencentrum. Reprinted with permission.

NGT is a comparably well-studied sign language, but its description is an ongoing project. NGT has two common word orders, namely SOV and SVO (van Gijn 2004, Oomen & Pfau 2017). As in any sign language, NGT employs manual

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and non-manual elements to express meaning. Non-manual elements are linguistic signals produced by the head, face and upper body. The non-manual element that is most relevant for the current chapter is the headshake: a (single or repeated) side-to-side movement of the head that has grammaticalized from the gestural negating headshake in NGT (van Loon et al. 2014). Another non-manual articulator that will occasionally be mentioned is the mouth, which can produce articulations that are word-like (e.g. the silent articulation ‘if’ accompanying the sign IF), so-called mouthings, and articulations that are not word-like (e.g. the articulation ‘ssh’ [ʃ] accompanying the sign BE.PRESENT), so-called mouth gestures (Bank 2014).

In terms of methodology, we base the descriptions presented in this chapter on earlier corpus research performed by Oomen & Pfau (2017), on additional corpus data extracted for the purpose of this chapter, on previous literature, and on data from several deaf consultants. The corpus data come from the Corpus NGT (Crasborn et al. 2008), in which, in its current version, 92 deaf signers (17 to 84 years old) participated. Note, however, that only about 16% of the corpus is annotated for sign glosses, and about 9% for Dutch translations – i.e. only a small part of the data allows for automatic searches. The deaf consultants varied in age, gender and language background (e.g. at which age they acquired NGT and which variant they use), but all indicated that NGT is their first and most-used language.

The structure of this paper follows the structure of the questionnaire for describing the negation system of a language presented in the volume in which this article appears (Miestamo 2025).

Before embarking on our description of NGT negation, we wish to point out that negation, unlike many other domains of grammar, is a topic which has been relatively well described for a considerable number of sign languages; see e.g. Zeshan (2004) for a typological survey of negative constructions in 37 different sign languages, and Quer (2012) and Gökgöz (2021) for comprehensive overviews. From the body of work that is already available, it is abundantly clear that – just like in spoken languages – there is considerable variation in how negation is expressed in different sign languages. We therefore remind the reader that the observations and patterns reported in this chapter are specific to NGT and should thus not be assumed to apply across sign languages.

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

Similar to what has been described for many other sign languages, the realization of standard negation in NGT involves two types of markers. Firstly, a side-to-side headshake is used as an obligatory non-manual marker, which simultaneously accompanies (part of) the negated clause. Secondly, there are manual markers, the most common one being the particle NOT1, which is articulated with a hand-shape with extended index finger performing a single sideward movement in front of the signer's body (see Figure 2(a)). Alternatively, the negator NOT2 may be used, which involves the same movement but a handshape with all fingers extended (see Figure 2(b)). The forms may be articulated with one or two hands moving outward to the side.¹



(a) NOT1



(b) NOT2

Figure 2: Two manual signs that may function as basic clause negators in NGT. Video stills from the Corpus NGT.

Considering first the manual particles, it has been observed that they can occur in two positions in the clause, either directly preceding the verb phrase or in clause-final position, the latter position being the more common one (Oomen & Pfau 2017, Oomen et al. 2018). Crucially, the different positions do not trigger interpretive differences, that is, differences in the scope of negation (see further §4.1). The two options regarding the placement of NOT are illustrated in (1a) and (1b) (Oomen & Pfau 2017: 21, 30). The codes following the translations in the

¹In constructed examples and in the running text, the gloss NOT is used as an umbrella gloss for both basic clause negator forms.

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examples refer to the corresponding video files in the Corpus NGT and the signer ID; an explanation of the **glossing conventions** can be found at the end of the paper.

- (1) a. INDEX₁ POINT $\frac{\text{UNDERSTAND NOT1}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘I don’t understand/get the point.’ [390-S019]
- b. $\frac{\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ NOT1 OPINION HAVE INDEX}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘I don’t have an opinion on that.’ [063-S005]
- c. $\frac{\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ REACT NOTHING1}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘I don’t react (to it).’ [539-S026]

Occasionally, the n-word NOTHING1 (see Figure 16(c) in §3.2) may be used for standard negation, as, for instance, in (1c) – a pattern that is familiar from spoken languages (Jespersen 1917). From the context in which (1c) was signed, it is evident that the intended meaning was not ‘I don’t react to anything’. At present, it is not clear whether NOTHING1 allows for variable positioning within the clause on a par with NOT, as it consistently follows the verb in the available examples.

This combination of two markers – a manual and a non-manual one – in the expression of standard negation is reminiscent of Negative Concord (cf. split negation in French).² Importantly, however, the use of a manual negative sign is optional in NGT. NGT thus qualifies as a so-called ‘non-manual dominant’ sign language, that is, a sign language in which the non-manual marker is obligatory while the manual negator is optional (Zeshan 2006). In fact, clauses are commonly negated by a headshake only. Oomen & Pfau (2017), for instance, report that 59.8% of the negative clauses they extracted from Corpus NGT are negated by a headshake only (also see Coerts 1992). Two examples are provided in (2). The clause in (2a) displays SOV order, but the verb is followed by a so-called subject pronoun copy, a pointing sign that refers back to the subject (Oomen & Pfau 2017: 23); the constituent order in (2b) is SVO.

- (2) a. INDEX₁ INDEX $\frac{\text{REACT INDEX}_1}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘I don’t react to it/reply to it.’ [539-S026]
- b. $\frac{\text{BOY WATCH TELEVISION INDEX}_{3b}}{\text{hs}}$

²For a discussion of Negative Concord involving two manual negators in NGT, see van Boven et al. 2023.

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‘The boy did not watch television’ (Coerts 1992: 218)

The fact that headshake alone is capable of changing the polarity of a clause is clear evidence that it is not just a gestural element – as has been claimed for e.g. Australian Sign Language (Johnston 2018) – but rather a functional element that is part of the grammar of the language (Pfau 2015). In addition, while there is some variation in the scope of the headshake, its exact distribution is constrained. The first aspect to emphasize is that there is no one-to-one relation between scope of the headshake, that is, its onset/offset in relation to the manual sign(s) it accompanies, and scope of negation (see §4.1). This is illustrated by the near-minimal pair in (3), two clauses that were articulated by the same signer in close proximity to each other: the scope of the headshake differs in the two utterances, but the scope of negation is the same.

- (3) a. $\text{INDEX}_1 \overline{\text{MAYBE INDEX}_1 \text{ GRASP}}^{\text{hs}}$
 ‘Maybe I didn’t notice (it).’ [069-S005]
- b. $\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ MAYBE GRASP INDEX}_1^{\text{hs}}$
 ‘Maybe I didn’t notice (it).’ [069-S005]

As for the scope of the headshake in standard negation, the following observations can be made:

- When NOT is present, it is always accompanied by headshake, see (1);
- The headshake combines with at least the verb, even when the negative particle NOT is used;
- Objects (pronominal and non-pronominal ones) are optionally accompanied by headshake, but they are highly likely to be accompanied by headshake when they follow the verb, as in (2b);
- Subjects tend to be outside the scope of the headshake except when they are pronominal, as in (1b) and (1c);
- Some clause-final signs like subject pronoun copies, as in (2a) and (3b), and the sign PALM-UP (PU) – a multifunctional sign which commonly appears clause-finally – may be accompanied by headshake;
- Clause-initial topics always fall outside the scope of the headshake, as illustrated in (4), where the direct object has been topicalized, marked by means of raised eyebrows (‘re’).

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- (4) $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{RED CABBAGE}} / \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ LIKE INDEX}_1}$
 ‘Red cabbage, I don’t like (it).’

Given these facts, it has been claimed that the scope of the headshake, rather than being determined by its semantic scope, tends to align with the prosodic structure of the clause (Oomen et al. 2018). This explains why (i) topics, which constitute separate intonational phrases, are outside the scope of the headshake; (ii) pronominal subjects are more likely to fall under the scope of the headshake, as they are more easily prosodically integrated into the clause (Oomen & Pfau 2017); (iii) headshake may spread onto certain clause-final elements, as these are prosodically light elements (Crasborn et al. 2012).

Based on these patterns, it has been argued by Oomen et al. (2018) that standard negation in NGT involves the combination of (i) an optional negative particle, which is lexically specified for a headshake, and (ii) a non-manual (suprasegmental) affix, the headshake, which attaches to the verb and optionally spreads over prosodically defined domains (comparable to tone sandhi phenomena in spoken language; see Pfau 2016).

Neither in negative clauses containing NOT nor in those without do we observe constructional or paradigmatic asymmetry (Miestamo 2009). As for the former, the marker(s) are simply added to the corresponding affirmative clause, and just as in affirmative declarative clauses, both SOV and SVO order is attested, and pro-drop is commonly observed. As for the latter, inflectional categories on the verb are not influenced by the polarity of the clause (note, however, that inflectional categories that commonly partake in paradigmatic asymmetry, like tense and irrealis, are not marked on NGT verbs).

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

The only sentence type we know of to have a dedicated negative form in NGT is the imperative. Negative imperatives (also called prohibitives) partially show the same marking as negative declaratives, but can also involve a specific prohibitive manual marker and specific non-manual markers – note, however, that this generalization is based on only one small-scale study with data on 27 negative imperatives in NGT. We describe the results of this study (Spruijt 2019) step by step: first, we present the manual markers of negative imperatives; second, we describe the non-manual markers; and third, we address how NGT negative imperatives fit into the classification of prohibitives as proposed by van der Auwera & Lejeune (with Valentin Goussev) (2013).

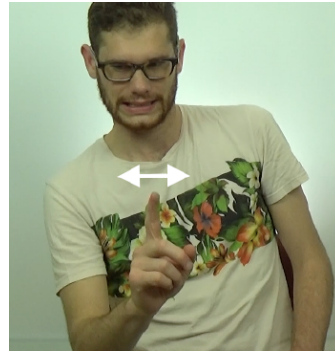
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As for manual markers, NGT has the prohibitive particle *PROH*, which can occur in two forms (Figure 3) and always occurs sentence-finally (Spruijt 2019). The forms are similar to *NOT1* and *NOT2* (see Figure 2), apart from the movement: the prohibitive forms in Figure 3 involve a repeated side-to-side movement, while *NOT1* and *NOT2* are articulated with a single sideward movement. The prohibitive marker is optional, and can be observed in prohibitions, negative instructions, and negative recommendations. An example of the latter is presented in (5).

- (5) NOT CHOOSE INDEX₃ *PROH*
 ‘Don’t choose it!’ (Spruijt 2019: 18)³



(a) *PROH1*



(b) *PROH2*

Figure 3: Two variants of the prohibitive marker *PROH* (Spruijt 2019: 18).

In example (5), the prohibitive marker is combined with the basic negator *NOT*. However, *NOT* can also occur on its own in prohibitive contexts, as in (6), which demonstrates the optionality of the prohibitive marker.

- (6)
$$\begin{array}{c} \text{hs} \\ \hline \text{HEY REQUEST } \overline{\text{NOT SALT MUCH PUT.IN}}^{\text{sq}} \\ \text{‘Hey, please don’t put in too much salt.’ (Spruijt 2019: 20)} \end{array}$$

Example (6) is additionally marked by non-manual markers. Firstly, there is a headshake, which is, as mentioned in §2.1, an obligatory marker of sentential negation in NGT. Secondly, the main part of the clause in (6) is accompanied by

³Spruijt (2019) does not specify headshake marking or which forms of *NOT* and *PROH* are used.

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squinted eyes, one of the non-manual markers that are specifically found in negative imperatives but not in negated declaratives. Figure 4 illustrates this marker.



Figure 4: Squinted eyes (adapted from Spruijt 2019: 18).

Other non-manual markers that are associated with prohibitives are furrowed brows (displayed in Figure 3(a) above) and a wide, closed or slightly opened, tensed mouth (visualized in Figures 3(a) and 3(b), respectively). Squinted eyes usually mark the entire sentence, while the scope of furrowed brows and of a tensed mouth varies (Spruijt 2019). The following negative instruction is accompanied by a headshake, furrowed brows, and a tensed mouth.

- (7) TRAFFIC.LIGHT $\frac{\text{hs+fb+tm}}{\text{STRAIGHT.AHEAD PROH}}$
 ‘At the traffic light, don’t go straight ahead.’ (Spruijt 2019: 20)

Interestingly, however, none of the described manual and non-manual markers are obligatory. We now turn to the typological classification of NGT imperatives. The classification of van der Auwera & Lejeune (with Valentin Goussev) (2013) captures two morphosyntactic characteristics: whether the sentential negative marking of declaratives is used, and whether the second-person singular verb form is used in imperative contexts. As for the first aspect, we have shown above that NGT can indeed use the same strategy for negative sentential marking in prohibitives as in declaratives. The main marker of sentential negation in both sentence types is the headshake, and there is no clear evidence that there are differences in the occurrence and spreading of the headshake between prohibitives and declaratives. The manual negator NOT is in both cases an optional marker. However, another strategy is to use a dedicated prohibitive marker, which gives rise to an asymmetric pattern. As for the second aspect, NGT verbs do not have

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a special form in prohibitive as opposed to positive imperative contexts: it is the regular second-person form which is utilized (see [Spruijt 2019](#)).

As such, NGT shows characteristics of both type 1 and type 2 languages in [van der Auwera & Lejeune \(with Valentin Goussev\)](#)'s (2013) classification. Type 1 languages use the verbal construction of the second singular imperative and a sentential negative strategy found in (indicative) declaratives, comparable to NGT imperatives without dedicated prohibitive marker. Type 2 languages also employ a second singular imperative construction, but the sentential negation strategy is not found in (indicative) declaratives, as in NGT imperatives with *PROH*.

2.3 Negation in stative predicates

It has been reported for some sign languages that the position of the manual negator relative to the predicate differs in stative vs. verbal predications (see e.g. [Bergman 1995](#) on Swedish Sign Language and [Vogt-Svendsen 2000](#) on Norwegian Sign Language).

In NGT, most types of stative predications, including predications of proper inclusion, equation, attribution, and possession, do not seem to involve special negation strategies. As in negated verbal predications, the manual negator (if present) in these types of stative predications may occur before (8a) or after (8b) the predicate. As illustrated by the examples in (8), (8c) being an instance without manual negator, the attested headshake spreading patterns in stative predications also mirror those in standard negated sentences (see §2.1).

- (8) a. $\frac{\text{hs}}{\text{NOT DIFFICULT}}$
 '[It] isn't difficult.' [060-S006]
- b. $\text{INDEX}_1 \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{SICK NOT}}$
 'I am not sick.' [476-S024]
- c. $\text{INDEX}_3 \text{ SELF BASIS } \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{STRONG ENOUGH INDEX}_3}$
 'Their basis isn't strong enough.' [386-S019]

Negated locative predications also display regular behavior. NGT, like other sign languages, tends to use classifier predicates to convey locative relations between entities. Classifier predicates are productive complex signs which combine a handshape morpheme representing an entity and a verb stem expressing a location or movement trajectory. For example, in the constructed sentence in (9a),

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the signer uses the classifier handshape for thin flat objects to represent a book, and combines it with a short downward movement to demonstrate that the book is located on top of another object, in this case a table. The place of articulation of the classifier predicate aligns with that of the sign *TABLE*. The construction in (9a) may be negated through the addition of a headshake over the predicate (9b). As usual, a manual negator is optional. Figure 5 illustrates the string of signs that make up (9b) in pictures.

- (9) a. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{BOOK TABLE}_3 \text{ CLF:FLAT.OBJECT.ON.SURFACE}_3}$
 ‘The book is on the table.’
 b. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{BOOK TABLE}_3} \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{CLF:FLAT.OBJECT.ON.SURFACE}_3}$
 ‘The book is not on the table.’

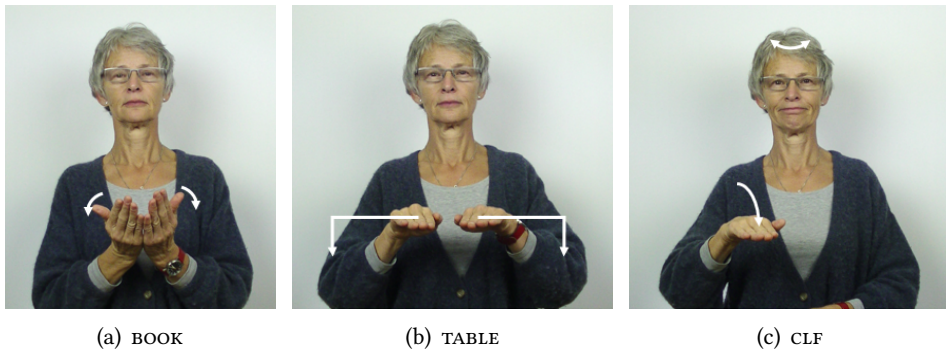


Figure 5: The string of signs from the example in (9b).

Interestingly, existential constructions with a classifier predicate such as (10a), which are otherwise structurally very similar to locative predications, cannot be negated by simply adding a headshake, an observation that implies paradigmatic asymmetry (Miestamo 2009).⁴ Indeed, it is ungrammatical to negate a classifier predicate if the entity the classifier refers to has an indefinite interpretation (10b). Instead, signers opt for alternative strategies. One possibility is the use of the predicate *BE.PRESENT*. This sign can be used in lieu of a classifier predicate in

⁴As far as we are aware, there are no studies that discuss indefiniteness in NGT. As for the locative constructions in NGT under discussion, our consultant indicates that reversal of the figure (*BOOK*) and the ground (*TABLE*), as in the constructed examples in (10), is associated with an indefinite interpretation.

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affirmative existential constructions, as illustrated in (10c).⁵ In a negative existential construction, BE-PRESENT is negated like any other predicate, that is, by means of a headshake (10d).

- (10) a. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{TABLE}_3} \text{BOOK CLF:FLAT.OBJECT.ON.SURFACE}_3$
 ‘There is a book on the table.’
 b. $\frac{\text{re}}{* \text{TABLE}_3} \text{BOOK} \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{CLF:FLAT.OBJECT.ON.SURFACE}_3}$
 ‘There is no book on the table.’
 c. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{TABLE}_3} \text{BOOK BE.PRESENT}_3$
 ‘There is a book on the table.’
 d. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{TABLE}_3} \text{BOOK} \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{BE.PRESENT}_3}$
 ‘There is no book on the table.’

The predicate sign *NOBODY.HERE* (Figure 6; also see §3.2 on negative indefinites) can also be used in negative existential contexts. It conveys the meaning ‘nobody (is) present/here’ (Nederlands Gebarencentrum n.d.).



Figure 6: *NOBODY.HERE*. Video still from the Corpus NGT.

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Finite and non-finite subordinate clauses are not easily distinguished in NGT, as verbs do not inflect for tense; also, there are no word order differences between main and embedded clauses (as there are in, for instance, spoken Dutch). The

⁵BE.PRESENT may also be used in locative predications.

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available evidence strongly suggests that both complement clauses under *know*-type predicates (which commonly take finite complements) and under *want*-type predicates (which commonly take non-finite complements; Noonan 2007) are negated in exactly the same way as main clauses, that is, by the manual negator in combination with headshake, or by headshake only. The latter option is illustrated by the examples in (11).

- (11) a. MARIJKE INDEX_{3a} KNOW / INGE $\frac{\text{hs}}{3b\text{COME}_{3a}}$
 ‘Marijke_i knows that Inge doesn’t come to her_i.’
 b. INGE INDEX_{3a} WANT / MAN INDEX_{3b} $\frac{\text{hs}}{\text{PRESENT } 3b\text{GIVE.PRESENT}_{3a}}$
 ‘Inge_i wants the man not to give her_i a present.’
 (adapted from van Gijn 2004: 123f)

Similarly, adverbial clauses do not employ any construction-specific negation strategy either. In (12), we provide examples involving a negative conditional clause (see also Klomp 2019) and a negative cause clause.

- (12) a. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{IF HEARING.AID}} \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{WORK NOT}} / \text{PU BACK OLD DEAF PU}$
 ‘If the hearing aid does not work, you’re back at your old deaf self.’
 [2035-S081]
 b. INDEX₁ DISAPPOINTED / BECAUSE $\frac{\text{hs}}{\text{TEST PASS}}$
 ‘I’m disappointed because I didn’t pass the test.’

Although this section is about non-main clauses, we also briefly have to address the main clause, or rather the main clause predicate, involved in the complex construction. This is of relevance, as it has been observed that in complex sentences in which only the main clause predicate is negated, the headshake may spread over the embedded clause. In other words: the non-main clause appears to be affected by matrix negation even though its polarity is positive, as is illustrated in (13a). Still, as also pointed out by van Gijn (2004), spreading is not obligatory in these cases, as evidenced by the corpus example in (13b) (see §4.6.1 for further discussion in the context of negative transport).

- (13) a. $\frac{\text{hs}}{\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ WANT} / \text{COME.ALONG}_1}$
 ‘I do not want you to come along.’ (adapted from van Gijn 2004: 113)
 b. $\frac{\text{hs}}{\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ SAY NOT}} / \text{MUST EVERYTHING ORAL}$
 ‘I’m not saying that everything should be about speaking.’ [429-S022]

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2.5 Negative lexicalizations

NGT has verbal and non-verbal negative lexicalizations. The morphological processes that resulted in these lexicalized forms are not always transparent, which sometimes makes it difficult to distinguish cases of cliticization from cases of true negative lexicalizations. We base the categorization of the following lexicalized negative forms on the extent to which they differ phonologically from potential corresponding positive forms.

First, we take a look at the modal verbs that have specialized negative forms. These negatives are the signs $CAN^{\wedge}NOT$, $MAY.NOT$, $WANT.NOT$, and $NEED.NOT$. The first example $CAN^{\wedge}NOT$ (Figure 7(b)) is a result of cliticization, where the manual negator NOT (see Figure 2(a)) has cliticized onto the modal verb CAN (Figure 7(a)).



(a) CAN



(b) $CAN^{\wedge}NOT$

Figure 7: The modal verbs CAN and $CAN^{\wedge}NOT$. Video stills from the Corpus NGT.

The negative modals $MAY.NOT$ (Figure 8(b)) and $WANT.NOT$ (Figure 9(b)) are clearly different from $CAN^{\wedge}NOT$ in that they are phonologically more distinct from their positive counterparts (Figures 8(a) and 8(b)); still they maintain some of the phonological characteristics of MAY and $WANT$, respectively. The sign MAY contains an outward movement, which is maintained in $MAY.NOT$, but the handshape of MAY has changed into the ✌ -handshape in $MAY.NOT$. Also note that $MAY.NOT$ in Figure 8(b) is articulated with one hand, making it very similar in form to the basic clause negator $NOT1$ (Figure 2(a)). Often, however, the sign is articulated with both hands, which is not the case for $NOT1$. If we compare $WANT.NOT$ to $WANT$, we observe a handshape change as well, which is furthermore accompanied by a downward path movement instead of the hand-internal

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movement in WANT (in which the fingers flex repeatedly). The modal NEED.NOT is a negative lexicalization without a clear positive counterpart.



(a) MAY

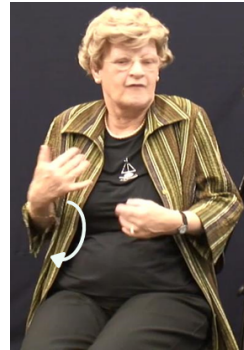


(b) MAY.NOT

Figure 8: The modal verbs MAY and MAY.NOT. Video stills from the Corpus NGT.



(a) WANT



(b) WANT.NOT

Figure 9: The modal verbs WANT and WANT.NOT. Video stills from the Corpus NGT.

It is worth pointing out that naturalistic corpus data suggest that the use of a specialized negative modal, such as the ones illustrated above, is not always obligatory. That is, at least some modal meanings can also be negated using standard negation strategies. In (14), we illustrate this for the modal verb CAN: (14a) exemplifies the use of the negative modal CAN^NOT; in (14b), the base form of the modal combines with the negative particle NOT (and headshake); in (14c), the modal is negated by headshake only.

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- (14) a. $\frac{\text{DISABLED MOVE}_3 \text{ CAN}^{\wedge} \text{NOT}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘The disabled cannot move (to another place).’ [486-S024]
- b. $\frac{\text{SIGN.LANGUAGE CAN NOT1 COMBINE}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘(You) can’t combine sign language [...].’ [428-S022]
- c. $\frac{\text{CAN IMAGINE INDEX}_1 \text{ THEN}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘Then I can’t envision it.’ [430-S022]

Another specialized negative verb form, although not modal, is the cliticized form $\text{DO}^{\wedge} \text{NOT}$ (Figure 10(b)).⁶ The handshake of DO (Figure 10(a)) is maintained in the negative $\text{DO}^{\wedge} \text{NOT}$ (Figure 10(b)) but the movement has changed and is now similar to the movement of the particle NOT (but see Klomp (2021) for two alternative analyses).

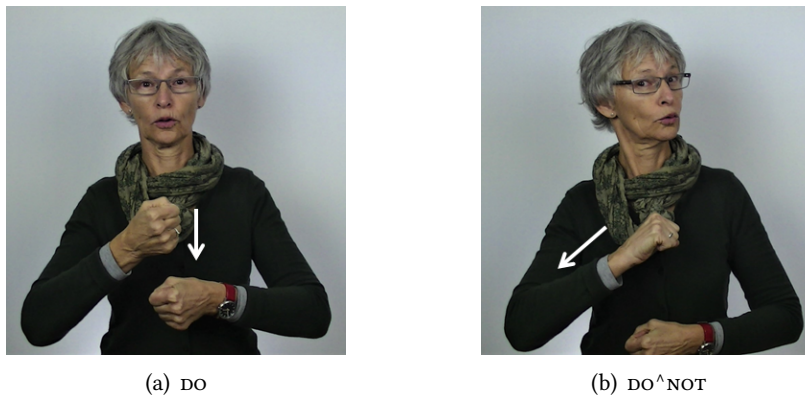


Figure 10: The verbs DO and $\text{DO}^{\wedge} \text{NOT}$.

An example of a non-verbal specialized negative is the adjectival predicate NOT.AWARE . The sign is shown in Figure 11(b), together with the positive predicate AWARE (Figure 11(a)), which has the same initial place of articulation.

Furthermore, NGT employs a dedicated negative construction in perfective / completive contexts. While these aspectual meanings are commonly expressed by the marker ALREADY in affirmative clauses (15), in negative contexts, the marker NOT.YET (Figure 12) is used, as illustrated in (15b). It appears that NOT.YET , just like NOT , may precede or follow the verb.

⁶ $\text{DO}^{\wedge} \text{NOT}$ is a main verb that appears in contexts such as ‘I will (not) do it tomorrow’.

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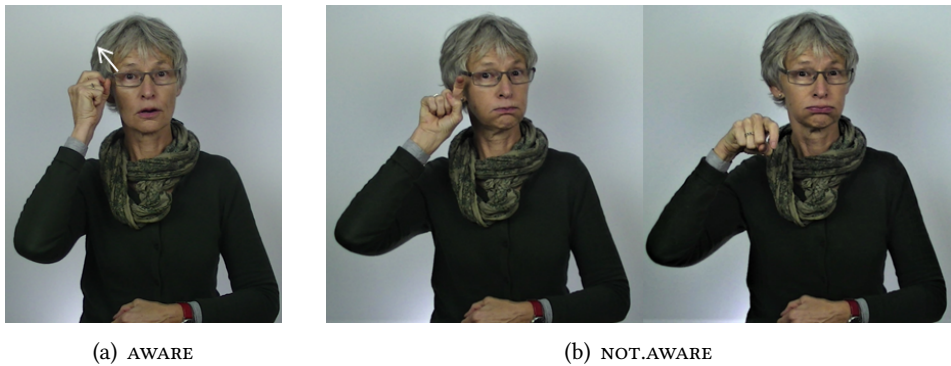


Figure 11: The verbs AWARE and NOT.AWARE.



Figure 12: The negative adverbial NOT.YET.

- (15) a. AIRPLANE $_{3a}$ COME₁ ALREADY
‘The plane has (already) arrived.’
hs
b. AIRPLANE NOT.YET $_{3a}$ COME₁ PU
‘The plane has not yet arrived.’ (adapted from Coerts 1992: 209)

Let us add one final example of a negative lexicalization, which behaves as an idiomatic clausal construction in NGT: DOES.NOT.MATTER, which translates as ‘[it] does not matter’, involves a repeated alternating brushing movement of the two hands, as shown in Figure 13. In example (16), the sign is used twice.

- (16) INDEX₁ $\frac{\text{DOES.NOT.MATTER}}{\text{hs}}$ / DEAF OR HEARING OR BLIND
 $\frac{\text{DOES.NOT.MATTER}}{\text{hs}}$

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Figure 13: DOES.NOT.MATTER

‘To me, it doesn’t matter. Deaf, hearing or blind, it doesn’t matter.’

[061-S006]

On the one hand, the negative lexicalizations reported in this section are known to be cross-linguistically common, both in sign languages as well as spoken languages; they represent senses from a limited set of cognitively salient categories such as modal (e.g. MAY.NOT), emotional attitude (WANT.NOT), cognition (NOT.AWARE), and tense / aspectual meanings (NOT.YET) (see Zeshan 2004). On the other hand, NGT displays a cross-linguistically uncommon feature in that there is no general lexicalized negative existential (but see §3.2 on the sign NO-BODY.HERE). This is unexpected, since negative existentials appear first on the hierarchy of lexicalized negative expressions (Veselinova 2013).

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative replies

There are several ways to give a negative reply to a polar question. First of all, the non-manual headshake by itself is a legitimate negative reply. As for manual options, there is much variation. We attested the following ways to sign ‘no’:

1. A sign identical to the negative particle NOT1 (see §2.1), which we gloss here NO1 for the sake of convenience. It is articulated with one or two hands, with the index finger extended, making an outward movement. This movement may be singular, or it may be a bidirectional repeated movement.
2. The sign NO2, where one or two hands have all fingers and thumb extended and make an outward movement. This movement may be singular or it may be a bidirectional repeated movement. In repeated form, it is identical to the prohibitive marker PROH1 (see §2.2).

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3. The sign NO3, where one hand has the index- and middle-finger extended, as in the manual letter ‘n’, and makes an outward movement; see Figure 14.
4. Sideward fingerspelling of the Dutch word *nee* (‘no’), with the hand palm pointing towards the addressee.
5. Fingerspelling of the ‘n’ and a single ‘e’, with palm pointing upwards and the hand moving away from the signer.



Figure 14: The sign NO3.

All these negative replies express negation of the content of a question. Whether they can also be used to negate the polarity of a question is still open for research. As for the distribution of the various signs, it is not known whether manual replies are more frequent than only non-manual replies.

Compared to the six available possibilities for negative replies, the options to provide a positive reply are limited. Here, the options are firstly non-manual through a (repeated) head nod, and secondly manual, either through the very frequently used sign YES1 (Figure 15) or a less common sign, in which the -handshape is used and the wrist is flexed (YES2). There is no fingerspelled option, although it must be noted that the handshape in YES1 and YES2 is the result of assimilation of fingerspelling the letters ‘j’ () and ‘a’ () , which form the Dutch word *ja* (‘yes’).

Thus, the non-manual options for negative and positive replies are both articulated by the head. The manual options, however, are quite different: whereas the negative reply has five different options available, of which three are based on fingerspelling, the affirmative reply only has two, which both derived from fingerspelling but are conventionalized signs now.

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Figure 15: The sign YES1. Video still from the Corpus NGT.

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

There are three main signs which function as negative indefinites in NGT, and which are always accompanied by a headshake. The form glossed as NEG.INDF1, depicted in Figure 16(a), is a general negative indefinite and can convey the meanings ‘nothing’, ‘nobody’, ‘never’, and ‘nowhere’. An accompanying mouthing may distinguish between meanings. When used with the meaning ‘nobody’ or ‘nothing’, the sign occurs in argument position, i.e. sentence-initially in the case of a subject, or pre- or postverbally in the case of an object (17a).⁷ When used as a negative adverbial, the sign typically comes after the subject but before the predicate (17b).



(a) NEG.INDF1



(b) NEG.INDF2



(c) NOTHING1

Figure 16: Three negative indefinites in NGT. Video stills from the Corpus NGT.

⁷The final INDEX (‘there’) in (17a) is signed with the non-dominant hand.

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- (17) a. $\frac{\text{INDEX}_a \text{ NEG.INDF1 SEE INDEX}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘He didn’t see anybody there.’ [704-S034]
- b. $\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ SELF SEE PERSON} / \text{INDEX}_a \frac{\text{NEG.INDF1 DEAF MEET}}{\text{hs}}$
 ‘I once saw a person who had never met a deaf person.’ [062-S005]

The sign NEG.INDF2 (Figure 16(b)) is a general negative adverbial which may mean ‘nothing’, ‘never’, or ‘nowhere’; again, the mouthing can differentiate more specific meanings. NEG.INDF2 tends to occur before the predicate, although it is also attested in sentence-final position. In the latter case, which often coincides with an increase in the amplitude of the movement of the sign, the adverbial appears to receive emphasis (see §4.4 for a discussion of strategies for reinforcing negation).

Another commonly attested negative indefinite sign is NOTHING1 in Figure 16(c), which is articulated with the index, middle or ring finger repeatedly being released by the thumb. The sign may occur pre- or postverbally. As noted in §2.1, NOTHING1 is sometimes also used as a basic clause negator.

Several other forms, often articulatorily similar to the signs illustrated in Figure 16, are also attested in (variants of) NGT, albeit less frequently. Also recall from §2.5 that the sign NOBODY.HERE can be used predicatively with the meaning ‘nobody (is) here’. As such, it can be considered to be an indefinite predicate.

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

NGT does not have case marking, but, unlike many sign languages studied so far, NGT has two derivational manual negative affixes (Klomp 2021). One is a prefix and the other a suffix, and both are loan elements from Dutch. The prefix is glossed as UN- and it is articulated with an index finger on the nose. Although the signed prefix occurs much less frequently than the corresponding Dutch prefix ‘on-’, its use is actually quite similar to the Dutch prefix, meaning that it mainly combines with adjectives, adverbials, and some verbs. There is great variety among signers in using UN- productively – it is frequently used in the Groningen region, but still, some signers do not consider the element really part of NGT, since it is derived from sign-supported Dutch. However, the combination illustrated in Figure 17, which shows the sign UN-DEEP ‘shallow’, was judged to be natural and acceptable by five consultants.

Another case is the negative suffix -LESS (Klomp 2021). This suffix attaches to nouns and changes the word class from noun to adjective/adverbial. It is not used

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Figure 17: The sign UN-DEEP ‘shallow’. Video stills from the Corpus NGT.

productively, but it occurs in specific lexemes that are loan words from Dutch, such as WORTH-LESS or ROOF-LESS ‘homeless’ (Figure 18).

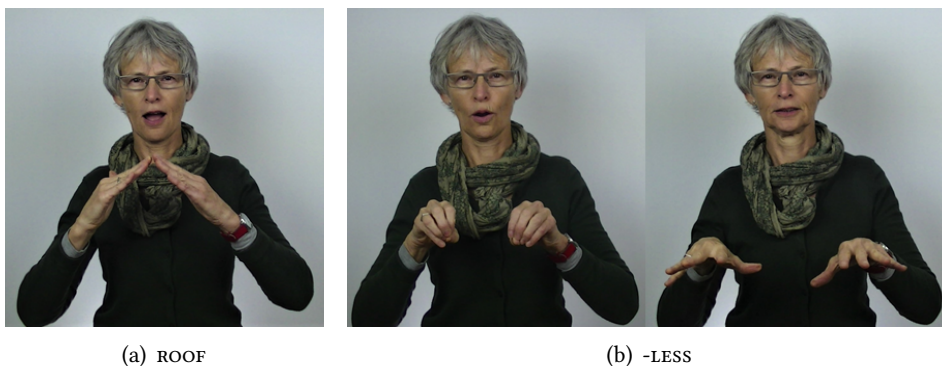


Figure 18: The sign ROOF-LESS ‘homeless’.

Furthermore, the negating headshake could be analyzed as a non-manual affix (as suggested by Pfau 2016), as it attaches to verbs in a systematic and productive way.

3.4 Other negative constructions/expressions

We are not aware of any other negative constructions or expressions. There is, for instance, no construction corresponding to English *neither... nor*. Future (corpus-based) studies, however, might well uncover such expressions.

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

In fact, to date little is known about how NGT realizes constituent negation. Discussions with a consultant, however, suggest that there are two common strategies for narrowing down the scope of negation onto a specific constituent: (i) by overtly marking contrast, and (ii) by topicalizing that constituent. We consider both options in turn.

In the examples in (18), negation semantically scopes over the subject. Note that, following a prosodic break (indicated by '/'), the signer presents a contrasting noun phrase, which is accompanied by an affirmative headnod, thereby clearly narrowing down the scope of negation. Given what we described in §2.1, two aspects of this example are noteworthy. First, the non-pronominal subject falls under the scope of the headshake. We have argued above that this is uncommon in standard negation, but it may be characteristic for narrow negation on the subject. Second, in this case, the optional negative particle may precede the subject (18a), which is not attested in standard negation, or follow the subject (18b). However, both these aspects require more systematic research in order to determine in how far they are characteristic for subject negation.

- (18) a. $\frac{\text{hs}}{(\text{NOT}) \text{ SISTER } {}_3\text{VISIT}_1} / \frac{\text{hn}}{\text{BROTHER}}$
 'Not my sister has visited me, but my brother.'
- b. $\frac{\text{hs}}{\text{SISTER } (\text{NOT}) {}_3\text{VISIT}_1} / \frac{\text{hn}}{\text{BROTHER}}$
 'Not my sister has visited me, but my brother.'

Constituent negation involving the object or verb is realized in a similar fashion. In both cases, narrow scope on the object (19a) and narrow scope on the verb (19b), the object and the verb are accompanied by the headshake (in this and the following example, we ignore the manual negator NOT because the options with respect to its clausal position are no different from standard negation, i.e. it can precede or follow the VP). Consequently, it is only the contrastive element (object NP vs. verb) that gives away which constituent is negated – as before, this element is accompanied by a headnod (similar results are reported in [van der Kooij et al. 2006: 1606](#)).

- (19) a. $\text{INDEX}_1 \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{VEGETABLES BUY}} / \frac{\text{hn}}{\text{FRUIT}}$
 'I didn't buy vegetables, but fruit.'

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- b. $\text{INDEX}_3 \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{BOOK BUY}} / \frac{\text{hn}}{\text{STEAL}}$
 ‘He didn’t buy the book, he stole it.’

Besides headshake and headnod, the consultant used further specific non-manual markers to signal the contrast: body leans towards opposing sides (e.g. in (19a), slight lean to the right while signing *VEGETABLES BUY* and slight lean to the left during the articulation of *FRUIT*) and, sometimes, wide eyes to mark focus (on *FRUIT* in (19a) and *STEAL* in (19b)). Thus, it is clear that the realization of constituent negation is supported by non-manuals that are more generally employed to mark contrastive focus (see Crasborn & van der Kooij 2013). As mentioned previously, more research is needed to identify clear patterns with regard to the distribution of non-manual markers in constituent negation.

The second option we identified for marking constituent negation, viz. topicalization, is only available for subjects and objects (and possibly locative/temporal adjuncts), but not for verbs. In this case, the negated constituent – the subject in (20a), the object in (20b) – appears in a clause-initial topic position, where it is marked by a non-manual topic marker, raised eyebrows. In both cases, the topicalized constituent falls outside the scope of the headshake (see (4) in §2.1), but still, topicalization signals that the scope of negation is narrowed down to these specific constituents. As in the examples above, the clause may be followed by a contrasted constituent accompanied by headnod, but – depending on the context – this appears optional; that is, topicalization alone may be sufficient to signal constituent negation.

- (20) a. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{BROTHER}} \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{VISIT}_1} / \frac{(\text{hn})}{(\text{SISTER})}$
 ‘My brother, (he) didn’t visit me (but my sister did).’
 b. $\frac{\text{re}}{\text{VEGETABLES}} \frac{\text{hs}}{\text{INDEX}_1 \text{ BUY}} / \frac{(\text{hn})}{(\text{FRUIT})}$
 ‘Vegetables, I didn’t buy (but fruit).’

4.2 Negative polarity

No negative polarity items have been identified in NGT.

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

As far as we are aware, NPs that appear under the scope of negation do not receive special marking in NGT. As there is no case marking in NGT, no interaction with negation is possible.

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4.4 Reinforcing negation

There are several strategies to reinforce negation in NGT. One such strategy is the repetition of signs, or using several negating signs in combination. An example from our corpus data is shown in (21).

- (21) SOMETIMES NOTHING₂ LANGUAGE ACQUIRED NOTHING₁ ZERO COMMA ZERO
 ‘Sometimes [they] haven’t acquired a language at all, nothing, completely zero.’ [254-S013]

In this example, two negative indefinites are used together with the phrase ‘zero comma zero’, to emphasize a complete lack of language.

Other reinforcing strategies are of a prosodic nature; these can involve both manual and non-manual signals. As for manual emphasis, a sign can be produced larger and/or more tensed (Klomp 2021). Non-manual emphasis is mainly found in the form of squinted eyes, although this non-manual element probably has a more general use for signaling emphasis; this requires further study. In (22), the sign for ‘nothing’ is marked by squinted eyes, yielding the interpretation ‘completely nothing’. The non-manual signals accompanying the sign are illustrated in Figure 19.

- (22) NEVER THINK PREGNANCY DEAF NEVER PU / THINK ^{sq}NOTHING₁ INDEX₁ PU
 ‘During my pregnancy, I never thought about whether the child would be deaf. I really never thought about it at all.’ [2216-S088]



Figure 19: The sign NOTHING₁ from (22) accompanied by squinted eyes. Video still from the Corpus NGT.

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4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

At present, we cannot offer information on specific negation strategies in complex clauses (coordination and subordination) beyond what we have described in previous sections (see §2.4). To the best of our knowledge, NGT does not have dedicated negative conjunctions or coordinators (see §3.4). Constructions used for contrastive negation have been addressed in §4.1.

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

4.6.1 Negative transport

NGT allows negative transport readings with certain predicates. A thorough inventory of neg-raising predicates pends further investigation, but at least THINK and EXPECT can be counted among them.

Interestingly, there appears to be a qualitative difference between sentences with and without neg-raising predicates. As reported in §2.4, the headshake may spread from matrix onto embedded clause in complex constructions (see (13), van Gijn 2004). Discussion with two consultants indicates that, crucially, predicate type seems to determine the occurrence of such spreading. More specifically, in negative transport constructions, the headshake may spread over the embedded clause, as in (23a). Narrow spreading over just the matrix clause verb (23b) is also allowed; however, one of the consultants suggested that such constructions have a reading in which the emphasis lies on the matrix clause subject ('I don't think my sister is in love').

- (23) a. $\text{INDEX}_1 \overline{\text{THINK} / \text{SISTER INDEX}_3 \text{ IN.LOVE}}^{\text{hs}}$
 'I don't think my sister is in love.' ($\approx$ 'I think my sister is not in love.')
- b. $\text{INDEX}_1 \overline{\text{THINK}}^{\text{hs}} \text{SISTER INDEX}_3 \text{ IN.LOVE}$
 'I don't think my sister is in love.' ($\approx$ 'I think my sister is not in love.')
- c. $?? \text{INDEX}_1 \overline{\text{SAY SISTER INDEX}_3 \text{ IN.LOVE}}^{\text{hs}}$
 'I didn't say my sister was in love.' or 'I didn't say my sister was **not** in love.'
- d. $\text{INDEX}_1 \overline{\text{SAY}}^{\text{hs}} \text{SISTER INDEX}_3 \text{ IN.LOVE}$
 'I didn't say my sister was in love.'

Wide spreading in constructions with standard complement-taking predicates such as SAY, on the other hand, yields ambiguity between a reading in which the

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matrix clause is negated and a reading in which both matrix and embedded clause are negated (23c). Moreover, it appears that this ambiguity is partially caused by the fact that there is a strong dispreference in NGT for combining two manual negative markers within a complex sentence. Our consultants indicate that this is perceived as a form of sign-supported Dutch. That is, the latter interpretation would be more appropriate but may be rejected on independent grounds. The preferred way to express matrix clause negation with standard predicates is with narrow scope of the headshake, i.e. limited to just the matrix predicate (23d).

The pattern described above seems to suggest that wide spreading of the headshake with negative transport predicates, as in (23a), serves to signal that the matrix clause negation is interpreted in the embedded clause. As far as we are aware, there are no spoken languages that overtly mark negative transport in any comparable way. For more on Neg-raising constructions in NGT, and two other sign languages, see Oomen et al. 2023.

4.6.2 Non-negative uses of negatives and expletive negation

It is interesting to note that one of the markers that is crucial in the expression of standard negation, that is, the headshake, is also occasionally observed in non-negative contexts, for instance to express intensification (i.e. a meaning that could be paraphrased as ‘unbelievable’) or insecurity (e.g. a headshake accompanying a non-negated wh-question). One has to keep in mind, however, that similar uses of the headshake are also attested in spoken languages (McClave 2000, Kendon 2002). Yet, given that in such cases, the headshake appears to be less tightly linked to the syntactic structure of the utterance it accompanies, it is likely that its use is gestural in nature. In contrast, we argued in §2.1 that the negative headshake, as used in NGT, is a grammatical marker – or, to put it differently, a grammaticalized gesture (cf. van Loon et al. 2014, Pfau 2015).

4.6.3 Diachronic notes and observations

Given that NGT does not have a written form, diachronic data with considerable time depth are not available, and it is therefore notoriously difficult to make statements about diachronic changes. Still, two points are worth mentioning. First, it is sometimes claimed that the use of the manual negator NOT (see §2.1) is more common among older signers, while younger signers prefer headshake-only negation. If this is indeed true, then we might be dealing with a change from a split negation system to a system with a single negative marker (cf. Colloquial French). However, the evidence is mostly anecdotal in nature, and therefore, further research is needed to verify this hypothesis. Second, as mentioned in §3.3, at

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least one of the two derivational affixes we described is considered old-fashioned by some younger signers. These diachronic changes may reflect changes in the influence of spoken Dutch on NGT, possibly as a result of shifts in educational policies (see [Klomp 2021](#)). After all, both the use of a negative particle and the use of the negative prefix are characteristic of spoken Dutch.

5 Conclusion

The presentation in the previous sections makes clear that NGT, a language in the visual-spatial modality, is not typologically unusual when it comes to the expression of negation. Basically all of the strategies, patterns, and idiosyncrasies we described are also attested in spoken languages, including those compiled in the present volume. In [Table 1](#), we offer an overview of our findings, and we include – to the extent possible – a comparison to spoken languages (for previous attempts at cross-modal comparison, see [Pfau \(2002, 2015\)](#) and [Gökgöz \(2021\)](#)).

Table 1: Forms attested in various types of negative constructions in NGT and cross-modal comparison (negative markers are in bold face).

Forms employed	Functions	Cross-modal comparison
- Optional use of negative particles NOT1, NOT2, NOTHING1; at least NOT1 and NOT2 may precede or follow the verb phrase. - Obligatory use of simultaneous non-manual marker (headshake), which accompanies the manual negator (if present) and at least the verb.	Standard negation Non-main clauses	Combination of two elements in standard negation is reminiscent of bi-partite negation; cf. French, where one of the two markers is also optional (see discussion below). Use of standard negation strategies in non-main clauses is attested in many spoken languages (e.g. English, French).
Negators PROH1 and PROH2 may appear in negative imperatives, specifically prohibitives, in clause-final position; however, use of these markers is optional.	Negative imperatives	Reminiscent of languages that do not employ a dedicated strategy for the negation of imperatives.
Same strategies as described for standard negation; negation of classifier predicates requires further study.	Stative predicates	Use of standard negation strategies in stative predicates is attested in many spoken languages (e.g. English, French).
Use of negative lexicalizations (cliticized or suppletive forms) for: - negative modals (e.g. CAN^NOT, MAY.NOT); - the negative predicate NOT.AWARE; - negative perfective/complete NOT.YET.	Negative lexicalizations	Negative lexicalizations in the domains of modality, cognition, and aspect are attested in many spoken languages (but not in Dutch). There is no general lexicalized negative existential, which is cross-linguistically uncommon.
- Multifunctional negative indefinites NEG.INDF1 and NEG.INDF2, which can express the meanings ‘nothing, never, nowhere’, and the former also ‘nobody’. - Negative indefinite NOTHING1 (which is also attested in standard negation – see above).	Negative indefinites	While the use of dedicated negative indefinites is common across languages, the multifunctionality of the signs we identified appears cross-linguistically less common.
Identification of - negative prefix UN-, which combines with adjectives, adverbials, and verbs; - negative suffix -LESS, which combines with nouns.	Negative derivation	Comparable negative derivations are familiar from e.g. various Germanic languages; in fact, the two affixes are loans from Dutch.
Negative transport (NT) is possible with certain cognitive matrix predicates (e.g. THINK , EXPECT ; options for spreading of headshake appear to differ between NT- and non-NT-predicates.	Negative transport	The matrix predicates that allow for NT overlap with those identified for spoken languages (e.g. English); overt marking of NT is, to the best of our knowledge, not attested in spoken languages.

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Our comparison in the third column reveals that corresponding patterns exist, and are indeed for the most part common, in spoken languages. One marker that deserves additional attention is the headshake, as its simultaneous articulation with the proposition that is being negated may, at first sight, appear to present us with a modality-specific phenomenon. However, as already mentioned in passing in §2.1, it has been suggested that (certain) non-manual markers are suprasegmental in nature and thus function like tone in spoken languages. Just like tone, they may be lexically specified for a lexeme or may function as grammatical morphemes (Yip 2002). This also holds true for the headshake. Split negation involving the combination of a negative particle and a tone change (i.e. a featural affix) may be rare in spoken languages, but it is attested.⁸

Much work remains to be done in order to identify further negative elements and strategies in NGT, and to disentangle whether certain elements or constructions cannot be negated.

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Glossing conventions and abbreviations

Following common conventions in sign language linguistics, NGT signs are glossed in English words in SMALL CAPS that represent the meaning of the sign but provide no information about its form. Most of the negative signs are therefore illustrated in figures by means of video stills; arrows are added when the movement of the hand is important. When two words are necessary to gloss a single sign, we use a period (e.g. COME.ALONG). A caret indicates cliticization, for instance of

⁸Note that this line of reasoning is based on the premise that the headshake is a grammaticalized gesture (see Pfau 2015). It is important to emphasize again that the same need not be true for all sign languages that employ headshake in the context of negation (see e.g. Johnston 2018: for Australian Sign Language).

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a negative sign to a modal verb (e.g. CAN^NOT); cliticization is typically characterized by phonological reduction and/or assimilation. The gloss INDEX represents a pointing sign (usually articulated with extended index finger) that fulfills the function of a pronoun. The gloss PU stands for ‘palm-up’, a sign articulated with the palm(s) of the hand(s) facing upwards which has various grammatical and discourse-related functions. A forward slash (‘/’) indicates a clause boundary.

Subscripts that appear on INDEX and certain verbs refer to locations in the signing space: ‘1’ = location close to signer’s body; ‘2’ = location of the addressee; ‘3’ = location in the space in front of the signer (where ‘3a’ is to the right and ‘3b’ to the left). That is, in _{3b}GIVE.PRESENT_{3a}, the verb sign is articulated with a movement from the left side towards the right side of the signing space.

Lines above the glosses indicate the presence of a non-manual marker that simultaneously accompanies manual signs; the length of the line reflects the scope, i.e. the onset and offset, of the marker. The following abbreviations are relevant in the chapter:

non-manual markers		manual markers	
fb	furrowed eyebrows	CLF	classifier
hn	headnod	INDF	indefinite
hs	headshake	NEG	negative
re	raised eyebrows	PROH	prohibitive
sq	squinted eyes	PU	palm up
tm	tensed mouth		

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Chapter 2

Negation in Bulgarian

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This article offers an overview of negation strategies in Bulgarian. The language follows several wide-spread cross-linguistic trends: its most general SN marker is a pre-verbal particle; there are several dedicated encodings of the prohibitive; negative indefinite pronouns are abundantly used with predicate negation. In terms of symmetric or asymmetric relations between affirmative and negative statements, we observe symmetric negation in predications set in present and past tense as well as in hortatives. However, there is a constructional asymmetry between affirmative and negated predications in the future tense. In this connection, we should highlight the fact that negation encoded by a complex compound predicate is, in fact, commonly used in Bulgarian. Such encoding includes indicative predications set in the future as well as several variants of the prohibitive. The negative lexicalizations identified in the language fall into known cross-linguistic tendencies, namely lexicalizing of expressions for nonexistence, lack of ability and lack of knowledge. Bulgarian features special emphatic negators *nito...nito* or *ni...ni* which also function as coordinative negators; this trait has been shown to be typologically less common and also contingent on areal distribution. Another characteristic that is perhaps typologically less common is the presence of a special negative question particle *nima*.

Keywords: symmetric and asymmetric negation, negation by particle, negation by complex compound predicate, coordinative negators, negative question particle

1 The language

Bulgarian (ISO: **bul**, Glottocode: **bulg1262**) is a South Slavonic language currently spoken by about 9 million people, out of whom close to 7 million live in Bulgaria. Modern Bulgarian is a direct descendant of Old Church Slavonic and has a long

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written history, with the Glagolitic script being spread in Bulgaria in the 9th century and with the later creation and maintenance of the Cyrillic alphabet. Scatton (1993: 188) summarizes the main periods of the history of the language as follows. (i) *Prehistoric period*, which coincides with Proto-Slavic, from the time of the Slavonic invasion of the Eastern Balkans to the Cyrillo-Methodian mission in Moravia in the 9th century. (ii) *Old Bulgarian*, 9th to 11th centuries, recorded in Old Church Slavonic manuscripts. (iii) *Middle Bulgarian*, 11th through the beginning of the 15th century. This period includes the Second Bulgarian Empire (1185–1393/96) during which its territory expanded on the Balkans but also its collapse and occupation by the Ottomans at the end of the 14th century. As one of the reviewers points out, literary activity was vibrant and continued some decades after the collapse of the Empire. Many structural innovations in the language can be traced back to that time. (iv) *Modern Bulgarian*, in Scatton's (1993) view from the 15th century until 1878. This covers the time of the Ottoman domination (1394–1878).

It should be noted that many of the innovations that occurred during the Middle and Early Modern Bulgarian periods are not systematically reflected in written records. As Scatton (1993: 188) states, there are a number of reasons for this, one of the most important ones being conservative scribal attitude which prevented vernacular features from entering the written language. A prescriptive attitude dominated Bulgarian grammar writing well into the 20th century. Consequently, the formal and written varieties have been the focus of many descriptions where examples are commonly taken from literary works. In contrast, the **Bulgarian National Corpus** (BulNC 2023), developed since the late 1990's, includes a rich variety of samples from both written and spoken registers.

Bulgarian dialects are traditionally divided into Western and Eastern, based on the realization of Proto-Slavonic *ě /jat/. Thus in Western dialects *ě becomes /e/ as in *млеко/mleko* 'milk', *нема/нема* 'not.have, not.exist' etc. while in Eastern dialects *e is typically, though not always, realized as /ja/ as in *мляко/ml-jako* 'milk', *няма/няма* 'not.have, not.exist'. In addition to this feature, there are also several other phonological and grammatical characteristics that support the Eastern-Western divide, see (Scatton 1993: 244–245) for a concise outline. The Eastern dialects, specifically those from Veliko Tŕnovo, the capital of Medieval Bulgaria and one of the main centers of the national renaissance, were the basis for the written as well as the formal and prestigious language for a long time. Once Sofia, which lies in the Western part of the country, became capital in 1878, some western features penetrated formal registers and the literary language. A detailed overview of Bulgarian dialects is considered outside the scope of this

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article; for a comprehensive analysis and data, see [Stoykov & Mladenov \(1993\)](#), [Antonova-Vasileva et al. \(2016b\)](#).

Modern Bulgarian has 6 vowels and 22 consonant phonemes.¹ The language has free stress, rich inflectional and derivational morphology, relatively well defined morpho-syntactic categories of open classes such as nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs. The most neutral word order is SVO. Bulgarian has a number of features which set it apart from other Slavonic languages. The most important ones include the loss of the case system, the development of a definite article suffixed to the noun and the loss of the infinitive form. On the other hand, Bulgarian has retained and further complicated the Proto-Slavic tense-aspect system. As a result, currently the verb system covers a complex interplay of tense-aspect categories expressed mostly by prefixes on the verb stem but sometimes also by suffixes and infixes. As a consequence of the long contact with Turkish, Bulgarian has evidential as a grammatical category, which encodes the source of information, witnessed or inferred, or reported speech.

The language has been in intensive contact with other languages throughout its history. It is obviously part of the Balkan Sprachbund and shares a number of features with its neighbors. Some of them were already mentioned above: a vowel system consisting of six cardinal vowels, the development of a suffixed definite article and the loss of infinitives. Other features typically associated with the Balkan Sprachbund and observed in Bulgarian as well include the development of a periphrastic future formed by a particle from the verb ‘want’, cf. (3a) in §2.1; distinctions between accomplishments and ongoing activities in the verb system; the use of one and the same construction to indicate subordination and subjunctive functions. A variant of this construction is also used for the encoding of specific subdomains of negation such as negation of predications set in the future as well as several variants of the prohibitive (see §2.1 as well as §2.2.1). Borrowing of lexicon has been extensive throughout the history of Bulgarian. Greek borrowings date from the time of Old Bulgarian. They became especially frequent during the Ottoman rule. Borrowings from Turkish are numerous during the time of the Ottoman domination. As noted by [Scatton \(1993: 240\)](#) a major change that occurred after 1878, the end of the Ottoman domination, included the replacement of Turkish loan words with Bulgarian neologisms or borrowings from Russian and other European languages such as Latin, Italian, French and German. In the 20th century and to this day, we observe a constant influx of English loans.

¹The number of consonant morphemes is reported here following [Maddieson \(2013\)](#). Scholars who consider palatalization to be a distinctive feature in the language count 35 consonant morphemes, cf. [Scatton \(1993: 191\)](#)

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Most of the data in this article have been produced by the author who is a native speaker of the language. The [BulNC \(2023\)](#) has been amply consulted as well together with reference sources such as grammars, dictionaries and earlier analyses of negation in Bulgarian.

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard Negation

Simple declarative sentences with an overt lexical verb as a predicate are negated by a pre-verbal particle *ne* when the verb is in present or in past tense, cf examples (1) and (2) below.

(1) Negation in predications with present time reference

- a. Стефан тича.
Stefan tič-a.
Stefan runs.IPFV-3SG.PRS
'Stefan runs.' (constructed example)
- b. Стефан не тича.
Stefan ne tič-a.
Stefan NEG run.IPFV-3SG.PRS
'Stefan does not run.' (constructed example)

(2) Negation in predications with past time reference

- a. Стефан тичаше.
Stefan tič-aše.
Stefan run.IPFV-3SG.IMPF
'Stefan was running.' (constructed example)
- b. Стефан не тичаше.
Stefan ne tič-aše.
Stefan NEG run.IPFV-3SG.IMPF
'Stefan was not running.' (constructed example)

In very broad lines, we can describe negation in predications with non-future time reference as symmetric, following [Miestamo \(2005\)](#). However, it has to be said that the preference for aspect in affirmative versus negative predications is yet to be studied. For instance, the verbs in examples (1b) and (2b) above are imperfective. Setting them in perfective aspect would be grammatical but it is

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my impression that imperfective is generally preferred in negated predications. More research is necessary to fully substantiate this statement. The preference for aspect will become even more important in the discussion on negation in non-declaratives, in §2.2.

The future tense is formed by a particle *šte* and an inflected form of the lexical verb, cf. (3a). The construction can be traced back to the Old Church Slavonic construction which involved the verb *xotěti* ‘want’ plus the infinitive of a lexical verb. It was one among several alternative ways to indicate futurity, cf. [Duri-danov \(1991: 418\)](#), [Slavova \(2017: 288-296\)](#). Verbal predications in the future tense are negated by a complex compound predicate that includes the negative existential *njama* together with the lexical verb introduced by the conjunction *da*², see example in (3b) and §4.6.5 for a discussion on diachrony.

(3) Negation in predications with future time reference

- a. Стефан ще тича.
 Stefan šte tiča.
 Stefan FUT run.IPFV.3SG.PRS
 ‘Stefan will run.’ (constructed example)
- b. Стефан няма да тича.
 Stefan njama da tič-a.
 Stefan NEGEX CONJ run.IPFV-1SG.PRS
 ‘Stefan will not run.’ (constructed example)

It should be noted that compound complex predicates that include an auxiliary and a lexical verb preceded by *da* are seemingly identical to complex sentences that consist of a main clause and a subordinate one. In this sense, the complex compound predicates are strongly reminiscent of the Balkan subordinate construction. However, a complex sentence, the subject of the main clause may be different from the one in the subordinate clause as in (4). A complex compound predicate has one single subject. The particle *da* is a multifunctional conjunction used in a variety of contexts. It is beyond the scope of this article to offer a detailed description of its uses. The ones most relevant here are collocating with present tense of verbs as (3b)³, indicating a complement or a subordinated clause as in (4) or being used with subjunctive-like functions in hortative constructions, see (9b). Throughout this text, *da* is referred to as either a conjunction or a subordinator depending on which function is most relevant.

²I thank Björn Wiemer for the discussion on this construction. The views expressed here are entirely my own.

³This is the modern version of an infinitive, see [Scatton \(1983: 378\)](#).

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- (4) Искам да дойдат тук.
 Iskam da dojdat tuk.
 want.1SG.PRS SUB.CONJ come.3PL.PRS
 ‘I want them to come here’ (constructed example)

Following *Miestamo*’s (2005) typology, we can say that in Bulgarian negation in predications with future time reference shows constructional asymmetry and can be in the type (A/Fin). Affirmative and negative verbal clauses with future time reference differ in terms of constructional complexity of the predicate: affirmatives are encoded by a simple predicate and negative by a complex one.

To conclude, SN in Bulgarian can be described as symmetric for verbs marked present or past, and asymmetric with regard to construction for predications where the verb is in the future tense. The symmetric construction falls in line with well known cross-linguistic tendencies to encode verbal negation by a particle that precedes the verb (cf. *Dahl 1979, 2010, Dryer 2013a,b*). The asymmetric construction can be said to abide by general cross-linguistic tendencies as well since the negative auxiliary precedes the lexical verb which is to be negated.

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

2.2.1 Negative commands

Negative commands can be formed in several ways: (i) By adding the particle *ne* to a positive imperative as in (5b), and (ii) By a compound complex predicate which includes an auxiliary and a lexical verb or a proposition to be negated introduced by the conjunction *da*. In fact, this construction is exactly the same as the one used to negate verbal clauses in the future. There are several different verbs or specific verb forms that can be used as prohibitive auxiliaries: *nedej* ‘do not/don’t’, *nemoj* ‘not.be.able.to.2SG.IMP’, *njama* ‘negative existential’ and also *stiga* ‘enough’, see (5c), (5d), (5e) for some illustrations. This prohibitive formed by a complex predicate is hereafter referred to as the *complex predicate prohibitive*; whenever a specific sub-construction is discussed it is referred by citing auxiliary in question, for instance the *nedej*-prohibitive. Discussion on the diachronic origins of the prohibitive auxiliaries is offered in §4.6.5.

- (5) Imperative vs. prohibitives
- a. Тичай!
 Tič-aj!
 run.IPFV-2SG.IMP
 ‘Run!’ (constructed example)

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- b. Не тичай!
 Ne tič-aj!
 NEG run.IPFV-2SG.IMP
 ‘Do not run!’ (constructed example)
- c. Недей да тичаш!
 Nedej da tič-aš!
 do_not.2SG.IMP CONJ run.IPFV-2SG.PRS
 ‘Do not run!’ (constructed example)
- d. Няма да тичаш с празни ръце.
 Njama da tič-aš s prazni rətse
 NEGEX CONJ run.IPFV-2SG.PRS with empty.PL hand.PL
 ‘Don’t run with empty hands’ (literal translation ‘You won’t run with empty hands.’) (Bulgarian National Corpus)
- e. Стига си тичал!
 Stiga si tič-al
 enough be.2SG.PRS run.IPFV-PST.PTCP.M.SG
 ‘Stop running/enough running/do not run!’ (constructed example).

Counts in the Bulgarian National Corpus indicate that the regularly negated imperative as in (5b), is definitely more frequent than the *complex predicate prohibitives* shown in (5c, 5d, 5e). However, the existing variation in the encoding of the prohibitive should still be noted.

A comment on the form *Cmuza/Stiga* shown in (5e) is in order. In Bulgarian dictionaries, see Popov et al. (1994: 925–926), the form *stiga* is classified as a particle used in prohibitive commands. Unlike other admonitive particles such as *haide* ‘come on’ and *neka* ‘let’s’, that have no obvious relation to any lexical items,⁴ the form *stiga* clearly comes from the verb *stigam* ‘arrive, reach, be enough’, see also van der Auwera (2006: 11) citing Greenberg (1996: 166). It is a polysemous word with a number of functions. With some of them, such as being a prohibitive auxiliary or part of a complex subjunction *cmuza da/stiga da* ‘as long as, if’, *stiga* can be described as a word with more general grammatical functions. Since it is also used as a motion verb meaning ‘arrive, reach’, both literally and metaphorically, it clearly belongs to lexicon as well. Morphologically, *stiga* is the third person singular present form of *stigam*. However, this description is relevant only when it is used with its lexical senses; when used with its grammatical functions, it is best described as an invariant form. For this reason, it is probably justified to

⁴The word *hajde* is a borrowing from Turkish.

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classify it as a particle when used as a grammatical item. Seeing as it is clearly still used as with a referential sense as well, its classification becomes a complex task. See further discussion and data on this issue in §4.6.5.

The WALS classification (van der Auwera et al. 2013) of the Bulgarian prohibitive takes into account only the *nedej*-prohibitive; thus Bulgarian is classified in the type *Special imperative + special negative* which is cross-linguistically the most frequent type. In an updated classification Bulgarian should be also classified in the type *Normal imperative + normal negative*, as in (5a-5b) which comes third in cross-linguistic frequency among the four possible types of the prohibitive. Generally, it is safe to say that Bulgarian follows well-established cross-linguistic tendencies for the formation of its prohibitive.

The following can be said as regards aspect in prohibitives. Scatton (1983: 46) notes that negative imperative is not formed from perfective stems. This statement is probably best illustrated by one of the most common commands ‘Come!’ cf. (6a) which is a suppletive perfective form and one of the most frequently used direct commands. It cannot be negated but the corresponding suppletive imperfective has to be used in the prohibitive, cf. (6c). Scatton (1983: 46) also notes that “positive imperatives from perfective stems are stylistically unmarked; positive imperatives from imperfectives carry a sense of urgency”, see (6b).

- (6) a. Ела!
Ela!
come.PFV.2SG.IMP
‘Come!’ (constructed example)
- b. Идвай!
Id-v-aj!
come-IPFV-2SG.IMP
‘Come!’ [with an implication of ‘Come right now/immediately!’]
(constructed example)
- c. Не идвай!
Ne id-v-aj!
NEG come-IPFV-2SG.IMP
‘Don’t come!’ (constructed example)

An example of a regular verb such as *сядам/sjadam* ‘sit’ is shown in (7). The perfective form, cited in (7a), is a neutral invitation to sit. The imperfective form in (7b) is more marked. It may indicate irritation or urgency. Only the imperfective form can be negated, see (7c); the use of the negator with the perfective *sedni*

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in (7d) is ungrammatical. Following Miestamo (2005), this should be classified as a paradigmatic asymmetry.

- (7) a. Седни!
Sed-n-i!
sit-PFV-2SG.IMP
'Sit (down)!' (constructed example)
- b. Сядай!
Sjad-aj!
sit.IPFV-2SG.IMP
'Sit (down) (now)!' (constructed example)
- c. Не сядай!
Ne sjad-aj!
NEG sit.IPFV-2SG.IMP
'Don't sit!' (constructed example)
- d. * Не седни
Ne sed-n-i
NEG sit-PFV-2SG.IMP
Intended reading: 'Don't sit!' (constructed example)

It appears that it is much more common to use the imperfective aspect in the prohibitives and generally under negation. However, as already mentioned in §2.1, the preference for specific aspect categories under negation has to be subject to a more focused study.⁵

There is variation of the *complex predicate prohibitive* see Map 145 in Antonova-Vasileva et al. 2016a.⁶ The observed variation is along several parameters: (i) the

⁵If it is indeed valid that imperfective aspect is the preferred one under negation, then we could say that Bulgarian falls in line with Schmid's (1980) suggestion that such a preference is cross-linguistically common. Unlike Schmid (1980), who does not rely on a stratified sample, Miestamo & van der Auwera (2011) use data from a balanced sample with world coverage. These authors argue that the available cross-linguistic data do not provide any support for a clear preference of either perfective or imperfective aspect under negation. As one of the reviewers points out, while both standard and non-standard Bulgarian seem to conform to generalization that imperfective is preferred under negation, data from a closely related language, Serbian, has constructions similar to (8c) where a perfective verb is used e.g. *Nemoj da se naljutiš* 'Don't be cross'.

⁶The following disclaimer is offered as suggested by one of the reviewers: The value of the Bulgarian Dialect Atlas is in that it displays the entire Eastern South Slavic dialectal continuum. Note, however, that many of the speakers outside the Bulgarian state borders do not consider themselves Bulgarian speakers

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choice of the prohibitive auxiliary, (ii) the form of the negated lexical verb, and (iii) the presence or absence of the conjunction *da*. These parameters are discussed below.

As already stated, the auxiliary in the *complex predicate prohibitive* can be *nedej* ‘don’t do’, *nemoj* ‘not.be.able.to.2SG.IMP’, *njama* ‘not.have’, *stiga* ‘enough’. The forms *nedej* and *nemoj* are restricted to the negative domain without any positive counterparts, see §4.6.5 for further discussion of their origins as well as for reasoning on the grammaticalization of *stiga* as a prohibitive auxiliary.

The form of the negated/prohibited lexical verb can be: (i) modern citation form or a short/truncated infinitive as in (8a); (ii) regular imperative, as in (8b); (iii) an older infinitive as in (8c); or (iv) an active past participle as in (8d).

The forms identified in the Bulgarian Dialect Atlas, Map 145 (Antonova-Vasileva et al. 2016a) are shown in (8) below. The punctuation in the examples follows the punctuation in the source.

- (8) a. Недей/Немой плака.
Nedej/Nemoj plaka.
do.not.2SG.IMP cry.IPFV.SHORT.INFINITIVE
‘Do not cry.’ (Central Eastern dialects, red-pink area on Map 145)
- b. Недей/Немой плачи.
Nedej/nemoj plači.
do.not.2SG.IMP cry.IPFV.IMP
‘Do not cry.’ (Several disparate areas, yellow areas on Map 145)
- c. Немой плакати.
Nemoj plaka-ti.
do.not.2SG.IMP cry.IPFV-INF
‘Do not cry!’ (Southern, red area on Map 145)
- d. Стига плакал.
Stiga plakal.
enough cry.IPFV.ACTIVE.PTCP
‘Do not cry.’⁷ (Western areas, green areas on Map 145)

⁷The glossing in the source is *minalo svēršeno dejatelno pričastie* which should have resulted in a gloss such as PFV.ACTIVE.PTCP. However, as one of the reviewers rightfully points out that the verb is imperfective, hence the change of gloss. It should be noted that it is formed on the aorist stem, which for this particular group of verbs ends in /k/. The imperfective stem ends in /č/ so the imperfective past participle is *плачел/plačel*. As far as I can tell, the latter form is used mostly in evidential constructions.

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- e. Недей/Немой плачеш.

Nedej/nemoj plač-eš.

do.not.2SG.IMP cry.IPFV-2SG.PRS

‘Do not cry.’ (Western dialects, light blue areas on [Map 145](#))

As indicated on [Map 145](#) in [Antonova-Vasileva et al. \(2016b\)](#), the use of a specific auxiliary does not seem to be geographically conditioned, except for the *Stiga*-construction which appears especially common in some non-standard variants west of Sofia. On the other hand, the use of a specific form of the lexical verb does show a geographically conditioned distribution. Specifically, Eastern dialects opt for some form of the infinitive while in the west a finite form of the lexical verb is clearly preferred. The use of a regular imperative in the complex clause prohibitive construction is observed in delimited areas all over the Bulgarian speaking territory. It should be noted that the *njama*-constructions (the negated declarative future) which can be used as a prohibitive is not observed in this function in non-standard variants of Bulgarian as cited by [Antonova-Vasileva et al. \(2016b\)](#).

Hortatives are formed periphrastically using the same template as the one we have seen for the complex predicate prohibitive. The particles *hajde* or *neka* are used as auxiliaries followed by proposition introduced by the subordinating conjunction *da* as in (9a). Another possibility is to omit these particles as in (9b). The construction in (9b) is referred by [Scatton \(1983: 379\)](#) as the *compound imperative*.

- (9) a. Хайде/Нека да тичаме!
 Hajde/Neka da tič-ame!
 Let’s/Let’s CONJ run.IPFV-1PL.PRS
 ‘Let’s run!’ (constructed example)
- b. Да тичаме!
 Da tič-ame!
 CONJ run.IPFV-1PL.PRS
 ‘Let’s run!’ (constructed example)

Both hortative constructions in (9) can be negated by the particle *ne* as shown in (10).

- (10) a. Хайде/Нека да не тичаме!
 Hajde/Neka da ne tič-ame!
 Let’s/Let’s CONJ NEG run.IPFV-1PL.PRS
 ‘Let’s not run!’ (constructed example)

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- b. Да не тичаме!
 Da ne tič-ame!
 CONJ NEG run.IPFV-1PL.PRS
 ‘Let’s not run!’ (constructed example)

Based on the data in (9) and (10) negation in hortatives can be classified as symmetric. It should be noted, however, that usage based data, obtained from searches in the Bulgarian National Corpus and on social media highlight the fact that the particles *neka* and *hajde* differ with regard to their uses under negation and that affirmative and negated hortatives have very different discourse functions. These generalizations are further substantiated below.

First, the particles *neka* and *hajde* are not equal with regard to their uses with negation. In the Bulgarian National Corpus, *neka* shows 2271 hits in contexts of negation while *hajde* occurs with negation about five times less frequently, in 522 contexts.⁸

Second, completely different verbs are used in positive versus negated hortatives. Specifically, positive hortative typically encode expressions of well wishes and good will as illustrated in (11a) and (11b). It should be noted that the constructions in (11a) and (11b), which are fairly common hortatives, are rarely, if ever, negated. Negated hortatives, on the other hand, are often admonitions and mitigated commands, which include verbs such ‘forget’, ‘limit’, ‘hurry’ as in (11c) and (11d). Thus the functions of the positive and the negated hortative are completely different even if their encoding appears symmetric.

(11) Frequently occurring hortatives

- a. Нека да е лято!
 Neka da e ljato!
 let CONJ is summer
 ‘Let it be summer!’ (popular song by the Tonika Family, a music group)
- b. Хайде да поговорим.
 Hajde da po-govor-im.
 let’s CONJ IPFV-talk.IPFV-1PL.PRS
 ‘Let us talk.’ (social media)

⁸Searches in social media yield even more striking proportions, specifically 20 600 000 for *neka* with negation and 3 900 000 hits for *hajde*. However, since the data on social media are not as controlled as the data in the Bulgarian National Corpus, it is probably safer to rely on the frequencies obtained from the latter

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- c. Хайде да не бързаме.
 Hajde da ne bərz-ame.
 let's CONJ NEG hurry.IPFV-1PL.PRS
 'Let's not hurry.' (social media)
- d. Нека (да) не забравяме...
 Neka (da) ne zabrav-jame...
 let's (CONJ) NEG forget-1PL.PRS
 'Let's not forget...' (social media)

A comment on the use of the use of the conjunction *da* together with *neka* is in order. The examples in (11a) and in (11d) may give the impression that it is obligatory in the affirmative and optional with negation. This is not the case: the conjunction *da* is optional in both contexts but it would be odd to leave it out in (11a) which is a lyric from a song, highly entrenched for the generation who know the group.

2.2.2 Negative questions

Polar questions are formed by the question particle *li* which follows the main verb in the clause and is typically clause final. Negative polar questions can be formed by either the standard negator *ne* or by the negative existential *njama*; their use follows the restriction to non-future vs. future tense as described in §2.1. The negators *ne* and *njama* can be used as short negative answers as well, see examples (12), (13), (14). The repetition of the full verb sentence in all answers is optional and a matter of politeness: the more complete the answer, the higher the degree of politeness.

- (12) A: Пишеш ли?
 Piš-eš li?
 write.IPFV-2SG.PRS Q
 'Are you writing?'
 B: Не, не пиша.
 Ne, ne piš-a.
 No, NEG write.IPFV-1SG.PRS
 'No, I am not writing.' (constructed example)
- (13) A: Не пишеш ли?
 Ne piš-eš li?
 NEG write.IPFV-2SG.PRS Q
 'Are you not writing?'

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B: Не, (не пиша).
 Ne, (ne piš-a).
 No, (NEG write.IPFV-1SG.PRS)
 ‘No, I am not (writing).’ (constructed example)

(14) A: Няма ли да дойдеш?
 Njama li da dojd-eš?
 NEGEX Q CONJ come.PFV-2SG.PRS
 ‘Aren’t you going to come?’

B1 Не, няма (да дойда).
 Ne, njama (da dojd-a).
 No, NEGEX (CONJ come.PFV-1SG.PRS)
 ‘No, I won’t /No, I am not going to come.’ (constructed example)

B2 Няма.
 Njama.
 NEGEX
 ‘No, I won’t.’ (constructed example)

Negative polar questions can also be formed by using the particle *nima* as in (15). Such questions express either surprise, (15a), or are rhetorical in nature, cf. (15b). They belong to formal registers or high literary style as for instance, poetry.⁹

(15) a. Нима не ги беше видял никой?
 Nima ne gi beše vid-jal nikoj?
 NEG.Q NEG 3PL.OBJ be.3SG.IMPF see.PFV-PTCP.PST.M.SG nobody
 ‘Didn’t anyone see them?’ (Popov et al. 1983: 46)

b. Нима така поета люби?
 Nima taka poet-a ljub-i?
 NEG.Q so poet.M.SG-DEF.M.SG love-3SG.PRS
 ‘A poet does not love this way.’ (lit. ‘Doesn’t the poet love this way?’¹⁰) (Popov et al. 1983: 46)

⁹The example in (15b) is from a famous Bulgarian poet, Pencho Slaveykov, who was active at the turn of the 19th and beginning of the 20th century. He remains a significant, debated and controversial figure in Bulgarian literature. The line cited by Popov et al. (1983) is from the poem *Izgorata na Šemzedin Hafisa* / ‘The love of Šemzedin Hafisa’.

¹⁰A generic use of the definite article is a characteristic feature of several Balkan languages.

2.3 Negation in stative predications

Predications of identity, class membership and property assignment are negated by the standard negator *ne*. Even though negation in these predications is structurally identical to negation in verbal predications, it is functionally different in that it is mostly used for contrastive purposes cf. (16b), see also [Mettouchi \(2006\)](#) for the contrastive uses of negation in ascriptive predications. Constrative negation is further discussed in §4.1 and §4.6.2.

- (16) a. Стефан ми е брат.
 Stefan mi e brat.
 Stefan 1SG.DAT/POSS is brother
 ‘Stefan is my brother’ (lit. Stefan is a brother to me.) (constructed example)
- b. Стефан не ми е брат, ами братовчед.
 Stefan ne mi e brat, ami bratovčed.
 Stefan NEG 1SG.DAT/POSS is brother, but cousin
 ‘Stefan is not my brother, he is my cousin’ (lit. Stefan is not a brother to me, but a cousin.) (constructed example)
- c. Стефан е висок.
 Stefan e visok.
 Stefan is tall.M.SG
 ‘Stefan is tall.’ (constructed example)
- d. Стефан не е висок.
 Stefan ne e visok.
 Stefan NEG is tall.M.SG
 ‘Stefan is not tall.’ (constructed example)

Locative predications can be negated either by the particle *ne* or by the negative existential *njama* as shown in (17).

- (17) a. Тодор (си) е в къщи.
 Todor (si) e v kăšti.
 Todor (REFL) is in at.home
 ‘Todor is at home.’ (constructed example)
- b. Тодор не (си) е в къщи, (а на кино)
 Todor ne (si) e v kăšti (a na kino).
 Todor NEG (REFL) is in at.home (but at cinema)
 ‘Todor is not at home (but at the movies).’ (constructed example)

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- c. Тодор го няма в къщи.
 Todor go njama v kăšti.
 Todor 3SG.OBJ NEGEX in at.home
 ‘Todor is not at home.’ (constructed example)

Some noteworthy facts about negation of locative predications are as follows:
 (i) The reflexive marker in (17a) and (17b) is optional which is why it is within brackets; its addition makes the sentence more informal. (ii) Negation by the SN marker *ne* can be used with contrastive focus as indicated in (17b). When the negative existential *njama* is used, there is no such possibility. The information that Todor is at some place other than home has to be supplied in a new clause. This falls in line with a general cross-linguistic tendency for negative existentials to be mutually exclusive with focus (cf. [Veselinova 2013b](#)). (iii) When the negative existential *njama* is used for the negation of locative predications, the subject has to be marked with an object clitic as shown in (17c). If the locative adverbial *v kăšti* is omitted, the sentence would still be grammatical. However, depending on the situation, the utterance may mean either that Todor is absent from a specific location, which can be deduced from context, or that Todor is dead.

Predications of existence and possession are negated by the negative existential *njama* which replaces pertinent forms of the habeo verb *ima* ‘have’.

- (18) a. Има питомни лъвове.
 Ima pitomn-i ləv-ove.
 have.3SG.PRS tame-PL lion-PL
 ‘There are tame lions.’ / ‘Tame lions exist’ (constructed example)
- b. Няма питомни лъвове.
 Njama pitomn-i ləv-ove.
 NEGEX.3SG.PRS tame-PL lion-PL
 ‘There are no tame lions.’ / ‘Tame lions do not exist’ (constructed example)
- c. (Ние) имаме кола.
 (Nie) ima-me kola.
 (1PL) have-1PL.PRS car.F.SG
 ‘We have a car.’ (constructed example)
- d. (Ние) нямаме кола.
 (Nie) njama-me kola.
 (1PL) not.have-1PL.PRS car.F.SG
 ‘We don’t have a car.’ (constructed example)

As indicated by the data (18a) and (18b), the existential predicate, either affirmative or negative is clause initial, which is a marked position for a predicate in Bulgarian. Furthermore, it has defective morphology in that it appears in a frozen third person singular form; it does not inflect for number but does inflect for tense. Conversely, when used in possessive predications as in (18c) and (18d), both the affirmative *ima* and the negative *njama* occur in clause-medial position and agree with their syntactic subjects. It is easy to see that the negative existential *njama* is a univerbation between the negator *ne* and the verb *ima*. However, as discussed in §4.6.5, *njama* is a single meaningful unit; it is not justified to postulate two morphemes in it.

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Negation in non-main clauses is encoded in the same way as negation in main clauses, by *ne* and *njama* as shown in (19).

- (19) Стефан каза че няма да кара защото не е спал.
 Stefan каза če njama da kara zaštoto ne e
 Stefan said that NEGEX CONJ drive.3SG.PRS because NEG be.3SG.PRS
 spal.
 sleep.M.SG.PST.PTCP
 ‘Stefan said he wouldn’t drive because he hadn’t slept’ (constructed
 example)

The closest equivalent to dependent non-finite clauses in Bulgarian are constructions which are headed by a form labeled *active adverbial participle*/Bulgarian *деенпичастие*. It is formed from the present/imperfective stem of the verb and the suffix *-йку/-jki*. The final vowel of the stem can be either /a/ or /e/; its quality depends on the inflectional class of the verb, see Pärvev (1983: 382) and data in (20).

- (20) Examples of active adverbial participles
- | | | | | | |
|----------|----------|------------------------|-----------|------------|-------------|
| каз-в-ам | kaz-v-am | ‘say-IPFV-1SG.PRS’ | казва-йки | kazva-jki | ‘saying’ |
| пея | peja | ‘sing-IPFV.1SG.PRS’ | пее-йки | pee-jki | ‘singing’ |
| вярв-ам | vjarv-am | ‘believe-IPFV.1SG.PRS’ | вярва-йки | vjarva-jki | ‘believing’ |

This active adverbial participle is used to indicate action that is often simultaneous with the action indicated by the main verb; the clause headed by it is described as an adverbial constituent (cf. Popov et al. 1983: 238–239). Dependent non-finite clauses are negated by the SN marker *ne* as shown in (21).

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- (21) Не вярвайки на собствените си очи, аз се приближих до будката.
 Ne vjarv-ajki na sobstven-i-te si oči, az se
 NEG believe-ADV.PTCP PREP OWN-PL-DEF.PL REFL eyes, I REFL
 približ-ix do budka-ta.
 approach.PFV-PST PREP kiosk-DEF.F
 ‘Not believing my own eyes, I approached to the kiosk.’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)

It has to be said that non-finite clauses headed by a gerund-like form are negated very seldom. Out of the 205061 hits of such clauses in the Bulgarian National corpus, there are only 1279 where the active adverbial participle (деепричастие) is negated.¹¹

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

Negative lexicalizations include negative existential *njama* and the special prohibitive forms *nedej* and *nemoj*, cf. §2.2 as well as §2.3 for examples. In addition, there is a special form *невем/nevem* ‘I don’t know’ observed in the non-standard dialect of Trojan (Balkan Mountain, Central Bulgaria), cf. Georgiev et al. (1971: v.4:585).

All of these lexicalizations fall in line with the cross-linguistic generalizations outlined for this phenomenon, cf. Veselinova (2013a). The origin of these lexicalizations is discussed in §4.6.5.

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative replies

Both the standard negator *ne* as well as the negative existential *njama* can be used as short negative replies. Examples (12–13) above show *ne* in this function while (22) illustrates the same for *njama*, see also discussion and data in 2.2.2.

¹¹The seed for the corpus search uses the morphological tagging of the Bulgarian National Corpus. Thus I used a regular expressions including the tag for active adverbial participle, **pos=v ivf=z* to locate dependent clauses headed by it. That yields 205601 hits. To locate such clauses in the context of negation I used *‘не *pos=v ivf=z’*. This yields 1488 hits; however in 209, we do not observe negation of the active adverbial participle; rather the dependent clause occurs after a standalone negative answer or precedes a negated constituent such as a negated object or a place adverbial.

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- (22) A: Ще дойдеш ли?
 Šte dojd-eš li?
 FUT come.PFV-2SG.PRS Q
 ‘Are you going to come?’
 B: Не/Няма!
 Ne/Njama!
 NEG/NEGEX
 ‘No!’ (constructed example)

To change the polarity of a negative question, as in (13), the adverb/sentence tag *naprotiv* ‘on the contrary’ must be used. The affirmative particle *da* ‘yes’ cannot be used in answers to negative polarity questions.

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

Negative indefinite pronouns are formed by prefixing the particle or prefix *ni* to content question words such as *koj* ‘who’, *kakvo* ‘what’, *kakъв* ‘what.ADJ’, *kъде* ‘where’, *кога/кога* ‘when’ etc. Some examples are shown in (23).

- (23) Negative indefinite pronouns
 никой/nikoj ‘no one’
 никакъв/nikakъв ‘none’
 никъде/nikъде ‘nowhere’
 никога/nikoga ‘never’

The forms listed in (23) inflect according to number and gender of their referent when applicable. In addition to these forms, there is also the negative quantifier *нищо/ništo* ‘nothing’ which is a lexicalized form resulting from the fusion of *ni* and *što* ‘what’. The form *što* is used as a question word in fixed phrases and non-standard variants of Bulgarian only; *kakvo* ‘what’ is the standard content question word.

Indefinite pronouns co-occur with predicate negation as demonstrated in (24). On this parameter Bulgarian follows a wide-spread cross-linguistic tendency (cf. Haspelmath 2013).

- (24) Никой никъде няма да ходи.
 Nikoj nikъде njama da xodi.
 no.one no.where NEGEX CONJ go.IPFV.3SG.PRS
 ‘No one will go anywhere.’ (constructed example)

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3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

Case marking is not relevant for Bulgarian, therefore, only derivation is discussed in this section. Negative derivation is done by using the particle *ne* and by the preposition *bez* ‘without’. The particle *ne* is typically prefixed to a positive stem, see data in (25). The suffixes *-u6/iv* and *-en/-en* are used for the derivation of adjectives regardless of polarity, that is they derive both affirmative and negative adjectives.

- (25) Negative derivations by using the particle *ne* (constructed examples)

щастие	šťastie	‘happiness, bliss’
нещастие	ne-šťastie	‘misery, a stroke of bad luck’
справедлив	spravedliv	‘just’
несправедлив	ne-spravedliv	‘unjust, partial’
доволен	dovolen	‘content, happy, satisfied’
недоволен	ne-dovolen	‘unhappy, dissatisfied’

The derivational operation shown in (25) is very productive. As is common with derivation, there are also cases of mismatches. For instance, the derivation of *ne-šťasten* ‘unhappy’ presents an example of a stem mismatch since it is derived from a stem different from the one used for its positive correspondent *šťastliv* ‘happy’. A semantic mismatch can be exemplified by the derivation of *neumoren* ‘energetic, somebody who never gets tired’ from *umoren* ‘tired’. The positive adjective refers to a resulting state, the derived negative adjective refers to a constant property of a person’s disposition; thus even if there is a seeming symmetry in form, the senses of the two lexemes do not form an opposition.

Privative or caritive marking is encoded by prepositional phrases where the preposition *bez* ‘without’ is used together with a nominal; the resulting prepositional phrase indicates the absence of that nominal. These prepositional phrases are further univerbated and used as bases for the derivation of adjectives with a similar meaning as shown in data in (26).

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(26) Privative expressions with *bez*

- a. без дом → бездомен
bez dom → bez-dom-en
without home → without-home-ADJ
'without (a) home' → 'homeless' (Stojanov et al. 1983: 156)
- b. без смисъл → безсмислен
bez smisəl → bez-smisl-en
without sense → without-sense-ADJ
'without (a) sense' → 'senseless' (following Stojanov et al. 1983: 156)
- c. без съвест → безсъвестен
bez səvest → bez-səvest-en
without conscience → without-conscience-ADJ
'without (a) conscience/scruples' → 'unscrupulous' (following Stojanov et al. 1983: 156)
- d. без утеха → безутешен
bez uteha → bez-uteš-en
without consolation → without-consolation-ADJ
'without (a) consolation' → 'inconsolable' (following Stojanov et al. 1983: 156)

The preposition *bez* 'without' can be also prefixed directly to some adjectives as shown in (27).

- (27) полезен¹² → безполезен
polezen → bez-polezen
useful → without-useful
'useful' → 'useless' (constructed example)

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

The scope of negative markers may differ. When used as SN, the particle *ne* typically scopes over the entire proposition as in (28). The same applies for the negative lexicalizations listed in §2.5.

¹²The adjective *polezen* 'useful' is a derivation from *polza* 'use' by adding an epenthetic vowel to the stem and the adjectivizer *-en*.

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- (28) Не знам какво да кажа.
 Ne znam kakvo da kaža.
 NEG know.1SG.PRS what CONJ say.1SG.PRS
 ‘I do not know what to say.’ (constructed example)

The particle *ne* can be also used with a narrow scope, that is, as a constituent negator. For instance, in (29), it scopes only the adverbial phrase *na šega*, ‘as a joke’ rendering the sense ‘not as a joke’. Other negative particles with narrow scope include *ni* and *nito*, cf (37b) in §4.4 below.

- (29) Райко се уплаши не на шега и взе да се взира отново в шумата.
 Rajko se u-plaši ne na šega i vze da
 Rajko REFL PFV-be.scared.3SG.PST NEG on joke and take.PFV.3SG.PST CONJ
 se vzira otново v šuma-ta.
 REFL stare.PFV.3SG.AOR again in forest.leaves.F.SG-DEF.SG.F
 ‘Rajko was scared, not as a joke, and started staring into the forest leaves again.’ *Stojanov et al. (1983: 492)*

In many cases of contrastive negation, the negated construction is emphasized by a special intonation as it would be in (30) when spoken. However, I cannot think of cases where the contrast is achieved by prosodic means only. *Lashkova (1980)* offers a detailed discussion on the use of negation and parsing of the predication.

- (30) Казах ти да купиш пиле, не петел!
 Kaza-x ti da kup-iš pile, ne petel!
 say-AOR.1SG 2SG.DAT SUB.CONJ buy-2SG chicken, NEG rooster!
 ‘I told you to buy a chicken, not a rooster!’ (constructed example)

4.2 Negative polarity

In the strict sense of a negative polarity item, that is, words which only occur with negation and other irrealis contexts, Bulgarian has only two, *gək* and *hič* ‘none, not at all’.¹³ In addition, there are two adverbs *izobšto/vəobšte* ‘generally, at all, (ever)’ that are used very frequently in irrealis contexts which is why it is fitting to mention them when negative polarity items are discussed.

The form *gək* occurs exclusively in negative contexts and typically together with the emphatic negators *nito* or *ni*.

¹³I am very grateful the reviewer who brought up *hič*, which I had missed, and likewise prompted me to examine the adverbs *izobšto/vəobšte*.

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- (31) Стефан не каза нито гък цяла вечер.
 Stefan ne kaza nito gək tsjala večer.
 Stefan NEG say.PFV.3SG.AOR NEG.EMPH gək entire evening
 ‘Stefan did not say a single word the entire evening.’ (constructed example)

In the Bulgarian Etymological Dictionary (Georgiev et al. 1971: v. 1: 300), *gək* is described as an onomatopoetic form. I am not aware of any referential meaning of this word. It occurs mostly with verbs of utterance such as *кажа/kaža* ‘say’ or the more archaic *пека/reka* ‘say’. Occasionally, it is also observed with the verb of hearing *чувам/čuvam* ‘hear’ as shown in (32) where *gək* is used in a ban to utter any kind of sound/say anything.

- (32) Да не чувам нито гък!
 Da ne ču-v-am nito gək!
 CONJ NEG hear-IPFV-1SG.PRS NEG.EMPH gək!
 ‘May I not hear a single word/sound!’ = ‘Not a single sound!’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)

The form *gək* is described in Bulgarian dictionaries as an interjection. It has to be said that it invariably occurs in an object position, so based on syntactic criteria, it can also be said to have nominal properties. This contrasts with the form *hič* ‘none, not at all’ which is always used in a modifying function and is thus classified as an adverb, see also Dictionary of the Bulgarian Language (Bulgarian Academy of Sciences 1993). It is a loan from Turkish. Some examples follow in (33).

- (33) a. Хич не ме интересува.
 hič ne me interesuva.
 not.at.all NEG 1SG.ACC interest.IPFV.3SG.PRS
 ‘[it/this] does not interest me at all.’ (Dictionary of the Bulgarian Language Bulgarian Academy of Sciences 1993)
- b. Хич не му мига окото.
 hič ne my miga oko-to.
 not.at.all NEG 3SG.DAT blink.3SG.PRS eye.N.SG-DEF.SG.N
 lit. ‘To him the eye never blinks.’ = ‘He never blinks an eye.’ = ‘He does not care.’ (Dictionary of the Bulgarian Language Bulgarian Academy of Sciences 1993)

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The adverbs *izobšto*/*vəobšte* ‘generally, at all, entirely’ are very close in meaning, with *izobšto* showing a broader polysemy than *vəobšte*, see the entries for *izobšto* and *vəobšte* in the [Dictionary of the Bulgarian Language online](#). Examples are shown in (34) and (35).

- (34) a. Двигателят изгасна и колата изобщо не даваше признаци за живот.
 Dvigatel-jat iz-gas-na i kola-ta
 enginesG.M-DEF.SG.M PFV-extinguish-PST and car.SG.F-DEF.SG.F
 izobšto ne dava-še priznatsi za život.
 not.at.all give.IPFV-IMPF sign-PL indication.PL for life.M.SG
 ‘The engine died and the car showed no signs of life at all.’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)
- b. Но хепатитът често протича изобщо без пожълтяване.
 No hepatit-ət često protiča izobšto bez
 But hepatitisM.SG-DEF.M.SG often occur.IPFV.PRS.3SG at.all without
 po-žəlt-javane.
 PFX-yellow-NMLZ
 ‘But hepatitis often occurs without yellowing at all.’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)
- (35) a. Въобще не се е постарал за това ние да вникнем в дилемата му...
 Vəobšte ne se e postar-al za tova
 at.all NEG REFL be.3SG.PRS make.an.effort-PST.PTCP.M.SG for this
 nie da vnkn-em v dilemma-ta
 1PL CONJ get.an.insight.PFV-1PL.PRS in dilemma.SG.F-DEF.SG.F
 mu...
 3SG.DAT/POSS
 ‘[Apparently] [he] made no effort for us to get an insight into his dilemma...’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)
- b. Въобще селото изглежда като след война.
 Vəobšte selo-to izgležda kao sled vojna.
 at.all village.SG.N-DEF.SG.N look.like.IPFV.PRS.3SG like after war
 ‘Generally, the village looks like after a war.’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)

As mentioned above, both *izobšto* and *vəobšte* are very frequently used in irrelevant contexts. Analyses of their contextual preference based on random samples

of 200 sentences extracted from the Bulgarian National Corpus are presented in Table 1.

Table 1: Contexts of use for *izobšto* and *vəobšte* in a random sample of 200 sentences

Context	<i>izobšto</i>	<i>vəobšte</i>
negative/irrealis	74,50%	67%
positive	25,50%	33%
	100%	100%

As indicated in Table 1, in one-fourth of its uses, *izobšto* appears in positive contexts; this is valid for one-third of the uses *vəobšte*. Both adverbs show a clear preference for negative/irrealis contexts but they are also used often enough in the affirmative domain. This, in turn, precludes classifying them as full-fledged negative polarity items. In contrast, *gak* and *hič* are entirely restricted to the negative domain.

4.3 Marking of NPs under the scope of negation

Noun phrases under the scope of negation do not receive any special marking as shown by the data in (36a) and (36b). The only exception is the subject of a negated locative predication when the negative existential is used for its negation. In that case, the subject is marked by an object clitic, cf. example (17c) and pertinent discussion.

Full noun phrases in object position follow the predicate and the standard negator as shown in (36b). The following can be said about pronominal objects. In affirmative sentences, they occur between the overt subject and the predicate as in (36c). If the subject is dropped as in (36d), the object pronoun follows the verb. In negated sentences, pronominal objects are placed between the negator and the lexical verb as in (36e). There is dialectal variation on this parameter. Within the entire Southeastern Slavic continuum, the pronoun is placed before the entire predicate phrase as in (36f) mainly in Central-Western varieties with a single pocket to the East, see blue areas on Map 143 (Antonova-Vasileva et al. 2016b). It is noteworthy that the varieties where the pronominal object occurs between the negator and the predicate surround the varieties where it is placed before the negator.

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- (36) a. *Аз чувам телефона.*
Az ču-v-am telefon-a.
 1SG hear-IPFV-1SG.PRS telefon-DEF.M.SG
 ‘I hear the phone.’ = ‘I am hearing the phone ring.’ (constructed example)
- b. *Не чувам телефона.*
Ne ču-v-am telefon-a.
 NEG hear-IPFV-1SG.PRS phone.M.SG-DEF.M.SG
 ‘I don’t hear the phone’ (constructed example)
- c. *Аз те чувам.*
Az te ču-v-am.
 1SG 2SG.OBJ hear-IPFV-1SG.PRS
 ‘I hear you.’ (constructed example)
- d. *Чувам те.*
ču-v-am te.
 hear-IPFV-.1SG.PRS 2SG.OBJ
 ‘I hear you.’ (constructed example)
- e. *Аз не те чувам.*
Az ne te ču-v-am.
 1SG NEG 2SG.OBJ hear-IPFV-1SG.PRS
 ‘I don’t hear you.’ (Central Eastern dialects within Bulgarian territory, red areas on the [Map 143](#) in [Antonova-Vasileva et al. 2016b](#))
- f. *Аз те не чувам.*
Az te ne ču-v-am.
 1SG 2SG.OBJ NEG hear-IPFV-1SG.PRS
 ‘I don’t hear you.’ (Western dialects within Bulgarian territory, blue areas on the [Map 143](#) in [Antonova-Vasileva et al. 2016b](#))

The data presented in [Antonova-Vasileva et al. \(2016b\)](#) include only sentences with overt subject. In standard Bulgarian, the only possibility is for the object pronoun to occur in between the negator and the predicate even when the subject is not overtly expressed, e.g. *He me чувам/Ne te ču-v-am*, similarly to (36e).

4.4 Reinforcing negation

There are various ways to reinforce negation: by the special emphatic negative markers *ni* and *nito* as in (37), by topicalizing a negated object as shown in (37a),

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by indefinite pronouns and negative concord as in (38), and by the use of a minimizer together with *nito* or *ni*, see (31) and (32) above and (39) below. The use of the adverb *hič* ‘not at all’ is another strategy to reinforce negation, see (33) in §4.2.

The special emphatic negative markers *ni* and *nito* are used together with the predicate negator as in (37). They are frequently used in coordinated constructions, cf §4.5. The negative structures they produce are, however, always emphatic.

- (37) a. Ни думица горката му невеста не смея да каже.
 Ni dum-itsa gorka-ta mu nevesta ne
 NEG.EMPH word-DIM.F poor.F.SG-DEF.F.SG 3SG.M.DAT bride NEG
 смея да каже.
 dare.PFV.3SG.AOR CONJ say.IPFV.3SG.AOR
 ‘Not a single little word did his poor bride dare say.’ (Stojanov et al. 1983: 492)
- b. Не чакай нито минута!
 Ne čak-aj nito minuta!
 NEG wait-IMP.2SG NEG.EMPH minute
 ‘Do not wait a single minute!’ (constructed example)
- (38) a. Никой нищо не знае.
 Nikoj ništo ne znae.
 nobody nothing NEG know.3SG.PRS
 ‘No one knows anything/a single thing’ (constructed example)
- b. Нищо не чувам
 Ništo ne ču-v-am.
 nothing NEG hear-IPFV-1SG.PRS
 ‘I don’t hear no nothing.’ (constructed example)
- (39) Тя не хапва нито трошичка.
 Tja ne хар-v-a nito troš-ička.
 3SG.F NEG bite-IPFV-3SG.PRS NEG.EMPH crumb-DIM.F.SG
 ‘She does not eat anything.’
 lit. ‘She does not bite a single little crumb.’ (constructed example)

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

Bulgarian has a special construction for emphatic negative coordination. Following Salaberri (2022: 664, in passim), it can be classified as having an ENC construc-

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tion encoded by the particles *nito...nito* or their shortened variant *ni...ni*. They can be the sole predicate negator as in (40a) or appear together with predicate negation as in (40b). In this respect, Bulgarian differs from a closely related language, Croatian (ISO: *hrv*, Glottocode: *croat1245*), where the longer and the shorter variants of the construction have different distributional properties. Specifically, in Croatian, the longer variant, *niti...niti* scopes over the entire predication while the shorter one, *ni...ni* is used for the negation of noun phrases only, see *Salaberri* (2022: 670) citing *van der Auwera & Krasnoukhova* (2020). In Bulgarian the shorter variant *ni...ni* can be also used for predicate negation, see (40c) below.¹⁴

- (40) a. Нито съм го чула, нито съм го видяла.
 Nito səm go ču-la, nito səm
 ENC be.1SG.PRS 3SG.OBJ hear.PFV-PST.PTCP.F.SG ENC be.1SG.PRS
 go vid-jala.
 3SG.OBJ see.PFV-PST.PTCP.F.SG
 ‘I have neither heard, nor seen him.’ (constructed example)
- b. Не искам нито едното, нито другото.
 Ne iska-m nito edno-to, nito drugo-to.
 NEG want-1SG.PRS ENC one.N.SG-DEF.N.SG ENC other.N.SG-DEF.N.SG
 ‘I don’t want either one or the other.’ (constructed example)
- c. Стъкленият блясък в очите на Гъси говореше, че ни приема, ни предава.
 Stəkl-en-ijat bljasək v oči-te na Gəsi
 glass-ADJ.M.SG-DEF.M.SG glint in eye.PL-DEF.PL PREP Gussie
 govore-še, če ni priem-a, ni predav-a
 speak-IMPF.3SG that ENC accept-PRS.3SG ENC send.out-PRS.3SG
 ‘The glassy look in Gussie’s eyes suggested he neither took in [anything], nor was he communicating.’ (lit. ‘The glassy glint in Gussie’s eyes spoke to [the fact] that he was neither accepting [anything], nor was he sending out [anything].’ (Bulgarian National Corpus))

In *Salaberri*’s (2022) classification, Bulgarian falls into the most populated $\alpha 1$ type since the ENC construction is expressed by correlative markers without the addition of any other element.

¹⁴The differences between Bulgarian and Croatian might be correlated with the fact that Croatian, unlike Bulgarian has a special negation strategy for identification and property predications which is also closely connected to special strategies for contrastive negation.

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

In this section I discuss negative transport in §4.6.1, contrastive negation, §4.6.2 and metalinguistic negation, §4.6.3. Non-negative uses of negation markers are presented in §4.6.4. I also offer a brief discussion on the origin of some of the expressions of negation discussed in this article in §4.6.5.

4.6.1 Negative transport

The phenomenon of negative transport refers to the interpretation of negation in a complex clause structure. Specifically, the marking of negation in the higher/main clause is interpreted as negation scoping over the predicate of the subordinate clause. For instance, in English, when verbs such as *think*, *believe*, *expect* are negated as predicates in the main clause, the implication is that their complement clause is negated as in *I don't think they will come*=*I think they will not come*.

Negative transport does not occur in Bulgarian. In (41a) below the negator scopes over the act of thinking, not over the action described in the subordinate clause. To negate that action, the negator has to be placed in the subordinate clause as in (41b).

- (41) a. Не мисля че ще дойдат.
 Ne misl-ja če šte dojd-at.
 NEG think.IPFV-1SG.PRS that FUT come.PFV-3PL.PRS
 ‘I don’t think they will come.’ (constructed example)
- b. Мисля че няма да дойдат.
 Misl-ja če njama da dojd-at.
 think.IPFV-1SG.PRS that NEGEX CONJ come.PFV-3PL.PRS
 ‘I think they will not come’ (constructed example)

4.6.2 Contrastive negation

As discussed in §4.1, several of the already mentioned expressions of negation, the SN marker *ne* as well as *nito/ni* can be used for the encoding of *contrastive negation*, that is, the opposition between a negated element and an alternative. This is shown in (42) where the SN marker *ne* is used as a constituent negator; see (40b) for an examples of *nito...nito* as both a constituent and a contrastive negator.

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- (42) Следобед пия чай, не кафе.
 Sledobed pi-ja čaj, ne kafe.
 Afternoon drink.IPFV-1SG.PRS tea NEG coffee
 ‘In the afternoon, I drink tea, not coffee’ (constructed example)

As noted in §2.3, when the SN marker *ne* is used as an ascriptive negator, it is also typically marking contrastive negation as well, see (16b) as well as pertinent discussion in [Mettouchi \(2006\)](#), also [Mettouchi \(2021\)](#)¹⁵.

4.6.3 Metalinguistic negation

Metalinguistic negation is shown in (43). By using negation the speaker objects to the choice of *časovnik* ‘clock’, a term for a broader category, and opts for the more specific term *budilnik* ‘alarm clock’ which is a subcategory of the broader one.

- (43) Не часовник, ами цял будилник ще ти намеря.
 Ne časovnik, ami tjal budilnik šte ti namerja.
 NEG clock, but whole alarm_clock FUT 2SG.OBL find.1SG.PRS
 lit. ‘Not a clock, but I will find you a whole alarm clock’ =
 ‘Not [just] a clock, but I will find you an alarm clock’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)

4.6.4 Non-negative uses of negatives and expletive negation

Expletive negation refers to the use of a negative marker when no negative meaning is intended. Among the expressions of negation discussed in this article, only *ne* can be used as an expletive negator. This is typically triggered by the adverbial subjunction *dokato* ‘until’ as shown in (44)¹⁶.

- (44) Няма да тръгна докато не заспиш.
 Njama da tragna dokato ne za-spi-š.
 NEGEX CONJ leave.PFV.1SG.PRS until NEG PFV-sleep-2SG.PRS
 ‘I won’t leave until you fall asleep’ (constructed example)

Negative polar questions shown in (45) and also (12–15) are also often interpreted as rhetorical questions; in these cases the negative markers used in them

¹⁵ [Mettouchi 2021](#) suggests the term *attributive-equative* for this kind of negator.

¹⁶ See [Zhereva \(2012\)](#) for further discussion of non-negative uses of negation markers in Bulgarian.

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ne and *nima* can be said to have a non-negative function. Or we could say that the entire negative question is used to convey a non-negative meaning (Matti Miestamo, p.c.).

(45) Не улових ли те два пъти?

Ne u-lov-ix li te dva pət-i?

NEG PFV-catch-1SG.PST Q 2SG.OBJ two.M way.M-PL

‘I caught you twice.’ (lit. ‘Did I not catch you twice’) (Stojanov et al. 1983: 492)

4.6.5 Diachronic notes and observations

In this section I present diachronic information about some of the negation markers discussed in this chapter and also outline hypotheses about their development. I start with a discussion on the evolution of *Stiga* as a prohibitive auxiliary, proceed with the lexicalizations of negation, and close with a discussion on the non-operation of the Negative Existential Cycle in Bulgarian although examining the modern data only would suggest otherwise.

The following can be said about the form *stiga*. Morphologically, it is the third person singular present of the verb *stigam* which is a polysemous verb. One of its senses is motion ‘reach, arrive’, another is ‘reach to X, be able to touch’. Yet another sense is ‘be enough, be satisfied’, for this sense the verb is used with a dative subject. The regular imperative *stigaj* occurs only with the sense of motion, e.g. reaching a specific place; it is form of very low frequency, with only 18 occurrences in the Bulgarian National Corpus.

The form *Stiga* is formally part of the paradigm of the verb *stigam* ‘1. reach, arrive; 2. be enough’. Yet, it is best described as a special form, split from this verb. In Bulgarian dictionaries it is described as a particle. It is used to indicate that the action performed by the listener should stop immediately, its literal meaning is ‘Enough!/End!’. It is the most frequent form of this verb. In the Bulgarian National Corpus a search for all forms of the verb *stigam* yields 46 904 hits. Among them, the form *stiga* alone occurs 32 999 times, so 70% of all occurrences of *stigam*. The uses of the form *stiga* are examined in greater detail based on a random sample of 200 sentences extracted from all hits with the randomizing tool of SketchEngine. The analysis of the random sample allows for the postulation of four broad categories/groups. The first group covers examples where *stiga* is used as a prohibitive auxiliary as in (5e), see also (47). The second group includes examples where it is part of a complex conjunction *stiga da* ‘as long as, if’ shown in (46a). The third group covers examples where *stiga* is used as a

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verb of motion that includes the reaching of a goal ‘reach, arrive’, either literally or metaphorically, see (46b). The fourth group includes examples where *stiga* is used with the sense ‘enough’ in various constructions, one of which is shown in (46c).

- (46) a. Всяка криза предлага възможности, стига да ги изобретиш.
 Vsjak-a kriza preglaga vȳzmožnost-i, stiga da
 every-SG.F kriza.SG.F offer.IPFV.3SG.PRS opportunity-PL, enough CONJ
 gi izobret-iš.
 3PL.OBJ invent.IPFV-2SG.PRS
 ‘Every crisis offers opportunities as long as you invent them.’
 (Bulgarian National Corpus)
- b. До плажната ивица се стига по черен път.
 Do plažna-ta ivitsa se stiga po čeren
 PREP beach.ADJ.SG.F-DEF.SG.F stripe.SG.F REFL reach PREP blackSG.M
 pət.
 road.SG.M
 ‘The beach is reached by a dirt road.’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)
- c. За тях най-важното е пенсията да им стига за хляб, кисело
 мляко, лекарства, [...].
 Za tjah naj-važno-to e
 for 3PL.OBJ most-important.3SG.N-DEF.3SG.N be.3SG.PRS
 pensija-ta da im stiga za hljab,
 pension.SG.F-DEF.SG.F CONJ 3PL.DAT be.enough.3SG.PRS for bread,
 kiselo mljako, lekarstv-a [...]
 sour.SG.N milk.SG.N, medicine-PL
 ‘For them, the most important thing is that their pension is enough
 for bread, yogurt, medicine,[...]’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)

A summary of the frequency of occurrence of these groups in the random sample is presented in Table 2 below.

As indicated in Table 2, the form *stiga* is used with both grammatical and lexical meanings. Its uses as a prohibitive auxiliary are the most interesting ones here given the topic of this article. *Stiga* is used with this function in close to 40% of the randomized sample. It is observed in several different constructions: in a complex predicate construction as shown in (5e), with nominal constituents as in (47a) or in elliptic sentences on its own as in (47b).

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Table 2: Functions of the form *cmuza/stiga* in a random sample of 200 sentences

Function	Number of hits	Per cent
<i>cmuza /stiga</i> ‘stop, prohibitive auxiliary’	75	37.50%
<i>cmuza ce (do)/stiga se (do)</i> ‘arrive at, reach’	53	26.50%
<i>cmuza da/stiga da</i> ‘as long as, if’	48	24%
<i>cmuza /stiga</i> ‘be enough’ (various constructions)	24	12%
	200	100%

- (47) a. Стига хленчене!
Stiga hlenč-ene!
enough whine-NMLZ
‘Stop whining!’ (lit. ‘enough whining’) (Bulgarian National Corpus)
- b. Айде стига!
Ajde stiga!
c’mon enough
‘Come on, stop!’ (Bulgarian National Corpus)

Conceptually, we can suggest grammaticalization paths such as those outlined in (48) and (49).

- (48) reach, arrive > satisfaction/fullness > stop/end
- (49) reach, arrive > stop/end

The fact that the form *stiga* appears in elliptical sentences with the sense ‘enough/stop’ and also that imperative morphology is preserved for the motion sense suggest that the construal of stopping an action or banning it builds on the sense of reaching satisfaction or fullness rather than on directed motion alone. As pointed out by [van der Auwera \(2006\)](#), the semantic connection between the sense ‘enough’ and prohibition is easy to understand when we think of uses of expressions meaning ‘enough’ which in many languages also indicate that the action should stop. In other words, the synchronic data seem to give more support to (48). However, more research is necessary where historical data are analyzed as well. Besides, as one of the reviewers suggests, the grammaticalization of *stiga* as a prohibitive auxiliary has to be contrasted with the evolution of the complex subjunction *stiga da* ‘as long as, if’.

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The lexicalizations of negation cited in §2.5 together with several of the prohibitive auxiliaries are all fairly transparent univerbations of the negative particle *ne* and a positive stem, see data in (50).

- (50) a. няма/*njama* ‘not.have, not.exist’ < *ne* + Old Church Slavonic имѣти, имамъ, имаши/*iměti*, *imamъ*, *imeši* ‘have, hold’
 Georgiev et al. 1971: v.4:732, see also Old Church Slavonic Online 2020
- b. Недей/*Nedej* ‘do not’ < *ne* + Old Church Slavonic дѣяти, дѣѣ, дѣѣши/*dějati*, *dějō*, *děješi* ‘do, commit’
 Georgiev et al. 1971: v.4:597 see also Old Church Slavonic Online 2020
- c. Немой/*Nemoj* ‘do not’
 < *ne* + Old Church Slavonic мошти, могъ, можеши/*mošti*, *mogō*, *možeši* ‘be able, can’
 Georgiev et al. 1971: v.4:610 see also Old Church Slavonic Online 2020
- d. Невем/*Nevem* ‘I don’t know’
 < *ne* + Old Church Slavonic вѣдѣти, вѣмъ, вѣси/*věděti*, *věmъ*, *věsi* ‘see, know’
 Georgiev et al. 1971: v.4:585 see also Old Church Slavonic Online 2020

It should be noted that although the forms cited in (50) clearly originate from the fusion of two morphemes, synchronically they constitute single meaningful units. As demonstrated by the data in (50), the erstwhile morpheme boundaries have been blurred to various degrees. For instance, any further morphological analysis and morphemic segmentation would be misguided with *njama* ‘not.have, not.exist’. Morpheme boundaries are still discernible with the remaining lexicalizations. However, it has to be said that the stems following the prefixed *ne*, while still having an identifiable sense, are effectively restricted to the forms cited in (50b) through (50d).

Among the lexicalizations listed in (50) only *njama* has a positive counterpart *ima* ‘have.3SG.PRS, exist’. The Old Church Slavonic дѣяти, дѣѣ, дѣѣши *dějati*, *dějō*, *děješi* ‘do, commit’ is not used in the positive in Modern Bulgarian while мошти, могъ, можеши/*mošti*, *mogō*, *možeši* ‘be able can’ survives as the modal verb *moga* ‘be able to, can’ but it does not have an imperative. As for вѣдѣти, вѣмъ, вѣси/*věděti*, *věmъ*, *věsi* ‘see, know’ its stem appears only in compounds or derived forms. Some of them express knowledge/expertise of X as in (51a) and (51b) but many of them are negative derivations, which typically express negative content as in (51c) and (51d).

- (51) a. литератур-о-вед

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- literatur-o-ved
 literature-LINK-expert/one.who.knows
 ‘Literature expert, literature /scholar’ (constructed example)
- b. език-о-вед
 ezik-o-ved
 language-LINK-expert/one.who.knows
 ‘Language expert, language scholar’ / ‘linguist’ (constructed example)
- c. не-вед/не-веж
 ne-ved/ne-vež
 NEG-expert/one.who.knows
 ‘not-knowing, one who does not know, clueless, illiterate’
- d. не-веде-ние
 ne-vede-nie
 NEG-know-NMLZ
 ‘(state of) lack of knowledge, lack of information’

Another issue relevant for the diachrony of negation in Bulgarian is the operation of the Negative Existential Cycle. This diachronic model was first formulated by Croft (1991) to model the evolution of standard negation markers from negative existentials. The synchronic data may suggest that in Bulgarian we observe a partial operation of the cycle because of use of the negative existential *njama* for the negation of verbal predications marked for future tense cf. (3b) above repeated as (55) below for convenience. However, the diachronic data do not support this hypothesis.

As indicated in (52), in Old Church Slavonic there were several ways to encode future tense. One of the affirmative future constructions resulted from the grammaticalization of the verb хотѣти/*xotěti* ‘want’, shown in (52b), into the current particle *уе/šte*, shown in (54). Another Old Church Slavonic future construction involved *имѣти* ‘have’ + infinitive of the lexical verb, cf. (52a). This construction, shown in (53), was frequently used with negation, cf. Đorđić (1975: 201). Consequently, the construction we see in Modern Bulgarian in (55) does not result from an expansion of the uses of the negative existential but represents an inherited, modernized version of the Old Church Slavonic construction, cf. Veselinova (2010, 2014, 2016) for detailed discussions.

(52) Different ways to encode future tense periphrastically in Old Church Slavonic

- a. имѣти/*iměti* ‘have’ + infinitive

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- b. хотѣти/xotěti ‘want’ + infinitive
 - c. начати/načati ‘begin’ + infinitive
 - d. бѣждѣ/bǫdǫ ‘be.FUT, become’ + infinitive
- Duridanov 1991*: 418, see also *Slavova (2017)*: 288-294)

- (53) Не иматъ остати съде каменъ на камен-и.
 Ne imat ostati s’de kamen na kamen-i.
 NEG have.3SG.PRS.IND leave.INF here stone PREP stone-M.LOC.SG
 ‘there shall not be left one stone upon another’
Duridanov 1991: 418 citing Mark 13.2 ¹⁷

- (54) Стефан ще тича.
 Stefan šte tiča.
 Stefan FUT run.IPFV.3SG.PRS
 ‘Stefan will run.’ (constructed example)

- (55) Стефан няма да тича.
 Stefan njama da tič-a.
 Stefan NEGEX CONJ run.IPFV-1SG.PRS
 ‘Stefan will not run.’ (constructed example)

Generally, the Bulgarian facts cited above highlight the need to test diachronic hypotheses by diachronic data whenever possible.

5 Summary

Negation in Bulgarian operates on clause, constituent or word level. The language follows several wide-spread cross-linguistic trends: its SN marker is a preverbal particle, it has a special negative existential, several dedicated encodings of the prohibitive and negative indefinite pronouns are abundantly used with predicate negation. A complex predicate construction, seemingly identical to the Balkan subordinate clause construction, is used for the encoding of predications set in the future as well as for several variants of prohibitive and also for the hortative. The negative lexicalizations identified in the language also fall into known cross-linguistic tendencies, namely lexicalizing of expressions for nonexistence,

¹⁷The glossing follows the one offered in the Proiel Project, specifically for this verse, <http://foni.uio.no/proiel/sentences/37108>; note that a registration, free of charge, is required in order to access the data in the project. The translation is cited from the King James Bible Online, <https://thekingsbible.com/Bible/41/13>.

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lack of ability and lack of knowledge. Features that are perhaps typologically less common include the presence of special emphatic negators which also function as coordinative negators as well as the presence of a special negative question particle. However, this conclusion may be subject to revision given that world-wide typologies of these features are still in demand. The main expressions of negation in Bulgarian are summarized in Table 3 below.

Table 3: Expressions of negation in Bulgarian

Negative expression	Word class	Function
<i>не/ne</i>	particle	Standard negation non-future, negative reply, constituent negator, expletive negator
<i>няма/njata</i>	auxiliary, verb	Standard negation future, negative existential, negative reply
<i>недей/nedej</i>	auxiliary	prohibitive auxiliary
<i>немой/немој</i>	auxiliary	prohibitive auxiliary (non-standard variants)
<i>стига/stiga</i> ‘enough’	auxiliary	prohibitive auxiliary
<i>невем/nevet</i>	invariable verb form	‘I don’t know’ (non-standard variant)
<i>нито/ни / nito/ni</i>	particle	emphatic negator, coordinative negator
<i>нима/nima</i>	particle	negative question particle

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Abbreviations

ACTIVE	active	M	masculine
ADJ	adjective	NEG	negation/negator
ADV	adverb(ial)	NEGEX	negative existential
AOR	aorist	NMLZ	nominalization
CONJ	conjunction	OBJ	object
DAT	dative	OBL	oblique
DEF	definite	PFV	perfective
DIM	diminutive	PL	plural
EMPH	emphatic	POSS	possessive
ENC	emphatic negative	PFX	prefix
	coordination	PREP	preposition
F	feminine	PRS	present tense
FUT	future	PST	past tense
IMP	imperative	PTCP	participle
IMPF	imperfect	Q	question
INF	infinitive	REFL	reflexive
IPFV	imperfective	SG	singular
IVF	Infinite Verb Form	SN	standard negation
LINK	linking morpheme	SUB	subordinator

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Chapter 3

Negation in Pashto

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In this paper, we explore negation in Pashto – an Eastern Iranian language spoken mainly in Pakistan and Afghanistan. Based on the Yousafzai dialect of Pashto, with the questionnaire provided by the editors as our main instrument, we explore e.g., standard negation, negation in non-declaratives, stative predications, and negation in non-main clauses. Standard negation in Pashto is expressed with a single negative particle *na*, typically added pre-verbally. For imperatives, there is a dedicated negative particle *ma*, also added pre-verbally, constituting the only formal contrast between imperatives and corresponding prohibitives. No structural differences between negation in main clauses and negation in non-main clauses of simplex verbs, or in non-periphrastic categories, have been observed, whereas there are instances of structural asymmetry in some periphrastically expressed verbal categories. Pashto displays paradigmatic asymmetry in that positive imperatives can make an aspectual distinction between perfective and imperfective, whereas negative imperatives are aspectually neutralized. Negation in Pashto can be further reinforced by changing the position of the negative element to occur post-verbally. Clauses with negated pronouns or adverbs always display negative concord.

Keywords: Iranian, negative particle, paradigmatic asymmetry, Pashto, structural asymmetry.

1 Introduction

The aim of this paper is to explore negation in Pashto (ISO: [pbu](#), Glottocode: [nort2646](#)) in a typological perspective. Although there are several book-length grammatical descriptions of Pashto ([Babrazai 1999](#), [David 2014](#), [Grjunberg 1987](#), [Lorenz 1979](#), [Penzl 1955](#), [Tegey & Robson 1996](#)), there is still no dedicated study of negation in the language. The language material used for the present study

was almost exclusively elicited by means of the *Questionnaire for describing the negation system of a language* designed by Matti Miestamo and subsequently revised together with Ljuba Veselinova (Miestamo 2025). The target variety is a northeastern dialect of Pashto often referred to as Yousafzai Pashto, spoken in the northern part of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province of Pakistan. This is the native language of one of the co-authors and is also considered the basis of literary Pashto in Pakistan. Our assumption is that the characteristics of negation emerging in our description is largely common to all of the major varieties of Pashto, in Pakistan as well as in Afghanistan. In our examples, we have essentially adopted the broad phonemic transcription of Pashto used by David (2014), while the glossing reflects our own analytical choices.

Pashto is an East Iranian language spoken primarily in Pakistan and Afghanistan. Its exact classification in relation to other Iranian languages is in no way final, but suffice it to say that some of its closest relatives within Iranian are found among the so-called Pamir languages (spoken by comparatively small populations in northeastern Afghanistan and in adjacent areas of Pakistan and Tajikistan), whereas its relatedness to e.g. Farsi-Dari-Tajik (considered West Iranian) is of a much more distant kind (Windfuhr 2009: 9–15; Skjaervø 1989a: 370; MacKenzie 2009: 443). Pashto is the second largest language of Pakistan, spoken by approximately 18 per cent of the population, surpassed only by Punjabi.¹ Most speakers are found in the west and the northwest of the country, with a main concentration in the northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, but there are also large speaker populations in Balochistan and in all of the major cities. In Afghanistan, Pashto enjoys the status of official language, along with Dari, and is a main native language in the east, south and southwest of the country, corresponding to approximately 50 per cent of the total population (Robson & Tegey 2009: 721). Outside of Pakistan and Afghanistan, Pashto is also spoken by sizeable groups in India, Iran and the United Arab Emirates. Although there is no indisputable statistics when it comes to the number of speakers, there is an estimated figure of 30 to 50 million Pashto speakers in total, making it the most widely spoken Iranian language after Persian (MacKenzie 2009: 460). Although Pashto exhibits significant linguistic variation, and relatively little (conscious or spontaneous) standardization, there is a high level of mutual intelligibility, even over great geographical distances (Robson & Tegey 2009: 721–722, 766). The latter can most likely be attributed to the fact that all major variation is phonological and lexical, rather than morphosyntactic (MacKenzie 1959: 231; Elfenbein 1997: 736).

¹Pakistan Bureau of Statistics. 2023. Final Results of Census-2017. <https://www.pbs.gov.pk/content/final-results-census-2017-0> (23 August, 2023).

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Pashto is a strongly head-final language, typically displaying an SOV clause word order. However, it also has a large inventory of second-position clitics, encoding modal, pronominal as well as adverbial meanings (Tegey 1977, Pate 2012). In the past tenses, nominal as well as verbal alignment is ergative-absolutive, while it is fully nominative-accusative in non-past tenses. From an Iranian perspective, Pashto has an unusually complex nominal and verbal morphology (MacKenzie 2009; Grjunberg 1987: 111), with added complexities in the form of stem and stress alternations (Morgenstierne 1942: 111). Nouns inflect for gender (masculine, feminine), number (singular, plural) and case (primarily contrasting direct and oblique). Numerous case relations are expressed by pre- and postpositions, or a combination of both. Verbs inflect for person, number and gender, and have two stems, one for present and another for past. Based on those stems, morphologically distinct imperfective vs. perfective verbs (both in the present and in the past) are formed. A few other verbal categories, including perfect and pluperfect, are formed periphrastically with auxiliaries derived from ‘be’ and ‘become’. Pashto verbs are a closed rather than an open class, a feature that is clearly areal in its distribution, with new predicates entering the language via productive light verb constructions (to a large extent overlapping with the class of denominal verbs) with *kedəl* ‘to become’ and *kol* (*kawəl*) ‘to do, make’ (Butt 2010: 50; David & Goodman 2014: 186; Liljegren 2010: 51–52; Masica 1993; Wohlgemuth 2009: 152–155).

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

In Pashto, standard negation, as defined and applied by e.g., Miestamo (2005), is expressed with a negative particle *nə* (alternatively *na*, particularly in its stressed realization) which typically precedes the finite verb of a clause. Example (1) shows a declarative verbal main clause, in this case in the present imperfective, first in the affirmative, (1a), and then in the corresponding negative clause, (1b).

- (1) a. Šādo gaḍ-eg-i.
 monkey dance-PRS-3
 ‘The monkey is dancing.’
 b. Šādo nə gaḍ-eg-i.
 monkey NEG dance-PRS-3
 ‘The monkey is not dancing.’

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There are good reasons to treat *nə* as a particle rather than an affix. On the one hand, it does form a prosodic unit with the finite verb, and it also carries the main stress of the verb phrase when occurring in this preverbal position (Tegey 1977: 110). When, for instance, an *a*-initial verb (a distinct verb class in Pashto), e.g., *axli* in (2a), is negated, the vowel hiatus creates a long vowel, as in *nāxli* in (2b).

- (2) a. Kamāl kitāb axl-i.
Kamal book take.PRS-3
'Kamal is buying the book.'
- b. Kamāl kitāb nāxl-i.
Kamal book NEG.take.PRS-3
'Kamal is not buying the book.'

On the other hand, the negative particle is sometimes moved to the end of the utterance, i.e. occurring after the finite verb, thus lending support to Pashto standard negation as essentially non-affixal and syntactic (Dahl 1979: 83–84). The post-verbal, or utterance-final, position has a function of placing emphasis on the negation or stressing the impossibility of the proposition, as earlier noted by e.g. Skjaervø (1989b: 398). Example (3a) shows a regular negative clause, and (3b) shows the corresponding emphatic negative clause with a right-dislocated *na*. See §4.4.

- (3) a. Haya ye nə darkaw-i.
3SG.DIST.DR 3.CLT NEG give.you.IPFV-3
'She is not giving it to you.'
- b. Haya ye darkaw-i na.
3SG.DIST.DR 3.CLT give.you.IPFV-3 NEG
'She is not ever giving it to you.'

Pashto standard negation is largely symmetric. Nearly every member of the verb paradigm used in the affirmative can also appear in the negative. Apart from the presence of the negative marker *nə*, negative declarative clauses expressed in other non-periphrastic tense-aspect categories, show no structural differences as compared to their corresponding affirmative expressions. In (4), an affirmative clause in the past imperfective, another category formed exclusively by verb morphology, is shown with its corresponding negative clause.

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- (4) a. Šādo gaḍ-ed-o.
 monkey dance-PST-3SG.M
 ‘The monkey was dancing.’
 b. Šādo nə gaḍ-ed-o.
 monkey NEG dance-PST-3SG.M
 ‘The monkey was not dancing.’

The same grammatical categories are also available in negative as well as in affirmative clauses, as can be seen in the following examples, in (5a) a negated past imperfective clause with feminine singular agreement, and in (5b) a negated clause with plural agreement.

- (5) a. Šādogay nə gaḍ-ed-a.
 female.monkey NEG dance-PST-3SG
 ‘The female monkey was not dancing.’
 b. Šādo-gān nə gaḍ-ed-əl.
 monkey-PL NEG dance-PST-3PL.M
 ‘The monkeys were not dancing.’

In addition to suffixing verb morphology, some crucial aspectual and modal differentiations are expressed with particles. That is for instance the case with the past perfective, which is (regularly) expressed with the prefixed perfective marker *wə*, as in (6), and with the future, which is expressed with the modal clitic *ba*, as in (7). It should be noted that the negative particle, provided it is placed in pre-verbal position, invariably occurs between the aspectual/modal marker(s) and the inflected verb stem, as also noted by Brugman and David (2014: 408).

- (6) a. Šādo wə-gaḍ-ed-o.
 monkey PFV-dance-PST-3SG
 ‘The monkey danced.’
 b. Šādo wə-nə-gaḍ-ed-o.
 monkey PFV-NEG-dance-PST-3SG
 ‘The monkey did not dance.’
 (7) a. Šādo ba gaḍ-eg-i.
 monkey FUT dance-PRS-3
 ‘The monkey will be dancing.’

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- b. Šādo ba nā gaḍ-eg-i.
 monkey FUT NEG dance-PRS-3
 ‘The monkey will not be dancing.’

Pashto transitive clauses in the past tenses, as the ones in (8), follow an ergative alignment pattern, in which the finite verb agrees with the direct object and the subject is expressed in a non-direct case form. Even in such cases a symmetrical relationship is maintained between affirmatives and their corresponding negatives.

- (8) a. Saṛi mewa wə-xwaṛ-a.
man.OBL fruit(F) PFV-eat.PST-3SG.F
'The man ate the fruit.'
- b. Saṛi mewa wə-nə-xwaṛ-a.
man.OBL fruit(F) PFV-NEG-eat.PST-3SG.F
'The man didn't eat the fruit.'

However, in the compound (i.e. periphrastically formed) verbal categories, such as in the present and past perfect, or in the potential categories, the finite auxiliary always follows the main (participial) verb in the affirmative, as in the present perfect clause in (9a), whereas in the negative, the negated, inflected, auxiliary can occur either before the participle, as in (9b), or after the participle, as in (9c). It should be noted that it is the pre-participle order that is the unmarked one, whereas the post-participle order puts focus or emphasis on the negation (and corresponds in function to the dislocated negative particle in example (3b) above).

- (9) a. Kamāl rāyl-ē dē.
Kamāl come.PFV-PTCP.SG.M be.PRS.3SG.M
'Kamāl has come.'
- b. Kamāl nə dē rāyl-ē.
Kamāl NEG be.PRS.3SG.M come.PFV-PTCP.SG.M
'Kamāl hasn't come.'
- c. Kamāl rāyl-ē nə dē.
Kamāl come.PFV-PTCP.SG.M NEG be.PRS.3SG.M
'Kamāl has *not* come.'

As was mentioned in §1, numerous predicates in Pashto are formed with a non-verb element (normally an adjective or a noun) and a “light verb” (or verbalizer),

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of which *kedəl* ‘to become’ (forming intransitive verbs) and *kawəl* (or *kol*) ‘to do, make’ (forming transitive verbs) are the most productive (Brugman & David 2014: 401–403). This large group of Pashto verbs has variously been referred to as denominal verbs (David & Goodman 2014: 200–203) and derivative verbs (Robson & Tegey 2009: 740; Tegey & Robson 1996: 105), although these terms are not entirely overlapping in all treatments of Pashto verbs. In reality, verbs of this type occur along a continuum of lexicalization, from those in which the two components are phonologically fused in some parts of the verb paradigm to those (newer ones) that remain more phrase-like. When clauses with such complex verbs are negated in the imperfective, the negative particle *nə* may occur either before the entire construction, as in (10b), or immediately before the inflected verb, as in (11b), depending on the degree of fusion/lexicalization.²

- (10) a. Dā wādə keg-i?
 3SG.F.DR marriage become.IPFV.PRS-3
 ‘Is she getting married?’
 b. Na, dā nə wādə keg-i.
 no 3SG.F.DR NEG marriage become.IPFV.PRS-3
 ‘No, she is not getting married.’
- (11) a. Āyā kamāl wādə kaw-i?
 Q Kamal marriage do.IPFV.PRS-3
 ‘Is Kamal getting married?’
 b. Na, haya os wādə nə kaw-i.
 no 3SG.DIST.DR now marriage NEG do.IPFV.PRS-3
 ‘No, he is not getting married now.’

In the perfective, however, the two parts of the complex are always separated by the negation, as can be seen in the examples (12) and (13). Note, that when the verbs ‘become’ and ‘do’ are used as verbalizers (i.e. not as simplex verbs), the perfective is not formed with the prefix *wə-*, as in (6) and (8); the aspectual contrasts are instead achieved by means of stem alternations: *keg-* (IPFV.PRS), *ked-* (IPFV.PST), *š-* (PFV.PRS), *šw-* (PFV.PST) ‘become’; *kaw-* (IPFV), *kɾ-* (PFV) ‘do’.

²Note the intransitive complex construction that is used with reference to female persons getting married, and the corresponding transitive one that is used with reference to male persons, reflecting the patrilocal marriage pattern typically observed in the Pashtun society (Grima 1993: 52–57).

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- (12) Də bača tror parun wādə nə šw-a.
of Bacha aunt yesterday marriage NEG become.PFV.PST-SG.F
‘Bacha’s aunt didn’t get married yesterday.’
- (13) Də bača trə parun wādə nə wə kaṛ-ē.
of Bacha uncle yesterday marriage NEG be.PST.3SG.M do.PFV-PTCP.SG.M
‘Bacha’s uncle didn’t get married yesterday.’

One particular construction that deserves to be mentioned is *lā nə* (< *lā* ‘still, even, yet’ + the negative particle *nə*), the semantic equivalent of the English phasal adverbial ‘not yet’. An example is given in (14) of an affirmative stative proposition with *lā* ‘[is] still’ and its corresponding negative with *lā nə*.

- (14) a. Kamāl lā dalta dē.
Kamal still here be.PRS.3SG.M
‘Kamal is still here.’
- b. Kamāl lā dalta nə dē.
Kamal yet here NEG be.PRS.3SG.M
‘Kamal is not here yet.’

As is shown in (15), a clause containing *lā nə*, can occur as the negative answer to a question in which *lāwal* (< *lā awal* lit. ‘still first’), corresponding to the phasal adverbial ‘already’, is used.

- (15) a. Kamāl lāwal tal-ē dē?
Kamal already go.IPFV.PRS-PTCP.3SG.M be.PRS.3SG.M
‘Has Kamal already gone?’
- b. Na, kamāl lā nə dē tal-ē.
no Kamal still NEG be.PRS.3SG.M go.IPFV.PST-PTCP.SG.M
‘No, Kamal has not yet gone.’

We leave it open to further examination, and the availability of more data, as to whether the different interpretations of the construction can be related to telicity (as suggested by one of the reviewers).

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

Pashto prohibitives have a dedicated negative construction, different in form from standard negation. This is the globally most commonly occurring type, ac-

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cording to van der Auwera & Lejeune (with Valentin Goussev)'s (2013) cross-linguistic study of prohibitives. The particle *mə* (alternatively *ma*) typically occurs before the second singular or plural imperative verb form, as can be seen in example (16).

- (16) a. Wāpas ye rāwṛ-a!
 back 3.CLT bring.me-IMP.SG
 'Return it!'
 b. Wāpas ye mə rāwṛ-a!
 back 3.CLT NEG bring.me-IMP.SG
 'Don't return it!'

There is an asymmetry in the imperative. For many verbs, a perfective and an imperfective imperative are available. However, there is normally only one corresponding prohibitive construction using the imperfective, as can be seen in examples (17–19).³ This is an example of what Miestamo (2005: 114) labels paradigmatic asymmetry of type A/Cat/TAM, in which neutralization between aspectual distinctions arises in the negative. Commands are typically expressed with perfective imperatives, as in (17a), (18a) and (19a), but imperfective imperatives ((17b), (18b) and (19b)) can be described as intensifying or adding aspects of urgency, repetition or continuation (David & Goodman 2014: 284), and, at times, to show emphasis on the action. Similar effects of using the imperfective in imperatives have been observed for e.g., Bulgarian and Kabyle (pc. Ljuba Veselinova).

- (17) a. Wə-xwar-a!
 PFV-eat.PRS-IMP.SG
 'Eat (it)!'
 b. Xwar-a!
 eat.PRS-IMP.SG
 'Go on and eat (it)!'
 c. Mə xwar-a!
 NEG eat.PRS-IMP.SG
 'Don't eat (it)!'
- (18) a. Lār š-a!
 go.PFV become.PFV.PRS-IMP.SG
 'Go!'

³This aspectual neutralization in the negative also applies to jussives, i.e., constructions in which the deontic particle *de* is used in order to express first and third person obligation (or non-obligation in the corresponding propositions with the standard negation *nə*).

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- b. Z-a!
go.IPFV.PRS-IMP.SG
'Get going!'
 - c. Mə z-a!
NEG go.IPFV.PRS-IMP.SG
'Don't go!'
- (19)
- a. Bača ta wə-wāy-a!
Bacha to PFV-tell.PRS-IMP.SG
'Tell Bacha!'
 - b. Bača ta wāy-a!
Bacha to tell.PRS-IMP.SG
'Keep telling Bacha!'
 - c. Bača ta mə wāy-a!
Bacha to NEG tell.PRS-IMP.SG
'Don't tell Bacha!'

Just like the particle *nə* used in standard negation, the particle *mə* can occur sentence-finally, too. In such cases, it is to show a special focus or put emphasis on the negation. See the contrasting examples in (20).

- (20)
- a. Mə ye axl-a!
NEG 3.CLT take.PRS-IMP.SG
'Don't take it!'
 - b. Axl-a ye ma!
take.PRS-IMP.SG 3.CLT NEG
'Don't take it!'

The alternation between a pre-verbal and non-emphatic *mə* and an utterance-final and emphatic *ma* is parallel to the previously mentioned (§2.1) alternation between *nə* and *na*.

Another somewhat special case, that deserves to be mentioned, is the use of *mə* with second person singular inflected indicative verb forms, instead of with an imperative form, in a few set constructions with an optative meaning. These are for instance found in greetings or routine expression of well-wishing or encouragement. The expression in (21) may typically be uttered by an acquaintance addressing a farmer working in his field as he passes by, thus wishing him luck and good health. Similarly, the expression in (22) may be uttered encouragingly to another participant in a group-singing session to go on singing.

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- (21) Stəṛē mə š-e!
tired.SG.M NEG become.PFV.PRS-2SG
'May you not get tired!'
- (22) Xwār mə š-e!
poor NEG become.PFV.PRS-2SG
'May you not become weak!'

As exemplified by [David & Goodman \(2014: 275–276\)](#), the corresponding affirmative expression *xwār še* 'may you be miserable!' can be used to express an ill-wish, or even a curse.

2.3 Negation in stative predications

In many non-verbal clauses too, the negation particle *nə* is used, to negate equation (23), proper inclusion (24), attribution (including temporary attribution) (25), and locative predication (26), just like it is applied in standard negation.

- (23) Equation
- Bača zəmə ustāz dē.
Bacha 1SG.POSS teacher be.PRS.3SG.M
'Bacha is my teacher.'
 - Bača zəmə ustāz nə dē.
Bacha 1SG.POSS teacher NEG be.PRS.3SG.M
'Bacha is not my teacher.'
- (24) Proper inclusion
- Malang yaw tarkān dē.
Malang one carpenter be.PRS.3SG.M
'Malang is a carpenter.'
 - Malang yaw tarkān nə dē.
Malang one carpenter NEG be.PRS.3SG.M
'Malang is not a carpenter.'
- (25) Attribution
- Adam lewanē dē.
Adam insane.SG.M be.PRS.3SG.M
'Adam is insane.'

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- b. Adam lewanē nə dē.
Adam insane.SG.M NEG be.PRS.3SG.M
'Adam is not insane.'
- c. Adam os xapa nə dē.
Adam now sad NEG be.PRS.3SG.M
'Adam is not sad now.' [temporal attribution]

(26) Locative predication

- a. Bača pa kor dē.
Bacha at house be.PRS.3SG.M
'Bacha is at home.'
- b. Bača pa kor nə dē.
Bacha at house NEG be.PRS.3SG.M
'Bacha is not at home.'

However, existential (27) and, at least some, possessive predications (28) make use of a non-inflected existential negator (NegEx), the particle *nište* 'doesn't exist, isn't there, isn't available' (< *nə šte*) for negating. This reflects a general cross-linguistic tendency (Veselinova 2013: 123–124). The corresponding affirmative predications use a dedicated existential copula *šte* 'exists, is there, is available'.

(27) Existential predication

- a. Pa zangal ki mzari šte.
in forest in lion.PL EX
'There are lions in the forest.'
- b. Pa zangal ki mzari nište.
in forest in lion.PL NEGEX
'There are no lions in the forest.'

(28) Possessive predication

- a. Adam sara topak šte.
Adam with gun EX
'Adam has a gun.'
- b. Adam sara topak nište.
Adam with gun NEGEX
'Adam does not have a gun.'

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NegEx can also be used in contrastive negation, when the presence of somebody or something in one place is contrasted with its absence in another place. In this case, however, the affirmative part is expressed with the copula used in locative predication, as in (29).

- (29) Kamal hujra ki dē kor ki nište.
 Kamal hujra in be.PRS.SG.M home in NEGEX
 ‘Kamal is at the *hujra* (village common house), not at home.’

Additionally, NegEx can carry a connotation of being gone for good, i.e., having died, as in (30).

- (30) Zəmung də stargo ašnā os nište.
 1PL.POSS of eye.PL.OBL known now NEGEX
 ‘(People) known to our eyes are no more (alive).’

Occasionally, it can be used adjectivally, in a contracted form, *ništ*, again with the sense ‘gone’, ‘is no more’, as in (31), in this case along with the inflected form of ‘become’.

- (31) Zəmung xwag-ə yār-ān os ništ š-u.
 1PL.POSS sweet-PL.M friend-PL now gone become.PFV.PRS-1PL
 ‘Our sweet friends are now gone.’

Certain locative predications may alternatively use the construction in (26) and the one normally associated with existential predication, as in (27). This is particularly the case if the presence of a third person is queried over the phone (Tegey & Robson 1996: 93–94), as in (32a). The reply may use either construction, but it is more common for the negative reply to make use of the negative existential, as in (32b), and the affirmative to use the inflected copula *dē*, etc., as in (32c).

- (32) a. Kamāl pa kor ki šte?
 Kamal in house in EX
 ‘Is Kamal at home (i.e. available)?’
 b. Na, kamāl pa kor ki nište.
 no Kamal in house in NEGEX
 ‘No, Kamal is not at home.’
 c. Ao, kamāl pa kor ki dē.
 yes Kamal in house in be.PRS.3SG.M
 ‘Yes, Kamal is at home.’

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2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Negation in Pashto dependent and subordinate clauses is expressed with the negation particle *nə*, just like in standard negation. The following examples illustrate the use of it in both a finite, relative clause (33), and in a non-finite, noun complement, clause (34).

- (33) Haya halək [če imtihān ye nə šo pās
 that.DR boy COMP test 3.CLT NEG become.PFV.PST.3SG.M passing
 kol-e] skul prexud.
 do.PFV.PST-OPT school abandon.PST.PFV.3SG.M
 ‘The boy [who could not pass the examination] left school.’
- (34) [Ṭem nə zāya kol] yaw xa ādat dē.
 time NEG wastage do.INF one good habit be.PRS.3SG.M
 ‘[Wasting no time] is a good habit.’

The main verb of the subordinate clause in (33) is part of a complex verb construction, *pās kol* ‘to pass, succeed’, and occurs here in the past potential, in which it is the auxiliary *šo* that is inflected and is immediately preceded by the negation particle. The non-finite verb in the noun complement in (34) is also part of a complex verb, *zāya kol* ‘to waste’; in this case, the negation particle precedes the complex verb construction as a whole.

In Youzafzai Pashto, negative purpose could be expressed in two different ways. Either the verb in the subordinate clause that is introduced with the complementizer *če* is negated, as in (35), also mentioned by Pate (2012: 85), or the complementizer itself is negated, *hasi na če* ‘thus not’, as in (36). Note that in the latter case, the verb in the purpose clause is not negated in concord.

- (35) Zar kaw-a če dar bāndi nāwaxtā nə š-i.
 quick do.IPFV-IMP.SG COMP 2 on late NEG become.PFV.PRS-3
 ‘Hurry up, lest you get late.’
- (36) Zar kaw-a hasi na če dar bāndi nāwaxtā
 quick do.IPFV-IMP.SG thus NEG COMP 2 on late
 š-i.
 become.PFV.PRS-3
 ‘Hurry up, lest you should get late.’

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

No clear examples of negative lexicalizations have been found in Pashto.

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative replies

In Pashto, negative replies to polar questions are often expressed by using a one-word negative reply *na*, similar in use to English ‘no’ (see further examples above: (10b), (11b), (32b)). Note the following two polar questions, (37Q) and (38Q), and their answers, (37A) and (38A), respectively.

- (37) Q: Dā spē yap-i?
 this.DR dog bark-3
 ‘Is the dog barking?’⁴
 A: Na!
 no
 ‘No (it is not barking)!’
- (38) Q: Dā spē nə yap-i?
 this.DR dog NEG bark-3
 ‘Isn’t the dog barking?’
 A: Na!
 no
 ‘No (it is not barking)!’

As these examples show, the polarity particle *na* expresses in both cases a negative answer, in the case of a positive question, a non-confirmation of the positive polarity of the question, and in the case of a negative question, a confirmation of its negative polarity. It is therefore an example of a so-called yes-no answer system (König & Siemund 2007: 320–321).

3.2 Negative indefinites and adverbs

The negation of indefinite pronouns and adverbs (corresponding to English ‘nobody’, ‘no-one’, ‘nowhere’, ‘never’) is obtained by prefixing *hīts* ‘none’ to an indefinite pronoun or adverb. Some examples are given in (39–42). Note the negative concord, i.e. that also the verb in those clauses must be negated, with the standard negation *nə* as in (39), (41) and (43), the negative existential *nište*, as in (40),

⁴Polar questions with an utterance-initial question particle *āyā*, as reported by Brugman & David (2014: 417), are also observed in Youzafzai Pashto. In everyday speech, however, polar questions are normally identical to statements apart from an utterance-final rising pitch in questions, whereas the *āyā*-construction is mostly used in formal speech.

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or the negative prohibitive particle *ma*, as in (42). Note that *hīts* can be left out in (43), or be entirely replaced by *bəl*, as in (44), to express a negative exclusivity, ‘nobody else’.

- (39) Haya hīts kala nə š-i rātl-e.
3SG.DIST.DR none when NEG become.PFV.PRS-3 come.IPFV.PST-OPT
‘She can never come.’
- (40) Apīm was hīts čarta nište.
opium now none where NEGEX
‘Opium is now found nowhere.’
- (41) Zəmā hīts tsok mrašta nə kaw-i.
1SG.POSS none who.DR help NEG do.IPFV.PRS-3
‘Nobody helps me.’
- (42) Xpala jəba hīts kala mə pregd-a.
own language none when NEG abandon.PRS-IMP.SG
‘Never give up your own language!’
- (43) Q: ‘What are you buying?’
A: Zə (hīts) tsə nāxl-əm.
1SG.NOM none what NEG.buy.IPFV.PRS-1SG
‘I’m buying nothing.’
- (44) Xesta ɖer turzən dē; bəl tsok dāse nə
Khesta very brave be.PRS.3SG.M other who.DR like.that NEG
š-i kaw-e.
become.PFV.PRS-3 do.IPFV.PRS-OPT
‘Khesta is so brave. Nobody else can do it.’

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

The Pashto lexicon includes numerous, particularly adjectival, derivations that encode absence, opposition or antonymy. A number of different negating derivational prefixes occur, approximately corresponding to English ‘-less’, ‘un-’, ‘non-’, ‘in-’, etc. The most common such negating prefixes are *nā-*, *be-* and *la-*. The prefix *nā-* is the most productive, while *be-* (of Persian origin) mostly occurs with roots of Persian (or Perso-Arabic) origin, and *lā-* (of Arabic origin) primarily occurs with roots of Arabic origin. Some examples are displayed in Table 1.

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Table 1: Negative derivation in Pashto

Root	Negative prefix	Derivation
<i>joṛ</i> ‘healthy, well’ ADJ	<i>nā-</i>	<i>nājoṛa</i> ‘unwell, sick’ ADJ
<i>roy</i> ‘complete, healthy, well’ ADJ		<i>nāroya</i> ‘incomplete, unwell, sick’ ADJ
<i>poha</i> ‘intelligent, learned’ ADJ		<i>nāpoha</i> ‘ignorant, foolish’ ADJ
<i>āšnā</i> ‘acquaintance’ N		<i>nāšnā</i> ‘unknown, strange’ ADJ
<i>hak</i> ‘just’ ADJ, N		<i>nāhak</i> ‘unjust’ ADJ
<i>rawā</i> ‘lawful, permitted’ ADJ		<i>nārawā</i> ‘illegal, unlawful’ ADJ
<i>tars</i> ‘fear’ N		<i>nātars</i> ‘pitiless, fearless’ ADJ
<i>pedā</i> ‘born, created’ ADJ		<i>nāped</i> ‘rare, unavailable’ ADJ
<i>lew</i> ‘plastering’ N		<i>nālewa</i> ‘not plastered’ ADJ
<i>waxt</i> ‘time’ N		<i>nāwaxta</i> ‘late, out of time’ ADJ
<i>gumān</i> ‘expectation, thought’ N		<i>nāgumāna</i> ‘unexpected’ ADJ
<i>saritob</i> ‘human nature’ N	<i>be-</i>	<i>besaritoba</i> ‘immodest’ ADJ
<i>kār</i> ‘work’ N		<i>bekāra</i> ‘useless’ ADJ
<i>darak</i> ‘place; trace’ N		<i>bedaraka</i> ‘lost, without direction’ ADJ
<i>akal</i> ‘wisdom, reason’ N		<i>beakla</i> ‘unwise, stupid’ ADJ
<i>waxt</i> ‘time’ N		<i>bewaxta</i> ‘untimely’ ADJ
<i>hāsil</i> ‘produce, profit’ N	<i>lā-</i>	<i>lāhāsil</i> ‘fruitless’ ADJ
<i>parwā</i> ‘care, concern’ N		<i>lāparwā</i> ‘careless’ ADJ

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

Pashto clausal negation, expressed with a pre-verbal negative particle, typically takes scope over the proposition as a whole, as in (45a). However, the scope can also be narrowed down to a specific lower-level constituent by means of prosodic stress (while the sentence structure remains unaffected). In (45b), emphatic stress on the subject pronoun *hayo* shifts the scope of negation from the proposition as a whole to the subject argument of the clause. The sentence now means that ‘they’, i.e., a few specific people, are not coming to the village, while some others might be coming. Similarly, in (45c), emphatic stress on *kāli* shifts the scope of negation to the goal, meaning that they are coming to the village rather than to some other place, such as the city, which could be uttered with reference to some expected visitors coming from abroad.

- (45) a. *Hayo kāli ta nə rāz-i.*
 3PL.DIST.DR village.OBL to NEG come.IPFV.PRS-3
 ‘They are not coming to the village.’

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- b. Hayo kəli ta nə rāz-i.
 3PL.DIST.DR village.OBL to NEG come.IPFV.PRS-3
 ‘They are not coming to the village.’
- c. Hayo kəli ta nə rāz-i.
 3PL.DIST.DR village.OBL to NEG come.IPFV.PRS-3
 ‘They are not coming *to the village*.’

Another way of narrowing down the scope of negation is by negating indefinite pronouns or adverbs with *hīts* ‘none’ in negative concord with a clause-level negative particle such as *nə*, as previously described in §3.2.

4.2 Negative polarity

The following is by no means intended as an exhaustive list (Table 2), but covers some of the most frequent and prominent negative polarity items in Pashto. Note that many of them include *hīts* as a component, co-lexicalized with, and sometimes phonologically fused, with an indefinite (or interrogative) pronoun/adverb (see §3.2), alternatively occurs as a nominal modifier (e.g. with *kār* ‘work’, *waxt* ‘time’, *sūrat* ‘image’). In each case this negative polarity item displays negative concord with a clause-level negative particle. It is probably more correct to describe these as negative polarity constructions along with the clause-level negative particle rather than as negative polarity items in isolation (especially since *hīts* in some cases can be left out, while the negative meaning of the sentence remains).

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

As shown in many other examples, clausal negation is largely symmetric in Pashto. The addition of a negative particle is for most of the TAM categories the only formal difference between a negative and a corresponding affirmative clause. Neither is case marking in any way affected under negation. As can be seen in the present tense utterances in (46), the direct case marking of the transitive subject and the oblique case marking of the pronominal direct object remains the same, whether affirmative or negative.

- (46) a. Spē mā xwar-i.
 dog.DR 1SG.OBL eat.PRS-3
 ‘The dog is biting me.’

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Table 2: Negative Polarity Items (NPIs) in Pashto

Form	Meaning	Use (licencing conditions)
<i>hīts-tsok</i>	‘anybody, nobody’	negated nominative NP with human reference
<i>bəl-tsok</i>	‘anybody else, nobody else’	negated nominative NP with human reference
<i>hīts-čā, hī-čā</i>	‘anybody, nobody’	negated non-nominative NP with human reference
<i>bəl-čā</i>	‘anybody else, nobody else’	negated non-nominative NP with human reference
<i>(hīts-)tsə</i>	‘anything, nothing’	negated NP with inanimate reference
<i>hīts-kār</i>	‘anything, nothing’	negated NP with reference to activity
<i>hīts-šē</i>	‘anything, nothing’	negated NP with reference to inanimate physical entity
<i>hīts-čerta, hī-čerta</i>	‘anywhere, nowhere’	negated locational adverbial
<i>hīts-čere, hī-čere</i>	‘never’	negated time adverbial
<i>hīts-kala</i>	‘never’	negated time adverbial
<i>hīts-waxt</i>	‘never’	negated time adverbial
<i>hīts-tor</i>	‘by no means, in no way’	negated manner adverbial
<i>hīts-sūrat</i>	‘by no means, in no way’	negated manner adverbial

- b. Spē mā nə xwar-i.
 dog.DR 1SG.OBL NEG eat.PRS-3
 ‘The dog is not biting me.’

Similarly, in (47), when the ergative alignment of the corresponding past tense utterances assigns oblique case to the transitive subject and direct case to the pronominal direct object, no changes as far as case marking takes place between the affirmative expression and the corresponding negative one.

- (47) a. Spi zə wə-xwar-əm.
 dog.OBL 1SG.DR PFV-eat.PST-1SG
 ‘The dog bit me.’
 b. Spi zə wə-nə-xwar-əm.
 dog.OBL 1SG.DR PFV-NEG-eat.PST-1SG
 ‘The dog did not bite me.’

4.4 Reinforcing negation

As already noted, and exemplified in (3b), movement of the negative particle from its unmarked pre-verbal position to the post-verbal, or utterance-final, posi-

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tion has a function of reinforcing the negation. In periphrastically formed verbal tenses, it is the negative particle along with the following auxiliary that is moved to the utterance-final position, as exemplified in (9c). The same movement of the negative particle is applied when expressing the non-optionality in prohibitive utterances, as seen in (20b).

An adverb, *bīxi*, that can, although rarely, be used affirmatively as an intensifier of e.g., human-propensity adjectives, as in (48), with the approximate meaning ‘completely, very’, is used in order to emphasize the negative truth-value of a clause-level negation, as in (49), translatable as ‘not at all’.

- (48) Zə bīxi warxatā yəm.
1SG.NOM completely confused be.PRS.1SG
‘I’m completely confused.’
- (49) Xesta bīxi kəli ta wāpas nə rāz-i.
Khesta at.all village.OBL to back NEG come.IPFV.PRS-3
‘Khesta is not coming back to the village at all.’

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

Negative disjunction in Pashto is expressed bisyndetically with a *na ... na* ‘neither ... nor’ construction, as exemplified with verbal predicates in (50), and with non-verbal in (51). The negator is in each case placed before the constituent or proposition that is being negated.

- (50) Pa roja ki saṛē na doḍəy xwar-i aw na obə tsk-i.
in fasting in man NEG food eat.PRS-3 and NEG water drink.PRS-3
‘During Ramazan, we neither eat food nor drink water.’
- (51) Haya na ɣal dē aw na də ɣal mal dē.
3SG.DIST.DR NEG thief be.PRS.3SG and NEG of thief friend be.PRS.3SG.M
‘He is neither a thief nor the friend of a thief.’

The coordinating conjunction *aw*, occurring before the second *na* in (50) and (51), can also be left out, as in (52).

- (52) Haya na uxyār dē na nəṛ.
3SG.DIST.DR NEG wise be.PRS.3SG.M NEG brave
‘He is neither wise nor brave.’

In another bisyndetic construction *na yawā ze ... balki ham* ‘not only ... but also’, it is only the first element that is expressed with a negative particle, as in (53).

- (53) Haya na yawwāze yaw xə ustāz dē balki yaw
3SG.DIST.DR NEG only one good.SG.M teacher be.PRS.3SG.M but one
xə insān ham dē.
good.SG.M human also be.PRS.SG.M
'He is not only a good teacher but also a nice person.'

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

Pashto has a frequently used affirmation particle or interrogative tag *kana* ‘isn’t it?’, ‘don’t you?’, ‘won’t we?’ etc. (< *ka na* ‘or not’), as exemplified in (54) and (55)Q. Often the affirmative answer *ao* ‘yes’, is followed by the same particle, as in (55)A. Intonation further differentiates a request (whether actual or rhetoric) for affirmation and an affirmative answer, corresponding to the intonational difference between statements and questions in general in Pashto.

- (54) Xob darz-i kana?
sleep come.to.you.IPFV.PRS-3 TAG
'You feel sleepy, don't you?'
- (55) Q: Kəli ta ba z-u kana?
village.OBL to FUT go.IPFV.PRS-1PL TAG
'We will go to the village, won't we?'
- A: Ao kana.
yes TAG
'Yes, of course.'

Pashto can in various ways express negative meanings as understatements, i.e., by means of clauses that are formally affirmative but include phrases indicating “impossibility” or “difficulty”, thus in principle negating the proposition. It may in some cases be a way of politely declining a request without literally – and bluntly – expressing it with a standard negator. In example (56), it is virtually out of question that the proposition would be realized.

- (56) Haŷio grān-a da če rāš-i.
3PL.DIST.OBL difficult-F be.PRS.3SG.F COMP come.PFV.PRS-3
'They might not come.' / 'They aren't coming.' (lit. 'It is difficult for them to come')

In yet other cases, it is the larger (cultural) context, along with intonation, that triggers a negative reading. In example (57), the extremely negative connotation of *xīrən* as ritually unclean and in every way objectionable, implicitly/contextually attributed to a particular person, effectively excludes an affirmative meaning.

- (57) Haya xīrən ba rāš-i.
3SG.DIST.DR dirty FUT come.PFV.PRS-3
'That scumbag is *not* coming here.' (lit. 'That dirty will come here.')

5 Summary

Table 3 is a summary of the most important observations regarding negation in Pashto.

Table 3: Main properties of Pashto negation

Form	Formal characteristics	Function
<i>nə=</i>	Pre-verbal (finite) particle	Standard negation (SN)
<i>mə=</i>	Pre-verbal negative particle of imperatives	Prohibitive negation
<i>nište</i>	Replacing clause-final existential copula	Negative existential
<i>na</i>	Confirming/ non-confirming (yes-no system)	Negative reply
<i>hīts-...nə</i>	Typical prefixed element of indefinite pronoun or adverb; negative concord with clausal negation	Indefinite pronouns/adverbs
<i>na...na...</i>	Negative elements bisyndetically preceding negated constituents	Negative disjunction
	The default clausal scope narrowed down by prosodic stress	Scope of negation
	Right-dislocation of clausal negation	Reinforcement
<i>nā-, be-, lā</i>	Numerous, largely idiosyncratic, derivations by means of prefixes	Negative derivation
The asymmetries observed in the domain of negation are of the A/Cat/TAM type: a) Constructional asymmetry in periphrastic verbal categories; b) Paradigmatic asymmetry in prohibitives (perfective-imperfective neutralization)		

Standard negation is expressed with a single negative particle *nə*, typically added pre-verbally. When negating clauses in non-periphrastic verbal categories

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there are no accompanying structural differences between affirmatives and negatives. All such clauses can be negated solely by adding *nə*, regardless of TAM or nominal grammatical categories. Periphrastically formed categories, however, show constructional asymmetry in applying the order VERB+AUX in affirmative clauses, while having the order NEG+AUX+VERB, in negative clauses. For imperatives, there is a dedicated negative particle *mə*, normally added pre-verbally, constituting the only formal contrast between imperatives and corresponding prohibitives. Pashto shows paradigmatic asymmetry in that positive imperatives can make an aspectual distinction between perfective and imperfective, whereas negative imperatives (normally) only occur in the imperfective. Most stative predications are negated by means of standard negation too. The inflected copula used in the affirmative is prefixed by *nə* in the corresponding negative predications. Existential, most possessive and a few locative predications, instead make use of a non-inflected existential copula, *šte*. In the corresponding negated predications, the existential copula is replaced with an existential negator, *nište*. No structural differences between negation in main clauses and negation in non-main clauses have been observed. Negative replies to polar questions can be given by using a one-word negative particle *na*. The use of it, as non-confirming and confirming answers to questions with positive and negative polarity, respectively, suggests that Pashto applies a yes-no answer system. Indefinite/interrogative pronouns and adverbs are typically negated by a preceding (or prefixed) *hits*. Clauses with such negated pronouns or adverbs always display negative concord. Negation in Pashto is normally reinforced by changes in the position of the negative element. In main clauses in the non-periphrastic categories, this is obtained by placing the negative particle, *nə* or *mə*, in utterance-final position. In periphrastically formed categories, reinforcement is instead exercised by the occurrence of NEG+AUX post-verbally vis-à-vis its typical pre-verbal position. Pashto clausal negation typically takes scope over the proposition as a whole, but can be narrowed down to a lower-level constituent by means of prosodic stress.

Pashto gives evidence of a few other specific negative constructions, including a bisyndetic negative disjunction, and a small number of negative - primarily adjectival - derivations are productively applied, all of which are prefixal.

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Abbreviations

1	first person	IPFV	imperfective
2	second person	M	masculine
3	third person	N	noun
ADJ	adjective	NEG	negation
AUX	auxiliary	NEGEX	negative existential
CLT	clitical element	OBL	oblique case
COMP	complementizer	OPT	optative
DR	direct case	PFV	perfective
DIST	distal	PL	plural
EX	existential copula	POSS	possessive
F	feminine	PRS	present
FUT	future	PST	past
IMP	imperative	PTCP	participle
INF	infinitive	SG	singular
		TAG	tag question

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Chapter 4

Negation in Modern Hebrew

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This chapter provides an overview of negation in Modern Hebrew, an Afroasiatic language of the Semitic branch. Standard negation is typically expressed by a construction where the negative particle *lo* precedes the finite verb. However, in formal registers, the negative copula *en*, historically derived from a negative existential particle, is employed instead of *lo* in the present tense. This negative copula can appear in two distinct standard negation constructions, with no difference in meaning: (i) in an inflected form (person, number, and gender) positioned before the finite verb; or (ii) in an uninflected form in clause-initial position. Beyond clausal negation, particular attention is paid to negative indefinites and polarity items.

Keywords: Hebrew, standard negation, negative copula, constituent negation, negative indefinites, polarity items.

1 The language

Modern Hebrew (ISO: [heb](#), Glottocode: [hebr1245](#)) belongs to the Semitic branch of the Afroasiatic family. It is spoken by over 5 million native speakers, and it is the official language of Israel ([Eberhard et al. 2023](#)). Pre-modern Hebrew ceased to be a spoken language at the end of the second century CE but continued to be used in liturgical, scholarly, legal, and literary writings by Jewish communities world-wide. It is commonly classified into several periods based on existing corpora: (i) Biblical Hebrew (the Hebrew Bible); (ii) Mishnaic Hebrew (the Mishna and parts of the Talmud); (iii) Medieval Hebrew (religious, philosophical, poetic, and scientific texts written during the period of Islamic rule in the Middle East, North Africa, and the Iberian Peninsula); (iv) Late Rabbinic Hebrew and Hasidic

Hebrew (religious writings of Jewish communities in Europe); and (v) Maskilic Hebrew (secular writings which began to appear in Central and Eastern Europe during the Enlightenment, starting from the middle of the eighteenth century). The language of the latter period, which was usually characterized by a linguistic mixture of different historical styles, had considerable influence on the development of Modern Hebrew. Another major influence was the Hebrew spoken by Jewish communities in Palestine in the late nineteenth century. Their native languages were usually Arabic, Judeo-Spanish, or Yiddish, but they used Hebrew as a *lingua franca* for inter-community communication. Jewish immigrants who came to Palestine from Europe at the end of the nineteenth century adopted Hebrew as their primary community language and became the first speakers of Modern Hebrew. Hebrew later became one of the official languages of Mandatory Palestine in 1922 and the state of Israel in 1948 (Doron 2015: 2–4).

Due to an extended history of bilingualism, Hebrew had long-standing contact with Yiddish (Indo-European), Slavic languages (Indo-European), and Arabic (Afroasiatic) (Doron 2015: 7). In recent decades, Hebrew's main contact languages are English (Indo-European) and Palestinian Arabic. Modern Hebrew shows almost no regional variation (Berman 1997: 313). However, it exhibits sociolinguistic variation in phonology, syntax, semantics, and the lexicon (Henshke 2013).

The basic word order is SVO, though VS is a possible alternative in certain contexts, especially in intransitive clauses. Hebrew is predominantly head-initial and dependent-marking. Like in other Semitic languages, all verbs and many nouns and adjectives are formed from a triconsonantal root and, sometimes, additional affixes (Berman 1997: 317). Adjectives and demonstratives agree in number and gender with the noun that they modify, and numerals agree in gender. Past and future tense verbs inflect for person, number, and gender. Present tense verbs inflect for number and gender but not person because this form is historically derived from the present participle and has retained its adjective-like morphology (Tzivoni 1993: 205).

Many aspects of negation in Modern Hebrew have been previously described in the literature. Tzivoni (1993) is a comprehensive description (written in Hebrew) of the system of negation, which is mostly based on written corpora. Shor (2020) studies the expression of negation in spontaneous conversation. In addition, chapters about negation can be found in grammars such as Glinert (1989: 293–307), Rosén (1977: 225–230), and Berman (1978: 145–146, 220–224).

The linguistic examples in this paper represent both formal and informal registers.¹ They are drawn from several sources, which are indicated in the glosses: (i)

¹The examples are transcribed using the following phonetic notation: “c” stands for a voiceless

previous literature, primarily Tzivoni (1993) and Glinert (1989); (ii) the Beʔofen Tivʔi Hebrew Textual Corpus, which is based on an internet forum dedicated to homeschooling and other alternative lifestyles; (iii) web examples (URLs are given in footnotes); and (iv) constructed examples. The structure of this chapter follows the structure of the questionnaire (Miestamo 2025).

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

Standard negation is expressed by a construction in which the negative particle *lo* appears before the finite verb. This construction is symmetric with the corresponding affirmative (1), according to the criteria of Miestamo (2005). *lo* is considered a particle based on Dryer's (2013) criteria since it carries its own stress and does not inflect.

- (1) Hem (lo) makir-im ot-a.
 3PL.M (NEG) know.PRS-PL.M ACC-3SG.F
 'They (don't) know her.' [constructed]

In formal registers, present tense forms are not negated by *lo* but by the negative copula *en* (2). On the other hand, past and future tense verbs are negated by *lo*, as in the spoken language. The negative copula *en* typically inflects for person, number, and gender (Tzivoni 1993: 205), e.g., in (2a). However, *en* is not a verb for two reasons. First, it does not inflect for tense. Second, it inflects for person, whereas present tense verbs do not inflect for person (see §1). Syntactically, *en* belongs to a small class of particles, which also includes the presentatives *harey* and *hine*, the latter of which has also grammaticalized into the copula *hin-*, which is the affirmative counterpart of *en* in formal registers (see §2.3). These particles are unique in that they can either precede a clitic pronoun, as in (2a), or an independent pronoun, as in (2b), while other grammatical constructions may only occur with one type of pronoun or the other. The construction with inflecting *en* (2a) may be considered an instance of constructional asymmetric negation because *en* is followed by a clitic pronoun, which is absent in the corresponding affirmative. The construction with clause-initial, non-inflecting *en* (2b), by contrast, is symmetric.

alveolar affricate /tʃ/, "š" stands for a voiceless post-alveolar fricative /ʃ/, "y" stands for a palatal approximant /j/, "x" stands for a voiceless uvular fricative /χ/, and "r" stands for a voiced uvular approximant /ʁ/. The transcription represents standard General Israeli Hebrew.

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- (2) a. Hem (en-am) makir-im ot-a.
 3PL.M (NEG-3PL.M) know.PRS-PL.M ACC-3SG.F
 ‘They (don’t) know her.’ [constructed]
- b. (En) hem makir-im ot-a.
 (NEG) 3PL.M know.PRS-PL.M ACC-3SG.F
 ‘They (don’t) know her.’ [constructed]

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

Prohibitives are expressed by a construction in which the negative particle *al* precedes the future tense form (3a). The dedicated imperative form cannot occur in this construction. However, in most cases, prohibitives are symmetric with the corresponding affirmative because the imperative paradigm has been largely replaced by the future tense paradigm in the spoken language (Glinert 1989: 284–285). Note that several verbs have preserved the imperative form, most of which have a “weak” root, i.e., one of the consonants of the root is not pronounced in part of the verb conjugation (The Hebrew Academy 2017). In this case, then, negation is asymmetric (3b–3c). In indirect speech, the standard negation particle *lo* is used instead of *al* (3d).

- (3) a. (Al) ta-kšiv-Ø l-o!
 (PROH) 2.FUT-listen-SG.M DAT-3SG.M
 ‘(Don’t) listen to him!’ [constructed]
- b. Lex-Ø!
 go.IMP-SG.M
 ‘Go!’ [constructed]
- c. Al te-lex-Ø!
 PROH 2.FUT-go-SG.M
 ‘Don’t go!’ [constructed]
- d. Ta-gid-i l-a še-lo te-lex-Ø!
 2.FUT-tell-SG.F DAT-3SG.F COMP-NEG 3.F.FUT-go-SG
 ‘Tell her not to go!’ [constructed]

In formal registers, *al* may also occur in a jussive construction, in which it is either followed by a dative noun phrase or pronoun and a non-finite clause (4a) or a future tense verb (4b).

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- (4) a. Al l-anu lehit?arev.
 NEG DAT-1PL get.involved.INF
 ‘We shouldn’t get involved.’ [Be?ofen Tiv?i]
 b. Al ni-štameš be-mil-im lo?azi-ot.
 NEG 1PL.FUT-use in-word-PL foreign-PL
 ‘Let us not use foreign words.’²

The particle *lo* can be used in another jussive construction with a finite clause introduced by the complementizer *še* (Bar-Adon 1966). This construction usually has a flavor of a warning (5a). It is symmetric with the affirmative, which is usually used as an optative in the second person (5b).

- (5) a. Še-lo ti-škax-Ø lavo maxar!
 COMP-NEG 2.FUT-forget-SG.M come.INF tomorrow
 ‘Don’t forget to come tomorrow!’ (Bar-Adon 1966: 410)
 b. Še-ta-mut-Ø!
 COMP-2.FUT-die-SG.M
 ‘Drop dead!’ (Bar-Adon 1966: 411)

Negative obligation is expressed by a construction in which the non-inflecting modal *asur* ‘forbidden’ precedes a non-finite clause (6a). This modal is also used to express a general prohibition (e.g., *It is forbidden to smoke here*), and in this context the standard negation particle *lo* and the formal negative particle *en* may be used as well (6b). Despite the fact that these three items appear to be interchangeable in (6b), they give rise to different types of speech acts: when *asur* and *en* are used, (6b) is an assertion, but when *lo* is used, (6b) is a directive. Evidence for this comes from the fact that only *lo* is compatible with *na* and *bevakaša* ‘please’ (6c). Note that the construction in which *en* is followed by a non-finite clause may express not only prohibition (6b) but also impossibility (6d).

- (6) a. Asur l-i ledaber it-xa.
 forbidden DAT-1SG talk.INF with-2SG.M
 ‘I’m not allowed to talk to you.’ [constructed]
 b. {Asur / Lo / En} leha?axil et ha-xay-ot.
 forbidden/NEG/NEG feed.INF ACC DEF-animal-PL
 ‘Do not feed the animals!’ [constructed]

²https://www.daat.ac.il/daat/ezrachut/begin/48_5-2.htm (Accessed on 2022-08-22)

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- c. Na lo leha?axil et ha-xay-ot!
 please NEG feed.INF ACC DEF-animal-PL
 ‘Please do not feed the animals!’ [constructed]
- d. En lada?at matay.
 NEG know.INF when
 ‘There is no knowing when.’ (Tzivoni 1993: 376)

2.3 Negation in stative predications

In existential and possessive predication, *lo* is in complementary distribution with the negative particle *en*. In the present tense, *en* is used (7a–7b), and in other tenses *lo* is used, followed by the copular verb *haya* ‘be’ (7c–7d) (Tzivoni 1993: 173). The construction with *lo* is symmetric with the corresponding affirmative, while *en* contrasts with the affirmative existential particle *yeš*. The use of a special negative existential which replaces the affirmative one reflects a widespread cross-linguistic tendency (Veselinova 2013).

- (7) a. {Yeš / En} oxel.
 EX/NEG.EX food
 ‘There is (no) food.’ [constructed]
- b. {Yeš / En} l-i oxel.
 EX/NEG.EX DAT-1SG food
 ‘I have (no) food.’ [constructed]
- c. (Lo) hay-a oxel.
 (NEG) be.PST-3SG.M food
 ‘There was (no) food.’ [constructed]
- d. (Lo) hay-a l-i oxel.
 (NEG) be.PST-3SG.M DAT-1SG food
 ‘I had (no) food.’ [constructed]

In the case of other non-verbal predicates such as equation (8a), proper inclusion (8b), attribution (8c), and locative predication (8d), *lo* is used in all tenses. However, in formal registers, the negative copula *en* is used instead of *lo* in the present tense (Tzivoni 1993: 201). There is a related use of *en* in locative predication where the location is not specified (8e). In such cases, the argument can be understood to be absent either temporarily or permanently (Tzivoni 1993: 181). Notice that the negative particle precedes the copular verb *haya* ‘be’ (8f) but

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follows non-verbal copulas such as those in (8a-b), which are derived from third-person independent pronouns. Finally, in formal registers, affirmative copular clauses may be formed with the inflecting copula *hin-* (8g), which is the affirmative counterpart of *en* (see §2.1). This copula cannot be negated.

- (8) a. Gila (hi) {lo / en-a} ima šel-i.
Gila COP.SG.F NEG/NEG-3SG.F mother POSS-1SG
'Gila is not my mother.' [constructed]
- b. Dani (hu) {lo / en-o} rofe.
Dani COP.SG.M NEG/NEG-3SG.M doctor
'Dani is not a doctor.' [constructed]
- c. Ha-bdixa {lo / en-a} macxik-a.
DEF-joke NEG/NEG-3SG.F funny-SG.F
'The joke isn't funny.' [constructed]
- d. Ha-patiš {lo / en-o} b-a-argaz.
DEF-hammer NEG/NEG-3SG.M in-DEF-box
'The hammer is not in the box.' [constructed]
- e. Ha-yeled en-enu.
DEF-child NEG-3SG.M
'The child is not present.' or: 'The child is gone [dead].' (Tzivoni 1993: 181)
- f. Ha-patiš lo hay-a b-a-argaz.
DEF-hammer NEG be.PST-3SG.M in-DEF-box
'The hammer was not in the box.' [constructed]
- g. Ha-neʔešam-im hin-am hor-e-ha šel ha-yalda.
DEF-defendant-PL COP-3PL.M parent-PL-2SG.F POSS DEF-girl
'The defendants are the girl's parents.' [Beʔofen Tivʔi]

Usually, *en* follows the subject and inflects for person, number and gender (9a), but it can also precede the subject, in which case it occurs in an uninflected form (9b) (Tzivoni 1993: 211).

- (9) a. Ha-hanhala en-a axraʔi-t le-ovdan xafac-im.
DEF-management NEG-3SG.F responsible-SG.F for-loss.of item-PL
'The management is not responsible for lost items.'³

³<https://www.kfar-saba.muni.il/?CategoryID=776> (Accessed on 2019-09-26)

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- b. En ha-hanhala axraʔi-t le-ovdan xafac-im.
 NEG DEF-management responsible-SG.F for-loss.of item-PL
 ‘The management is not responsible for lost items.’⁴

The negative copula *en* cannot be used with predicates that do not have a subject argument (10a). When the subject position is filled by a non-deictic demonstrative *ze* ‘this’, *en* has to precede the subject (10b–10c) (Glinert 1989: 297).

- (10) a. {Lo / *En} kar l-i.
 NEG/NEG cold DAT-1SG
 ‘I’m not cold.’ [constructed]
 b. Ze {lo / *en-o} yaf-e.
 this NEG/NEG-3SG.M nice-SG.M
 ‘It’s not nice.’ [constructed]
 c. En ze yaf-e.
 NEG this nice-SG.M
 ‘It’s not nice.’ (Tzivoni 1993: 216)

Some copular constructions exhibit symmetric negation, while others exhibit asymmetric negation. In past and future tense, the negative particle *lo* precedes the finite copular verb *haya* ‘be’ (8f), which is also used in the affirmative. Hence, these constructions are symmetric. In the present tense, a copula is usually used in the affirmative in the case of equation (8a) and proper inclusion (8b) unless the subject is an independent pronoun. The constructions with *lo* are symmetric with the affirmative because the copula is used in the negative as well, but those with *en* are asymmetric because the copula is often omitted in the negative. Stative predicates expressing attribution (8c) and location (8d) usually do not occur with a copula in the affirmative, and hence the negative only differs from the affirmative by the presence of the negative particle or inflecting copula.

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Negation in finite (11a) and non-finite (11b) dependent clauses is normally expressed by the standard negation particle *lo*. The formal negative copula *en* may only be used in the former case (11a). Privative prepositions such as *bli* ‘without’ may take a non-finite clause as an argument too (see §3.3.1).

⁴<https://www.rehovot.muni.il/238/> (Accessed on 2019-09-26)

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- (11) a. Ze ma še-ani {lo / en-i} yoda?-at.
 this what COMP-1SG NEG/NEG-1SG know.PRS-SG.F
 ‘This is what I don’t know.’ [Be?ofen Tiv?i]
- b. Ani ma?adif-a lo lada?at.
 1SG prefer.PRS-3SG.F NEG know.INF
 ‘I prefer not to know.’ [Be?ofen Tiv?i]

However, Hebrew has several negative counterfactual conditional conjunctions, which express negation by themselves: *ilule*, *lule*, and *ilmale* (12). The latter two can also take a nominal complement, e.g., *ilmale ha-gešem* ‘if it weren’t for the rain’. Other types of negative conditionals (e.g., hypothetical) are expressed by the ordinary conditional conjunction *im* ‘if’ and the negative particle *lo* (Tzivoni 1993: 378–381).

- (12) Ilmale hay-ta l-a-šnaim haškafat olam dom-a, [...]
 if.not be.PST-3SG.F DAT-DEF-two view.of world similar-SG.F
 ‘If the two of them didn’t have a similar world view, [Barak wouldn’t be able to implement his novel approaches].’ (Tzivoni 1993: 381)

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

The phasal polarity adverb *terem* ‘not yet’ (also ‘before’), which is restricted to formal registers, is used in a clausal negation construction where it precedes the finite verb (13a). This adverb is interchangeable with *adain lo* ‘not yet’ (lit. ‘still not’), except for the fact that *terem* cannot be used with negative indefinites of the *af/šum*-series (13b) (see §3.2.2). The adverb *terem* can also be used as a negative reply to a polar question (14) (see §3.1 for a discussion of negative replies).

- (13) a. Terem nifgaš-nu.
 not.yet meet.PST-1PL
 ‘We haven’t met yet.’ [constructed]
- b. * Af exad terem higia-Ø.
 even one not.yet arrive.PST-3SG.M
 (‘Nobody has arrived yet.’) [constructed]
- (14) Q: Gamar-ta kvar et ha-avoda?
 finish.PST-2SG.M already ACC DEF-job
 ‘Have you finished the job yet?’

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- A: Terem.
not.yet
'Not yet.' (Tzivoni 1993: 335)

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative replies

Negative replies to polar questions are expressed by the negative particle *lo* (15), while affirmative replies are expressed by the affirmative particle *ken* 'yes'. In the spoken language, a negative reply can also be expressed by a dental click, which can occur as a freestanding element or followed by *lo* (Shor 2020: 614–615). This interjection is probably borrowed from Arabic.

- (15) A: Dibar-ta it-o?
 talk.PST-2SG.M with-3SG.M
 'Did you talk to him?'
 B: Lo.
 NEG
 'No.' [constructed]

Burstein (1999) collected and examined thousands of question-and-answer pairs from interviews that appeared in the Israeli press. She observes that negative replies to negative questions agree with the negative proposition in the question (16).

- (16) A: Moše lo omer-Ø l-ax še-at rak-a miday?
 Moše NEG say.PRS-SG.M DAT-2SG.F COMP-you soft-SG.F too
 'Does Moshe not say to you that you are too soft?'
 B: Lo.
 NEG
 'No [he doesn't].'

Burstein (1999: 146) reports that she didn't find any example in the corpus of a single word *ken* 'yes' reply to a negative question. On the other hand, standalone negative replies to negative questions are to be found, e.g., (16). Positive replies to negative questions are often used when the question has a positive bias (Burstein 1999: 387), as in (17).

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- (17) Q: Lo mafxid-Ø? ibad-eta et ha-regel.
 NEG scary-SG.M lose.PST-2SG.M ACC DEF-leg
 ‘Isn’t it scary? You lost your leg.’
 A: Ken. Aval ata ro?e-Ø še-ata xay-Ø.
 yes but you see.PRS-SG.M COMP-you alive-SG.M
 ‘Yes [it is]. But you see that you’re alive.’ (Burststein 1999: 388)

When a question has a negative bias, a positive reply is interpreted as confirming this bias (18) unless the affirmative particle is preceded by an adverb like *davka* ‘actually’ (19), which is similar in meaning to German *doch*.

- (18) A: Lo ko?ev-Ø, naxon?
 NEG hurt.PRS-SG.M right
 ‘It doesn’t hurt, right?’
 B1: Ken, bixlal lo.
 yes at.all NEG
 ‘Yes, not at all [constructed]’
 B2: #Ken, koev-Ø.
 yes hurt.PRS-SG.M
 #Yes, it hurts.’ [constructed]
- (19) A: Lo ko?ev-Ø, naxon?
 NEG hurt.PRS-SG.M right
 ‘It doesn’t hurt, right?’
 B: Davka ken. Kcat.
 actually yes a.little
 ‘Actually, it does. A little.’⁵

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

3.2.1 Overview

The most common series of negative indefinites is the *af/šum*-series (see §3.2.2). In formal registers, the *iš*-series is an alternative, and it has a slightly broader distribution than the *af/šum*-series (see §3.2.3). Finally, the *-šehu*-series, which is primarily used in non-negative contexts, can also co-occur with negation when the indefinite pronoun is modified by a relative clause or other modifiers (see

⁵<http://stage.co.il/Stories/445839> (Accessed on 2019-09-19)

§3.2.4). Negative indefinite pronouns obligatorily co-occur with clausal negation, regardless of their position with respect to the verb (20a–20b). However, in rare cases, the negative marker is omitted for emphatic purposes (20c), possibly under the influence of English. For negated quantifier phrases, see (4.6.4).

- (20) a. {Klum / Davar} lo kar-a.
 nothing/thing NEG happen.PST-3SG.M
 ‘Nothing happened.’ [constructed]
- b. Lo kar-a {klum / davar}.
 NEG happen.PST-3SG.M nothing/thing
 ‘Nothing happened.’ [constructed]
- c. Hirgaš-ti klum ve-šum davar.
 feel.PST-1SG nothing and-no thing
 ‘[In my last pregnancy I felt that I just loved my embryo, and this time when I first saw the embryo in an ultrasound scan,] I felt absolutely nothing.’ [Beʔofen Tivʔi]

3.2.2 The *af/šum*-series

The *af/šum*-series is restricted to negative sentences. The forms *af* ‘no’ (lit. ‘even’) and *šum* ‘no’ function as determiners, e.g., *af yeled* ‘no child’. The main difference between *af* and *šum* is that *af* can only combine with singular count nouns, while *šum* is also compatible with mass nouns and plurals, e.g., *šum tlunot* ‘no complaints’ (Tzivoni 1993: 112, 118). Both *af* and *šum* can combine with generic nouns to form indefinite pronouns such as *af exad* ‘nobody’ (lit. ‘even one’), *af paʔam* ‘never’ (lit. ‘even time’), *šum makom* ‘nowhere’ (lit. ‘no place’), *šum davar* ‘nothing’ (lit. ‘no thing’). This series also includes *klum* ‘nothing’ and the formal *meʔum(a)* ‘nothing’, which only have pronominal forms. This series is unrelated to the positive *-šehu*-series, which is derived from interrogative pronouns followed by parametric concessive conditional clause (Haspelmath 1997: 298).

The *af/šum*-series can co-occur with clausal negation (20), negative modals (21a) and the privative preposition *bli* ‘without’ (21b).

- (21) a. Asur lesaper et ze le-af exad.
 forbidden tell.INF ACC this DAT-even one
 ‘We mustn’t tell anyone about it.’ (Tzivoni 1993: 336)
- b. Bli šum haxana mukdem-et.
 without no preparation prior-SG.F
 ‘Without any prior preparation.’ [Beʔofen Tivʔi]

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The *af/šum*-series cannot co-occur with implicitly negative predicates such as *sirev* ‘refuse’ (22), *besafek* ‘doubt’ and *hikxiš* ‘deny’ (Glinert 1989: 306). Note that these predicates fall under the category of INDIRECT NEGATION in Haspelmath (1997), just like *bli* ‘without’. The fact that the *af/šum*-series can co-occur with the latter but not the former suggests that the category of INDIRECT NEGATION should be split into at least two subcategories.

- (22) *Hu sirev-Ø laʔasot klum.
 3SG.M refuse.PST-3SG.M do.INF nothing
 (‘He refused to do anything.’) [constructed]

The *af/šum*-series can co-occur with superordinate negation when the matrix predicate is neg-raising (23a), and more rarely when it is non-neg-raising but also non-factive (23b) (see §4.6.1 for a discussion of neg-raising). However, the *-šehu*-series (see §3.2.4) is preferred in this context. If the matrix predicate is factive (23c) or a saying predicate (23d), only the *-šehu*-series can be used.

- (23) a. Ani lo xošev-et še-af exad beʔemet
 1SG NEG think.PRS-SG.F COMP-even one really
 hevin-Ø ma kor-e it-i.
 understand.PST-3SG.M what happen.PRS-SG.M with-1SG
 ‘I don’t think anyone really understood what was going on with me.’
 [Beʔofen Tivʔi]
- b. Ani lo batuax-Ø še-af exad b-a-xeder kan yodea-Ø
 1SG NEG sure-SG.M COMP-even one in-DEF-room here know.PRS-SG.M
 mi ze ha-koʔalicya ve-mi ze ha-opozicya.
 who COP DEF-coalition and-who COP DEF-opposition
 ‘I’m not sure anyone in this room knows who the coalition is and
 who the opposition is.’⁶
- c. Lo yada-ti še-mi-šehu moxer-Ø b-a-arec.
 NEG know.PST-1SG COMP-who-INDF sell.PRS-SG.M in-DEF-country
 ‘I didn’t know someone sells it in Israel.’ [Beʔofen Tivʔi]
- d. Makabi tel-aviv af paʔam lo taʔan-a še-mi-šehu
 Makabi Tel Aviv even time NEG claim.PST-3SG.F
 hitʔa ot-a.
 COMP-who-INDF mislead.PST-3SG.M ACC-3SG.F
 ‘Maccabi Tel Aviv (basketball club) has never claimed that someone

⁶https://www.nevo.co.il/law_html/law103/ksafim2005-02-25.htm (Accessed on 2019-09-26)

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misled it.’⁷

The *af/šum*-series can be used as a negative reply without the negative particle *lo* (24). Prescriptivists maintain that *lo* should also be used in this context (see Tzivoni 1993: 143 for references). For instance, the answer in (24) would be *lo xlum* (where /k/ is pronounced as [x] due to post-vocalic spirantization).

- (24) A: Ma amar-ta?
 what say.PST-2SG.M
 ‘What did you say?’
 B: Klum.
 nothing
 ‘Nothing.’ [constructed]

In very formal registers, *lo xlum* ‘nothing’ can also be used in full declarative clauses, but clausal negation is still obligatory (25).

- (25) En-a os-a ve-lo xlum kedey limnoa...
 NEG-3SG.F do.PRS-3SG.F and-NEG nothing in.order prevent.INF
 ‘[The government] doesn’t do anything to prevent...’ (Tzivoni 1993: 144)

3.2.3 The *iš*-series

The formal *iš*-series is almost entirely restricted to negative sentences, such as (26), but it also rarely occurs in questions and conditionals. This series consists of *iš* ‘anyone’ (lit. ‘person’) and *davar* ‘anything’ (lit. ‘thing’). The determiner *kol* ‘any’ can also be considered part of this series, but it can also function as a free-choice item (Haspelmath 1997: 298).⁸

- (26) David Levi meʔolam lo hivti-Ø le-iš davar.
 David Levi never NEG promise.PST-3SG.M DAT-person thing
 ‘David Levi has never promised anything to anyone.’ (Tzivoni 1993: 111)

The *iš*-series has a slightly broader distribution than the *af/šum*-series. For instance, the *iš*-series can co-occur with implicitly negative predicates (27a) and with then negative phasal polarity adverb *terem* ‘not yet’ (27b) (compare with (22) and (13b), respectively).

⁷<http://10tv.nana10.co.il/Article/?ArticleID=577708> (Accessed on 2019-09-26)

⁸Note that *meʔolam* in (26) is not part of the *iš*-series since it can occur in superlatives (see §4.2.2).

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- (27) a. Ax ha-yehudi sirev- $\emptyset$ lekabel davar.
 but DEF-Jew refuse.PST-3SG.M accept.INF thing
 ‘But the Jew refused to accept anything [as a reward].’⁹
- b. Ax terem neʔes-a davar.
 but not.yet do.PASS.PST-3SG.M thing
 ‘But nothing has been done yet.’¹⁰

The *iš*-series occurs very rarely in non-negative contexts such as questions and conditionals. It seems that questions with *iš*-series indefinites have a negative bias, as in (28a), but there aren’t enough examples to confirm this conjecture. It also seems that conditionals with *iš*-series indefinites have a flavor of a warning, as in (28b).

- (28) a. Axrey kol ha-mil-im [...] haʔim notar- $\emptyset$, davar haʔim notr-a
 after all DEF-word-PL Q left-SG.M thing Q left-SG.F
 I-a ahava?
 DAT-3SG.F love?
 ‘After all these words [...] is there anything left, is there any love left?’¹¹
- b. Ki im te-saper- $\emptyset$ le-iš al ha-mikre, te-kabel- $\emptyset$
 COMP if 2.F.FUT-tell-SG DAT-person about DEF-event 2.F.FUT-get-SG
 hetkef lev.
 attack heart
 ‘[The defendant told the plaintiff] that if she tells anyone about the incident, she will get a heart attack.’¹²

Indefinite pronouns of the *iš*-series cannot be used as freestanding negative replies (Tzivoni 1993: 135, 139), as demonstrated by (29). It is unclear if the reason for this is that speakers do not consider the *iš*-series as inherently negative or that this series is rarely used in spoken language, which is where one expects to find negative replies.

- (29) A: Ma asi-ta?
 what do.PST-2SG.M
 ‘What did you do?’

⁹<http://www.chabad.org.il/Magazines/Article.asp?ArticleID=13712&CategoryID=2215> (Accessed on 2019-09-29)

¹⁰<https://www.israelhayom.co.il/article/678211> (Accessed on 2019-09-26)

¹¹<https://simania.co.il/showReview.php?reviewId=49727> (Accessed on 2019-09-29)

¹²<https://www.news1.co.il/Archive/001-D-270469-00.html> (Accessed on 2019-09-29)

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B: * Davar!
 thing
 ‘Nothing!’

3.2.4 The *-šehu*-series

According to Haspelmath (1997: 135–136), the *-šehu*-series is derived from a concessive conditional clause, headed by an interrogative pronoun. For instance, *mišehu* ‘someone’ consists of *mi* ‘who’, *še* ‘that’, and the third person singular masculine pronoun *hu* literally meaning ‘who that it (is)’ or ‘whoever it may be’. The *-šehu*-series is primarily used in non-negative contexts (Haspelmath 1997: 298–299). However, a *-šehu* indefinite can occur in the same clause with negation when it is modified by a relative clause (30), an adjective, or a prepositional phrase.

- (30) Ani lo makir-Ø mi-šehu še-xolek-Ø al ze.
 1SG NEG know-SG.M who-INDF.SG.M COMP-dispute-SG.M on this
 ‘I don’t know anyone who disputes that.’ [Beʔofen Tivʔi]

However, unlike the *af/šum*-series and the *iš*-series, indefinite pronouns of the *-šehu*-series have to follow negation in order to be interpreted in its scope. For instance, in (31) *mišehu* ‘someone’ precedes negation and can only be interpreted outside its scope.

- (31) Mi-šehu še-ani makir-a lo sagar-Ø et ha-delet.
 who-INDF that-1SG know-SG.F NEG close.PST-3SG.M ACC DEF-door
 ‘Someone I know didn’t close the door.’ [constructed]

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

3.3.1 Privative markers

Privative prepositions include *bli* ‘without’, sometimes preceded by another preposition, and the negative particle *lo*, which is always preceded by another preposition, e.g., *le-lo* and *be-lo* (Tzivoni 1993: 68). Bare *bli* can either take a noun phrase (32a) or a non-finite clause (32b). When *bli* is preceded by another preposition, it can only take a clausal complement (32c) (see §2.4 for a discussion of negation in non-main clauses).

- (32) a. bli simxa
 without happiness
 ‘without happiness’

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- b. bli laševet
without sit.INF
'without sitting'
- c. mi-bli laševet
ABL-without sit.INF
'without sitting' (Tzivoni 1993: 68)

The negative particle *lo* most often combines with the dative/allative preposition *le-*. It can take either a noun phrase (33a) or a non-finite clause (33b). When *lo* combines with *be-* 'in', only a noun phrase complement is possible.

- (33) a. le-lo simxa
DAT-NEG happiness
'without happiness'
- b. le-lo nua
DAT-NEG move.INF
'without moving' (Tzivoni 1993: 68)

Neither *bli* nor *lelo* can take personal pronouns as complements. Instead, the preposition *bilʔadey* 'without' is used (34). This is the sole function of *bilʔadey* in the spoken language, but in formal registers it can also take a definite noun phrase as a complement (Tzivoni 1993: 74).

- (34) Bilʔadey-ha lo i-hiy-e sipur.
without-3SG.F NEG 3.M.FUT-be-SG story
'Without her, there will be no story.' (Tzivoni 1993: 74)

Hebrew has another set of privative markers, which are derived from participial forms. These markers can only modify noun phrases: *xasar* (e.g., *xasar buša* 'shameless'), *neʔedar* (e.g., *neʔedar haskala* 'uneducated'), and *netul* (e.g., *netul kafeʔin* 'caffeine free'). The former two forms have nominal equivalents, e.g., *xoser buša* 'shamelessness' and *heʔeder haskala* 'lack of education' (Tzivoni 1993: 55–66, 77–81).

3.3.2 Opposition and antonymy

Markers of opposition and antonymy include *bilti*, *lo*, *i-*, and *al*. *bilti* modifies adjectives, e.g., *bilti racuy* 'undesirable'. *bilti* usually cannot modify adjectives that have lexical antonyms. For instance, **bilti tov* ('ungood') is arguably blocked

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by *ra* ‘bad’. On the other hand, *lo* is not subject to such a restriction, e.g., *lo tov* ‘not good’. Another restriction is that *bilti* cannot modify adjectives such as color terms, which do not have antonyms, e.g., **bilti lavan* ‘unwhite’ (Tzivoni 1993: 31).

Since *lo* is also used in stative predication (see §2.3), there is often a structural ambiguity in the present tense between clausal negation and negative derivation (35). On the other hand, structural ambiguity does not arise in other tenses due to the presence of the verbal copula (36a–36b).

- (35) Clausal negation / negative derivation
 Ze lo menumas.
 this NEG polite
 ‘It’s not polite.’ or: ‘It’s impolite.’ [constructed]
- (36) a. Clausal negation
 Ze lo hay-a menumas.
 this NEG be.PST-3SG.M polite
 ‘It wasn’t polite.’ [constructed]
- b. Negative derivation
 Ze hay-a lo menumas.
 this be.PST-3SG.M NEG polite
 ‘It was impolite.’ [constructed]

The prefix *i-* modifies abstract nouns, e.g., *i-racon* ‘unwillingness’, including action nominals, e.g., *i-havana* ‘misunderstanding’ (Tzivoni 1993: 43–44). The prefix *al-* modifies adjectives, e.g., *al-xuti* ‘wireless’, and nouns, e.g., *al-mavet* ‘immortality’ (Tzivoni 1993: 25–26). This prefix is no longer productive.

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

Contrastive negation is expressed by employing prosodic stress on the focused constituent (37a) or by placing the negative particle *lo* immediately before that constituent (37b) (Shor 2020: 599).

- (37) a. Ve-gam lo xani-ta ro, xani-ta lemala.
 and-also NEG park.PST-2SG.M here park.PST-2SG.M up
 ‘And you didn’t park here either, you parked up [the street].’ (Shor 2020: 599)

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- b. Yoce sof-šavua lo ha-karov, ha-ba.
 come.out.SG.M end-week NEG DEF-upcoming DEF-next
 ‘It will be not the upcoming weekend, but the next.’ (Shor 2020: 599)

A focused element may also be preposed together with the negative particle (38a). In fact, preposing is obligatory when the negative particle is not in its normal pre-verbal position unless the clause is followed by a corrective *but* clause. For instance, in (38b) the first clause is odd without the presence of the second clause. Note that the conjunction that is used in corrective clauses is *ela* ‘but’ rather than the ordinary adversative conjunction *aval* ‘but’.

- (38) a. Lo IT-I dibar-ta.
 NEG with-1SG talk.PST-2SG.M
 ‘It wasn’t me you talked to.’ [constructed]
 b. Dibar-ta lo IT-I, ela im ax šel-i.
 talk.PST-2SG.M NEG with-1SG but with brother POSS-1SG
 ‘You didn’t talk to ME, you talked to my BROTHER.’ [constructed]

4.2 Polarity items

4.2.1 Overview

Negative Polarity Items (NPIs) are items that can co-occur with negation but cannot occur in a positive declarative episodic sentence, i.e., a sentence that relates a specific event. Hebrew NPIs include:

- phasal polarity adverbs, e.g., *yoter* ‘anymore’
- maximizers, e.g., *meʔolam* ‘ever (in the past)’ (lit. ‘from eternity’), *baxaim* ‘ever’ (lit. ‘in life’)
- minimizers, e.g., *nakaf echa* ‘lift a finger’, *acam ain* ‘sleep a wink’
- vulgar idioms, e.g., *lo meziz li* ‘I don’t give a damn’ (lit. ‘it doesn’t move [the tip of my belly button/finger/etc.]’)
- idiomatic expressions, e.g., *lo bixdi* ‘not for naught’

Positive Polarity Items (PPIs) are items that can occur in a positive declarative episodic sentence but cannot co-occur with negation in the same clause and be interpreted in its scope. Hebrew PPIs include:

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- phasal polarity adverbs, e.g., *kvar* ‘already’, *adain* ‘still’
- minimizers, e.g., *kcat* ‘a little’, *tipa* ‘a little bit’ (lit. ‘a drop’)
- approximators, e.g., *dey* ‘rather’, *be?erex* ‘approximately’

The rest of this section focuses on those items that appear to be of typological interest.

4.2.2 *me?olam* and *le?olam* ‘ever’

Hebrew has two adverbs that are built on the word *olam* ‘eternity’: *me?olam* ‘ever (in the past)’ and *le?olam* ‘ever (in the present or future)’. Their literal meaning is ‘from eternity’ and ‘to eternity’, respectively. In the spoken language, both of these items are NPIs.

The adverb *me?olam* has a broader distribution than *le?olam*. For example, the former, but not the latter, can occur in superlatives (39), questions and conditionals.

- (39) a. Ha-maim haxi mera?anen-im še-ta?am-ti me?olam.
 DEF-water most refreshing-PL that-taste.PST-1SG ever
 ‘The most refreshing water I have ever tasted.’ [Be?ofen Tiv?i]
- b. *Ze ha-seret haxi tov še-ti-r?-e le?olam!
 it DEF-movie most good that-2.FUT-see-SG.M ever
 (‘It’s the best movie you’ll ever see!’) [constructed]

However, in formal registers *le?olam* can also be used in affirmative sentences, where it means ‘forever’ (40). *me?olam* is used in such contexts mostly in the idiom *me?az u-me?olam* ‘since time immemorial’.

- (40) Le?olam e-zkor l-ahen xesed ziknat-an.
 forever 1SG.FUT-remember DAT-3PL.F devotion old.age-3PL.F
 ‘I will always remember the devotion of their old age.’ [Be?ofen Tiv?i]

4.2.3 *tipa* ‘a little bit’

Minimizers are idiomatic expressions of minimal amount, e.g., *lift a finger*, *sleep a wink*, *say a word* (Giannakidou 2011: 1662). Minimizers are usually associated with NPIs, but in Modern Hebrew some of them are PPIs. *tipa* ‘a little bit’ (lit. ‘a drop’) is particularly interesting because in one construction it behaves like a

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PPI, and in another like an NPI. As an adverb, *tipa* is a PPI (41a–41b). However, note that *tipa* can co-occur with negation when it is in the focus of the scalar additive particle *afilu* ‘even’ (41c).

- (41) a. Ani *tipa* *meʔuxzav*-Ø.
1SG drop disappointed-SG.M
‘I’m a little bit disappointed.’ [Beʔofen Tivʔi]
b. *Ani lo *tipa* *meʔuxzav*-Ø.
1SG NEG drop disappointed-SG.M
‘(I’m not one bit disappointed.)’ [constructed]
c. Ani *afilu* lo *tipa* *mešuʔašaʔ*-at.
1SG even NEG drop amused-SG.F
‘I’m not even one bit amused.’¹³

On the other hand, when *tipa* functions as a noun in a pseudo-partitive construction (i.e., ‘a drop of’), it is an NPI (42).

- (42) a. En l-i *tipat* *pratiyut*.
NEG.EX DAT-1SG drop.of privacy.
‘I don’t have any privacy whatsoever.’ [Beʔofen Tivʔi]
b. *Yeš l-i *tipat* *pratiyut*.
EX DAT-1SG drop.of privacy.
‘(I have a little privacy.)’ [constructed]

4.2.4 *ey paʔam* ‘ever’ and *paʔam* ‘some time, once’

The adverbs *ey paʔam* ‘ever’ (lit. ‘which time’) and *paʔam* ‘some time, once’ (lit. ‘time’) are interchangeable in most contexts, e.g., questions (43a), but *ey paʔam* ‘ever’ is an NPI, and *paʔam* ‘some time, once’ is a PPI. In positive episodic sentences, only *paʔam* can be used (43b). In comparatives and superlatives, only *ey paʔam* can be used (43c). Interestingly, *ey paʔam* cannot occur in the same clause with negation (43d) (Tzivoni 1993: 155, Francez & Goldring 2012: 366). In this context, *af paʔam* ‘never’ (see §3.2.2) or *baxaim* ‘ever’ are used instead.

- (43) a. Nahag-ta (ey) *paʔam* l-a-avoda?
drive.PST-2SG.M which time to-DEF-work
‘Have you ever driven to work?’ (Francez & Goldring 2012: 366)

¹³<http://www.themarket.com/misc/smartphonexmlfeed/1.2655748> (Accessed on 2019-09-29)

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- b. Pagaš-ti ot-o paʔam b-a-kanyon.
meet.PST-1SG ACC-3SG which time in-DEF-mall
'I've met him once at the mall.'¹⁴
- c. Zot ha-memšala haxi grua ey paʔam.
this.SG.F DEF-government most bad.SG.F which time
'This is the worst government ever.' (Francez & Goldring 2012: 366)
- d. ? Ani lo nahag-ti (ey) paʔam l-a-avoda.
I NEG drive.PST-1SG which time to-DEF-work
'(I haven't ever driven to work.)' (Francez & Goldring 2012: 366)

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

Marking of NPs is not affected by negation.

4.4 Reinforcing negation

Negation can be reinforced by intensifiers such as *bixlal* 'at all' (44a) and minimizers (44b).

- (44) a. Ani bixlal lo maskim-a.
1SG at.all NEG agree.PRS-SG.F
'I don't agree at all.' [Beʔofen Tivʔi]
- b. Lo amar-ti mila.
NEG say.PST-1SG word
'I didn't say a word.' [Beʔofen Tivʔi]

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

Coordination of a positive and a negative clause may involve verb phrase ellipsis (45). This type of ellipsis is also available in coordination of two positive clauses.

- (45) Anaxnu yodʔ-im ve-atem lo [yodʔ-im].
1PL know.PRS-PL.M and-you.PL NEG know.PRS-PL.M
'We know and you don't [know].' [Beʔofen Tivʔi]

Hebrew does not have negative coordinators. However, there is a construction in which the negative particle *lo* precedes each of the conjuncts (46a). This construction is more emphatic than its unmarked counterpart (46b).

¹⁴<https://www.ynet.co.il/Ext/App/TalkBack/CdaViewOpenTalkBack/0,11382,L-4944298-2,00.html> (Accessed on 2019-09-29)

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- (46) a. Lo hay-a l-i ixpat lo me-ha-yehudi-m ve-lo
 NEG be.PST-3SG.M DAT-1SG care NEG from-DEF-Jew-PL and-NEG
 me-ha-aravi-m.
 from-DEF-Arab-PL
 ‘I cared neither about the Jews nor about the Arabs.’ (Tzivoni 1993: 353)
- b. Lo hay-a l-i ixpat me-ha-yehudi-m o
 NEG be.PST-3SG.M DAT-1SG care from-DEF-Jew-PL or
 me-ha-aravi-m.
 from-DEF-Arab-PL
 ‘I didn’t care about the Jews or the Arabs.’ [constructed]

When the verb precedes the conjuncts, e.g., (46a), clausal negation is obligatory. However, when the verb follows the conjuncts (47), clausal negation is optional (Tzivoni 1993: 354).

- (47) Lo ha-doktor ve-lo ha-profesor (lo) dibr-u al
 NEG DEF-doctor and-NEG DEF-professor NEG talk.PST-3PL about
 šituf našim b-a-šilton.
 participation.of women in-DEF-administration
 ‘Neither the doctor nor the professor [...] talked about letting women take part in the administration.’ (Tzivoni 1993: 354)

4.6 Other aspects of negation

4.6.1 Negative transport

Negative transport is a phenomenon where negation of a higher clause is interpreted as negating a subordinate clause. Neg-raising predicates are listed below based on the classification in Horn (1978).

- **Opinion:** *xošev* ‘think’, *maʔamin* ‘believe’, *savur* ‘of the opinion that’, *mešaʔer* ‘suppose’, *meniax* ‘assume’, *metaʔer leʔacmi* ‘I imagine’, *nirʔe li* ‘it seems to me’ (Tzivoni 1993: 275), *nidme li* ‘it seems to me’, and *cofe* ‘predict’.
- **Perception:** *nirʔe* ‘look like’, *nišma* ‘sound like’, and *margiš* ‘feel like’.
- **Probability:** *savir* ‘likely’.

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- **Intention/volition:** *roce* ‘want’ (Tzivoni 1993: 280), *xošev* ‘think of’ (Tzivoni 1993: 273), *ba li* ‘I want’, *meʔunyan* ‘interested in’, *mitkaven* ‘intend’, and *metaxnen* ‘plan’.
- **Judgment/obligation:** *amur* ‘supposed’, *carix* ‘need’, and *mamlic* ‘recommend’.

Some of the aforementioned categories also include non-neg-raising predicates:

- **Opinion:** *menaxeš* ‘guess’, *mešuxna* ‘convinced’, and *batuax* ‘sure’.
- **Intention/volition:** *mekave* ‘hope’ and *maʔadif* ‘prefer’.
- **Judgment/obligation:** *xayav* ‘must’.

The difference between a neg-raising predicate and a non-neg-raiser is exemplified in (48) in the domain of necessity modals. Example (48a) contains the neg-raising *carix* ‘need’, and its salient reading is one where the modal takes wide scope over negation: it is necessary that children not be exposed to such horrors. By contrast, *xayav* ‘must’ in (48b) is not a neg-raiser, and negation takes wide scope over the modal: it is not necessary that children be exposed to such horrors. Also see §3.2 for a discussion of the relevance of neg-raising to licensing of negative indefinites.

- (48) a. Yelad-im lo crix-im lehexasef le-zvaʔ-ot kaʔele.
 child-PL NEG need-PL.M be.exposed.INF DAT-horror-PL.F such
 ‘Children shouldn’t be exposed to such horrors.’¹⁵
- b. Yelad-im lo xayav-im lehexasef le-zvaʔ-ot kaʔele.
 child-PL NEG must-PL.M be.exposed.INF DAT-horror-PL.F such
 ‘Children don’t have to be exposed to such horrors.’ [constructed]

4.6.2 Metalinguistic negation

Metalinguistic negation is a use of negation where what is negated is not the assertive content of the proposition but the way it is expressed (Horn 1989: 363). Metalinguistic negation looks like ordinary negation in Hebrew.

- (49) Ze lo tov, ze meʔule.
 this NEG good this great
 ‘It’s not good, it’s great.’ [constructed]

¹⁵<https://www.haaretz.co.il/gallery/television/tv-review/1.1866196> (Accessed on 2020-07-03)

4.6.3 Non-negative uses of negatives and expletive negation

Expletive negation—i.e., a non-negative use of a negative marker—is found in several contexts, and it is always optional. First, expletive negation is often used in free relative clauses (50). In this context, expletive negation gives rise to an interpretation which is similar to English *-ever*, i.e., speaker indifference or ignorance (Eilam 2007: 41).

- (50) Ma še-dani lo katav-Ø, hitparsem-Ø
 what that-Dani NEG write.PST-3SG.M publish.PASS.PST-3SG.M
 b-a-iton.
 in-DEF-newspaper
 ‘Whatever Danny wrote was published in the newspaper.’ (Eilam 2007: 41)

A related use of expletive negation is in exclamative rhetorical questions (Rubinstein et al. 2015: 167).

- (51) Be-ma lo heʔešim-u ot-o!
 in-what NEG blame.PST-3PL ACC-3SG.M
 ‘The things he’s been blamed for!’ (lit. ‘What hasn’t he been blamed for?!’) (Rubinstein et al. 2015: 167)

Second, expletive negation is used in clausal complements of *ad* ‘until’ (52), *bli* ‘without’ and, less often, *lifney* ‘before’ (Rubinstein et al. 2015: 168).

- (52) Ad še-lo ya-gia milyarder rusi, nyukasel
 until that-NEG 3.FUT-arrive-SG.M billionaire Russian Newcastle
 ti-tkaše-Ø.
 3.F.FUT-have.trouble.SG
 ‘Newcastle will be in trouble until a Russian billionaire comes along.’
 (Rubinstein et al. 2015: 168)

Expletive negation is not used in complements of emotive predicates such as ‘fear’ and ‘doubt’. However, it is used in complements of negated ‘surprise’ predicates (Rubinstein et al. 2015: 169).

- (53) Ani lo e-tpale im hu lo yazam-Ø et kol
 1SG NEG 1SG.FUT-be.surprised if 3SG.M NEG initiate.PST-3SG.M ACC all
 ha-takrit ha-mexoʔer-et ha-zo.
 DEF-incident DEF-ugly-SG.F DEF-this
 ‘I wouldn’t be surprised if he is the one behind this ugly incident.’
 (Rubinstein et al. 2015: 169)

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4.6.4 Negated quantifier phrase constructions

Modern Hebrew has two types of negated quantifier phrase constructions: (i) *lo kol* ‘not all (NP)’ and *lo harbe* ‘not many (NP)’; (ii) *lo meʔat* ‘quite a few’. The difference between the two types is that the former may only occur pre-verbally (54a–54b), whereas the latter may also occur post-verbally (55a–55b). Another difference is related to their interaction with prepositions. In the case of *lo kol*, the negative particle *lo* has to precede the entire prepositional phrase (54c). On the other hand, a preposition takes *lo meʔat* in its entirety as its complement (55c).

- (54) a. *Lo kol ha-student-im ba-u.*
 NEG all DEF-student-PL come.PST-3PL
 ‘Not all of the students came.’ [constructed]
- b. **Ba-u lo kol ha-student-im.*
 come.PST-3PL NEG all DEF-student-PL
 (‘Not all of the students came.’) [constructed]
- c. *Lo le-kol ha-student-im yeš mexonit.*
 NEG DAT-all DEF-student-PL EX car
 ‘Not all of the students have a car.’ [constructed]
- (55) a. *Lo meʔat student-im ba-u.*
 NEG few student-PL come.PST-3PL
 ‘Quite a few students came.’ [constructed]
- b. *Ba-u lo meʔat student-im.*
 come.PST-3PL NEG few student-PL
 ‘Quite a few students came.’ [constructed]
- c. *Le-lo meʔat student-im yeš mexonit.*
 DAT-NEG few student-PL EX car
 ‘Quite a few students have a car.’ [constructed]

4.6.5 Diachronic notes and observations

The expansion of the functions of the negative existential *en* into the verbal domain is an instance of the Negative Existential Cycle (Croft 1991; Veselinova 2014, 2016). Hebrew exhibits an overlap of two types in the cycle: A~B and B~C. On the one hand, it belongs to type A~B because *en* is used in existential negation only in the present tense, whereas the standard negator *lo* is used in other tenses

(see §2.3). On the other hand, it belongs to type B~C because *en* may be used to negate present tense verbs, which are historically derived from the present participle (see §2.1). This overlap dates back to Biblical Hebrew (Naudé et al. 2019, Naudé et al. 2022).

5 Summary

In clausal negation, the choice of negative particle depends on three criteria, namely, sentence type (declarative or imperative), type of predication, and tense. The main negation strategies in Hebrew are summarized in Table 1.

Table 1: Summary of negation strategies in Hebrew

Negative marker	Function	Section
<i>lo</i> (negative particle)	verbal predication	§2.1
	nominal, adjectival, and locative predication	§2.3
	existential and possessive predication, except in the present tense	§2.3
	negative reply	§3.1
	constituent negation	§4.1, §4.6.2
	impersonal prohibition	§2.2
<i>en</i> (negative copula)	existential and possessive predication in the present tense	§2.3
	verbal predication in the present tense, formal register	§2.1
	nominal, adjectival, and locative predication in the present tense, formal register	§2.3
	impersonal prohibition, formal register	§2.2
<i>al</i> (negative particle)	prohibitives	§2.2
	jussive construction	§2.2
<i>terem</i> (adverb)	phasal polarity adverb ‘not yet’	§2.5

The constructions with *lo* and *terem* are symmetric with the affirmative. On the other hand, existential and possessive constructions with *en* are asymmetric with the affirmative because *en* is in contrastive distribution with the affirmative existential particle *yeš*. Copular constructions with *en* typically exhibit a constructional asymmetry because *en* is followed by a clitic pronoun, which is absent in the affirmative. However, *en* may also occur clause-initially rather than

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after the subject, in which case it does not co-occur with a clitic pronoun, and hence there is no asymmetry. Finally, prohibitives exhibit a paradigmatic asymmetry in those cases where a verb has retained the dedicated imperative form, which is restricted to the affirmative (see §2.2).

In addition to the above-mentioned negative markers, Modern Hebrew has several negative indefinites (see §3.2), a wide variety of negative derivations (see §3.3), and several negative counterfactual conditional conjunctions (see §2.4).

Abbreviations

1	first person	INDF	indefinite
2	second person	INF	infinitive
3	third person	M	masculine
ABL	ablative	NEG	negation
ACC	accusative	PASS	passive
COMP	complementizer	PL	plural
COP	copula	PN	proper name
DAT	dative	POSS	possessive
DEF	definite	PROH	prohibitive
EX	existential	PRS	present
F	feminine	PST	past
FUT	future	Q	question particle
IMP	imperative	SG	singular

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Chapter 5

Negation in Veps

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This chapter presents an overview of different negation strategies and diachronic changes in Veps, an endangered northwestern Uralic language belonging to the Finnic branch. Basic negation patterns in Veps share many characteristics with other northern Finnic languages. However, Veps displays a negation system with many innovations and manifests several language-specific morphosyntactic patterns, a lot of syntactic variation, and secondary lexicalization in negative phrases. Several specifically Veps features and syntactic changes, such as number agreement between the negative auxiliary and the verb in plural, alternating word order, and negative existentials increase the divergence of Veps negation in comparison with neighboring and related languages. Language contacts play a significant role as well, as lexical negation and indefinites involve a strong Russian influence, whereas in clausal negation it is not as significant.

Keywords: Veps, Finnic, negation, language contact, Russian, scope of negation.

1 Introduction

Veps (ISO: **vep**, Glottocode: **veps1250**) is the eastern-most Finnic language spoken in Northwestern Russia in the Republic of Karelia, Leningrad oblast and Vologda oblast. The historical core area is located between the lakes Ladoga, Onega, Beloe Ozero and along the shores of river Oyat'. Veps is more heavily influenced by Russian than other Finnic languages and long-term bilingualism involves both intensive lexical and grammatical borrowing. The population size has constantly decreased since 1930's, which is caused by the lack of sustainable development, insufficient political rights and an unfavorable position of minority languages in the Soviet Union and Russia. The estimated current number of speakers is

less than 2500¹ consisting mainly of elder generations with a rural background (Grünthal 2011; Puura et al. 2013: 23–32; Strogal'sčikova 1989, 2006). In the beginning of 1990's a new Veps standardized language was introduced. It is regularly used in a monthly newspaper and more randomly in media and other printed publications.

A number of linguistic works describing the Veps language and the history of the Veps people have been published since the 19th century, the first linguistic descriptions dating back to 1840's and 1850's (Branch 1973: 83–92; Grünthal 2015: 18–24; Karjalainen 2016; Korhonen 1986: 43–45, 76–80; Puura 2019; Puura et al. 2013: 2–8; Strogal'sčikova 2008; Zaitseva 1981, 2001). The dialects are divided into Northern, Central and Southern Veps, which are mutually easily intelligible, the southern dialect having more distinctive features than the two other ones.

Typologically, the Veps language displays abundant suffixal morphology and has clearly distinct nominal and verbal paradigms. It has 17–18 inflectional cases and distinguishes between two conjugation types as it displays reflexive conjugation that diverges from the basic paradigm (Grünthal 2015, 2017: 133–135; Ket-tunen 1943a: 421–434; Zaitseva 1981, 2001). It manifests much less morphophonological alternation than other Finnic and Saamic languages and lacks consonant gradation typical of these two Uralic branches. Language contact with Russian has evoked changes in word order which shows variation between the Finnic default pattern SVO and inherited Uralic SOV, which is secondary in Veps and used for pragmatic purposes. Word order variation is a language-specific characteristic of Veps negation in declarative clauses (see, Sections §2.1.1 and §2.1.2).

The considerably high amount of variation and divergence in Veps negation shows that negative phrases are liable to morphosyntactic changes. Like other northern Finnic languages, Veps does not distinguish between present and past tense negative auxiliary, which is characteristic of more eastern Uralic languages, such as Mordvin and Mari (Hamari & Aasmäe 2015; Saarinen 2015) and has been preserved as a recessive archaic feature in South Estonian, Insular dialects of Estonian, and Livonian. Language-specific changes have secondarily increased the means of negation in Veps, which displays strongly divergent features in plural negation and the fusional negative existential. (For negation in other Finnic languages, cf. Lindström et al. 2021; Metslang et al. 2015; Rozhanski & Markus 2017; Vilkuna 2015, 2022.)

¹The last population census of Russia was carried out in 2021. The data were published at the end of 2022. The official statistics show a decrease in the number of ethnic Veps from over 5900 in 2010 to over 4300 in 2021 (Prozes 2023). The number of Veps speakers is critically assessed in literature (Grünthal 2011; Puura et al. 2013: 23–32; Strogal'sčikova 1989, 2006), which shows that it is considerably smaller than the number of ethnicity.

In this paper, data illustrating Veps negation are drawn from published text collections (Kettunen 1920, 1925, Kettunen & Siro 1935, Kettunen 1943b) representing spoken language from the first half of the 20th century, and the author's fieldtrips between 2005–2014.² Examples from vernacular speech are presented in a phonologically standardized form lacking diacritics.

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

2.1.1 Basic declarative sentence

Verb conjugation distinguishes between present, simple past and, most notably, the standardized language (Zaitseva 2000, 2001: 107–120), two compound past tenses. In colloquial speech and dialects, however, the system often operates with a simplified contrast between two tenses, namely present and simple past (Grünthal 2015: 120–149; Kettunen 1943a: 62–63, 76–77). The same negative auxiliary is used both in present and past tense inflecting for person as in most other Finnic languages. In present tense, the main verb displays an unmarked connegative form (1–2), whereas past tense is indicated with the past tense participle (3). The copula *lii-da* be.FUT-INF ‘be (fut.)’ is the only verb that indicates future, whereas the declarative negative clause is identical with present tense (4). The default word order is NEG + verb.

- (1) Mams se sanu-i: e-n rohti libu-da.
mother it say-PST.3SG NEG-1SG dare.CNG arise-INF
‘The mother said: I daren’t arise.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 32)
- (2) E-taa mahta išt-taaze.
NEG-2PL can.CNG sit-INF.REFL
‘You can’t sit down.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 116)
- (3) Kana-š-t, sanu-b, e-d to-nd.
chicken-DIM-PAR say-3SG NEG-2SG bring-PST.PTCP
‘You didn’t bring a chicken, (s)he says.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 92)
- (4) Ma-d jaugoo-d’en aa ii muja-nd.
soil-PAR foot-PL-GEN under NEG.3 feel-PST.PTCP
‘(S)he didn’t feel the soil under her/his feet.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 83)

²Data from these fieldtrips are marked with the village and year in which the data was collected in parentheses after the translation of the example.

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- (5) Nece-n maksa-n taga ii liine annie mehe-l.
 this-GEN friend-GEN behind NEG.3 FUT.CNG Annie man-ADE
 ‘Annie will not marry this friend.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 166)

In affirmative clauses the main verb inflects for both person (6) and tense (7). In the negative phrase person marking is transferred to the auxiliary as indicated above, whereas in past tense the main verb has a past tense participle affix (3–4) instead of the primary past tense marker.

- (6) Mina tabada-n tii-d da riko-n.
 1SG catch-1SG 2PL-PAR and kill-1SG
 ‘I will catch and kill you!’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 39)
- (7) El-i-maa nel’ vo-t hän-mu.
 live-PST-1PL four year-PAR 3SG-COM
 ‘We lived four years with him.’ (VeS, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 5)

Structurally a basic affirmative declarative clause and its negative pair are asymmetric. The morphosyntactic pattern of the negative VP diverges from the affirmative one as the person marker shifts to the inflecting negative auxiliary (NEG.AUX) in negative phrases. This happens both in the subjective (basic) and the reflexive paradigm (Table 1³). However, reflexive verbs display a morphologically split strategy in negation as the auxiliary adopts the regular person marker, whereas the lexical verb manifests a distinct reflexive stem for connegative. In most dialects connegative forms index plural. In contrast to declarative clauses, the affirmative and negative imperative clauses are, however, symmetric (see, §2.2).

A similar negation pattern is used in simple past tense clauses. Given that there is no past tense NEG.AUX, tense is marked on the lexical verb both in affirmative (-i-) and negative clauses that have a past tense participle (-nu(d) ~ -nd) like other Finnic languages (Table 2). The morpheme order in past tense negative forms is NEG-PERSON V-PST-PL as in (8) and (9). Connegative forms agree in number (plural) with inflecting plural NEG.AUX (see, §2.1.3).

³Historically, present tense 3PL forms originate from an impersonal form labeled as “passive” in the grammatical descriptions of various Finnic languages. However, vernacular Veps does not make the distinction between 3PL and passive form because both can be used in impersonal functions. Paradigmatically, this has caused the merger of 3PL and passive paradigms. In this article, historical passive forms that mostly represent Northern and Central Veps are encoded as 3PL, whereas in Ludic the glossing PASS is applied.

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Table 1: Affirmative and negative paradigm of the verb *tehta* ‘do’ and *pestas* ‘wash (oneself)’ in Central Veps (Zaitseva 2001: 254, 267–268)

	subjective conjugation teh-ta do-INF		reflexive conjugation pes-tas wash (oneself)-INF	
1SG	tege-n	e-n tege	peze-moi	e-n peste
2SG	tege-d	e-d tege	peze-toi	e-d peste
3SG	tege-b	ii /ei tege	peze-soi / peze-se	ii /ei peste
1PL	tege-m	e-m / e-mei teh-koi	peze-moiš	e-m peste / e-mei pes-koiš
2PL	tege-t	e-d / e-tei teh-koi	peze-toiš	e-d peste / e-tei pes-koiš
3PL	teh-tas	ii / ei teh-koi	peze-soiš	ii peste / ei pes-koiš

- (8) E-mei teh-nu-goi

NEG-1PL do-PST-PL

‘We didn’t do.’

- (9) E-m pez-nu-ks-oi(š).

NEG-1PL wash-PST-REFL-PL

‘We didn’t wash ourselves.’

Occasionally negation may trigger a specific connegative form which, contrary to affirmative declarative sentences, displays a derivative suffix *-ške* (10–11) (cf., below (13) and (72)). This particular suffix typically occurs only in 2SG imperative and connegative, which are morphologically unmarked categories. Here, it is labeled as the marker of perfective aspect.

- (10) E-n
- probi-ške**
- , ii
- ole-ške**
- mugoš-t.

NEG-1SG try-PFV NEG.3 be-PFV such-PAR

‘I didn’t try, there wasn’t such a thing.’ (VeC, Mäggär’v 2007)

- (11) Ningoš-t igas e-bad
- nägi-ške**
- durako-d.

such-PAR ever NEG-3PL see-PFV stupid-PAR

‘They never saw such an idiot.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 71)

2.1.2 Reversed word order V + Neg

In addition to the default word order NEG + v, Veps displays a reversed word order in negative clauses v + NEG. The previous one is more frequent but the latter one is relatively frequent as well. This kind of alternation indicates a special

Table 2: Affirmative and negative simple past tense paradigm of the verb *tehta* ‘do’ and *pestas* ‘wash (oneself)’ in Eastern and Western Central Veps ([Zaitseva 2001](#): 254–255, 268)

	subjective conjugation teh-ta do-INF		reflexive conjugation pes-tas wash(oneself)-INF	
1SG	teg-i-n	e-n tege-n(d)	pez-i-moi	e-n pez-nu-kse e-n pez-nu-s
2SG	teg-i-d’	e-d tege-n(d)	pez-i-toi	e-d pez-nu-kse e-d pez-nu-s
3SG	teg-i	ii tege-n(d)	pez-i-he	ii pez-nu-kse ei pez-nu-s
1PL	teg-i-m teg-i-me	e-m teh-nuhu e-me teh-nu-goi	pez-i-moiš	e-m pez-nu-ks-oi(š) e-me pez-nu-soiš
2PL	teg-i-d’ teg-i-tei	e-d teh-nuhu e-tei teh-nu-goi	pez-i-toiš	e-d pez-nu-ks-oi(š) e-tei pez-nu-soiš
3PL	teg-i-ba	ii teh-nuhu ei teh-nu-goi	pez-i-(he-)zoiš	ii pez-nu-ks-oi(š) ei pez-nu-soiš

emphasis and topical focus in discourse. More generally, the verb characteristically precedes its dependents following the SVO pattern. A sentence-final verb may occur in affirmative clauses shifting the focus to the preceding object or adverbial, which may also occur in sentence-initial position. The sentence-final negative auxiliary shifts the person-marking unit to the last position as in affirmative clauses. The scope of negation of the reversed order V + NEG is larger as the sentence-final NEG.AUX scopes over the whole clause (12–15).

- (12) Mö sö-htä-n e-maa.
1PL eat-MOM-PST.PTCP NEG-1PL
‘We didn’t eat.’ (VeS, [Kettunen 1920](#): 93)
- (13) Ende bajri-d aje-l-i-ške e-bad keloo-mu.
Earlier boyar-PL ride-CONT-PST-MOM NEG-3PL bell-PROL
‘Earlier the boyars didn’t ride around with ringing bells.’ (VeS, [Kettunen 1925](#): 17)
- (14) Hän-dast minä se tunde-nu vuu e-n.
3SG.F.ACC 1SG it know-PST.PTCP yet NEG-1SG
‘I didn’t know her, yet.’ (VeC, [Ladv 2014](#))

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- (15) Q: A vonuka-d maht-tas, elge-tas vepsa-ks?
 but grand.child-PL can-3PL understand-3PL Veps-TRA
 ‘But (your) grandchildren can, understand Veps?’
- A: Elge-tas, a pagiš-koi ii.
 understand-3PL but talk-CNG.PL NEG.3
 ‘They understand but don’t speak.’ (VeC, Ladv 2007)

This kind of permutation of constituent order is not limited to the position of the lexical verb and the negative auxiliary. The most fundamental change is seen in the use of the inherited demonstrative pronoun *se* ‘it’, which typically occurs in a prenominal position. However, it is very frequently used as a postnominal focus particle that has undergone both syntactic and semantic change. This kind of postnominal use of the particle is attested in certain other Finnic languages and Northern Russian dialects as well. In Veps, the frequency is considerably higher than in other Finnic varieties, which correlates with secondary changes in the system of demonstrative pronouns (Yurayong 2020).

The reversed constituent order *v* + NEG instead of NEG + *v* has not been investigated in more detail so far. A parallel instance can be shown in Ludic (16), an intermediate variety between Karelian and Veps, and Eastern South Estonian (Seto), in which it is highly frequent (Lindström et al. 2021).

- (16) Ludic (ISO: *lud*, Glottocode: *ludi1246*, Uralic)
 Üö-kš mindai ni ke-he laske-da ei.
 night-TRA 1SG.ACC NEG who-ILL let-PASS.CNG NEG
 ‘I am not allowed to anywhere for the night.’ (Ojansuu et al. 1934: 178)

2.1.3 Number agreement with plural subjects

Compared to other neighboring and related languages, number agreement between the main verb and subject is a language-specific Veps feature (see, Table 1 and Table 2 above). While an unmarked connegative form is characteristic of both the Finnic and Saamic languages, the main verb carries a specific plural marker in Veps (17–18). Thus, instead of having the verb stem as the sole connegative form, Veps has a morphologically distinct plural connegative. A similar agreement pattern is found in Komi, a more eastern Uralic language (Hamari 2015: 242, 246–248).

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- (17) Bat' da mam ii roht-kei külb-ma-ha päst-ta.
 dad and mom NEG.3 dare-CNG.PL bath-INF-ILL let-INF
 'Dad and mom dare not let [her/him] go to the sauna.' (VeN, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 157)
- (18) Papad i tütär kazaka-d familiou ii
 clergyman's.wife and daughter farmhand-PAR surname.ADE NEG.3
 kuc-koi.
 call-CNG.PL
 'The clergyman's wife and daughter do not call the farm-hand by
 surname.' (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 101)

In this case, too, Ludic (19) shares this characteristic with Veps. The use of a plural connegative in declarative sentences has a parallel in plural imperative (prohibitive)

- (19) Ludic (ISO: lud, Glottocode: ludi1246, Uralic)
 E-m ol-guu d'äl'ges kävü-tud, kaik nämä-d vahna-d.
 NEG-1PL be-CNG.PL after visit-PST.PTCP all 3PL-PL old-PL
 'We haven't been there afterwards, they are all old.' (Kettunen 1943b)

2.2 Non-declarative sentences

This section discusses negative sentences, which display one of the two morphologically marked moods, i.e. the imperative (prohibitive) and conditional. Furthermore, the negative question phrase and role of copula in non-declarative sentences will be discussed. The negative imperative is an analytic construction consisting of the auxiliary *ala* PROH and the main verb.

Imperative forms inflect for person except for first person singular. Second person singular imperative is unmarked both in affirmative and negative sentences. Both the prohibitive auxiliary and the connegative are unmarked (20–21). The imperative affix *-ga-*, used in other persons than second singular, is attached to both the lexical verb and the auxiliary, which both inflect for person (22–23). The same affix occurs in affirmative plural imperative as in the Russian borrowing *vzaderš-ka-t* hold-IMP-2PL '(you many) hold!'. There is quite a lot of phonological variation between the Veps dialects but the morphosyntactic pattern is the same in the whole language area (Zaitseva 2001: 121–137, 247–285).

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Table 3: Affirmative and negative imperative paradigm of the verb *nähta* ‘see’ and *pestas* ‘wash (oneself)’ in Standardized Veps (Zaitseva 2000: 212–213, 222)

	pur-da bite-INF		pes-tas wash (oneself)-INF	
	affirmative	negative	affirmative	negative
2SG	pure	ala pure	peste	ala peste
3SG	pur-ga-ha	al-g-ha pur-goi	pes-ka-has	al-g-ha peste
1PL	pur-ga-m	al-ga-m pur-goi	pes-ka-moi	al-ga-m pes-koiš
2PL	pur-ga-t	al-ga-t pur-goi	pes-ka-toi	al-ga-t pes-koiš
3PL	pur-ga-ha	al-g-ha pur-goi	pes-ka-has	al-g-ha pes-koiš

- (20) Ala **ambu**, Sašku, edha-n kondii, ii put-ta.
 PROH shoot.CNG Sašku distant-ESS bear NEG.3 hit-INF
 ‘Don’t shoot, Sašku, the bear is too far, one cannot hit.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 99)
- (21) Ala **lõ** mindei!
 PROH hit.CNG 1SG.ACC
 ‘Don’t hit me!’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 40)
- (22) A se pagiže-b: **al-ga-t män-gä-t!**
 but it talk-3SG PROH-IMP-2PL go-IMP-2PL
 ‘However, it says: don’t go!’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 20)
- (23) **Vzaderš-ka-t** neti-da neidiš-t i ni kut **au-ga-t päst-kä-t.**
 hold-IMP-2PL this-PAR girl-PAR and NEG how PROH-IMP-2PL let-IMP-2PL
 ‘Hold this girl and don’t let her in any case.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1925: 24)

The other affixal mood, the conditional, inflects for person in present and past tense. Unlike the imperative, the mood affix always attaches to the main verb and never to the auxiliary. In this case, the NEG.AUX *ei / ii* ‘no’ inflects for person while mood and tense are properties of the main verb, compare for instance *näg-iži-n* see-COND-1SG but *e-n näg-iži* NEG-1SG see-COND (see, Table 4).

The negative conditional sentence, as a rule, correlates morphosyntactically with negation in basic declarative sentences as the auxiliary inflects for person and the main verb inflects for tense and mood (see, Table 1 and Table 4,

Table 4: Affirmative and negative conditional paradigm of the verb *nähta* ‘see’ and *pestas* ‘wash (oneself)’ in Standardized Veps (Zaitseva 2000: 213–214, 223)

	näh-ta see-INF		pes-tas wash (oneself)-INF	
	affirmative	negative	affirmative	negative
1SG	näg-iži-n	e-n näg-iži	pez-iži-moi	e-n pez-iži-he
2SG	näg-iži-d	e-d näg-iži	pez-iži-toi	e-d pez-iži-he
3SG	näg-iži	ei näg-iži	pez-iži-he	ei pez-iži-he
1PL	näg-iži-m	e-m näg-iži	pez-iži-moiš	e-m pez-iži-he
2PL	näg-iži-t	e-t näg-iži	pez-iži-toiš	e-t pez-iži-he
3PL	näg-iži-ba	ei näg-iži	pez-iži-he	ei pez-iži-he

above). The only exception is that there is no plural agreement between the lexical verb and the subject in the conditional. In the reflexive conjugation the reflexive marker is attached to the mood affix and, hence, the morpheme order is NEG-PERSON V-COND-REFL. The third person singular and plural are always distinct in Southern Veps (24), whereas in other varieties they often have identical forms (25).

- (24) Pä-n kärri i paglaa sidoo, mise
 head-GEN(-ACC) wrap.PST.3SG and string.ADE tie.PST.3SG in.order.to
 velje-d e-bad tedustaa-ž.
 brother-PL NEG-3PL know-COND
 ‘(S)he wrapped the head and tied with a string so that the brothers would not know.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 68)
- (25) Peiteiči kundle-n (ukse-n taga), miise ii tetä-iž
 secretly listen-1SG (door-GEN behind) in.order.to NEG.3 know-COND
 rahvaz perti-š.
 people house-INE
 ‘I listen secretly (behind the door) so that people in the house would not know.’ (VeN, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 164)

The polar question phrase is formed by a question particle *-ik*, which is attached to the verb, in the negative phrase the inflecting NEG.AUX. The main verb displays an unmarked connegative form as in declarative clauses (26–27).

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- (26) **E-n-ik** mina **ole** si-lei mužik?
 NEG-1SG-Q 1SG be.CNG 2SG-ALL man
 ‘Am I not your husband?’ (VeN, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 155)
- (27) **E-d-ik** teda mi-dä ni, miše kazde-iž vaze-iže-d?
 NEG-2SG-Q know.CNG what-PAR NEG in.order.to grow-COND calf-DIM-PL
 ‘Don’t you know anything that would make the calves grow?’ (VeC,
 Kettunen & Siro 1935: 100)

2.3 Negation in stative predications

The Finnic languages, as a rule, always use a copula in stative relational clauses, which is characteristic of most Saamic languages as well but a fundamental syntactic difference in comparison with more eastern Uralic languages. Veps is an exception to this rule as it often omits the copula, although there is a lot of alternation (28–29) between Veps varieties (Grünthal 2015: 184–200). Dropping the copula is optional and functionally conditioned in affirmative clauses, whereas in negatives copula is syntactically obligatory and shows phonologically driven fusion. The lack of copula is most likely secondary and caused by the strong Russian influence.

- (28) Käzi=robeh om save-sine.
 hand=dish is clay-ADJ
 ‘There is clay in the handwashing dish.’ (VeN, Kettunen 1943b: 72)
- (29) Jorš se oghakas kala.
 ruff it thorny fish
 ‘Ruff is a thorny fish.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1943b: 70)

The difference between a clause with or without a copula is not seen in the paradigms. In the written standardized Veps copulaless clauses do not normally occur.

Unlike first and second person as well as third person plural, the constituents of the negative phrase merge in the third person singular. Forms such as *ii-li-ž* NEG-PST-COND inflecting for more categories, occur as well (Zaitseva 2001: 266). The copula may lack only in present tense affirmative declarative clauses. Other clause types involve more variation as there may be no copula in existential clauses as well (30). Tense (31–32), mood and negation are always marked by

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Table 5: Present and past tense paradigms of the verb *olda* ‘be’ in Central Veps (Zaitseva 2001: 254–275, 222)

	Present		Past	
	affirmative	negative	affirmative	negative
1SG	ole-n	en ole	ol-i-n	e-n ole-n(d)
2SG	ole-d	ed ole	ol-i-d	e-d ole-n(d)
3SG	om	iile ~ ele ~ ii ~ ei	ol-i	iilend ~ ele-n
1PL	ole-m	e-m(ei) uu-goi	ol-i-m(ei)	e-m(ei) uu-nu-goi
2PL	ole-t(ai)	e-t(ei) uu-goi	ol-i-t(ei)	e-t(ei) uu-nu-goi
3PL	oma	ii uugoi ~ ei uu-goi	ol-i-ba	ii uu-nu-goi

inflecting the copula. Predications of identity and location use the same copula or non-copula construction as stative predication shown here.

- (30) Me-ide derevna-s vähä norišto-d.
 1PL-GEN village-INE few youth-PAR
 ‘There are a few young people in our village.’ (VeC, Kettunen 1943b: 40)
- (31) Pert’ mugeine lačak ol-i.
 house such lousy be-PST.3SG
 ‘The house was such a lousy one.’ (VeN, Kettunen 1943b: 72)
- (32) Edō mā gol’u ole-l-ī-n humalakaz.
 earlier 1SG always be-FREQ-PST-1SG drunkard
 ‘Earlier I always used to be a drunkard.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1943b: 74)

The basic rule is that stative relational clauses often lack the copula but marked morphosyntactic properties, such as tense and mood, trigger it. This is reflected in the emergence of a negated copula in Veps. It is based on the fusion of NEG.AUX and the copula, which may alternate with syntactically segmentable units. Thus, there is often no copula in affirmative clauses, whereas a negative copula is obligatory in existential stative relational clauses like in more eastern Uralic languages. a feature that is more commonly found in more eastern Uralic languages (Veselinova 2015). The fused forms in Veps are most commonly third person forms, (a) *iile* be.NEG.3SG and (b) *iilen(d)* be.NEG.PST.3SG, whereas other persons use an inflecting NEG.AUX + V.CNG as in basic declarative sentences. Yet,

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the fusional negative existential is not fully lexicalized, and segmentable negative existential is frequently used besides the fusional pattern (33–34). Hence, the Veps negating copula alternates between two systems (cf. [Veselinova 2014](#)).

- (33) a. *Sinei vel'l'e-d sizare-d?*
 2SG.ALL brother-PL sister-PL
 ‘Do you have brothers or sisters?’
 b. *Ei ole vel'l'-i-d ni sizar-i-d.*
 NEG be.CNG brother-PL-PAR NEG sister-PL-PAR
 ‘There are no brothers nor sisters.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (34) *Mii-le kolhoza-s ka pasporta-d ni ii ole-nd.*
 1PL-ALL kolkhoz-INE yes passport-PAR NEG NEG.3 be-PST.PTCP
 ‘In the kolkhoz we did not have even a passport.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

The fusional negating copula that occurs in both older and contemporary data (35–36) inflects for tense. The negative past tense marking participle is simply attached to the negating copula (37) like any other verb in negative past tense forms.

- (35) *Biržuu mugažno eole elä-j-i-d nügude.*
 Birzh.ADE also NEG.be live-PTCP-PL-PAR now
 ‘Nowadays there are no inhabitants at Birzh either.’ (VeC, Mäggär’v 2007)
- (36) *Iile mü-i-le ni keng-ii-d', iile mü-i-le ni sob-ii-d'.*
 NEG.be 1PL-PL-ALL NEG shoe-PL-PAR NEG.be 1PL-PL-ALL NEG.3 cloth-PL-PAR

‘We don’t have shoes, we don’t have clothes.’ (VeS, [Kettunen 1925](#): 105)

- (37) *Sö-dä ii mi-da ol', ni soba-d iile-nd ni*
 eat-INF NEG.3 what-PAR be.PST.3SG NEG cloth-PAR NEG.be-PST.PTCP NEG
kenga-d iile-nd.
 shoe-PAR NEG.be-PST.PTCP
 ‘There was nothing to eat, there were no clothes and no shoes.’ (VeS, [Kettunen 1920](#): 56)

Functionally the negating copula has the role of a negative existential. We may formulate the reanalysis and grammaticalization from a segmentable construction to a fused form as in (38).

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(38) NEG.AUX + COP > NEGEX

Two inflecting units merge in this change. The negative auxiliary that inflects for person and number fuses with the copula, which inflects for tense and mood. However, there is no evidence that the Veps secondary negative existential would inflect for other than third person. A similar development is found Erzya, in which the negative existential has clear constraints and does not inflect for all persons (Hamari 2007: 188–207, 260–268; Hamari & Aasmäe 2015: 306–307). Instead of marking person, it operates as a generic negative existential. As in the case of number agreement of plural connegative forms (see, §2.1.3 above), the secondary negative existential occurs in Ladic as a shared feature (39) and may inflect for mood (40).⁴

(39) Ladic (ISO: **lad**, Glottocode: **ladi1246**, Uralic)
 Kunne-ni sua-nu aja-da, traktoruu-d ved' iel-nu.
 where-NEG get-PST.PTCP drive-INF tractor-PAR CLT NEG.be-PST.PTCP
 'There was nowhere to drive, there was no tractor.' (Kettunen 1943b)

(40) Ladic (ISO: **lad**, Glottocode: **ladi1246**, Uralic)
 Iel-iiž ni mičč-ii-d ur'k-ii-d da, butto
 NEG.be-COND NEG any.kind.of-PL-PAR smell-PL-PAR and, if
 iel-iiž.
 NEG.be-COND
 'If there were no smells, if there were not.' (Kettunen 1943b)

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Compared to basic declarative clauses, negation in subordinate clauses does not diverge in any significant way. The constituent order, for instance, remains the same because NEG.AUX precedes the verb even more regularly than in affirmative clauses (cf. §2.1.1 on reversed word order). This is valid both in basic subordinate clauses (41), negative conditional clauses (42), temporal subordination, example (43) showing the maintenance of the fused negative existential in a subordinate clause, relative clauses (44), and reversed question clauses (45).

⁴More research is needed on the encoding of negative existence in Veps.

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- (41) Sigä radnik ii anda-n kirjo-i-d, mišo kut vuu
 there employee NEG.3 give-PST.PTCP book-PL-PAR in.order.to how yet
 škol-ha ii kävele.
 school-ILL NEG.3SG go.CNG
 ‘There, the employee didn’t give books, because (he) doesn’t go to school,
 yet.’ (VeC, Ladv 2014)
- (42) Erašti po=telefonuu pagiže-mei ka po=vepsski, mišo
 sometimes CLT=telephone.ADE speak-1PL so CLT=Veps in.order.to
 sekreto-i-d ii teda-iž.
 secret-PL-PAR NEG.3 know-COND
 ‘Sometimes we speak Veps in the phone, so that they wouldn’t know the
 secrets.’ (VeC, Mäggär’v 2007)
- (43) Kuna mini seme-ta, ku ma-d ele.
 where 1SG.ADE plant-INF when land-PAR NEG
 ‘Where should I plant, when there is no land.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935:
 409)
- (44) Tul-i-bad pert’-he äja-d ristitu-d, kudamba-d ii
 come-PST-3PL house-ILL many-PL people-PL which-PL NEG.3
 pagiš-tut ičemoi kele-l.
 speak-PST.PTCP own language-ADE
 ‘Such people came to our house, who didn’t speak Veps.’ (VeC, Pžar’
 2005)
- (45) Probyi-ka-t, mijak e-t pagiž-koi.
 try-IMP-2PL why NEG-2PL speak-CNG.PL
 ‘Try, why don’t you speak.’ (VeC, Mäggär’v 2007)

In non-finite clauses, negation may involve a modal function. In (46–47) the negative clause consisting of NEG.AUX and a non-finite verb is the predicating unit that has an epistemic meaning excluding a possible action.

- (46) Näge mitte dikar’, ni kuna ii sat-ta.
 see what.a slacker NEG where NEG.3 send-INF
 ‘Look, what a slacker! You cannot send [him] anywhere.’ (VeS, Kettunen
 1943a: 485)

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- (47) Nu igä-n pagiže-moi sikš=ku, miše ii abit-ta
 well age-ACC talk-1PL because=of in.order.to NEG.3 insult-INF
 adivo-d.
 guest-PAR
 ‘We have always talked so that we wouldn’t insult the guest.’ (Päžar’ 2011)

In Veps, certain non-final verb forms may display some inflectional cases, but not all of them. The attaching of a case affix to a verb form is characteristic of non-finites that are marked with the affix *-ma-*. This is exemplified in (48), which displays the abessive case that functionally corresponds to a negative instrumental (see, §3.3 below).

- (48) Ii pida räkita-da, räkita-ma-ta pravi-ze azd’.
 NEG.3 must thrash-INF thrash-INF-ABE get.better-REFL.3SG thing
 ‘You need not thrash [him], the thing will get better without thrashing.’
 (VeN, Kettunen 1943a: 500)

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

The negation of the epistemic modal auxiliary *voi-da* ‘can’ has developed in the same way as the negating copula (see, §2.3, above). The segmentable construction consisting of NEG + v [MOD] has fused into an auxiliary which, contrary to the negative existential, formally inflects for person or, to put it more cautiously, actually reflects phonological assimilation in speech. The default negation of the epistemic modal auxiliary is manifested in Veps literary language (49–50)

- (49) No kaik-se ei voi seižu-ta-das.
 but all-FOC NEG can.CNG stand-CAUS-INF.REFL
 ‘But everything cannot be stopped.’
- (50) Siloi läžu-tihe kogonaize-l kanza-l... ei voi-nu-goi
 then be.sick-PST.3PL whole-ADE family-ADE NEG can-PST.PTCP-PL
 nous-ta homendese-l...
 get.up-INF morning-ADE
 ‘The whole family was sick then... it was not possible to get up in the morning.’

The original morpheme order is maintained in the fusion of the two segmental units. Hence, it does not involve the shift of person marking affix to the end of the fused form, which would indicate a complete reanalysis of the construction.

Instead, the original morpheme order is preserved and the first syllable *em* (< *e-n* NEG-1SG), alternatively *ii* NEG.3 indicates person (51–53).

- (51) Sousim mä **emboo** ra-ta.
 at.all 1SG cannot.1SG work-INF
 ‘I can’t work at all.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 78)
- (52) **Emboi** tora-ta tii-deke.
 cannot.1SG quarrel-INF 2PL-COM
 ‘I cannot quarrel with you.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 92)
- (53) Mä paigaah-ii-n’ kondja-d, put-ta **emboo-le-n**, pauš-gi
 1SG shoot-PST-1SG bear-PAR hit-INF cannot.1SG-FREQ-PST.PTCP Pauš-FOC
 ambuu da put-ta **iivoo-le-n** put-ta.
 shoot.PST.3SG and hit-INF cannot.3SG-FREQ-PST.PTCP hit-INF
 ‘I shot at the bear but I could not hit (it), P. shot, too, and could not hit.’
 (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 105)

3 Non-clausal negation

In Veps, there is a clear distinction between clausal and non-clausal negation, which is more strongly affected by Russian model. The negative focus particle *ni* borrowed from Slavic (Russian) is widely used as the basic means for non-clausal negation and is not inflected. It typically precedes a pronoun or a quantifier, whereas nouns are not negated, although the negative focus particle *ni* may occur as a connector (54) in a prenominal position and occasionally shift to a post-nominal position (55).

- (54) Ei ole vel’l’-i-d **ni** sizar-i-d.
 NEG be.CNG brother-PL-PAR NEG sister-PL-PAR
 ‘There aren’t (= I haven’t got) any brothers nor sisters.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (55) Mii-le kolhoza-s ka pasporta-d **ni** ii ole-nd.
 1PL-ALL kolkhoz-INE so passport-PAR NEG NEG.3 be-PST.PTCP
 ‘We didn’t have even a passport [identity card] in the kolkhoz.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

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3.1 Negative replies

There are different ways to reply to questions, proposals and statements that form polar interrogatives (cf. [Miestamo 2011](#)). Both question particles (56) and declarative clauses that lack a question marker (57-58) are used to form polar interrogatives in Veps, whereas intonation, for instance, does not play any role. Negative replies are typically finite constructions either repeating the predicate and converting the person to the respondent, 2SG > 1SG (56-57), or simply marking the predicative with the inflecting NEG.AUX (58; cf. also (33), above). In both cases the answer exhibits a negative reply to the propositional content of the question.

- (56) Q: Mahtad-ik sinä iče kirjuta-da vepsä-ks?
 can-Q 2SG self write-INF Veps-TRA
 ‘Can you write in Veps yourself?’
 A: E-n mahta. Nügüd ni-ken ii mahta-gi mii-l yes.
 NEG-1SG can.CNG now NEG-who NEG.3 can.CNG-FOC 1PL-ADE yes
 ‘No I can’t. Nowadays none of us can.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (57) Q: Sinä mahta-d luge-da vepsä-ks? Vot nügüd oma nene kniga-d da
 2SG can-2SG read-INF Veps-TRA well now are these book-PL and
 om...
 is
 ‘Can you read Veps? Nowadays there are these books and...’
 A: E-n mahta.
 NEG-1SG can.CNG
 ‘No, I can’t.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (58) Q: I el-i-d igä-n tägä Ladv-a-s?
 And live-PST-2SG age-ACC here Ladv-INE
 ‘And you have lived the whole life here in Ladv?’
 A: E-n. Ol-i-n evakuoi-tud Sverdlovskie oblasti-he.
 NEG-1SG be-PST-1SG evacuate-PST.PTCP Sverdlovsk oblast-ILL
 ‘No. I was evacuated to Sverdlovsk oblast.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

If the question involves a negative clause, the reply may simply repeat the NEG.AUX. In a focused position the fusional negative existential *iile* ‘there is not’ (see, §2.3 above) is not always used but occurs in its original form consisting of NEG.AUX + v. The grammaticalized negative existential consisting of two units is transparent in negative replies (59).

5 Negation in Veps

- (59) Q: Sinä konz openz-i-toi škola-s, vepsä-n kel-t
 2SG when learn-PST.REFL.2SG school-INE Veps-GEN language-PAR
 ii ole-nd?
 NEG.3 be-PST.PTCP
 ‘When you went to school, there was no Veps language?’
- A: Ii.
 no
 ‘No.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

Occasionally, the negative reply may be triggered by a negative question, which is initiated by the negative focus particle *ni* ‘no’ (60) (see, (54–55) above and §3.2 below).

- (60) Q: Ni e-d mahta kirjuta-da ka, mugažo?
 NEG NEG-2SG can.CNG write-INF yes, also
 ‘You cannot write either, can you?’
- A: Kirjuta-da multe po=vepsski e-n mahta, multe
 write-INF otherwise CLT=Veps NEG-1SG can.CNG otherwise
 mahta-n.
 can-1SG
 ‘In Veps I cannot write, otherwise I can.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

Indefinite pronouns in Veps are based on an interrogative pronoun, which is typologically very widespread (Haspelmath 2013). The interrogative is followed by a postnominal demonstrative pronoun *se* ‘it’ as in *ken-se* who-it ‘somebody’ and *kus-se* where-it ‘somewhere’ (Grünthal 2015: 278–281; Hienonen 2010, Karjalainen 2016: 51–55). A less frequent (cf. Kettunen 1943a: 417–420) but possible way of forming the indefinite pronouns applies the negative particle *ni* instead of the postinterrogative demonstrative *se* ‘it’ (61–63) (cf. Yurayong 2020).

- (61) Ken-ni elä-b sigä Mäggärve-s?
 who-NEG live-3SG there Mäggär’v-INE
 ‘Does anyone live there in Mäggär’v?’ (VeC, Kurba 2006)
- (62) Aka-le mi-n-ni sanu-b da ii tuukui.
 wife-ALL what-ACC-NEG say-3SG and NEG.3 understand.CNG
 ‘He says something to (his) wife but they don’t understand.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

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- (63) **Ku-s-ni** lug-i-n.
 where-INE-NEG read-PST-1SG
 ‘I have read (it) somewhere.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

Negative indefinite pronouns are formed by using the same negative focus particle *ni* ‘no’ in a pre-interrogative position, in which no affix or any other constituent can occur between the two units. This is a common pattern and any interrogatives can be converted to negative indefinites this way. The pronominal stem typically inflects for case (64–68). These examples represent one type of clausal negation and involve the whole verb phrase.

- (64) Minu-l **ni** **ken** ii küzu-n, ken mina ole-n.
 1SG-ADE NEG who NEG.3 ask-PST.PTCP who 1SG be-1SG
 ‘No one asked me, who I am.’ (VeC, Ladv 2005)
- (65) Ei ole-nd sigä enamb **ni** **ke-dä**. škola-d ei
 NEG.3SG be-PST.PTCP there more NEG who-PAR school-PAR NEG.3SG
 ole-nd i **ni** **mi-dä** ii ole-nd.
 be-PST.PTCP and NEG what-PAR NEG.3 be-PST.PTCP
 ‘There was nobody any longer. There was no school, there was nothing.’
 (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (66) Ni ühte-d kopeka-d **ni** **ku-spei** mii-lei.
 NEG one-PAR kopeck-PAR NEG where-ELA 1PL-ALL
 ‘We don’t get a single kopeck from anywhere.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (67) G’ägibaba neci-da uko-n tütar-t pagasta-ha ii pästa **ni**
 witch this-PAR man-GEN daughter-PAR village-ILL NEG.3 let.CNG NEG
 kut.
 how
 ‘The witch won’t let the man’s daughter to the village in any way.’ (VeC,
 Kettunen & Siro 1935: 125)
- (68) Ka iile mi-lei s’o-da ant-ta tii-le-tei **ni** **mi-da**.
 yes NEG.be 1SG-ALL eat-INF give-INF 2PL.ALL-2PL NEG what-PAR
 ‘Well, I don’t have anything to give you to eat.’ (VeN, Kettunen & Siro
 1935: 154)

The same particle *ni* functions as a focus particle when it precedes the quantifier *üks* ‘one’ but otherwise its use in quantifier phrases is limited. The quantifier inflects for case (69–70).

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- (69) Eras-i-š kül-i-š kole-b vähe-mb rahvas-t a ii
 some-PL-INE village-PL-INE die-3SG less-COMP people-PAR but NEG.3
 süнду ni üks laps.
 be.born.CNG NEG one child
 ‘In certain villages less people die but not a single child is born.’ (VeC, Päär 2005)
- (70) Ni ühte-d supalaš-t ii jä-nd.
 NEG one-PAR morsel-PAR NEG.3 remain-PST.PTCP
 ‘Not a single morsel remained.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 97)

Adverbs based on pronominal stems display the same negative particle *ni* ‘no’ which marks negative indefinites as shown above, and adverbs (71).

- (71) Ani hüvä-d ii ole-n mugažno. Ni sinnä ni tännä, ni
 Very good-PAR NEG.3 be-PST.PTCP likewise NEG there NEG here NEG
 huba ni hüvä.
 bad NEG good
 ‘It wasn’t very good either. Not there nor here, not bad nor good.’ (VeC, Mäggär’v 2007)

There are no adverbs, which are exclusively negative. Certain adverbs, such as *igas* ‘(n)ever’ (72) and *enamb(a)* ‘more’ can be used as negative polarity items in a negative clause but they lack any formal label of negation. The partitive form *enamba-d* more-PAR ‘(any) more’ often occurs in a negative clause (73–74) and follows a salient syntactic rule in all Finnic languages, in which the negative verb phrase triggers a partitive object. This is a more general characteristic of the verb’s nominal dependents in the negative clause.

- (72) Ningoš-t iga-s e-bad näg-i-ške durako-d.
 such-PAR age-INE NEG-3PL see-PST-PFV stupid-PAR
 ‘They had never seen such a stupid one.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 71)
- (73) Enamba-d ni kävele-nud e-n.
 more-PAR NEG visit-PST.PTCP NEG-1SG
 ‘I haven’t been there later.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (74) Uk se händäst enamb-i-d ii lö.
 man it 3SG.ACC more-PL-PAR NEG.3 hit.CNG
 ‘The man doesn’t hit her/him any more.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 40)

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

The abessive case *-ta*, functionally a negative counterpart of the comitative (instrumental) marking the lack of certain property, is frequently used in Veps (75). Unlike other Finnic languages, Veps does not display a negative adposition ‘without’ (Grünthal 2003: 81–83; Pantermöller 2007), which increases the frequency of the abessive. In addition to abessive, nouns may display a caritive derivative affix that is likewise used in attributes. In this respect, nouns inflecting for the abessive resemble derived adjectives, which display a caritive affix *-toi ~ -toma-* marking the lack of a certain property (76). There is one significant syntactic difference between these two categories because a prenominal attribute that displays the abessive agrees in case with the head, e.g. *voukta-ta hebo-ta* white-ABE horse-ABE ‘without a white horse’, whereas a caritive derivation does not trigger case agreement.

- (75) Minä oli-n rado-ta.
 1SG be-PST-1SG work-ABE
 ‘I was unemployed.’ (VeC, Ladv 2014)

- (76) Mö olo-mei tata-toma-d i mama-toma-d.
 1PL be-1PL father-CAR-PL and mother-CAR-PL
 ‘We are without father and mother.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 121)

In comparison with the comitative that may occur as a co-ordinating affix, the abessive functions in the opposite way. While the comitative makes two constituents co-referential the abessive lacks this property (77–78), cf. *ak mužika-nke* woman husband-COM ‘woman and/with man’.

- (77) Sid hii sanu-i-ba, mišto ni kut mii sinu-ta elä-da e-m
 then 3PL say-PST-3PL that NEG how 1PL 2SG-ABE live-INF NEG-1PL
 voi.
 can.CNG
 ‘Then they said that we cannot live without you anyway.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (78) Nece mužika-ta ak.
 this husband-ABE woman
 ‘This is an unmarried woman.’ (VeC, Kettunen 1943b: 354)

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

The reversed word order and multifunctionality of the NEG.AUX has given rise to syntactically ambiguous constructions, in which the scope of negation extends beyond the verb (cf. Kettunen 1943a: 437–439). In this particular phrase type NEG.AUX is a part of the VP and displays a standard pattern. However, as the closest constituent preceding the adverbial, it also functions as the marker of lexical negation of the adverbial despite the fact that it primarily marks the person of the verb. In these constructions both NEG.AUX and the lexical verb exceptionally mark the person. Furthermore, other constituents may occur between the verb and NEG.AUX (79–81).

- (79) Mä ajoo-n' e-n ani lähä-ks.
 1SG drive.PST-1SG NEG-1SG very close-TRA
 'I didn't drive very close.' (VeS, Kettunen 1920: 105)
- (80) Homaiče-moiš sinun-ked e-n pigai.
 notice-REFL.1PL 2SG-COM NEG-1SG/1PL soon
 'With you we didn't notice one another very soon.' (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 81)
- (81) Ven'a-ks jo sanu-n da erašti e-n pravil'no.
 Russian-TRA already say-1SG and sometimes NEG-1SG right
 'In Russian I sometimes do not say correctly.' (VeC, Ladv 2007)

This construction is ambiguous for two reasons as it contradicts two rules. Firstly, in a simple verb phrase, the NEG.AUX inflects for person, whereas the lexical verb displays a connegative form. In (74–76) both NEG.AUX and the lexical verb inflect for person manifesting a non-canonical pattern. Secondly, lexical negation should be based on an uninflecting negative particle that precedes the adverb (see, above §3.2). In (74–76) the inflection of NEG.AUX contradicts the rule of an uninflecting negative particle that precedes the adverb. The occurrence of post-verbal NEG.AUX correlates with predicates that occur in Veps in a sentence-final position more often than in other Finnic languages for topical reasons. There is no transparent reason for the emergence of this ambiguous negation pattern, which strongly deviates from two canonical morphosyntactic patterns. The reason for ambiguity lies in the location of NEG.AUX between the lexical verb and adverbial, and that additional verbal determinants may occur between the lexical verb and NEG.AUX.

4.2 Negative polarity

There are only few specialized negative polarity items in Veps. The same negative focus particle *ni*, which is commonly used in negative indefinites and adverbs (see, §3.2), operates as a general polarity marker. Individual words repeatedly occur in negative clauses, if they share some other morphosyntactic property characteristic of negation. Adverbials such as *(ni) ühte-d* (NEG) one-PAR, *ei üh-t kerda-d* NEG one-PAR time-PAR, *(ni) mittus-t* (NEG) what.kind.of-PAR, *enamba-d* more-PAR and *enamb-i-d* more-PL-PAR that are compatible with quantifiers (see, 3.2), for instance, occur in the partitive (see, §4.3), a typical indication of the scope of negation in NP. The same is valid to the adverb *igas ~ igäs* ‘(n)ever’ (82), a lexicalized inessive form of *igä* ‘age, time’.

- (82) *Vina-d igä-s e-n jo-n.*
 wine-PAR age-INE NEG-1SG drink-PST.PTCP
 ‘I have never drank wine.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 57)

None of the listed lexical units marks negation alone but functions as a dependent of a negative phrase.

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

The scope of negation is illustratively seen in those clause types and negative phrases which trigger the partitive in the dependent. Constituents that regularly display or may display the nominative or genitive(-accusative) case in an affirmative clause inflect for partitive in a corresponding negative phrase. Thus, a subject of a negative existential clause inflects for partitive (83), and so does the subject of a reflexive verb (84).

- (83) *Škola-d ei ole-nd i ni mi-dä ii ole-nd.*
 school-PAR NEG.3SG be-PST.PTCP and NEG what-PAR NEG.3 be-PST.PTCP
 ‘There was no school and there wasn’t anything.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)
- (84) *Ni kala-d ni rebaš-t ii teh-nu-nzhe.*
 NEG fish-PAR NEG fox-PAR NEG.3 do-PST.PTCP-REFL.3SG
 ‘There wasn’t any fish nor fox.’ (lit. ‘It didn’t become a fish nor a fox.’)
 (VeS, Kettunen 1943b: 440)

A similar permutation takes place in the object of a transitive clause, which regularly has the partitive in a negative clause (85).

- (85) **Bukv-i-d** ii teda.
 letter-PL-PAR NEG.3 know.CNG
 ‘(S)he doesn’t know (the) letters.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

This characteristic is shared by all Finnic languages as the partitive is the default case of object in negative transitive clauses. The correlation between negation and partitive and the dominance of this morphosyntactic pattern is so strong that adverbials such as *enamba-d* more-PAR ‘(no) more’ used as polarity items (cf. 4.2) in negative clauses display the partitive as well (86).

- (86) **Enamba-d** mii vepsä-n kel-t se te-tud e-mei.
 more-PAR 1PL Veps-GEN lang-PAR it know-PST.PTCP NEG-1PL
 ‘We didn’t know more Veps language.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

4.4 Reinforcing negation

There are several ways of reinforcing negation. Most frequently, the same negative focus particle *ni*, which is widely used in non-clausal negation, occurs as a reinforcing unit in a negative clause. While the inflecting NEG.AUX operates as the head of the VP, the negative focus particle precedes the nominal dependent of the verb (87–88).

- (87) **Ni ühte-d vajeh-t** e-n ope-nud.
 NEG one-PAR word-PAR NEG-1SG learn-PST.PTCP
 ‘I didn’t learn any single word.’ (VeC, Mäggär’v 2007)
- (88) **Ii ole ni keda.**
 NEG.3 be.CNG NEG who-PAR
 ‘There isn’t anybody.’ (Ladv 2006)

In certain clause types the negative focus particle parallelly functions as a coordinating conjunction 89 (cf. 4.5) and may also be reduplicated (90; cf. above also 84). This kind of connective negation in Veps is similar with Russian, other Balto-Slavic and Romance languages (van der Auwera et al. 2021: 46–53). In both (89) and (90) a negative VP manifests primary negation. In (90) the reversed order *v* + NEG is an additional way of reinforcing clausal negation.

- (89) **Vaštke-s ong-he ni uštke-he** ii koki.
 calm-INE hook-ILL NEG lure-ILL NEG.3 bite.CNG
 ‘In calm wheather (the fish) doesn’t bite the hook nor the lure.’ (VeC, Kettunen 1943b: 435)

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- (90) Neižne **ni** sö-ške **ni** jo-ške **ii** kahte-s nedali-s.
 Girl NEG eat.CNG-PFV NEG drink.CNG-PFV NEG.3 two-INE week-INE
 ‘The girl hasn’t eaten nor drunk for two weeks.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1943b: 277)

In replies to questions the interrogative *kutak* ‘how’ may operate both as a polarity item characteristic of negative phrases and reinforce negation by turning the question (91). This phrase corresponds to Russian *kak ne!* how NEG ‘Absolutely not!’. In Veps an enclitic focus particle *-ak* is attached to the interrogative stem *kut* ‘how’. Another interrogative *mijak* ~ *mejak* ‘why’ sharing the same affix may function the same way in reinforced replies.

- (91) a. Tütr-i-deke pagiže-d vepsa-ks?
 daughter-PL-COM speak-2SG Veps-TRA
 ‘With the daughters you speak Veps?’
 b. Pagiže-n, **kut-ak** **ii!**?
 speak-1SG how-CLT NEG.3
 ‘I do, why shouldn’t I!’ (Ladv 2006)

Although Veps has some focus particles, none of them is exclusively negative. In a negative clause the general focus particle *-gi/-ki* reinforces the statement (92). Standardized Veps separates this affix *-ki* with a hyphen, e.g. *tedand-ki*, glossed *teda-nd-ki* know-PST.PTCP.FOC.

- (92) Neci-l aka-l **ii** **küzu-nd-gi**.
 this-ADE woman-ADE NEG.3 ask-PST.PTCP-FOC
 ‘(S)he didn’t even ask this woman.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 118)

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

A very frequent clause type is the polar clause, which operates with a multifunctional particle *ka* ‘yes; so’. Syntactically, it corresponds to subordinating constructions, in which a conjunction initiates a clause that determines the main clause. However, the particle *ka* actually functions as a clause connector instead of an unambiguously subordinating conjunction (93–94).

- (93) Tata-in kucu-i-n svathuzi-i-le, **ka** **ii** **mäne-n**.
 father-1SG.POSS invite-PST-1SG courting-PL-ALL yes NEG.3 go-PST.PTCP
 ‘I invited my father to courting but he didn’t go.’ (VeC, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 37)

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- (94) Om radio, ka ii pagiže pole-s aiga-d ka.
 is radio yes NEG.3 speak.CNG half-INE time-PAR yes
 ‘There is the radio, but half of the time it doesn’t speak.’ (VeC, Ladv 2006)

There is a contrastive particle *e(i)ka/i(i)ka* ‘or’ that originates from the fusion of the negator and *ka*. It emphasizes the polar contrast between the two clauses by pointing that the statement will conditionally happen (95–96). The bimorphemic conjunction corresponds to English ‘if...not’.

- (95) Ot-ka-t i min-daa-n’ ela-m-ha, eka perti-n
 take-IMP-2PL and 1SG-PAR-1SG.POSS live-INF-ILL or house-ACC
 sarv-ii-l kändä-n.
 horn-PL-ADE turn-1SG
 ‘Take me to live (with you), or I’ll turn up the house with my horns.’ (VeS, Kettunen 1925: 44)
- (96) Enamba-d ii ela-nu siid, ika kondii sö-nu-iž
 more-PAR NEG.3 live-PST.PTCP then or bear eat-PST.PTCP-COND.3SG
 aka-iže-n.
 woman-DIM-ACC
 ‘(She) didn’t live any longer then, or the bear would have eaten the woman.’ (VeN, Kettunen & Siro 1935: 185)

In general, affirmative and negative phrases may occur as coordinated clauses that display the standard coordinating conjunction *i* ‘and’ or *da* ‘and’, both borrowed from Russian. Example (97) represents the literary Standardized Veps and is drawn from the newspaper Kodima.

- (97) Nece-l vede-l pes-t’he laps-i-d, miše hö
 this-ADE water-ADE wash-PST.3PL child-PL-PAR in.order.to 3PL
 pare-mb kaz-de-iž da ii läžu-te-iž.
 better-COMP grow-3PL-COND and NEG.3 be.sick-3PL-COND
 ‘They used to wash children with this water so that they would grow better and wouldn’t get sick.’

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

A special semantic effect can be seen in the lexically conditioned modal transformation of the verb *käsk-ta* order-INF ‘order; tell; ask’ and its negation *ei käsk-ta* NEG order-INF ‘forbid’ (98–100). Morphosyntactically, this sentence represents a

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basic declarative clause, whereas the semantic change based on negation is not characteristic of other verbs.

- (98) **Käsk-i-d**, ka mida-k e-n ota-nd?
 order-PST-2SG yes what-Q NEG-1SG take-PST.PTCP
 ‘You told to, so why didn’t I take?’ (VeC, [Kettunen & Siro 1935](#): 107)
- (99) **Näge-d, e-d käske-nd** vö-da i sünd ande-i
 see-2SG NEG-2SG order-PST.PTCP bring-INF and God give-PST.3SG
 kümne.
 ten
 ‘You see, you forbid to take along and God gave ten.’ (VeC, [Kettunen & Siro 1935](#): 108)
- (100) **Iče-moi kele-l ii käs-tud** ka openz-i-n i
 own-1PL language-ADE NEG.3 order-PST.PTCP yes learn-PST-1SG and
 venä-ks da i.
 Russian-TRA and and
 ‘They forbid to (learn) in Veps, so I learned in Russian.’ (VeC, [Ladv 2007](#))

5 Conclusions

This paper has discussed a number of features characteristic of Veps negation. Like other Finnic and, more broadly, Uralic languages, certain inherent features have been preserved in Veps, whereas several language-specific innovations can also be shown. Generally speaking, Veps constitutes an illustrative example of a dynamic system in constant change. A detailed analysis of negation patterns shows a clear distinction between verbal and non-verbal negation. In declarative sentences, Veps uses a negative auxiliary like many Uralic languages do, while a negative particle is used in non-verbal negation. The negative auxiliary inflects for person but not for tense and mood, which divides the core functions of predication between the NEG.AUX and the main verb. This kind of ambiguity increases the number of mutually dependent features which diachronically originate from separate units and are affected by various mechanisms of change. An inflecting NEG.AUX is an inherent Uralic feature (cf. [Miestamo et al. 2015](#)), whereas the particle *ni* used in non-verbal constructions is borrowed from Slavic (Russian).

The most significant language-specific characteristics include the alternating constituent order of a negative clause, the emergence of bivalent negation caused by the change of the constituent order, the morphosyntactic pattern of negative

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plural verbs, and the emergence of a negative existential. These are all features that distinguish the Veps negation from the neighboring languages, both genetically related and unrelated.

Table 6: Summary of negation in Veps

Form	Description	Section	Examples
<i>e-</i>	inflecting auxiliary		
	(1) Basic declarative sentences	§2.1	(1–5, 8–11, 56–58, 72, 74, 93–94, 99–100)
	(2) Reversed word order V+ Neg	§2.1.2	(12–15, 73, 76–81, 90)
	(3) Conditionals	§2.2	(24–25)
	(4) Questions	§2.2	(26–27)
	(5) Stative predications	§2.3	(33–34)
	(6) Subordinate clauses		(41–42, 44–47)
<i>iile</i>	fusional negating copula	§2.3	(35–37, 43, 53)
<i>emboo</i>	fusional modal negating (1sg)		
<i>ala</i>	imperatives	§2.2	(20–23)
<i>e(i)ka/i(i)ka</i>	contrastive negative particle used in subordinate clauses	§4.5	(95–96)
<i>ni</i>	negative particle that can be attached to all parts-of-speech		
	(1) pre- or postnominal particle	§3	(54–55, 83–84, 88–89)
	(2) negative focus particle preceding both affirmative and negative VP	§3.1	(60, 90)
	(3) indefinites and quantifiers	§3.2	(61–70, 87)
	(4) adverbs	§3.2	(71)
<i>-ta</i>	abessive case suffix (negative instrumental)	§3.3	(75, 77–78)
<i>-toi</i>	derivative suffix of caritive adjectives	§3.3	(76)
<i>igas</i>	negative adverb reinforcing negation	§3.2, §4.2	(72)
<i>enambad</i>	negative adverb reinforcing negation	§3.2	(73–74, 86)
<i>-ak</i>	polar focus particle in interrogatives	§4.4	(91)
<i>-gi</i>	reinforcing focus particle	§4.4	(92)

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Abbreviations

1	first person	GEN	genitive
2	second person	ILL	illative
3	third person	IMP	imperative
ABE	abessive	INE	inessive
ACC	accusative	INF	infinitive
ADE	adessive	MOD	modal
ADJZ	adjectivizer	MOM	momentative
ALL	allative	NEG	negative
AUX	auxiliary	P	person marker
CAR	caritive	PAR	partitive
CAUS	causative	PASS	passive
CNG	connegative	PFV	perfective
COM	comitative	PL	plural
CMPR	comparative	PROL	prolative
COND	conditional	PST	past
CONT	continuative	PTCP	participle
COP	copula	POSS	possessive suffix
DIM	diminutive	Q	question marker
ELA	elative	REFL	reflexive
CLT	enclitic	SG	singular
ESS	essive	TRA	translative
EX	existential	VeC	Central Veps
FOC	focus	VeN	Northern Veps
FREQ	frequentative	VeS	Southern Veps
FUT	future		

Fieldwork data

The fieldwork data has been collected in the following villages and is archived at the Institute for the Languages of Finland (<https://www.kotus.fi/en>).

village	district / rayon	region / oblast'	year
Kurba	Podporožskiy	Leningradskaya	2006
Ladv	Podporožskiy	Leningradskaya	2005, 2006, 2007, 2014
Mäggär'v	Podporožskiy	Leningradskaya	2007
Päžar'	Babaevskiy	Vologodskaya	2005, 2011

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Chapter 6

Negation in Andi

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Following the *Questionnaire for describing the negation system of a language*, the paper presents an overview of negation in Andi, a Nakh-Daghestanian (East Caucasian) language of the Avar-Andic branch. I proceed from clausal negation to non-clausal negation, also covering various additional aspects of negation (the scope of negation, reinforcing negation, etc.), and conclude with diachronic observations and a summary of findings. Negation in the verb paradigm of Andi is symmetric in the sense that all categories have affirmative and negative forms. A peculiarity of Andi among the closely related languages is the expansion of one and the same negative marker into several domains of negation: the suffix which is the marker of standard negation is also used with non-indicative and non-finite verb forms, and is homophonous with the negative copula. Another peculiarity is the phenomenon of endoclitisis, which is only attested in negative verb forms. Besides, Andi possesses a series of “counterexpectation” verb forms which seem to go back to a periphrastic construction involving some “inherently negative” auxiliary verb; forms with such semantics are not common in the languages of the family.

Keywords: negation, negative copula, counterexpectation, endoclititics, Andi, Nakh-Daghestanian.

1 The language

Andi (ISO: [ani](#), Glottocode: [andi1255](#)) belongs to the Andic group of the Avar-Andic branch of the Nakh-Daghestanian (East Caucasian) family. The Avar-Andic branch is one of the main subdivisions of the family alongside the Nakh, Tsezic, Dargwa and Lezgian language groups, and the Lak and Khinalug languages, each constituting its own branch. Alternatively, Avar-Andic can be united with Tsezic

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in a single Avar-Andic-Tsezic branch; see [Dobrushina et al. \(2020: 30–31\)](#) and [Ganenkova & Maisak \(2020: 88\)](#) for details. The other Andic languages are Akhvakh, Bagvalal, Botlikh, Chamalal, Godoberi, Karata, and Tindi, all of which are minority languages spoken in the north-western part of mountain Daghestan (Russia) by a few hundred to a few thousand speakers each. By and large, all these languages remain unwritten and are not taught at schools, but only function as means of everyday communication in the respective villages. Avar, the closest relative of the Andic languages, is, in contrast, one of the major languages of Daghestan, with more than 700,000 speakers, an elaborate dialectal system and a literary standard.

Estimates of the number of Andi speakers vary, but it is most plausible that the language is spoken by about 25,000 people, living in a few mountain villages of the Botlikhsky District (Andi, Gagatli, Rikvani, Ashali, Chanko, Zilo, and a few others) as well as in the lowlands of the Republic of Daghestan. Traditionally, the Andi varieties are subdivided into Upper Andi and Lower Andi, the latter (spoken in the villages Muni and Kvankhidatli) being mutually unintelligible with the former. In this sketch, I only use the data from Upper Andi varieties, in particular concentrating on the subdialects of the Andi and Rikvani villages, with some parallels from the Gagatli and Zilo varieties where relevant.

Although a number of grammatical sketches of Andi have been produced since the early 20th century, the language remains underdescribed. [Dirr \(1906\)](#), [Sulejmanov \(1957\)](#), [Cercvadze \(1965\)](#), and [Salimov \(2010\)](#), based on his 1968 dissertation) provide general overviews of Andi phonology and morphology. For this paper, I rely both on these sources and my own fieldwork in the village of Rikvani. Besides, I use the data from the available text corpus which includes a number of texts appended to the four aforementioned grammars (presenting different dialects), and the two books published in the 2010s which represent the first serious examples of literary production in Andi. The first of these is a collection of a dozen fairy tales from around the world, the second is a translation of the Gospel of Luke; although both are based on the variety of the largest Andi village (Andi proper), the Gospel of Luke in some aspects represents a mixture of multiple dialects. For the Zilo Andi data, I am indebted to Samira Verhees and other participants of the Zilo Andi documentation project (see also [Kaye et al. \(To appear\)](#)).

The description below is based on the *Questionnaire for describing the negation system of a language* by Matti Miestamo (with revisions carried out together with Ljuba Veselinova, see [Miestamo \(2025\)](#)) and follows the structure of the questionnaire. I proceed from clausal negation in §2 to non-clausal negation in §3, while §4 covers various additional aspects of negation (in particular, the scope

of negation, reinforcing negation, etc.). In §4 I also analyse the phenomenon of endoclisism, which is only attested in negative verb forms in Andi. I conclude with a few diachronic observations and a summary of findings.

Like the Nakh-Daghestanian languages in general, Andic languages are morphologically ergative and left-branching with SOV basic word order, and have rich case systems (including many locative forms) and pervasive gender agreement (comprising three to six genders depending on the language and dialect). Verb systems in Andic are also fairly elaborate, with many synthetic as well as periphrastic forms. Andi is unusual among the closely related languages of this branch in that its present-tense copula *i* (or *ži*, *ži*, depending on the dialect) has become restricted almost entirely to existential, possessive and locative contexts, thus representing a morphologically defective existential verb rather than a true copula. It is also not used as an auxiliary, which makes the core tense and aspect paradigm of Andi entirely synthetic.

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

The marker of standard negation in Andi is *-s:u*. The same marker *-s:u* is used with non-indicative and non-finite verb forms; moreover, the negative copula in Andi also has the form *s:u*, and *s:u* again is employed in constituent negation. In verb forms, I treat *-s:u* as a bound marker (suffix), as discussed in more detail in §4.6.3.

The core of the Andi verb paradigm is synthetic, and all the tense-aspect-mood inflection in synthetic verb forms is suffixal. In the indicative, there are two morphological subsystems based on two verb stems. There is a perfective subsystem comprising the two main perfective past tenses, namely the aorist and the perfect (the latter is syncretic with the perfective converb). The present progressive also belongs to this subsystem, being derived from the same verb stem. The other verb stem serves as the base for forms belonging to the imperfective and future/prospective domains, namely the present, the present habitual, the counterexpectation present, the prospective and the intentional, as well as the future proper (which is syncretic with the imperfective participle). Table 1 lists all the finite and the main non-finite synthetic forms of the verb ‘say’ in the Rikvani dialect, together with their negative counterparts. Other Upper Andi dialects may have minor differences in the form of the tense-aspect suffixes (e.g. the perfect/perfective converb suffix, which is *-d* in Rikvani, *-d:u* in the Andi and Gagatli dialects, and *-j* in Zilo). Note that the ‘not-yet’ present tense, i.e. the counterexpectation

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present, is included in the group of affirmative forms in Table 1, both because its meaning is not purely negative and because it has a regular morphological counterpart bearing the negative suffix *-s:u*; on the semantics and structure of this form, see further §2.6.

Table 1: Affirmative and negative forms of the verb ‘say’ in the Rikvani dialect

	Affirmative	Negative
Aorist and related forms		
Aorist	<i>ruli</i>	<i>ruli-s:u</i>
Perfect (= Perfective Converb)	<i>ruli-d</i>	<i>ruli-d-s:u</i> / <i>ruli-č’igu</i>
Perfective Participle	<i>ruli-b</i>	<i>ruli-s:u-b</i>
Masdar (action nominal)	<i>ruli-r</i>	<i>ruli-s:u-r</i>
Progressive Present	<i>rul-rado</i>	<i>rul-rado-s:u</i>
Imperative	<i>rul-o</i>	–
Infinitive and related forms		
Infinitive	<i>rul-du</i>	<i>rul-du-s:u</i>
Present	<i>rul-duq</i>	<i>rul-duq-s:u</i>
Prospective	<i>rul-dulq</i>	<i>rul-dulq-s:u</i>
Intentional	<i>rul-duʒojd</i>	<i>rul-duʒojd-s:u</i>
Habitual Present	<i>rul-do</i>	<i>rul-do-s:u</i>
Prohibitive	–	<i>rul-do-s:ub</i>
Future (= Imperfective Participle)	<i>rul-dja</i>	<i>rul-do-s:ja</i>
Counterexpectation Present	<i>rul-david</i>	<i>rul-david-s:u</i>

In most verb forms, the marking of negation is straightforward: *-s:u* is simply added to an affirmative verb form, cf. the aorist (perfective past) *ruli* ‘said’ ~ *ruli-s:u* ‘didn’t say’, the perfect *ruli-d* ‘has said’ ~ *ruli-d-s:u* ‘hasn’t said’, the progressive present *rul-rado* ‘is saying’ ~ *rul-rado-s:u* ‘isn’t saying’ (R)¹, etc. The following examples illustrate the use of two indicative forms with regular negation marking, the aorist in (1–2) and the present habitual in (3–4).

¹In example sources, the first letter stands for the dialect represented: “A” for Andi, “G” for Gagatli, “R” for Rikvani and “Z” for Zilo. “*Tales*” refers to the collection of world fairy tales (Magomedova 2010), and “*Luke*” refers to the translation of the Gospel of Luke. If a text/grammar source is not indicated, the example results from elicitation.

- (1) hege-li-li riL'i ik^won...
DEM-OBL.PL.FN-GEN meat eat.AOR
[I killed two deer.] 'I ate their meat...' (A; *Tales*)
- (2) ik^won-s:u den du-j-il boš-ul
eat.AOR-NEG 1SG 2SG-GEN.III.PL-PL offspring-PL
[The wolf says to the goat:] 'I didn't eat your kids.' (A; *Tales*)
- (3) di-<w>o c'in-no men i<m> hek'a=bolo!
1SG-AFF<M> know-HAB 2SG who<H> man=Q.INDIR
'I know who you are!' (A; *Luke 4:34*)
- (4) di-<w>o he-w c'in-no-su, jec:i...
1SG-AFFT<M> DEM-M know-HAB-NEG sister
'I don't know him, sister...' (A; *Luke 22:57*)²

Thus, negation in the Andi verb paradigm is overwhelmingly symmetric in *Miestamo*'s (2005) terms. There are, however, negative verb forms which are not derived from the corresponding affirmative ones by simply adding *-s:u* on the right edge, after the inflectional suffix of the corresponding tense-aspect-mood category. First, in a few non-finite forms *-s:u* precedes the inflectional suffix rather than following it (see §2.4). Second, in two verb forms the negation marker *-s:u* is historically present, but is fused with another marker. The forms in question are the negative future in *-dos:ja* and the prohibitive (negative imperative) in *-dos:ub*, which are not derived from their affirmative counterparts. Historically, they both probably go back to the habitual in *-do*. The affirmative future in *-dja* seems to be derived from the habitual by means of the suffix **-ja*, which ousts the final vowel of the habitual (*-dja* < **-do-ja*). In the negative future, we see the same habitual marker *-do* before the negation marker *-s:u-* (reduced to *-s:-*) and the same suffix **-ja* follows (*-dos:ja* < **-do-s:u-ja*). On the structure of the prohibitive, see §2.2. Both the negative future and the prohibitive display asymmetry of the A/Cat/TAM type, i.e. affecting the marking of tense-aspect-mood (*Miestamo* 2005: 116).

The third exception is different in nature, and is the only source of paradigmatic asymmetry in Andi negation, as the relation between the affirmative form and the negative form here is not one-to-one. In the perfect, which is syncretic

²The transliteration of intensive (geminate) consonants in the Gospel of Luke translation is not always consistent, so the negative marker *-s:u* is sometimes written there as *-su*. In examples, I have kept the transliteration as in the original.

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with the perfective converb, alongside the expected form in *-s:u* there exists a form involving a special negation marker *-č'igu*, which does not occur elsewhere in the language and is unrelated to *-s:u* historically. This second, “irregular” variant of the negative perfect / perfective converb is produced by adding *-č'igu* directly to the perfective stem, without the perfect ending *-d*, cf. *ruli-d* ‘has said’ ~ *ruli-č'igu* ‘hasn’t said’. Thus, *-č'igu* simultaneously expresses negation and the corresponding tense-aspect-mood value. On the whole, the “irregular” negative form in *-č'igu* seems to be the neutral one for both the perfect and the perfective converb, while the “regular” one is very marginal. In the available written texts of Andi (“*Tales*” and “*Luke*”), the regular form in *-d:u-s:u* is only found 5 times (as opposed to more than 170 occurrences of the form in *-č'igu*), and only in subordinate clauses with the adverbializer *-gu*, i.e. with a general meaning ‘without having done’ (see §4.6.1)³.

Examples (5–7) illustrate the use of the affirmative and negative future and the affirmative and “irregular” negative perfect.

- (5) den w-uci-dja men=nogu, mijarek’a!
 1SG M-come-FUT 2SG=COM lord
 ‘I will follow (lit. go with) you, Lord!’ (A; *Luke* 9:61)
- (6) den j-igi-dos:ja bis:i-li-k:u se-w-gulo-š:u-j
 1SG F-come-FUT.NEG 2PL-INTER-ELA one-M-INDF-OBL.M-DAT
 ‘I will not marry (lit. go to) any of you.’ (A; *Tales*)
- (7) mašen’ka-di hinc:’u t’ik’ešo-d:u- se-w-gulo w-ot’on-č’igu
 Mashenka-ERG door knock-PRF one-M-INDF M-talk-PRF.NEG
 ‘Mashenka knocked on the door – no one answered.’ (A; *Tales*)

As already mentioned in §1, there are no periphrastic forms in Upper Andi with a present-tense copula as auxiliary. There are, however, a few periphrastic constructions employing a regular verb *bik’udu* ‘be, become, happen’ or *bisidu* ‘be, stop, stand’. The latter verb is employed in the Rikvani dialect only with the meaning ‘come to a stop, stand’, while at least in the Andi, Gagatli and Zilo dialects it has evolved into a more general existential verb, widely used as an

³Kibrik (1985) puts forward a hypothesis on the choice between *-s:u* and *-č'igu* depending on the meaning of the (finite) perfect: he suggests that the regular negation is used with the perfect/resultative meaning of the form, while *-č'igu* appears only with the indirective evidential meaning. However, this conclusion is not supported by the data we have. See also Verhees (2019: 201–209) on the structure and use of the perfective converb (in her terms, general converb) in Andi.

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auxiliary (see Verhees & Rochant 2017 for details). As an auxiliary it is postposed and preferably occurs in one of the past tenses, e.g. the aorist or the perfect. Most common types of periphrastic constructions are those based on the perfect (perfective converb) or the progressive present form of a lexical verb: the combination of the former with a past tense auxiliary yields a pluperfect ('had done'), while the combination of the latter with a past tense auxiliary is an imperfect ('was doing, used to do').

When a periphrastic form is negated, in the most neutral case the negation is found on the auxiliary verb, as in (8) with the periphrastic future perfect (perfective converb + 'be' in the future tense) or (9) with the periphrastic past habitual (imperfective participle + 'be' in the perfect tense).

- (8) **b-eɣuk:u-d:u b-ik'u-dos:ja=bu!**
 IV-be.late-CVB IV-be-FUT.NEG=PTCL
 'There's no hurry!' (lit. 'It won't be late') (A; *Tales*)
- (9) **hege-li-di oɣ:od:oro-l-la-k:u heč'egido-l-lo=gilo**
 DEM-OBL.PL.FN-ERG morning-OBL-SUP-ELA at.night-OBL-SUP.LAT=until
se-b-gulo i-dja b-ik'w-o-č'igu
 one-IV-INDF do-IPFV.PTCP IV-be-PRF.NEG
 'They just lounged all day long.' (lit. 'They were not doing anything from morning till night.') (A; *Tales*)

At the same time, the marking of negation on the lexical verb is also attested, as can be seen in examples (10) and (11) with the same constructions: in (10), it is the perfective converb which bears negation, and in (11) it is the imperfective participle.

- (10) **ama q'adi šu-b=gu zamana-l-di razi-ŋi-č'igu w-uk'o-d:u**
 but judge good-IV=INTS time-OBL-ERG content-VBZ-CVB.NEG M-be-PRF
 'For some time the judge refused.' (A; *Luke* 18:4)
- (11) **amma en-š:u-b=gu ulka-l-l-ol adam-i-<w>o**
 but self-OBL.M-GEN.IV=INTS country-OBL-GEN-PL people-OBL-AFFT<M>
hege-w hilu-dosja w-uk'o-d:u
 DEM-M love-IPFV.PTCP.NEG M-be-PRF
 'But his subjects hated him.' (A; *Luke* 19:14)

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2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

In the formation of the negative imperative (prohibitive) Andi follows a strategy common to most other Nakh-Daghestanian languages in that the prohibitive is not derived directly from the imperative. In Andi, as in Andic languages in general, transitive and intransitive verbs have different imperative forms, the former in *-o* and the latter in *-b*. Intransitive imperatives are derived from the perfective stem and are syncretic with perfective participles (e.g. the form *bik'o-b* can be both the imperative 'be, become!' and the participle 'which became, which happened'). The prohibitives of transitives and intransitives, meanwhile, are derived uniformly and belong morphologically to the future/imperfective subsystem. Most probably, the prohibitive marker *-dos:ub* is historically derived from the habitual in *-do* followed by the negative *-s:u* and the participial suffix *-b* (*-dos:ub < *-do-s:u-b*). Thus, the prohibitive of the verb 'be, become' has the form *bik'u-dos:ub*; see also examples in (12).

- (12) *hinc':u arxin-nos:ub, se-w-gulo hinni=lo eld:os:ub*
 door open-PROH one-M-INDF inside=ADD let+PROH
 'Don't open the door, don't let anyone in.' (A; *Tales*)

Both yes/no-questions and wh-questions in Andi employ pairs of question enclitics, one used with the predicate in the aorist and the other with the predicate in any other form (Maisak 2020). In polar questions, the question markers are by default cliticized to the verb, but they can follow the focus of a question in case of narrow (constituent) focus. In wh-questions, the question markers are hosted by the wh-phrase. The use of question markers does not generally influence the marking of negation, cf. a wh-question in (13) with the negative aorist.

- (13) *ei=di bis:i-di č'erL'i-s:u?*
 what<IV>=WH 2PL-ERG divide.AOR-NEG
 'Why are you quarreling?' (lit. 'What haven't you divide among yourselves?') (A; *Tales*)

At the same time, it is common for negative polar questions to be employed with purely rhetorical function, when the speaker is sure that the addressee in fact knows the answer well, and a reply is not expected, cf. (14–16).

- (14) *du-o den c'inni-r s:u=le?*
 2SG-AFFT<III> 1SG know-PROG COP.NEG=Q
 [The mouse asks the lion:] 'Don't you recognize me?' [I am the one whose life you spared.] (A; *Tales*)

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- (15) men mesihi s:u=le?
 2SG messiah COP.NEG=Q
 [One of the criminals asked:] ‘Aren’t you the Messiah?’ [Save yourself and us!] (A; *Luke* 23:39)
- (16) du-o c’in-no-su=le hila=si-š:u-b-ul amr-odul
 2SG-AFFT<IV> know-HAB-NEG=Q above=ATTR-OBL.M-GEN.IV-PL order-PL
 ‘Don’t you know the commandments of the Lord?’ (A; *Luke* 18:20)

This use of negative polar questions is frequent in the translation of the Gospel of Luke, where negative questions are used to translate many sentences which are rendered in the affirmative declarative in e.g. English or Russian versions of the Gospel, as in (17) and (18).

- (17) ja, χ^wažain, hede-š-č’u ho-L’ol=lo hoc’o-gu misidi
 VOC landlord DEM-OBL.M-CNT DEM-MNR=ADD ten-NUM gold
 i=s:u=le
 COP=COP.NEG=Q
 ‘Sir, he already has (lit. hasn’t he?) ten golden coins as it is.’ (A; *Luke* 19:25)
- (18) talihi=logu=s-ol s:u=le moč’i ihi-su-b-ul, he-w-ul
 luck=COM=ATTR-PL COP.NEG=Q child do-NEG-PFV.PTCP-PL DEM-M-PL
 w-oχ:ontɪ-su-b-ul ješi-l!
 M-suck.CAUS-NEG-PFV.PTCP-PL girl-PL
 ‘Blessed are (lit. aren’t?) the women, that have never bore children and never fed them!’ (A; *Luke* 23:29)

2.3 Negation in stative predications

Affirmative stative predications do not behave in a uniform way. Although the affirmative present copula *i* (dialectal variants *ži*, *ži*) occasionally appears in contexts of equation, proper inclusion or attribution, these types of stative predication normally do not include a copula (19–21). On the other hand, in existential, locative and possessive predications the copula is regularly present (22–24).

- (19) hono-w i žuhut’a-w pač:ahi
 DEM-M COP JEW-OBL.PL-GEN.M king
 ‘This is the king of the Jews.’ (A; *Luke* 23:38)

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- (20) hege-w iši-li mijarek'a
DEM-M 1PL.EXCL-GEN landlord
[Domestic animals about Man:] 'He is our owner.' (A; *Tales*)
- (21) den=no ila=lo zolo miskin-ol
1SG=ADD mother=ADD very poor-PL
'Me and my mother are very poor.' (G; *Salimov 2010*: 222)
- (22) sor-da-j reč':-obil i, šekm-a-j bešem-il i
fox-OBL.PL-DAT cave-PL COP bird-OBL.PL-DAT nest-PL COP
'For foxes there are holes and for birds there are nests.' (A; *Luke 9:58*)
- (23) di-w wošo armi-l-la i
1SG-GEN.M son army-OBL-SUP.ESS COP
'My son is in the army.' (A; *Alisultanova 2010*: 58)
- (24) di-b č'e-gu mašina ži
1SG-GEN.IV two-NUM car COP
'I have two cars.' (R)

Under negation, the situation is different, as all these types make use of the negative copula *s:u* (identical in form with the standard verbal negation marker, as already mentioned above⁴). Thus, (25) illustrates the context of equation, (26) illustrates attribution, (27) describes location, (28) describes possession and (29) describes existence. There does not seem to be any difference in the negation marking depending on temporary vs. permanent property assignment, or generic vs. specific predicates.

- (25) hajman boc'o s:u
sheep wolf COP.NEG
'A sheep is not a wolf.' (A; *Tales*)
- (26) iš:il he-w-ul=g^wa burt'-ol s:u
1PL.EXCL DEM-M-PL=DEGR rich-PL COP.NEG
'We are not so rich as they are.' (A; *Tales*)

⁴The situation when a standard negation marker and a negative existential are formally identical, but one is a free form and the other is bound, is not unique cross-linguistically, see (*Veselinova 2013b*: 113–114) on the Dravidian language Kannada. Cases of such morphological difference are not very numerous in the languages of the world, e.g. in *Veselinova's* (2013b: 116) sample of 95 languages there are only 4 languages that demonstrate this type of syncretism; at the same time, they all belong to different genealogical stocks.

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- (27) ho-łu hege-w s:u. hege-w w-uč'o-b-łu-k:u w-uč'i
 DEM-LOC DEM-M COP.NEG DEM-M M-die-PFV.PTCP-LOC-ELA M-rise.AOR
 'He is not here; he has risen (lit. from where he died).' (A; *Luke* 24:6)
- (28) hono-w moč'i-š:u-r χuča s:u
 DEM-M child-OBL.M-GEN.V book COP.NEG
 'This boy doesn't have a book.' (R)
- (29) insan-š:-č'u s:ihir dan se-b-gulo s:u!
 person-OBL.M-CNT sly thing one-IV-INDF COP.NEG
 'There is no one as sly as Man!' (A; *Tales*)

From the negative copula *s:u* a participle *s:u-b* is derived, see (30). The corresponding converbial function can be fulfilled by the form *s:u-gu*, featuring the regular adverbializer *-gu*. The form *s:u-gu* is also found in contexts of exclusion ('except for', 'only'), see §4.6.1.

- (30) di-č'u soru s:u-b hek'a
 1SG-CNT together COP.NEG-PTCP man
 'Whoever is not with me [is against me].' (lit. 'The man who is not with me.')

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

As in Nakh-Daghestanian languages in general, complementation and subordination in Andi involves the use of non-finite forms – converbs, participles, the infinitive and the action nominal traditionally labelled “masdar”. All of these forms employ the standard negator *-s:u*. The only exception is the perfective converb, which is syncretic with the finite perfect tense; although a standard negative form does exist, this generally uses the special negative morpheme *-č'igu* discussed in §2.1 above, cf. (31) with a converbial dependent clause expressing temporal precedence.

- (31) hila=si-š:u-b pač:ahi-łir [adam-i-⟨b⟩o
 above=ATTR-OBL.M-GEN.IV king-ABSTR people-OBL-AFFT<IV>
 haco-č'igu] b-igi-dja
 see-CVB.NEG IV-come-FUT
 'The kingdom of God will come unseen by the people (lit. without the people having seen it).' (A; *Luke* 17:20)

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There are two dedicated participle forms: the perfective participle in *-b* (which happens to be syncretic with the imperative of intransitive verbs) and the imperfective participle in *-dja* (which is syncretic with the future tense). While the latter has an irregular negative form marker *-dos:ja* identical to that of the future (see §2.1 above), in the perfective participle the negator *-s:u* precedes the participial suffix rather than following it, cf. *hago-b* ‘(the one) that saw’ ~ *hago-s:u-b* ‘(the one) that didn’t see’. Examples (32) and (33) show the use of participles in prenominal relative clauses.

- (32) [...] hit'on-d:u [onš:i-gulo b-it'i- b-it'i boc'o=gu **hago-s:u-b**]
 say-PRF once-INDF III-alive III-alive wolf=INTS see-NEG-PFV.PTCP
 nuf-nuf-o-di=lo
 Nuf-Nuf-OBL-ERG=ADD
 ‘[...] said Nuf-Nuf, who had never seen a living wolf.’ (A; *Tales*)

- (33) [dunja-l-la q'ir=lo **b-ižun-nos:ja**] rihi
 world-OBL-SUP.ESS corn=ADD IV-grow-IPFV.PTCP.NEG time
 ‘In the times when rice didn’t yet grow on earth’ (A; *Tales*)

The conditional form in *-bor*, which is historically derived from the perfective participle, has the same position for the negative suffix before the conditional mood suffix⁵, cf. *bik'o-bor* ‘if (it) is’ ~ *bik'o-s:u-bor* ‘if (it) is not’, see also (34).

- (34) di-b t'alab **t'obannoŋi-s:u-bor**, du-č'u
 1SG-GEN.IV demand be.fulfilled.CAUS-NEG-COND 2SG-CNT
 gal-la mijar=lo r-ik'u-dos:ja
 shoulder-SUP.ESS head=ADD V-be-FUT.NEG
 ‘If you do not satisfy my requirement, it will cost you dear.’ (lit. ‘your head won’t remain on your shoulders’) (A; *Tales*)

Another non-finite form with the same placement of a negator before the inflectional marker is the verbal noun (“masdar”) in *-r*, cf. *bik'o-r* ‘being, existence’ ~ *bik'o-s:u-r* ‘not being, non-existence’. The use of the masdar, which inflects for case and number like a regular noun, can be seen in (35).

⁵Conditional forms (the ones used in protases of conditional sentences) are traditionally described in Nakh-Daghestanian languages as belonging to the group of specialized converbs, as they are almost totally restricted to subordinate clauses.

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- (35) tawbu i-du b-uk:u-dosja hoč'oc'o=lo hoč'o-gu
 repentance do-INF IV-need-IPFV.PTCP.NEG ninety=ADD nine-NUM
 mu?min w-uk'o-su-r-o-qi, se-w q'osuni-w
 faithful M-be-NEG-MSD-OBL-APUD one-M sinner-M
 kant'uni-r-o-č'u-k:u
 repent-MSD-OBL-CNT-ELA
 '[There will be more rejoicing in heaven] over one sinner's repentance
 than over the ninety-nine righteous persons who do not need to repent.'
 (A; Luke 15:7)

Unlike the perfective participle and the masdar, the negative infinitive is derived from its affirmative counterpart in the same way as negative finite forms are derived, i.e. by placing the negator on the right edge, cf. *bik'u-du* 'to be(come)' ~ *bik'u-du-s:u* 'not to be(come)'. The infinitive is employed both in purpose clauses, as in (36), and in complements of complement-taking verbs like 'can, be able', 'want' or 'need'.

- (36) [...] he-lu-di men kodi w-uɣi-dja, hinc'o-l-č'u=cin
 DEM-OBL.PL.M-ERG 2SG in.hand.LAT M-take-FUT stone-OBL-CNT=PTCL
 du-b čuk'a tunkun-nu-su
 2SG-GEN.IV leg strike-INF-NEG
 '[...] they will lift you up in their hands, so that you will not strike your
 foot against a stone.' (A; Luke 4:11)

Besides the perfective converb described above, there are a number of other forms which can head adverbial clauses, and which are derived from various finite verb forms by means of the adverbializer *-gu*, often in combination with the emphatic clitic =*ža*, i.e. *-guža*. In all these cases, negative counterparts are derived as in finite verb forms, with *-gu(ža)* following the negated finite form (Maisak 2022). (37) illustrates the use of an adverbialized negative future heading a preposed subordinate clause.

- (37) [he-ldu se-r t'iri i-du beɣel-losja=gu=ža],
 DEM-MNR one-V a.little do-INF can-FUT.NEG=ADVZ=EMPH
 sebu-se-b-ul=lo hok'or-ol dan-ol i-du w-uɣin-nu
 RED:one-IV-PL=ADD heavy-PL thing-PL do-INF M-PL.get.down-INF
 w-uk'u-dja=le bis:il?
 M-PL.need-FUT=Q 2PL
 'Since you cannot do this very little thing, why do you worry about the
 rest?' (A; Luke 12:26)

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2.5 Negative lexicalizations

Andi does not seem to have any true negative lexicalizations. As a phenomenon partly resembling a negative lexicalization, one can mention the use of the verb *tidu* ‘become; be possible’ in the negative future *tidos:ja* (or *tidos:a*), with the meaning ‘(it is) impossible’, ‘(one) may not’. This verb can be employed with the inchoative meaning ‘become’, in particular as a light verb in intransitive deadjectival complex verbs such as *razi-ti* ‘agreed’ (< *razi* ‘content, accepting’), *baru-ti* ‘became beautiful’ (< *baru* ‘beautiful’) etc.; see Rochant (2018: 116–125) for details. The same verb is used as a possibilitive modal, taking a complement clause headed by the infinitive. With the modal meaning, the verb mostly occurs in the future tense⁶, i.e. *tidja* ‘can, may’ and *tidos:ja* ‘cannot, may not’ in the negative, cf. (38). The negative form *tidos:ja* alone can be used as a semi-lexicalized modal word ‘(it is) impossible’, ‘(it is) not allowed’, as in the Bear’s answer to Mashenka’s question in (39). Salimov (2010) even includes both *tidja* ‘(one) may’ and *tidos:a* ‘(one) may not’ (Russian *можно* and *nel’zja*) in his Andi–Russian lexicon. Such impersonal use is, apparently, completely in line with the modal semantics of *tidu*. Note also that the sense ‘cannot, be unable’ is a cross-linguistically common negative lexicalization (the fourth most common in Veselinova’s (2013a) variety sample of 105 languages).

- (38) iš:i-di imperator-šu-j naluki ič:i-du *ti-dja*=le jagi
 1PL.EXCL-ERG emperor-OBL.M-DAT tax five-INF become-FUT=Q or
ti-dos:a=le?
 become-FUT.NEG=Q
 ‘Are we to pay taxes to the Emperor or not?’ (A; *Luke* 20:22)

- (39) A: [Oh Bear, let me go and see my grandparents.]
 B: *ti-dos:ja*, men reš:-Li j-it’u-dja
 become-FUT.NEG 2SG forest-INTER F-get.lost-FUT
 ‘No (lit. may not), you will get lost in the woods [said Bear].’ (A; *Tales*)

2.6 Other clausal negation constructions: the ‘not-yet’ tense

Andi possesses a remarkable case of a ‘not-yet’ grammaticalization in the verbal domain, namely the verb form we label “counterexpectation present” or ‘still

⁶The use of the verb ‘become’ as a possibilitive modal with an infinitival complement, and the preference for the future tense in modal function, are not exclusive to Andi, but are common to many other Nakh-Daghestanian languages.

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not’ present (see Maisak 2018 and Maisak & Verhees 2024 for a more detailed account). In isolated usage, the form in *-david* listed in Table 1 seems to have a negative meaning by itself, without any negation marker: that is, forms like *rul-david* (from the verb ‘say’) tend to be translated simply as ‘doesn’t say’. This form has a regular negative equivalent in *-s:u*, whose meaning is (as might be expected) affirmative, e.g. *rul-david-s:u* ‘says’, or more precisely ‘it’s not true that s/he doesn’t say’, see also (40).

- (40) *musa-d woc:-u-l’o kakar q^war-david-s:u*
 Musa-ERG brother-OBL-SUP.LAT letter write-CNTE.PRS-NEG
 ‘Musa is indeed writing his brother a letter.’ (In reply to another speaker who doubts that this is the case.) (R)

However, it becomes clear from other examples that the form *-david* does not simply express negative meaning, but signals counterexpectation on the part of the speaker – the correct translation of *rul-david* would be not just ‘doesn’t say’, but rather ‘s/he still doesn’t say, although I expected him/her to’, see (41) and (42).

- (41) *anzi r-el-david*
 snow V-GO-CNTE.PRS
 ‘It still isn’t snowing [even though it is already January].’ (R)
- (42) *djo hege-b c’in-naid*
 1SG.AFFT DEM-IV know-CNTE.PRS
 ‘I still don’t quite understand that [although you have explained it to me].’ (R)

Such a dedicated verb form with counterexpectation meaning is not typical of the languages of the family, and functionally resembles ‘not-yet’ tenses in Africa, also known under the labels *tardative* (Plungian 1999: 319) or *nondum* (Veselinova & Devos 2021). Cross-dialectal comparison helps to see that the Andi counterexpectation present, which is morphologically bound in most dialects (cf. the Rikvani suffix *-david*, the Andi/Gagatli suffix *-david:u*), probably originated in a periphrastic construction with an auxiliary **b-abi*, with a gender agreement prefix. In the Zilo dialect, the form is less morphologized, and its underlying structure is “habitual in *-e* + auxiliary verb *b-abi*” (43). In the other dialects, the original structure “habitual in *-do* + auxiliary verb *b-avid(:u)*” must have fused into a single morpheme *-david(:u)*, dropping the gender marker.

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- (43) he-w k'amm-e-b-aɣij
 DEM-M eat-HAB-IV-CNTE.PRS
 'He does not [want to] eat.' (Z)

The form of the auxiliary verb in the counterexpectation present, i.e. *-daɣid* / *-daɣid:u* in most dialects, and *-b-aɣij* in Zilo, is the perfect in *-d* / *-d:u* / *-j* which in Andi also has resultative meaning expressing a current state (e.g. 'is sitting' or 'is standing' is expressed with the resultative form of the verbs 'sit down' and 'come to a stop', respectively). Although attested almost exclusively in the perfect/resultative form, the counterexpectation present auxiliary can also appear in the unmarked aorist (perfective past). The meaning of such forms is something like a "counterexpectation aorist", i.e. 'did not do (as expected)'. Thus, in (44) the "counterexpectation aorist" (44a) is close in meaning to the negative aorist (44b).

- (44) a. sun wošu-d ruli-b ži-daɣi
 yesterday boy-ERG say-PFV.PTCP do-CNTE.AOR
 b. sun wošu-d ruli-b žij-s:u
 yesterday boy-ERG say-PFV.PTCP do.AOR-NEG
 'Yesterday, the boy did not do what (he) was told.' (R)

The original meaning of the auxiliary verb *b-aɣi* is not clear. In modern Andi, this stem is used as a lexical verb only with the meaning 'get tired'. So, either 'get tired' was indeed the grammaticalization source, or else the verb has changed its original semantics, which remains unknown. Comparison with the other Andic languages does not help much, as cognate lexical verbs seem to be lacking, except in Bagvalal, where a rare verb *b-aɣi* is attested with the meaning 'resist, refrain from doing' (45). For details on possible cognates among the negation markers of the Andic languages, see Maisak & Verhees (2024).

- (45) k'^wan-di haddiɬ:ir q'erL'eri din b-ih-i-ra
 Kvanada-PL long.while struggle.AOR religion N-take-IPFV.INF
b-aɣi-o
 N-resist-CVB.PFV<N>
 'The people from Kvanada struggled for a long time, refusing to accept the religion.' (Bagvalal; Kibrik et al. 2001: 732)

Although I am not aware of any Daghestanian grammaticalizations involving an "inherently negative" verb like 'resist, refuse' (or 'be tired'), the development itself looks semantically plausible. According to Givón (2001: 382–383), "inherently negative modality verbs such as 'fail', 'lack', 'refuse', 'decline', or 'avoid'

commonly grammaticalize as negation markers”, as “their more specific semantic features are bleached out, leaving only their negative inference”. For a detailed recent study of the functions and the origin of ‘not yet’ expressions in Bantu languages, see [Veselinova & Devos \(2021\)](#).

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative replies

The positive reply to a polar question is *hun* ‘yes’⁷; in the available written corpus this word is very rare and only attested as *hu*. As a negative reply, the negative copula *s:u* can be used ([46](#)), which is a very common function of negative existentials worldwide ([Veselinova 2013b](#): 118, 139). Even more common is a negative reply *huns:u* ‘no’ which, quite remarkably, represents the fusion of both ‘yes’ and ‘no’, see ([47](#)). Both negative replies negate the propositional content (rather than disagree with the polarity of the question).

(46) A: [Do you think I came to bring peace on earth?]

B: hit’o-mado bis:i-qi, s:u, den w-ugo bis:il
 say-PROG 2PL-APUD COP.NEG 1SG M-COME.AOR 2PL
 sonso-č’u-k:u bat’-ol-i-du
 each.other-CNT-ELA separate-PL-FACT-INF
 ‘No, I tell you, I came to divide you.’ (A; *Luke* 12:51)

(47) A: [We ask for your hand!]

B: hun=s:u, he-b s:u=b-i:xi di-j hažatib dan
 yes=COP.NEG DEM-IV COP.NEG=IV-AUX.AOR 1SG-DAT necessary thing
 ‘No, this was not⁸ what I needed.’ (A; *Tales*)

In [Dirr’s](#) (1906) texts, a negative expression *haj joχ* ‘no’ is used several times as a negative reply, which seems to include the Turkic negative reply *joχ*. In modern texts, there is also a particle *aj* attested as a form of negative reply, cf. ([48](#)), which, however, remains an isolated example. [Salimov \(2010: 245\)](#) describes the meaning of *aj* as ‘not to do anything’.

(48) A: [Open the door, or I’ll break it! said the Wolf.]

⁷Or rather *hũ*, with a nasalized vowel (see also [Dirr 1906](#): 130; [Salimov 2010](#): 12).

⁸In the Andi dialect, *s:u* can be combined with the past tense auxiliary verb *b-i:xi* to express past meaning (‘was not’).

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- B: aj, den arχin-nosja!
 NEG.PTCL 1SG open-FUT.NEG
 ‘No, I won’t open!’ [said the piglet.] (A; *Tales*)

On the whole, one gets the impression that negative replies employing particles are rarely found in texts (even in dialogues), and that it is rather the negative verb form which is preferably used in such contexts, as in (49). The same is true of the affirmative reply *hu(n)*: according to my consultants, it is not very felicitous to use ‘yes’ as a reply to a question like ‘Did you do it?’ – normally, the reply will include just a verb form (e.g. ‘Did’).

- (49) A: [Do you think they were more guilty than all the others living in Jerusalem?]
 B: hit’o-mado bis:i-qi, w-ok’o-su=ɣod:u
 say-PROG 2PL-APUD M-PL.be.AOR-NEG=QUOT
 ‘I tell you, they were not!’ (A; *Luke* 13:5)

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

Negative indefinites are derived by means of a suffix *-gulo*, which is a lexicalized combination of an intensifying clitic =*gu* and an additive clitic =*lo* ‘also, even’⁹. Besides being a marker of negative indefinites, *gulo* can be also used as an emphatic particle, see §4.6.2 for an example.

The most frequent negative indefinite pronoun is *se-w-gulo* (*se-b-gulo*, etc.) ‘no one, nothing’ based on the numeral *se-w* ‘one’, with a final gender agreement suffix. This pronoun can be used both attributively and as an NP head, in the latter case it inflects for case and number (the absolutive case is unmarked, and the other case forms are derived from an oblique stem). Case/number inflection follows *-gulo*, which confirms its status as a suffix rather than a clitic. Negative indefinites in *-gulo* occur together with clausal negation. In (50), *sewgulo* is a modifier (‘no man’), in (51) and also (7), (9), (12) and (29) above it occurs in the unmarked absolutive form (‘no one, nothing’), and in (6) above it occurs in the dative (‘to no one’) heading an NP in an argument position.

- (50) **se-w-gulo** hek’a q’int’i-dosub bis:i-di
 one-M-INDF man press-PROH 2PL-ERG
 ‘Don’t extort money from any man.’ (A; *Luke* 3:14)

⁹For a description of the range of functions typically associated with intensifying markers, see Forker (2015) on the Avar enclitic *go* which is a close equivalent, and a cognate, of the Andi *gu*. See also Forker (2016) on the semantic typology of additives.

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- (51) amma hege-lu-⟨b⟩o se-b-gulo bič':uni-su=łodi
 but DEM-OBL.PL.M-AFFT<IV> one-IV-INDF understand.AOR-NEG=REP
 'But they did not understand anything.' (A; *Luke* 18:34)

Although in the overwhelming majority of examples *sebgulo* is found in negative clauses, it is possible to use it outside negative contexts as well, e.g. in questions. In (52) the sentence includes several conjoined dependent clauses with negative converbs, but there is no negation in the main clause ('did you lack anything?'). Thus, in *Haspelmath's* (1997: 199) terms, *sebgulo* would be a negative indefinite pronoun "in the deliberately vague sense 'indefinite pronoun that has "direct negation" as an important function'".

- (52) ja orsi b-ik'ol-d:u tarha b-iχi-č'igu, ja q'aj
 or money IV-be.CAUS-CVB wallet IV-take-CVB.NEG or belongings
 b-ik'ol-d:u q'wac'a r-iχi-č'igu, ja b-eršol-d:u
 IV-be.CAUS-CVB sack v-take-CVB.NEG or IV-change.CAUS-CVB
 b-oli-du nasil-ol b-oχi-č'igu, bis:il den-ni w-olelta-b
 IV-put.on-INF shoe-PL IV-PL.take-CVB.NEG 2PL 1SG-ERG M-let-PFV.PTCP
 rihi, se-b-gulo kami b-ik'o=de bis:i-j?
 time one-IV-INDF lacking IV-be.AOR=Q 2PL-DAT
 'When I sent you without having taken a purse, without a bag with your
 things, without shoes to wear, did you lack anything?' (A; *Luke* 22:35)

It is not only the numeral 'one' from which a negative/indefinite pronoun can be derived by means of *-gulo*, see (53)–(55). Thus, *Salimov* (2010) mentions in his dictionary such interrogative-based derivatives as *inu-gulo* 'anywhere' (< *inu* 'where?'), *i<w>a-gulo* 'to anywhere' (< *i<w>a* 'where to?', with a gender agreement infix), *inna-gulo* 'always' (< *inna* 'when?'), *il'ol-gulo* 'because' (< *il'ol* 'why?'), cf. also *čom-gulo* 'some' (< *čom* 'how many?'). *Onš:i-gulo* 'never' is derived from an adverb *onš:i* 'once'.

- (53) di-b burt'a-lir inna-gulo di-č'u soru
 1SG-GEN.IV rich-ABSTR when-INDF 1SG-CNT together
 'My wealth is always with me.' (A; *Tales*)
- (54) naf-naf ho-r čom-gulo zubu en-li=gu milki-l-č'u
 Naf-Naf DEM-V some-INDF day self.FN-GEN=INTS house-OBL-CNT
 b-eqi-du b-ik'w-o-d:u
 III-reach-INF III-be-PRF
 'Naf-Naf had been busy building his house for a few days already.' (A;
Tales)

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- (55) hege-l-č'u reχudu min onš:i-gulo b-ič'i-dos:ja!
 DEM-OBL.FN-CNT after 2SG once-INDF III-die-FUT.NEG
 'After that you will never die!' (A; *Tales*)

Within Haspelmath's (1997: Ch.8, 2013) typology of indefinite and negative pronouns, the series of pronouns in *-gulo* are "interrogative-based negative indefinites" which co-occur with predicate negation (both the interrogative-based structure and the co-occurrence with predicate negation are the most cross-linguistically common values). There is also another interrogative-based series of indefinites in Andi derived by means of the marker *-bolo* (*-bollo*) which represents a concessive mood ending: the concessive is derived from the conditional in *-bor* by means of the additive *=lo* 'also, even', which assimilates /r/ (i.e. *bolo* < *bollo* < **bor=lo* [COND=ADD]). Indefinites in *-bolo* generally correspond to the English *some*-series pronouns, e.g. *im-molo* 'someone', *ib-bolo* 'something', *čom-bolo* 'some amount', *inna-bolo* 'at some time', etc. Concessive forms of auxiliary verbs 'become' and 'be', i.e. *tibollo* and *bik'obollo*, can also be used to form indefinite phrases. The series of indefinites in *-bolo* (*-bollo*) represents what is usually known as "ordinary indefinites" (i.e. not negative, not free-choice and not specific indefinites), and is not used in direct negation contexts.

3.3 Negative derivation and the caritive meaning

The meaning 'without' can be expressed by a dedicated particle *ti*, or by constructions involving the participle of the negative copula/existential verb *s:u*, i.e. *s:u-b*. Among the Andi particles, Salimov (2010: 216) even lists *s:ub* and *tigu* as "negative particles", giving the following illustrations:

- (56) me=s:u-b dunjal, miči=s:u-b bič:in
 2SG=COP.NEG-PTCP world sun=COP.NEG-PTCP shadow.side
 'A world without you [is] a mountainside without sunshine.' (G; Salimov 2010: 216)
- (57) hede-w men=ti-gu w-ugo
 DEM-M 2SG=CAR-ADVZ M-come.AOR
 'He came without you.' (G; Salimov 2010: 216)

As for (56), *s:ub* here is not a particle but a participial form of the copula, heading relative clauses, namely '(a world) that does not have you' and '(a mountainside) that does not have the sun', see also example (30) above. The caritive meaning here is thus expressed by means of a standard syntactic construction,

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not by a dedicated marker. Note that, according to Veselinova (2013b: 118), the use “as a pre-/postposition meaning ‘without’ or as a privative marker” is one of the common cross-linguistic functions of negative existentials.

In contrast, *ti* (in example (57), with the adverbializer) is a dedicated caritive enclitic or function word, which does not have any other uses.¹⁰ It is hosted by noun phrases, and is used with the adverbializer when it heads an adverbial clause, as in (57) and also in (58) below. The only example of *ti* attested (in texts) without the adverbializer (59) seems to represent use in a secondary predication ‘more dead than alive’ (lit. ‘being neither dead nor alive’).

- (58) iš:i-w-ul=gu saldat-ol **ti-gu** iš:i-o
 1PL.EXCL-GEN.M-PL=INTS soldier-PL CAR-ADVZ 1PL.EXCL-AFFT<IV>
 se-b-gulo i-du bild:os:ja
 one-IV-INDF do-INF can+FUT.NEG
 ‘We cannot do anything without our soldiers.’ (A; *Tales*)
- (59) nif-nif=lo nuf-nuf=lo hege-b zaman j-it’-ol-gu=lo **ti**,
 Nif-Nif=ADD Nuf-Nuf=ADD DEM-IV time III.PL-alive-PL-ADVZ=ADD CAR
 j-oč’o-d:u=lo **ti** naf-naf-o-Li milki-l-χo helli-d:u
 III.PL-PL.die-CVB=ADD CAR Naf-Naf-OBL-GEN house-OBL-AD.LAT run-CVB
 j-eqo-d:u
 III.PL-reach-PRF
 ‘And Nif-Nif and Nuf-Nuf, who were then more dead than alive, ran to
 Naf-Naf’s house.’ (A; *Tales*)

Thus, the caritive meaning in Andi is expressed by means of syntactic constructions rather than morphologically: as an attribute ‘which does not have’, this is a participial clause headed by *s:ub*, and as an adverbial ‘without having’, this is a clause headed by *ti(gu)*. There are no dedicated derivational affixes with the caritive or related meanings.

¹⁰It is unclear whether *ti* is a clitic or an autonomous function word: it is written together with its host in the single example by Salimov (2010), but always separately in the *Tales* and the Gospel of Luke. Interestingly, Salimov (2010: 361) also includes *tigu* as a separate lexical entry in the dictionary appended to his grammar sketch. Note that the caritive *ti* is unrelated to the comitative, which is =*logu*, an enclitic which represents the fusion of the additive marker =*lo* and the adverbializer -*gu*.

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4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

Specification of the scope of negation can be achieved by negating a particular constituent, and not the main predicate. Thus, while in (60a) we have a standard negative copular clause with a negative copula ('shouldn't'), in (60b) the focus of negation is on the dependent clause, so it is the infinitive as the head of a complement that bears negation ('not to speak').

- (60) a. ruL-du hažat s:u
 say-INF necessary COP.NEG
 'One shouldn't talk.' (R)
- b. ruL-du-s:u hažat
 say-INF-NEG necessary
 'One should keep silence (lit. not-talk).' (R)

Constituent negation on a non-verbal constituent can be also marked with *s:u*.¹¹ Thus, (61a) illustrates standard clausal negation, (61b) shows that the agent NP in the scope of negation hosts *s:u*, and in (61c) it is the patient NP which is in the scope of negation and hosts *s:u*.

- (61) a. imu-d riL' b-iχi-s:u
 father-ERG meat IV-take.AOR-NEG
 'Father didn't buy meat.' (R)
- b. [imu-d]=s:u riL' b-iχi, ilu-L woc:u-d
 father-ERG=NEG meat IV-take.AOR mother-GEN brother-ERG
 'It was not father who bought meat, but mother's brother.' (R)
- c. imu-d [riL']=s:u b-iχi, LuLa r-iχi
 father-ERG meat=NEG IV-take.AOR butter V-take.AOR
 'It was not meat that father bought, but butter.' (R)

A particle =ž*a* can be optionally added in the assertive part to emphasize the correct alternative, as in (62–63). Judging from its typical uses in other contexts, =ž*a* can be tentatively labelled the marker of “uncontroversial information” (in the sense of Panov (2020)).

¹¹In Rikvani, the use of *s:ub* (originally, the participial copula form) is also attested in constituent focus marking, see (63) below.

- (62) den χ:uča q^war-rado-s:u, r-al'-rado(=ža)
 1SG book write-PROG-NEG V-read-PROG=PTCL
 'I am not writing a book, I am reading one.' (R)
- (63) den χ:uča=s:ub, kazjat(=ža) b-al'-rado
 1SG book=NEG newspaper=PTCL IV-read-PROG
 'I am not reading a book, (but) a newspaper.' (R)

The question arises whether in (61b) and (61c) *s:u* is just “the same” negator as occurs in (61a) on the verb, but simply “moved” to a focused constituent. This is a natural assumption given that focus marking by means of predicative elements, including copulas, is a common strategy in Nakh-Daghestanian languages, including those of the Andic branch (see [Kazenin 2003](#), [Kalinina & Sumbatova 2007](#), [Semënova 2014](#) and [Maisak 2023](#) for details). Consider the two pairs of examples from Bagvalal, another Andic language. In (64a) and (65a) with the affirmative and the negative periphrastic perfect, the auxiliary verb (copula) is placed in the default position after the lexical verb. In (64b) and (65b), the auxiliary appears after the subject NP which is in focus. Thus, in the affirmative and the negative clauses the focus marking strategy is absolutely identical.

- (64) Bagvalal (Avar-Andic, Nakh-Daghestanian)
- a. maḥammad w-a-⟨w⟩o ek^wa
 Muhammad M-come-CVB.PFV<M> COP
 'Muhammad came.' ([Kibrik et al. 2001](#): 683)
- b. [maḥammad] ek^wa w-a-⟨w⟩o
 Muhammad COP M-come-CVB.PFV<M>
 'It was Muhammad who came.' ([Kibrik et al. 2001](#): 683)
- (65) Bagvalal (Avar-Andic, Nakh-Daghestanian)
- a. maḥammad w-a-⟨w⟩o weč'e
 Muhammad M-come-CVB.PFV<M> COP.NEG
 'Muhammad didn't come.' ([Kibrik et al. 2001](#): 683)
- b. [maḥammad] weč'e w-a-⟨w⟩o
 Muhammad COP.NEG M-come-CVB.PFV<M>
 'It was not Muhammad who came.' ([Kibrik et al. 2001](#): 683)

As mentioned above, in Upper Andi the copula does not occur in periphrastic forms, so focus constructions comparable to those in Bagvalal do not exist. It

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may be, however, that the mechanism of constituent focusing by means of copula placement is only applicable under negation. In this case, what we see in (61b–61c) could be interpreted as focus marking by means of a negative copula, as in (64b) and (65b) from Bagvalal. Still, it is not the case that in examples like (61b–61c) the Andi negative marker *s:u* simply changes its linear position. It is possible to have *-s:u* both on the verb and on the focused constituent in those cases when, e.g., the speaker focuses the lack of involvement of a certain participant in the situation. Thus, in (66) the idea that the speaker does not talk is being rejected: what is being asserted is that it is the addressee who does not do this.

- (66) den=*s:u* ruL-rado-*s:u*, men
 1SG=NEG say-PROG-NEG 2SG
 ‘It is not me who isn’t talking, (but) you.’

While the latter example was constructed by me and approved by a native speaker, not all speakers accept sentences with two *s:u* markers, one as constituent negation and the other as verbal negation. At the same time, such examples can be produced during elicitation by Andi speakers themselves, cf. (67) suggested as the translation (from a Russian stimulus) for ‘It was not the father who did not come, but the brother’. Although I do not propose any final decision on the status of *s:u* as a constituent negator, it seems highly dubious that *s:u* on an NP can be analysed simply as the result of a “mobile” verb negator shifting to a new location. Note, for example, that in (67) the perfect verb form does not make use of the standard negator *s:u* at all (see also §4.6.3 for further discussion).

- (67) ima=*s:u* w-ugo-č’igu, woc:
 father=NEG M-come-PRF.NEG brother
 ‘It was not the father who did not come, (but) the brother.’

4.2 Negative polarity

With the exception of negative indefinites in *-gulo* (see 50–52 in §3.2) and probably also the reinforcing element *t’iri* (see 73–74 in §4.4), no negative polarity items have been identified.

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

There are no effects of negation on case marking, nor on any other types of marking of NPs.

4.4 Reinforcing negation

There seem to be no special grammatical means for reinforcing negation. In constituent negation constructions, contrastive negation can be expressed by changing the linear position of the negative marker *s:u*, as shown in §4.1.

Negated sentences can be made emphatic by means of the intensifying clitic *=gu*, as in (68) with the negative aorist and (69) with the negative future. As shown in (70) with the negative perfective converb, the emphatic use of *=gu* is also possible on subordinate clauses. In general, however, the emphatic use of *=gu* is not restricted to negative contexts, and it can occur in affirmative clauses as well.

- (68) di-b χoj b-ik'o=**gu**=s:u
 1SG-GEN.III dog III-be.AOR=INTS=NEG
 'I had no dog at all.' (R)
- (69) iš:-l'o s:e-b-gulo rul-do<**gu**>s:ja
 1PL.EXCL-SUP.LAT one-IV-INDF say-FUT.NEG<INTS>
 'He won't tell us anything at all.' (R)
- (70) [...] halt'unni-r j-ik'^wo-d:u lek'u šanni=**gu**=č'igu
 work-PROG F-be-PRF more take.rest=INTS=CVB.NEG
 '[...] she was working hard, without even taking a rest.' (A; *Tales*)

The additive clitic is also employed in contexts of emphatic negation, where it regularly expresses the scalar meaning 'even', see (71) which is functionally similar to (70) above. In (72), the meaning 'not a single one' is rendered by using both the numeral 'one' and the additive clitic. In affirmative contexts, the meaning of the additive can be both additive proper ('and, also', see §4.5) and scalar emphatic ('even').

- (71) [...] amma hede-b hege-li-lo=χ:ard:u harč'on=**no**=č'igu
 but DEM-III DEM-OBL.PL.FN-SUP.LAT=towards look=ADD=PRF.NEG
 '[...] but he didn't even look back at them.' (A; *Tales*)
- (72) men-ni di-j se-b c'ek'ir=ga=**lo** ič:i-su...
 2SG-ERG 1SG-DAT one-III goat=DEGR=ADD give.AOR-NEG
 'Yet you never gave me even a young goat...' (A; *Luke 15:29*)

Note that with negative verb forms, both *=lo* and *=gu* behave as endoclitics, being placed word-internally (see §4.6.3 for discussion).

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One more construction employed in contexts of reinforcing negation includes the word *t'iri*, originally a noun meaning ‘spatter, drop’ according to Salimov’s (2010: 365) lexical materials. In all examples attested in texts, *t'iri* in the reinforcing function is accompanied by the additive clitic, as in (73–74). The reinforcing use of *t'iri* seems to be restricted to negative clauses.

- (73) amma hege-b t'iri=lo sir-du dan b-ik^wo-č'igu en-li=gu
 but DEM-IV drop=ADD fear-INF thing IV-be-PRF.NEG self.FN-GEN=INTS
 hinc'o-l-Li milki-l-č'u hinu
 stone-OBL-GEN house-OBL-CNT inside
 ‘But they had nothing to fear (lit. not a thing to fear even a drop) in his stone house.’ (A; *Tales*)

- (74) hinžerlja kunt'a t'iri=lo hege-l-la razi
 this.time husband drop=ADD DEM-OBL.FN-SUP.ESS content
 li-č'igu
 become-PRF.NEG
 ‘This time the husband was not content at all (lit. not a drop).’ (A; *Tales*)

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

Finite coordination strategies, whether with affirmative or negative predicates, are rarely used in Andi, where non-finite constructions are much more prominent. Finite clauses, affirmative as well as negative, can be conjoined symmetrically by means of the additive clitic =*lo* ‘and, also’, which is not a coordinating device as such, as it can occur with a single constituent as well. With negative verb forms, =*lo* is placed word-internally as an endoclititic, before the negation marker, as in (75) (see §4.6.3).

- (75) c'a-do=lo=s:u, k'amm-o=lo=s:u
 drink-HAB=ADD=NEG eat-HAB=ADD=NEG
 ‘He neither drinks nor eats.’ (R)

There is a double phrase-initial conjunction *ja... ja* (an Arabic loan found in many Nakh-Daghestanian languages) which is used with the meaning ‘either... or’ in affirmative sentences, and ‘neither... nor’ in negative ones, as in (76). Like the additive, the disjunctive *ja... ja* is not exclusively a clausal conjunction, as it can combine with NPs as well. The two devices are also mutually compatible, cf. (77) where *ja... ja* is employed clause-initially, and the additive is placed on the two NPs in the two contrasted clauses.

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- (76) ja dan-a-di b-ic'i-b ust'ol s:u, ja r-ik^wok^wo
 or thing-OBL.PL-ERG IV-be.filled-PFV.PTCP table COP.NEG or V-burn.PTCP
 c'a s:u haq'u-la
 fire COP.NEG house-IN.ESS
 'In the house there is neither a table set (for guests), nor a fire burning (in the fireplace).' (A; *Tales*)
- (77) ja hila=si-š-č'u-k:u=lo sir-do-su den, ja
 or above=ATTR-OBL.M-CNT-ELA=ADD fear-HAB-NEG 1SG or
 adam-č'u-k:u=lo sul-ol-i-do-su
 people-CNT-ELA=ADD shame-PL-FACT-HAB-NEG
 'I don't fear God or care what people think.' (A; *Luke* 18:4)

Although highly marginal, a negative particle *aj* (which we saw in §3.1) is also attested in clause-final position in the 'neither... nor' context, see (78).

- (78) c'a-du=lo aj, ikun-nu=lo aj, he-l-lo
 drink-INF=ADD NEG.PTCL eat-INF=ADD NEG.PTCL DEM-OBL.FN-SUP.LAT
 harč'in-nu goš:i-d:u=logu
 look-INF get-CVB=COM
 [A girl so beautiful that people used to say looking at her:] '(One should) neither drink nor eat, only look at her.' (A; *Tales*)

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

4.6.1 Negative copula in the 'only X' construction

There is a frequent construction involving an adverbial form of the copula *s:u-gu* in the context of clausal negation (that is, there are two negation markers in a single clause), see (79–82). This construction is a standard means of expressing the meaning 'only' or 'nobody/nothing but'¹². Both noun phrases and verb phrases, as well as adverbial phrases, can host *s:ugu*, which in this construction should be probably regarded as a particle, not functioning as a copula or an existential verb.

¹²The same construction type has been described for Bagvalal (Kibrik et al. 2001: 182, 721–722), see also Tatevosov (2021) for a semantic analysis.

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- (79) hol'u-gu rešin=su-gu k'unt'-u-χa r-uχi-č'igu
 seven-NUM year=COP.NEG-ADVZ husband-OBL-AD.ESS V-take-PRF.NEG
 hege-l-di
 DEM-OBL.FN-ERG
 'She had lived with her husband for only seven years.' (A; *Luke* 2:36)
- (80) [...] s:urat-a-la=s:u-gu onš:i-gulo boc'o
 picture-OBL.PL-SUP.LAT=COP.NEG-ADVZ once-INDF wolf
 haco-s:u-b nif-nif-o-di
 see-NEG-PFV.PTCP Nif-Nif-OBL-ERG
 '[...] [said] Nif-Nif, who had only seen wolves in pictures.' (A; *Tales*)
- (81) hila=si-š:-di munah-ol mič'-ol-gu
 above=ATTR-OBL.M-ERG sin-PL little-PL-ADVZ
 ačolja-š:u-o mič'i-gu=s:u-gu
 clean<IV>.CAUS+IPFV.PTCP-OBL(M)-AFFT<IV> little-ADVZ=COP.NEG-ADVZ
 hilu-dosja
 love-FUT.NEG
 'Whoever has been forgiven little (by God) will only love little.' (A; *Luke* 7:47)
- (82) b-ihu azab-aq'uba=lo ič:i-d:u=su-gu
 IV-many punishment-suffering=ADD give-CVB=COP.NEG-ADVZ
 w-olelto=lo=s:u
 M-let.HAB=ADD=NEG
 '[A spirit] doesn't leave him without torturing him.' (A; *Luke* 9:39)

4.6.2 Negative forms in disjunction constructions

It is common for Nakh-Daghestanian languages to express contrastive disjunction ('or else', 'otherwise') by means of a form involving negation, e.g. a negative conditional form of a copula/existential verb, literally 'if it is not'. Andi conforms to this tendency. Contrastive disjunction can be expressed with the form *s:utibor* 'if not', which is a combination of *s:u* and the conditional form *tibor* of the verb 'become', see (83) and (84)¹³.

¹³As a disjunction particle, *jatibor*, a combination of *ja* 'or' with *tibor*, can also be used.

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- (83) želal s:u=li-bor š:ela w-uč'i-dja din
 today COP.NEG=become-COND tomorrow M-die-FUT 1SG
 [My dear son, you see that I am one foot in the grave,] 'I will die any day
 now (lit. today or tomorrow).' (A; *Tales*)
- (84) su=li-bor e<m>i hagi-du=di w-olon-d:u w-ok'o?
 COP.NEG=become-COND who<H> see-INF=WH M-PL.go-CVB M-PL.be.AOR
 [What did you go out into the desert to see? A reed swayed by the
 wind?] 'If not, what did you go out to see?' (A; *Luke* 7:25)

Another way of expressing disjunction is the use of a negative reply word *huns:u* 'no' (see §3.1), either on its own or with an additional emphatic particle *gulo*, cf. (85) and (86). The negative copula *s:u*, which is also used as a negative reply, can be found in the same function (87).

- (85) ho-b ei=ɓil, χ:unt'-u-li boši-llo-j=s:i milki=le,
 DEM-IV what<IV>=WH pig-OBL-GEN offspring-OBL-DAT=ATTR house=Q
 hun=s:u qala=le?
 yes=COP.NEG fortress=Q
 'What is this, a piglet's house or a fortress?' (A; *Tales*)
- (86) hun=s:u=gulo den ho-r r-iqon-nja!
 yes=COP.NEG=EMPH 1SG DEM-V V-break.CAUS-FUT
 '[Open the door,] or I'll break it!' (A; *Tales*)
- (87) mijarek'a, se-w-ul=gu iš:i-j=le hene-b misal men-ni
 lord one-M-PL=INTS 1PL.EXCL-DAT=Q DEM-IV parable 2SG-ERG
 boso-mado, su, ib-ul-olo-j=le?
 tell-PROG COP.NEG all-PL-OBL.PL-DAT=Q
 'Lord, are you telling this parable to us alone, or to everyone?' (A; *Luke* 12:41)

4.6.3 Endoclysis in negative verb forms and the status of *s:u*

As already illustrated in §4.4 and §4.5 above, when the additive clitic =*lo* or the intensifying marker =*gu* are hosted by a negative verb form, they are placed word-internally, directly before the negation marker. That is, in forms with the standard negation marker -*s:u* these clitics precede it (see (68), (75), (82)), while in the irregular forms of the negative future and the prohibitive they appear inside the cumulative tense-aspect-mood-negation marker, after -*do* and before the

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negator *-s:u* fused with another former morpheme (see (69) and also additional examples (88–89)).¹⁴ In the perfect / perfective converb, the clitics occur before *-č'igu* (see (70)).

- (88) *men araq' c'a-do<gu>s:ub!*
 2SG vodka drink-PROH<INTS>
 'Don't you drink vodka at all!' (R)
- (89) *hege-ši-lo bužu-do<lo>s:ub*
 DEM-OBL.M-SUP.LAT believe-PROH<ADD>
 '[Be careful] and also do not trust him.' (A; *Tales*)

Both *=lo* and *=gu* are clitics, not affixes, as they display highly “promiscuous” behaviour and, besides verb forms, can be hosted by various other constituents (including noun phrases in various cases, adjectives, adverbs, etc.). On the other hand, negative verb forms are affixal, which is especially obvious in the case of forms with irregular negation. It can thus be argued that the placement of *=lo* and *=gu* in negative verb forms in Andi is an instance of endoclysis (for details of the argumentation, see Maisak 2021)¹⁵. To my knowledge, in Andi only *=lo* and *=gu* behave as endoclititics, and it is only the negative verb forms that can host endoclysis.

The placement of *=lo* and *=gu* in regular negative forms before *s:u* (e.g. *c'a-do=lo=s:u*, *k'amm-o=lo=s:u* ‘neither drinks nor eats’ with the present habitual) does not by itself provide conclusive evidence in favour of the endoclititic analysis. The reason is that it is not immediately clear whether *s:u* in verb forms should be regarded as a suffix or as a clitic. To summarize, the main Andi negator *s:u* occurs in the following contexts:

- i as an agglutinative right-periphery marker in (most) negative verb forms,
- ii as a suffix preceding another suffixal inflection in a few non-finite forms,

¹⁴In the examples to follow, as well as in (69) above, I adopt a convention of glossing *=lo* and *=gu* inside synchronically unanalysable suffixes by means of angle brackets.

¹⁵Endoclititics, a.k.a. *intracclitics* or *mesocclitics*, are a rare type of clitics occurring inside words, either intermorphemically or intramorphemically. They are attested in a number of languages, such as European Portuguese, the Iranian languages Pashto and Sorani Kurdish, the Delta Edoid language Degema and some Southern Mande languages. Endoclysis of person agreement markers (and also negation markers and the additive clitic) has previously been described for a Nakh-Daghestanian language, namely Udi, a Lezgic language spoken in Northern Azerbaijan and Eastern Georgia (Harris 2002).

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- iii as a former suffix now fused with other morphemes into a single negative complex (in the prohibitive and the negative future markers *-dos:ub* and *-dos:ja*),
- iv as a negative copula,
- v as a constituent negation marker.

Although *s:u* can be considered a clitic in functions (iv) and (v), a suffix in function (ii) and a “submorph” in function (iii), the status of *s:u* in (i) is not so clear. Moreover, different approaches can be taken to decide how many different *s:u* morphemes we are dealing with. Historically, of course, the negative copula and the constituent negation marker, as well as the verbal negator(s), all go back to one and the same morpheme, but on a synchronic level they may represent multiple distinct morphemes (at least two, the suffixal *s:u* and the clitic *s:u*).

As I have argued in §4.1, *s:u* as a verbal negator and *s:u* as a constituent negation marker are probably not one and the same “movable” morpheme synchronically, as the constituent negation marker can appear in predicates which either already contain the verbal negator (meaning that there are two instances of *s:u* in the same clause), or cannot take it on at all (e.g. with the verb form in *-č’igu*). Likewise, one probably should not treat the verbal negator *s:u* synchronically as the same morpheme as the negative copula *s:u*, unless one wishes to say that all negative verb forms are periphrastic (as opposed to the affirmative forms which are synthetic). First, in the perfective participle and the masdar *s:u* is definitely a suffix, and cannot be a copula. Likewise, although verb-final *s:u* occurs with some non-finite forms (cf. the infinitive *bik’udu-s:u* ‘not to be, not to happen’), it would be strange to claim that the negative infinitive is derived from its affirmative counterpart with the help of a negative copula. An alternative analysis might be that among the negative verb forms in *s:u*, some are underlying periphrastic forms with a negative copula *s:u*, while others (in particular, non-finite forms) are simply suffixal, but this analysis seems to be unreasonably complicated. I conclude that there are three *s:u* morphemes in modern Andi, namely a suffix found on verb forms (except some irregular ones) and two clitics, a constituent negator and a negative copula.

4.6.4 Diachronic notes and observations

The wide distribution of a single marker *s:u* which is found on both declarative and non-declarative, finite and non-finite verb forms is an unusual feature of Andi, as in Andic languages verb forms do not always have regular negative

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equivalents and different negation morphemes are usually used for the encoding of different domains of negation.

According to [Alekseev \(1988: 119\)](#) the main negation marker at the Proto-Andic level was probably **-č'i*, although in Andi *-č'igu* is the only remnant of this proto-language morpheme. One can possibly identify the element *gu* in *-č'igu* as diachronically related to the intensifier, but in present-day Andi *-č'i* cannot be used without *gu* in any context, nor can *-č'igu* as a whole be employed in any other way except as part of the negative perfect (perfective converb). It is also not impossible that the form or the very existence of the marker *-č'igu* in Andi has been influenced by Avar, where the negative perfective converb has the suffix *-č'ogo* (and *go* is an intensifier clitic in Avar).

Furthermore, as pointed out by [Alekseev \(1988: 119\)](#), another Proto-Andic negation marker **s:i* is generally restricted to prohibitive forms in modern Andic languages, so its expansion in Andi may be a “secondary phenomenon”¹⁶. The details of the historical evolution of negation in Andi are, however, obscure, as no records of the language are available from earlier centuries.

5 Conclusion

A peculiarity of Andi among the closely related languages of the Avar-Andic branch is the expansion of one and the same negative marker *s:u* into several domains of negation: the suffix *-s:u* is the marker of standard negation, but it is also used with non-indicative and non-finite verb forms. Besides, the negative copula has the same form *s:u*, and *s:u* is employed in constituent negation as well.

Negation in the verb paradigm is symmetric in the sense that all categories have affirmative and negative forms. In most verb forms, the suffixal marker *s:u* either follows or precedes another inflectional suffix, depending on the particular form. Although most negative constructions are symmetric in that “the negative does not differ from the corresponding affirmative in any other meaningful way than by the presence of the negative marker(s)” ([Miestamo 2005: 61](#)), three verb forms display constructional asymmetry of the A/Cat/TAM type.

There is a series of “counterexpectation” verb forms which seem to go back to a periphrastic construction involving some “inherently negative” auxiliary verb (**b-avi*); in general, forms with such semantics are not common in the languages of the family.

¹⁶It is not impossible that some version of the Negative Existential Cycle has been in operation in Andi and has fostered the expansion of a new standard negation marker from a negative existential (copula). On the the Negative Existential Cycle, see a seminal paper by [Croft \(1991\)](#) and a recent overview by [Veselinova & Hamari \(2022\)](#), among others.

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An interesting variant of a negative reply is *huns:u* which is a combination of a positive reply ‘yes’ with a negative copula (the latter can also function as a negative reply ‘no’ on its own).

The dedicated marker of negative indefinite pronouns *-gulo* is a lexicalized combination of two clitics, the intensifier *=gu* and the additive/scalar marker *=lo* ‘also, even’. There is also a dedicated adverbial caritive marker *ti(gu)* ‘without having’, while in the attributive construction, caritive phrases are headed by the participle of the negative copula.

As is common in Nakh-Daghestanian languages, contrastive disjunction (‘or else’, ‘otherwise’) can be expressed by means of a negative copula, a negative reply or a negative conditional form ‘if it is not’. A conventional means of expressing ‘only X’, ‘nobody/nothing except X’ is a combination of the adverbial form of the negative copula *s:ugu* with clausal negation (i.e. ‘saw only X’ will be expressed as ‘did not see not X’).

Table 2 summarizes the negative morphemes of Andi and the main constructions associated with them.

Table 2: Summary of negative morphemes and constructions

Negative morphemes / constructions	Functions
-s:u	standard negation (indicative, non-indicative, non-finite verb forms)
-dos:ja	negation of the future tense / imperfective participle (portmanteau morpheme historically including -s:u, < *-do-s:u-ja [-HAB-NEG-IPFV.PTCP])
-dos:ub	negation of the imperative (portmanteau morpheme historically including -s:u, < *-do-s:u-b [-HAB-NEG-IMP])
-č'igu	negation of the perfect tense / perfective converb (portmanteau morpheme, not cognate with -s:u)
-daɪd:u / -daɪd / b-aɪj	counterexpectation present (going back to a combination involving an inherently negative auxiliary verb *b-aɪ)
s:u	negative copula; also negative reply 'no'; also constituent negation marker
ɬidos:ja / ɬidos:a	'cannot, may not, is not allowed' (< 'become' in the negative future)
huns:u	negative reply 'no' (< hun 'yes' + negative copula s:u)
haj joχ, aj	negative replies 'no' (marginal)
-gulo	marker of negative indefinites (< intensifier =gu + additive =lo 'also, even')
-s:ub	head of an attributive caritive phrase ('one that does not have', < participle of the negative copula s:u)
ti(gu)	head of an adverbial caritive phrase ('without having', dedicated marker with or without the adverbializer gu)
t'iri	an element occasionally used to reinforce negation (< noun 'spatter, drop')
X=s:ugu + clausal negation	conventional means of expressing 'only', 'nobody/nothing except'
s:u, s:uɬibor	contrastive disjunction marker ('or else', 'otherwise'); negative copula s:u or its combination with a conditional form ɬibor 'if it is, if there is'
huns:u(=gulo)	contrastive disjunction marker ('or else', 'otherwise'); negative reply 'no' or its combination with an emphatic particle
ja... ja...	phrase-initial conjunction 'neither... nor' in negative sentences
...aj ...aj	phrase-final conjunction 'neither... nor' in negative sentences (marginal)

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Abbreviations

1	first person	HAB	habitual
2	second person	IN	localization ‘inside’
III	third (neutral) gender	INDF	indefiniteness
IV	fourth (neutral) gender	INDIR	indirect
V	fifth (neutral) gender	INF	infinitive
ABSTR	abstract noun	INTS	intensifier
AD	localization ‘near’	INTER	localization ‘in a mass’
ADD	additive	IPFV	imperfective
ADVZ	adverbializer	LAT	lative
AFFT	affective (case)	LOC	locative
AOR	aorist	M	masculine
APUD	localization ‘close to’	MNR	manner adverbial
ATTR	attributivizer	MSD	masdar (action nominal)
AUX	auxiliary	N	neutral gender
CAR	caritive	NEG	negation
CAUS	causative	NUM	numeral
COM	comitative	OBL	oblique
COND	conditional	PFV	perfective
CNT	localization ‘in contact’	PL	plural
COP	copula	PRF	perfect
CVB	converb	PROG	progressive
DAT	dative	PROH	prohibitive
DEGR	degree	PRS	present
DEM	demonstrative	PTCL	particle
ELA	elative	PTCP	participle
EMPH	emphatic	Q	polar question
ERG	ergative	QUOT	quotative
ESS	essive	RED	reduplication
EXCL	exclusive	REP	reportative
F	feminine	SG	singular
FN	feminine or neutral	SUP	localization ‘on top’
FACT	factitive	CNTE	counterexpectation
FUT	future	VBZ	verbalizer
GEN	genitive	VOC	vocative
H	human	WH	content question

Unmarked values (absolute, singular) are not glossed.

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Chapter 7

Negation in Tsova-Tush

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The present paper is a survey of negative constructions in the Nakh-Daghestanian language Tsova-Tush. Standard negation in main clauses, subordinate clauses and stative predications is expressed by a preverbal particle *co*. This negator is also found in the formation of other negative constructions like negative pronouns, or in tag questions, as well as in negative replies. Another negation particle *ma* is used with optatives and imperatives in order to form prohibitive constructions. Furthermore, there are several devices that can be used to derive negative items like privatives and to reinforce negation.

Keywords: negation, Tsova-Tush, negative pronouns, privative formation, negative lexicalization.

1 Introduction

Tsova-Tush (ISO: **bbl**, Glottocode: **bats1242**), also known as Batsbi, belongs to the Nakh branch of the Nakh-Daghestanian (or Northeast Caucasian) language family together with Chechen and Ingush. It is spoken by less than 500 people in a village in the Eastern part of the Republic of Georgia. The majority of speakers are older than 50 and children don't learn the language anymore. The Tsova-Tush people came from the mountains to the lowland in the 19th century and since then have been heavily influenced by Georgian, not only culturally but also linguistically, which is reflected in the vast amount of loanwords but also in some grammatical constructions.

Tsova-Tush is a morphologically ergative language, with some fluid intransitive verbs (Holisky 1987). Beside a number of grammatical cases, there are a number of spatial cases. All cases, beside the absolutive which is zero marked, need

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a so-called oblique stem marker to which they are attached. Another salient feature of Tsova-Tush is gender, a feature that is found in most Nakh-Daghestanian languages. There is a total of eight genders, and gender agreement is mainly triggered by the absolutive arguments, i.e. S and P arguments. Gender agreement is indexed by prefixes on many verbs, some adjectives, adverbs and one numeral and postposition. Due to the influence of Georgian, Tsova-Tush additionally developed person agreement which is not found in many other Nakh-Daghestanian languages. First and second person S and A arguments trigger person agreement which is marked by a suffix that is undoubtedly of pronominal origin.

The data presented here come from different sources. By far the biggest corpus is the Endangered Caucasian Languages in Georgia (ECLinG) corpus,¹ where most of the data stem from. More data is found in several Tsova-Tush dictionaries (Kadagidze & Kadagidze 1984; Bertlani et al. 2013; Bertlani et al. 2019) and other existing literature on the language (e.g. Holisky & Gagua 1994, a short grammar sketch; Schiefner 1856, the first description of the language). Additionally, I used data from my own fieldwork.

The focus of this paper is the expression of negation in Tsova-Tush and its structure follows the questionnaire for describing negation systems of languages (Miestamo 2025): §2 deals with clausal negation, i.e. negation in declarative and non-declarative clauses, negation in stative predications and negation in non-main clauses. In §3 non-clausal negation will be illustrated, that is negative replies, negative indefinites and negative derivational devices. Other aspects of negation such as the scope of negation, reinforcing negation and coordination of negated clauses are treated in §4. Finally §5 will sum up the most important features of negation in Tsova-Tush.

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

Standard negation in Tsova-Tush is quite regular and achieved by means of the negator *co*. This particle always appears preverbally, as is expected for an SOV language, and there is no structural asymmetry (cf. Miestamo 2005) between positive and negative clauses, i.e. they only differ in absence vs. presence of the negation marker as can be seen in examples (1) and (2) which both contain the

¹The ECLinG corpus is available in the MPI archive which can be accessed via <https://archive.mpi.nl/>

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verb *d-ał-iⁿ* ‘III-give-AOR’.² In the first clause it is affirmative while in the second one it is used with the negator *co*.

- (1) *ča pxi p’at’run d-ał-iⁿ son=e o tapar-v*
 one five cartridge(III).ABS III-give-AOR 1SG.DAT=COORD this gun-INS
daḥ-v-ax-en-es
 PVB-I-go-AOR-1SG.ERG
 ‘He gave me some five cartridge cases and I went there with that gun.’
 (ECLinG, bav22_11, 00:01:52)
- (2) *erek’le mepe-s oquj-n nal-i co d-ał-iⁿ*
 Erekle king-ERG 3SG.OBL-DAT horseshoe(III).ABS-PL NEG III-give-AOR
 ‘King Erekle didn’t give him horseshoes.’ (ECLinG, bav17_06, 00:00:28)

Tsova-Tush has several preverbs to express spatial and aspectual relations. In complex verbs that consist of a preverb and the lexical verb, the negation particle follows the preverb and precedes the verb, (3). This not only shows that the preverbs are not fully attached to the verb, but also that the negator *co* could be treated as a prefix rather than a particle. There are, however, some other instances, where *co* is not fully integrated into the verb, e.g. in polar interrogative clauses, the interrogative enclitic *=i* attaches to the item in preverbal position, which is – in negative polar interrogatives – *co*. Therefore, I will treat it as a particle, as in (3).

- (3) *atx uq deni ču co ix-atx*
 1PL.EXCL.ERG that.OBL day.IN PVB.in NEG go-1PL.EXCL.ERG
 ‘We don’t go inside that day.’ (ECLinG, bav21_05, 00:01:16)

Tsova-Tush has periphrastic verb forms consisting of a participle and the auxiliary *daⁿ* ‘be’. The negator *co* tends to precede the entire construction, i.e. it occurs either before the participle, as in (4), or it occurs before the auxiliary, as in (5). Its occurrence before the auxiliary is much less common.

- (4) *ištuⁿ vum co xac’-en d-a soⁿ žer*
 such thing(III).ABS NEG hear-PTCP III-be.PRS 1SG.DAT yet
 ‘I haven’t heard such a thing yet.’ (ECLinG, bav19_06, 00:01:03)

²Roman numerals in the gloss are used to indicate gender.

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- (5) co j-a-ħ daħ-q'anajlñ vʃalaʔ=a uišne
 NEG II-be.PRS-2SG.ABS PVB-become_old.PTCP at_all=COORD similar
 bubuk'-saⁿ lamzur j-a-ħ
 flower-like beautiful II-be.PRS-2SG.ABS
 'You have not become old at all, you are as beautiful as a flower.' (ECLinG, bav14_07, 00:00:13)

In complex verbs that consist of a root and a transitivizing or intransitivizing derivational suffix, *co* cannot intervene between the root and the suffix (cf. Harris (2009)), e.g. (24).

There is no inherent 'not yet' form in the sense of Comrie (1985: 54–55) in Tsova-Tush. Expression of such constructions is achieved by the Georgian particle *žer* 'yet', as in (6).

- (6) seⁿ badr-i-v žer co ałin d-a so-go
 1SG.GEN child-PL-ERG yet NEG say.PTCP III-be.PRS 1SG-ALL.IN
 'My children haven't said that to me yet.' (ECLinG, bav13_17, 00:05:16)

A suffix that is only found in negative contexts is *-gě* which is attached to verbs to express 'no longer, not anymore' and is used together with the negation particle *co*. In present and aorist forms it follows the tense suffixes, as in (7), while the past tense suffix and personal markers follow it, as in (8–9).

- (7) soⁿ ħo co j-ec'e-gě
 1SG.DAT 2SG.ABS NEG II-love.PRS-anymore
 'I don't love you (female) anymore.' (fieldnotes)
- (8) co j-il-ge-r
 NEG II-laugh-anymore-PST
 'She was no longer laughing.' (Holisky & Gagua 1994: 187)
- (9) co ał-in-ge-s
 NEG say-AOR-anymore-1SG.ERG
 'I no longer said it.' (Holisky & Gagua 1994: 187)

From time to time the suffix *-gě* is marked twice on verbs. According to my consultant this double marking is used to draw attention to the emotional bond the speaker has toward the event, as in (10).

- (10) *ese alni duq daxn co d-a-ge-gě*
 here Alvani.IN many cattle(III).ABS NEG III.be.PRS-anyone-anymore
 ‘Here in Alvani, there are not many cattle anymore.’ (ECLinG, bav07_13,
 00:04:36)

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

Non-declarative clauses, i.e. interrogative and imperative clauses show some deviation from the standard negation pattern illustrated in §2.1.

In content questions the negation particle *co* behaves as in standard negation, it simply precedes the verb as illustrated in (11) with the interrogative pronoun *vuⁿ* ‘why’.

- (11) *vux ał-in, vuⁿ co d-axk’-eⁿ*
 what say-AOR why NEG III-come-AOR
 ‘What did they say, why didn’t they come back?’ (ECLinG, bav19_16,
 00:01:47)

Polar questions, however, are marked by the interrogative enclitic =*i* which is attached to the item that precedes the verb. In case of negation this is *co*, which – through a regular phonological process – becomes *cu=j*, as in (12). If, however, the focus of the polar question is on another constituent, it will take the interrogative enclitic instead, as can be seen in (13), where the focus of the question is on *bader* ‘child’.

- (12) *dezert’ cu=j v-a?*
 deserter(I).ABS NEG=Q I-be.PRS
 ‘Isn’t he a deserter?’ (ECLinG, bav24_09, 00:00:51)
- (13) *bader=i co d-a?*
 child(III).ABS=Q NEG III-be.PRS
 ‘Isn’t it a CHILD?’ (fieldnotes)

Prohibitive constructions are formed by using the negation particle *ma*, which precedes the imperative. Just like the standard negator *co* it occurs in preverbal position, as in (14), and after preverbs, as in (15). Positive and negative imperatives only differ in presence vs. absence of the prohibitive particle, i.e. they belong to group II of *van der Auwera & Lejeune (with Valentin Goussev)*’s (2013) classification of prohibitives: “The prohibitive uses the verbal construction of the second singular imperative and a sentential negative strategy not found in (indicative) declaratives.”

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- (14) seⁿ ag bŋarçe is levan-ate-r [k'ak'al duq ma
 1SG.GEN grandmother always this say-HAB-PST nut(IV).ABS many PROH
 j-aq'o-t coḥek'a kort-i-x muc'uk' d-ejɬ
 IV-eat-IMP.PL otherwise head-OBL-CCS pimple(III).ABS III-appear
 šun=ajno]
 2PL.DAT=QUOT
 'My grandmother always used to say: "Don't eat too many nuts,
 otherwise pimples will break out on your head."' (ECLinG, bav04_01,
 00:08:33)
- (15) daḥ ma j-ic-j-o-l jaš-o
 PVB PROH II-forget-II-INTRZ-POL sister-VOC
 'Sister, don't forget!' (Mikeladze 2011: 146)³

In negative optatives, which express wishes, curses, and the like and are formed by adding the politeness suffix *-l* to the imperative suffix, the same particle *ma* is used, as in (16).

- (16) matx ma gib-a-l oquj-n
 sun PROH see-IMP-POL 3SG.OBL-DAT
 'May s/he not see the sun!' (Holisky & Gagua 1994: 182)

2.3 Negation in stative predications

Negation in stative predications does not differ from standard negation. All stative predications, i.e. equation, proper inclusion, attribution, locative predication, existential predication and possessive predication, are headed by the copula. If negated, the standard clausal negator *co* precedes the copula, as in (17–22), and, again, there is no structural asymmetry between negative and positive stative predications. Unlike periphrastic verbal constructions, where *co* precedes the entire construction, in stative predications, the negator precedes the copula, not the predicate.

Although Schiefner (1856: 63) mentions the omission of the copula-final vowel when used with *co*, i.e. *co d-a* 'it is not (NEG III-be.PRS)' becomes *cod*, I could not find examples of this form in my data. According to my speaker, this form is not used anymore even though she notes that her grandmother, born in the late 19th

³There is no vocative in Tsova-Tush; the suffix has been borrowed from Georgian

century, used this form. Later generations, however, only used it when mockingly imitating the speech of older people.⁴

(17) Equation

o juq' co j-a
this ball(IV).ABS NEG IV-be.PRS
'This is not a ball.' (ECLinG, bav23_08, 00:03:35)

(18) Proper Inclusion

meⁿ st'ak' st'ak' co v-a
some man(I).ABS man(I).ABS NEG I-be.PRS
'Some men are not men.' (Bertlani et al. 2013: 147)

(19) Attribution

e c'a d-aq:oⁿ co d-a
that house(III).ABS III-big NEG III-be.PRS
'This house is not big.' (fieldnotes)

(20) Locative Predication

kežbera co d-a č'er-e-x
spider(III).ABS NEG III-be.PRS wall-OBL-CCS
'The spider is not on the wall.' (fieldnotes)

(21) Existential Predication

normalurat ise samušao co j-a
normally here work(IV).ABS NEG IV-be.PRS
'Normally, there is no work here.' (ECLinG, bav21_10, 00:02:38)

(22) Possessive Predication

vir co d-a txo-go
donkey(III).ABS NEG III-be.PRS 1PL.EXCL-ALL.IN
'We don't have a donkey.' (ECLinG, bav07_01, 00:11:11)

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Tsova-Tush non-main clauses are headed by a number of non-finite verb forms like converbs to express temporal and other adverbial relations, participles, or

⁴Another similar contraction that is still in use is *comad* from *com* 'nothing' (see 3.2) and *d-a* 'III-be.PRS'

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verbal nouns (masdars). In negative subordinate clauses, these are preceded by the negation particle *co*.

Examples (23) and (24) illustrate negative adverbial clauses, marked by the simultaneous converb and the conditional converbs, respectively, with the preposed negator *co*.

- (23) [čuh co j-a-š] dayonbadjailnō j-a-sō
 home NEG II-be.PRS-SIM.CVB sad.II II-be.PRS-1SG.ABS
 ‘When I’m not at home, I’m sad.’ (Holisky & Gagua 1994: 203)
- (24) [xi co maɬ-d-i-čeh-a], [xi-n mak co
 water NEG drink-III-TR-COND.CVB-2SG.ERG spring-DAT on NEG
 hēc’-d-i-čeh-a] čuxui voma? daħ-daxašle-bala
 turn-III-TR-COND.CVB-2SG.ERG lamb(III).PL all PVB-die_out-INTRZ
 ho-go
 2SG-ALL.IN
 ‘If you don’t give the lambs water, if you don’t let them walk around a
 spring, all of them will die on you.’ (ECLinG, bav03_02, 00:06:54)

Negative adverbial clauses that are formed by means of the verbal noun behave just as the negative converbal adverbial clauses, i.e. the negator precedes the verbal noun as exemplified in (25) where the causal adverbial clause is headed by the verbal noun in the contact case which is preceded by the negator *co*.

- (25) [doⁿ co xiɬ-r-ex] kuitad v-eʔ-n-as
 horse NEG become-MSD-CCS on_foot I-come-AOR-1SG.ERG
 ‘Because of not having a horse, I came on foot.’ (Holisky & Gagua 1994: 204)

One of the strategies to form relative clauses in Tsova-Tush, as is typical for Nakh-Daghestanian languages, is by using participles. In (26), the head of the relative clause is a participle which, in negative contexts, is preceded by the negation particle.

- (26) [že-x daħ co v-ac’ujn] st’ak’
 sheep-CCS PVB NEG I-care_for.PST.PTCP man(I).ABS
 ‘A man who didn’t care for sheep.’ (ECLinG, bav24_08, 00:01:13)

While Chechen, one of the two sister languages of Tsova-Tush, has negative converbs that are used, for instance, in resultative constructions (cf. Molochieva 2010: 146), there are no negative converbs in Tsova-Tush.

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

There is one negative lexicalization in Tsova-Tush, *vuntxe?* ‘not know’, as in (27). Note that the use of *vuntxe?* as a complement taking item is rare and it mainly functions as a parenthetical. A more frequent way of expressing ‘not know’ is by means of the negator *co* and the verb *xe?aⁿ* ‘know.INF’.

- (27) oqus o xi hal-maɫ-en, vuntxe? oqujn vux d-a
 3SG.ERG that water PVB-drink-AOR not.know 3SG.DAT what III-be.PRS
 ‘She drank that water not knowing what it was.’ (ECLinG, bav18_02, 00:01:49)

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative replies

Negative replies to positive polar questions are expressed by the negation particle *co*. It can either function on its own as a prosentence as in example (28) or be accompanied by additional information.

- (28) Q: osih=i d-ex-ne-š?
 there=Q III-live-AOR-2PL
 ‘Did you live there?’
 A: co.
 NEG
 ‘No.’ (ECLinG, bav22_16, 00:02:04)

The same particle *co* is used in order to provide a negative reply to a negative polar question, as in (29). Repetition of the whole clause is also possible in negative replies although it is much less common. An example for complete repetition is (30) where the negated clause is used without an additional preceding negative particle *co*. The only difference is the shift in person marking from second person to first person.

- (29) dec’ar vux d-a cu=j xe? hoⁿ? co=en
 love(III).ABS what III-be.PRS NEG=Q know.PRS 2SG.DAT NEG=QUOT
 aɫ-iⁿ
 say-AOR
 ‘Don’t you know what love is? “No”, she said.’ (ECLinG, bav19_02, 00:00:52)

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- (30) Q: co mušebado?
 NEG work.PRS.2SG.ABS
 ‘Don’t you work?’
 A: co mušebado-s
 NEG work.PRS-1SG.ABS
 ‘I don’t work.’ (ECLinG, bav08_04, 00:00:40)

If there is an affirmative answer to a negative polar question there is a polarity-reversing particle *mohec*, whose primary meaning is ‘of course’, but it can be used to contradict the negative question, similar to special particles that are found in other languages which fulfill the same function, e.g. German *doch* or Hungarian *de* (for an extensive overview on polarity reversing particles cf. [Holmberg 2015](#), and [Moser 2019](#)). In (31), *mohec* is used in this function expressing the speaker’s familiarity with the harmonica in contrast to the propositional content of the question.

- (31) Q: lungyar nat’uiⁿ garmoⁿ cu=j xac’en j-a
 Longianti Nato.GEN harmonica(IV).ABS. NEG=Q hear.PTCP IV-be.PRS
 hoⁿ?
 2SG.DAT
 ‘Didn’t you listen to Logianti Nato’s harmonica?’
 A: mohec, xac’en j-a soⁿ
 of_course hear.PTCP IV-be.PRS 1SG.DAT
 ‘Yes, of course I listened to it.’ (ECLinG, bav24_12, 00:03:29)

The impact of the Georgian language can be seen in negative replies as well since the use of the Georgian negation particle *ara* is found occasionally, as in (32).

- (32) Q: dah-b-oxk’-aⁿ co le?-er hoⁿ?
 PVB-V-sell-INF NEG wish-PST 2SG.DAT
 ‘Didn’t you want to sell it?’
 A: ara, co b-ujxk’-n-as
 no NEG V-sell-AOR-1SG.ERG
 ‘No, I didn’t sell it.’ (ECLinG, bav05_10, 00:01:13)

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

Negative indefinites in Tsova-Tush are interrogative-based (cf. [Haspelmath 1997, 2013](#)) and are formed by combining the standard negation marker *co* with interrogative pronouns. The only exception to this is the negative indefinite *com* ‘nothing’ which is a contraction of the standard negator *co* and the indefinite pronoun *vum* ‘something’. A partial paradigm is given in Table 1 which shows the formation of negative indefinites with ‘who’ and ‘what’. As can be seen in Table 1, the interrogative pronouns are suppletive, i.e. absolutive pronouns are based on the stems *meⁿ* and *vux*, while the oblique pronoun stems are *ħan-* and *st’en-*.⁵

Table 1: Tsova-Tush interrogative and negative absolutive and oblique pronouns

		‘who’		‘what’	
		Interrogative	Negative	Interrogative	Negative
ABS		<i>meⁿ</i>	<i>comena</i>	<i>vux</i>	<i>com</i>
OBL		<i>ħan-</i>	<i>coħan-</i>	<i>st’en-</i>	<i>cost’en-</i>
DAT		<i>ħann</i>	<i>coħanna</i>	<i>st’enn</i>	<i>cost’enna</i>

Further negative indefinites are ‘nowhere’ and ‘never’ which are formed in a similar way. The combination of the standard negator *co* and the interrogative *mičēħ* ‘where’ yields *comičēħ* ‘nowhere’. This negative indefinite can be further modified by spatial case markers. In (33), the ablative marker is suffixed to the negative indefinite. Similarly, the negating particle *co* can combine with the interrogative *macaⁿ* ‘when’ which results in the negative indefinite *comacni*, as in (34), although the expression of ‘never’ is most of the time achieved by means of simple standard negation with the particle *co*.

- (33) iq dač’irba sašvelav comič-rena j-a so-go
 this.OBL trouble.IN help(IV).ABS nowhere-ABL IV-be.PRS 1SG-ALL.IN
 ‘In this trouble, help is coming from nowhere.’ ([Bertlani et al. 2013: 272](#))
- (34) comacni lax-mak’ soⁿ ħo
 never find-POT 1SG.DAT 2SG.ABS
 ‘I can never find you.’ (fieldnotes)

⁵This form is also found in answers to ‘Thank you’, i.e. *cost’eni* ‘You’re welcome!’

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According to Mikeladze (2011: 202ff) there are three types of clauses with negative indefinites, one of them being the original Nakh one while the others are borrowings from Georgian and mirror the historical development of Georgian negative indefinite clauses. The three patterns are as follows:

1. the use of an indefinite pronoun in a negative clause which seems to be the original Nakh pattern, as in (35), and (36) for comparison to Ingush
2. the use of a negative indefinite pronoun in an affirmative clause, as in (37–38)
3. the use of a negative pronoun in a negative clause, i.e. double negation, as in (39–40)

In the first pattern, an indefinite pronoun is used in a negated clause. This strategy is the original strategy in Nakh languages but seems to be in the course of being replaced by the Georgian patterns. Compare examples (35) from Tsova-Tush and (36) from Ingush, its sister language. There are no dedicated negative indefinite pronouns in Ingush but if used in negative clauses, the generic-noun-based indefinites *sag* ‘person’ and *hama* ‘thing’ function as negative pronouns (cf. Nichols 2011: 696).

- (35) ham-en co xajc’-n-or txe pharči-ⁿ axa-r
 someone.OBL-DAT NEG hear-AOR-REP 1PL.GEN dog.PL-GEN bark-MSD
 ‘Nobody heard our dogs’ barking.’ (Mikeladze 2011: 198)
- (36) Ingush (East Caucasian, ISO: inh, Glottocode: ingu1240)
 taxan balxa sag hwa-vendzar
 today work.ADV person DX-V.COME.NEG.WIT.PST
 ‘Nobody came to work today.’ (Nichols 2011: 696)

The second pattern, the use of a negative indefinite pronoun in an affirmative clause, seems to be a Georgian calque and presents a structurally intermediate stage between the lack of negative indefinite pronouns and negative concord. This strategy is also the most common in Schiefner’s early grammar of Tsova-Tush from 1856, although the third pattern is found occasionally. Examples (37) and (38) illustrate the use of negative indefinite pronouns in affirmative clauses. Just as in Georgian, the position of the negative pronoun in this construction is restricted to the preverbal position. In the third pattern, negation is additionally marked by preverbal *co*, allowing the negative pronoun to have a less restricted position (cf. for Georgian King 1996), as in (40).

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- (37) coḥan-na xajc'-n-or txe pḥarči-ⁿ axa-r
 nobody.OBL-DAT hear-AOR-REP 1PL.GEN dog.PL-GEN bark-MSD
 'Nobody heard our dogs' barking.' (Mikeladze 2011: 202)
- (38) isev comena d-ec'e-r d-aʔ-it-aⁿ oqus
 here nobody.ABS III-must-PST III-come-CAUS-INF 3SG.ERG
 'She wasn't allowed to let anybody enter there.' (ECLinG, bav18_04, 00:10:41)

The use of negative pronouns in negative clauses is a rather recent innovation, probably a calque from Georgian. Constructions with this double negation do not differ from the previous two strategies in meaning. Example (39) can be used to express the same proposition as examples (35) and (37). As mentioned above, negative pronouns or quantifiers do not need to be adjacent to the verb or the negator in this construction but can be followed by other constituents, as in (40).

- (39) coḥa-na co xajc'-n-or txe pḥarči-ⁿ axa-r
 nobody.OBL-DAT NEG hear-AOR-PST 1PL.GEN dog.PL-GEN bark-MSD
 'Nobody heard our dogs' barking.' (Mikeladze 2011: 202)
- (40) comiče ḥeⁿ žagnō co d-ag-ir soⁿ
 nowhere 2SG.GEN book(III).ABS NEG III-see-PST 1SG.DAT
 'I haven't seen your book anywhere.' (fieldnotes)

Negative pronouns in prohibitive constructions and optatives are used in the same manner although the standard negator *co* is replaced by the prohibitive particle *ma*, as in (41).

- (41) mamena ma d-o-la-l esev
 nobody.ABS PROH III-come-IMP-POL here
 'Nobody come here!' (fieldnotes)

In polar questions which contain negative indefinite pronouns, the position of the interrogative marker =*i* varies. With *com* 'nothing' the interrogative marker is attached to the negative pronoun, i.e. *com=i*, as in (42). On the other hand, in polar questions that involve *comena* 'nobody', the interrogative marker is attached to the negator, i.e. it is placed between the negator with which the negative indefinite is formed and the interrogative pronoun, *cu-j-mena* 'NEG-Q-who', as in (43).

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- (42) com=i xeʔ soⁿ
 nothing=Q know.PRS 1SG.DAT
 ‘Don’t you know anything?’ (ECLinG, bav16_02, 00:00:40)
- (43) psare cujmena lav-iⁿ šu-gö
 yesterday nobody.ABS.Q talk-AOR 2PL-ALL
 ‘Did nobody talk to you yesterday?’ (fieldnotes)

Further negative indefinites are formed with *com* ‘nothing’ and are used mainly to reinforce negation (see §4.4), *com-ač* ‘nothing at all (nothing.ABS-INTS)’, *com-c* ‘not at all (nothing.ABS-indeed)’, *ča-ʔ-com* ‘nothing at all (one-again-nothing)’, *com-gě* ‘nothing anymore (nothing-anymore)’, *com-c-ge-ʔ* ‘nothing anymore (nothing-indeed-anymore-again)’, *ča-ʔ-co* ‘not even one (one-again-NEG)’ and *ča-comena* ‘nobody at all (one-nobody.ABS)’.

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

There are several derivational processes in Tsova-Tush to form privatives. The primary strategy to form privatives is by means of the suffix *-c’iⁿ* which can be attached to nouns, as in (44), and verbal stems, as in (45).

- (44) txeⁿ c’a dadi-c’iⁿ d-is-en=e išt’aʔ
 1PL.EXCL.GEN house(III).ABS master-PRIV III-remain-AOR=COORD such
 d-a-r-atx
 III-be-PST-1PL.EXCL.ABS
 ‘Our house remained without a master and so we lived.’ (ECLinG, bav19_13, 00:01:58)
- (45) ʔamda-c’iⁿ j-a-r=e p’ap’ra gor-e-ⁿ joħ
 learn-PRIV II-be-PST=COORD Papashvili family-OBL-GEN girl(II).ABS
 j-a-r
 II-be-PST
 ‘She was uneducated and she was a girl from the Papashvili family.’
 (ECLinG, bav22_08, 00:00:18)

Another possibility to express privatives is direct borrowing of Georgian privatives that are formed by the circumfix *u-* *-o* with loss of the word-final vowel. While this strategy is restricted to Georgian loanwords, the Tsova-Tush privative suffix *-c’iⁿ* can be applied not only to indigenous Tsova-Tush words but to Georgian loanwords as well. In the first example below, Tsova-Tush has borrowed

the privative form of the Georgian word with loss of the suffix. In the second example, only the noun has been borrowed from Georgian, and the Tsova-Tush privative suffix is added.

1. Georgian *ut'vino* > Tsova-Tush *ut'viⁿ* 'brainless'
2. Georgian *uk'almo* vs. Tsova-Tush *k'almec'iⁿ* 'without a pen'

With some adjectives it is possible to derive antonyms by prefixing the standard negation marker *co* to it, e.g. *coyazen* 'not good, bad' from *yazen* 'good'.

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

In focused negative constructions, the scope of negation can be narrowed to the NP in focus. The NP in the scope of negation is followed by the negator *co* which – in standard negation – precedes the verb and can be additionally marked by *ma* 'however', as in (46).

- (46) mit'ö seⁿ vaš v-a=e p'et'ö ma co
 Mito 1SG.GEN brother(1).ABS I-be.PRS=COORD Peto however NEG
 'Mito is my brother, not Peto.' (Holisky & Gagua 1994: 210)

4.2 Negative polarity items

Beside the negative pronouns that are only found in negative constructions there are two more items that are only used in negative contexts. The first one is *vsala?* 'at all' which is used to reinforce negation (§4.4) The second one is the postposition *bedeⁿ* 'but, besides, except for' which is treated in §4.6.2. Although the resulting clause is does not express a negative meaning, it still requires the clause to be marked by the negation particle *co*.

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

There are no effects on the marking of NPs in negative constructions.

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4.4 Reinforcing negation

There are several items that are used to reinforce negation. A frequent one is the negative polarity item *vʃala?* which would best be translated as ‘at all’. It is only found in negative contexts and can be used with the standard negation marker *co*, as in (47), as well as with the prohibitive marker *ma*, as in (48), and negative pronouns, as in (49). Its position seems not to be fixed.

- (47) *co j-a-ħ daħ-qʻanjajln vʃala?=a uišne*
 NEG II-be.PRS-2SG.ABS PVB-become_old.PTCP at.all=COORD similar
bubukʻ-saⁿ lamzur j-a-ħ
 flower-like beautiful II-be.PRS-2SG.ABS
 ‘You have not become old at all, you are as beautiful as a flower.’ (ECLinG, bav14_07, 00:00:13)
- (48) *vʃala? tataⁿ ma j-aqo-t, aʃ-iⁿ o badri-g,*
 at.all noise(IV).ABS PROH IV-spread-IMP.PL, say-AOR this children-ALL,
atʻin ʔedaxkʻ-a-t, aʃ-iⁿ
 quiet sit.PL-IMP-IMP.PL say-AOR
 “‘Don’t make any noise,’ he said to the children, “sit there silently ...”
 (ECLinG, bav18_04, 00:15:57)
- (49) *j-ax:eⁿ bež j-a o Maqvle-go-ħ=e, lamzur*
 IV-long hair(IV).ABS IV-be.PRS this Maqvala-ALL-IN=COORD beautiful
zorejš=e, šer nana-s vʃala? comiče ix-it-or
 very=COORD REFL mother-ERG at.all nowhere.IN go-CAUS-PST
 ‘That Maqvala has long hair, very beautiful and her mother did not allow her to go anywhere at all.’ (ECLinG, bav18_02, 00:00:06)

Another strategy to reinforce negation is the use of the negative reinforcing item *comcge?* (*com-c-ge-?* ‘nothing-indeed-anymore-again’) that is used to express ‘nothing anymore’. Similarly *comgě* (*comgě* ‘nothing-anymore’) can be used to fulfill the same function. Further items found with *com* ‘nobody’ to reinforce negation are *comačʻ* ‘nothing at all’ which uses the intensifying suffix *-ačʻ*, as in (50) and *com-c* ‘not at all (nothing-indeed)’.

- (50) *ma kot:l-a-t, tiv-a-t=ajno*
 PROH sorrowful.INTRZ-IMP-IMP.PL relax-IMP-IMP.PL=QUOT
xajcʻno, baqʻe? comačʻ tag-din-or den-cha?
 understand.AOR really nothing_at_all do-TR-PST day-one
 “‘Don’t worry, relax!’, they understood and they did nothing at all for the

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whole day.’ (fieldnotes)

Other negative pronouns that are based on the numeral *čha* ‘one’ in order to express ‘at all’ are e.g. *čha-ʔ-co* ‘not even one (one-again-NEG)’, *čha-ʔ-com* ‘nothing at all (one-again-nothing)’, as in (51) and *čha-ʔ-comena* ‘nobody at all (one-again-nobody)’, as in (52).

- (51) inc marnan-i-v čhaʔcom d-ec’ aʔ-aⁿ
 now mother_in_law-PL-ERG nothing_at_all III-must.PRS say-INF
 ‘Now, the mothers-in-law mustn’t say anything at all.’ (ECLinG, bav16_06, 00:05:20)

- (52) qeⁿ aʔ-iⁿ o k’nat-i-v, msaxur-i-v me čhaʔcomena co
 then say-AOR that boy-PL-ERG servant-PL-ERG SUB nobody_at_all NEG
 d-a=en aʔ-iⁿ
 III-be.PRS=QUOT say-AOR
 ‘Then those boys, the servants, said “Nobody is here at all”.’ (ECLinG, bav18_04, 00:14:17)

The same strategy to reinforce negation is found in prohibitives, where *čhaʔcom* is replaced by its prohibitive counterpart *čhaʔmam*, as in (53).

- (53) čhaʔmam d-ik’-a-l=ajnö, d-ex-iⁿ vaš-a-s
 nothing_at_all III-take-IMP-POL=QUOT III-request-AOR brother-OBL-ERG
 nan-a-x
 mother-OBL-CCS
 ‘“Don’t take anything at all”, the brother asked his mother.’ (fieldnotes)

Finally, there is a suffix *-k’aʔ* ‘a little’ which is usually used with adjectives or adverbs (e.g. *kast’en-k’aʔ* ‘a little quickly (quickly-DIM)’). If used with the negator *co* it expresses a rather negative attitude of the speaker towards the proposition although not as drastic as standard negation, as in (54).

- (54) o hal-qexk’-ien co-k’aʔ j-ec’ soⁿ
 this PVB-boil-PTCP NEG-DIM IV-love.PRS 1SG.DAT
 ‘I don’t like it (the meat) too much when it is boiled up.’ (ECLinG, bav08_12, 00:08:20)

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4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

There is no special negative coordinating conjunction for coordinating affirmative and negative clauses, or two negative clauses. This can be achieved by juxtaposition, by using the coordinator *je* ‘and’ or the coordinating enclitic *=e* ‘and’ respectively.

Another strategy that is found with coordinated negative clauses, as well as with negated coordinated constituents, is coordination by means of the particle *le* ‘or’ which is used to form negative correlative conjunctions. If used to coordinate negative clauses, the particle is placed clause initially and each clause is either negated independently or, if they share the same verb, only one clause receives a negator.

In coordinated prohibitive clauses the same particle *le* ‘or’ is used but together with the prohibitive particle *ma*.

When used with negated coordinated constituents, *le* precedes each constituent, as in (55), while the negator is found in its standard position, i.e. preceding the verb.

- (55) txen pñeh dah co b-axk’l-ar xolme le qor, le sxal, le
 our village.IN PVB NEG V-rot-PST use_to or apple or pear or
 cha?com
 nothing_at_all
 ‘In our village neither the apples, nor the pears, nor anything else became
 rotten.’ (ECLinG, bav04_01, 00:17:57)

Tsova-Tush has a negative conjunction, *coñek’a?* ‘lest, otherwise’, which is made up of the negator, the conditional *-ñě*, and *-k’a?* ‘a little’, as in (14) and (56).

- (56) so-g v-ek-iⁿ me ñal ma qit: coñek’a? p’irdap’ir
 1SG-ALL I-shout-AOR SUB PVB PROH get_up lest straight
 qos-o-s ñoⁿ ał-iⁿ
 fire-FUT-1SG.ERG 2SG.DAT say-AOR
 ‘He shouted at me: “Don’t stand up, otherwise I will fire at you.”’
 (ECLinG, bav06_07, 00:02:37)

An example for contrastive negation can be found in §4.1.

Tsova-Tush has one modal verb to express possibilities, permission and the like, *mak’aⁿ* ‘can, be able’, which can appear in two constructions.

- *mak’aⁿ* can be attached directly to the verbal stem, as in (58)

- *mak'aⁿ* is used finitely together with an infinitive, as in (59–60)

In negation with the first pattern the negator *co* precedes the verbal stem to which the potential marker is attached, as in (57–58). Tense and person markers follow the potential suffix.

- (57) *co v-ax-mak' soⁿ*
 NEG I-go-POT.PRS 1SG.DAT
 ‘I can’t understand why men drink beer.’ (fieldnotes)
- (58) *co xaʔ-mak' soⁿ [ʃuⁿ meɬö vaser-v jeg]*
 NEG know-POT.PRS 1SG.DAT why drink.PRS men-ERG beer
 ‘I can’t understand why men drink beer.’ (fieldnotes)

In the second pattern, i.e. with *mak'aⁿ* used as a finite verb, the negator can either precede the potential verb, i.e. it negates the matrix clause, as in (59), or it precedes the infinitive inside the subordinate clause, as in (60).

- (59) *co mak' hoⁿ [inc moqb-aⁿ]*
 NEG can.PRS 2SG.DAT now sing-INF
 ‘You can’t sing now.’ (fieldnotes)
- (60) *[ču co v-ax-aⁿ] mak' soⁿ me [bin*
 PVB NEG I-go-INF can.PRS 1SG.DAT SUB flat(III).ABS
miyeba-d-o-lo-s]
 receive-III-TR-SUBJ-1SG.ERG
 ‘I can’t go there to take the flat.’ (ECLinG, bav25_15, 00:03:53)

In negative constructions, however, the first pattern is preferred. The second pattern is found rarely overall but seems to be preferred for affirmative constructions. The distribution of the two patterns in negative and affirmative contexts is illustrated in Table 2.

Table 2: Distribution of *mak'aⁿ* in negative and positive clauses

	NEG	POS	n
<i>V-mak'aⁿ</i>	91	5	96
<i>mak'aⁿ + V-INF</i>	6	21	27

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4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

4.6.1 Negative transport

There are at least two instances of negative transport, i.e. the negator of the matrix clause is interpreted as negating the subordinate predicate. Those two items that allow negative transport are the verb *mot:aⁿ* ‘think’ and *tabit* which can best be translated as ‘it seems (to me)’, as in (61–64).

(61) co mot: soⁿ [me o v-ay-ö]
 NEG think.PRS 1SG.DAT SUB 3SG I-come-PRS
 ‘I don’t think that he is coming.’ (fieldnotes)

(62) mot: soⁿ [me o co v-ay-ö]
 think.PRS 1SG.DAT SUB 3SG NEG I-come-PRS
 ‘I think that he is not coming.’ (fieldnotes)

(63) co tabit [v-ay-ö o]
 NEG it_seems I-come-PRS 3SG
 ‘It does not seem that he is coming.’ (fieldnotes)

(64) tabit [o co v-ay-ö]
 it_seems 3SG NEG I-come-PRS
 ‘It seems that he is not coming.’ (fieldnotes)

It is matter of future research to establish whether other predicates allow negative transport.

4.6.2 Non-negative uses of negatives and expletive negation

Another construction that involves the standard negation marker *co* is the tag question. Tsova-Tush tag questions are formally the same as negation in negative polar interrogatives, i.e. they are formed by combining the negative particle *co* and the interrogative enclitic *=i*. The resulting tag question marker *cuj* follows the clause it refers to. In contrast to e.g. English tag questions, in Tsova-Tush there is no reversed polarity, i.e. the negative tag question is used with positive as well as negative clauses. In (65), the clause that precedes the tag question marker *cuj* is negated, while in (66) the main clause is positive. In affirmative clauses there is another possibility by using the particle *ha?ⁱ* ‘yes=Q’, although the former strategy seems to be preferred with both polarities.

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- (65) *haʔ, magram oquj-go co j-a-r gač'irveb, cu=j?*
 yes but 3SG-ALL.IN NEG IV-be-PST poverty(IV).ABS NEG=Q
 'Yes, but this one wasn't poor, was he?' (ECLinG, bav25_16, 00:01:45)
- (66) *j-aq:oⁿ p'ativ j-eb1-or marnan-e-n*
 IV-big respect(IV).ABS IV-put-PST mother_in_law-OBL-DAT
 mardad-e-n, cu=j?
 father_in_law-OBL-DAT NEG=Q
 'They respected their mother-in-law and father-in-law, didn't they?'
 (ECLinG, bav15_06, 00:05:07)

The postposition *bedeⁿ* 'but, besides, except for' is another expression that is only found in formally negative contexts that actually encode a positive sense. In (67), the postposition governs its noun in the case that is required by the verb, here the contact case. While the proposition itself is not negative, the postposition can only be used together with the negator *co*.

- (67) *rvapeqaʔo surt-a-x bedeⁿ co d-ag-in d-a*
 octopus(III).ABS picture-OBL-CCS besides NEG III-see-PTCP III-be.PRS
 soⁿ
 1SG.DAT
 'I have only seen an octopus in a picture.' (Bertlani et al. 2013: 243)

4.6.3 Diachronic notes and observations

Since there is not a lot of historical data other than Schiefner (1856), and today there is no new generation speaking the language, there is not a lot of material for diachronic observations. We can still offer some reasoning based on the available data.

The first change we find is the expansion of the contraction in negative copula constructions. The formerly acceptable, morphologically complex forms *cod*, *cov*, *coj*, ... which consist of the negator and the gender marker with loss of word-final vowel of the copula are now only available as independent word forms, i.e. *co da*, *co va*, *co ja*, ... (see §2.3).

Another observation concerns negative pronouns. While the language started out with using indefinite pronouns in negative clauses, due to Georgian influence Tsova-Tush adopted negative indefinite pronouns which were first used in affirmative clauses and are now subject to negative concord, i.e. with additional negation of the clause in addition to negative indefinite marking (see §3.2).

5 Summary

This paper gave an overview on negation in Tsova-Tush. Table 3 summarizes the most important negation strategies.

Table 3: Summary of negation in Tsova-Tush

Clausal negation		Chapter	Examples
<i>co</i>	preverbal particle used to negate		
	(1) main clauses	§2.1	(2–4)
	(2) subordinate clauses	§2.4	(23–26)
<i>ma</i>	(3) stative predications	§2.3	(17–22)
	preverbal particle used to negate		
	(1) imperatives	§2.2	(14–15)
<i>cuj</i>	(2) optatives	§2.2	(16)
	preverbal particle <i>co</i> + interrogative enclitic	§2.2	(12–13)
-gě	= <i>i</i> used to negate polar interrogatives		
	verbal suffix only used in negative clauses, expresses ‘no longer’	§2.1	(7–10)
žer	particle to express ‘not yet’ in negative clauses	§2.1	(6)
<i>vuntxe?</i>	negative lexicalization ‘not know’	§2.5	(27)
Non-clausal negation			
<i>co</i>	negative particle used as default negative reply to positive and negative questions	§3.1	(28–29)
<i>mohec</i>	polarity reversing particle meaning ‘of course’, used as affirmative reply to negative questions	§3.1	(31)
<i>co/ma</i> + interrogative pronoun	formation of negative pronouns	§3.2	Table 1
	- <i>c’i</i> ⁿ	suffix used for the formation of privatives from nouns and verbal stems	§3.3 (44–45)
<i>cuj</i>	negative particle <i>co</i> + interrogative enclitic = <i>i</i> , used to mark tag questions	§4.6.2	(65–66)
Other aspects of negation			
<i>všala?</i>	NPI ‘at all’, used to reinforce negation	§4.4	(47–49)
<i>bedeⁿ</i>	NPI used in expletive negation expressing ‘only’	§4.6.2	(67)
<i>cohek’a</i>	negative conjunction ‘lest, otherwise’	§4.5	(56)

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Abbreviations

I-V	gender	INTS	intensifier
1	first person	INTRZ	intransitivizer
2	second person	MSD	masdar
3	third person	NEG	negator
ABL	ablative	OBL	oblique stem marker
ABS	absolutive	PL	plural
ADV	adverbial	POL	politeness
ALL	allative	POT	potential
AOR	aorist	PRIV	privative
CAUS	causative	PROH	prohibitive
COND	conditional	PRS	present
COORD	coordinating enclitic	PST	past
CCS	contact case	PTCP	participle
CVB	converb	PVB	preverb
DAT	dative	Q	polar question
DIM	diminutive	QUOT	quotative
DX	deictic prefix	REFL	reflexive
ERG	ergative	REP	reported past
EXCL	exclusive	SG	singular
FUT	future	SIM	simultaneous
GEN	genitive	SUB	subordinator
HAB	habitual	SUBJ	subjunctive
IMP	imperative	TR	transitivizer
IN	spatial case 'in'	VOC	vocative
INF	infinitive	WIT	witnessed
INS	instrumental		

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Chapter 8

Negation in Khalkha Mongolian

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This chapter offers an introduction to the negation system of Khalkha Mongolian structured according to typological and functional categories. The negation of declarative predicates, nominalized elements and adverbial clauses is all done by a former existential negator (=güi). For locative negation, the same negator generally combines with the copula. Alternatively, a new locational negator (*alac* ‘absent’) can be used for locative, dative-possessive and marginally privative-possessive negation. Possession is negated either by a dative-based or a privative-based pattern. Nouns are negated by the former adjective *biš* ‘other’, which usually also negates adjectival predicates and is used with participles for metalinguistic negation. Second person imperatives are almost exclusively negated by a preverbal negator (*bitgii*) which likely goes back to a verb form ‘desist!’. Negative one-word answers can be formed by both (*ü*)güi and *biš*, while lone *bitgii* can be used to turn down somebody else’s proposed action. Postverbal negators (=güi, *biš*) take scope over preceding elements within the predicate, while there tend to be strong preferences for the position of the negator in sentences with a matrix and subordinate predicate. The negation of indefinites is expressed by a focus clitic in combination with clausal negation. This paper also addresses negative lexicalizations and other aspects of negation.

Keywords: Standard negation, prohibitive, ascriptive negation, negative derivation, negative modal adjectives.

1 Introduction

This paper is intended as a comprehensive introduction to the negation system of Khalkha Mongolian (ISO: **khk**, Glottocode: **halh1238**) as spoken in the Mongolian

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state. The paper starts out from the author's general understanding of Mongolian negation, based on existing literature and experience as a second language user. To extend this limited basis, all negative forms within a 134,191 word (18 hours) Spoken Corpus in a partially phonetic transcription ("SC", Zolžargal & Brosig 2012 [=SC1], 2012/2017 [=SC2]) were annotated and classified. Since this corpus underrepresents several forms that a literate user of Khalkha Mongolian would consider part of her negation system, several individual patterns were additionally evaluated on the basis of a 34,642,687 word Internet Corpus ("IC", Östling & Brosig 2011). Regardless of whether data is taken from spoken, written or secondary sources, this paper employs a unified transcription trimmed towards phonemic accuracy.¹ In the bibliography and for citing text other than examples, a strict transliteration of Mongolian Cyrillic is used.² In examples from the non-televised part of SC2, person names are anonymized. Capitalization is retained in IC, but not imposed on SC.

Khalkha Mongolian is part of the Mongolic language family. Prehistorically, "Common Serbi-Mongolic" split into Proto-Serbi-Avar (including Xianbei, Taghbach, T'u-yü-hun and Kitan, first mentioned for the 1st century CE, linguistically attested from 6th century CE onwards) and Pre-Proto-Mongolic (Shimunek 2015: 25, 84–85, 116–118, 135–136). By the early 13th century, it had evolved into Middle Mongol (in the eastern parts of the contemporary Mongolian state), the ancestor of all contemporary Mongolic languages. In the 13th-14th century, Middle Mongol as the language of the Chingisid conquerors was used as an official language in large parts of Eurasia. From there, the Central Mongolic branch evolved that consists of the demographically major branches Buryat (Southern Siberia), Oirat (Dzungaria, Qinghai, western Mongolia, Kalmykia), Khorchin-Kharchin (western Manchuria) and Khalkha-Chakhar, along with a few smaller varieties (see Luvsanvandan 1959, Janhun 2006). Chakhar is spoken in central Inner Mongolia in north China, while Khalkha has historically been spoken in most of the current Mongolian state, excluding its west (Oirat, Kazakh, Tuvian) and north-east (Buryat). A fraction of Khalkha ("Chakhar") speakers are found on the Chinese side of the border (cf. Svantesson et al. 2005: 143).

In the present-day Mongolian state (except for Bajan-Ölgij Province with its Kazakh majority), Khalkha Mongolian is de facto the only official language, re-

¹The correspondences between phonemes and their transcriptions are as follows: α-a, ɔ-o, ʊ-u, e-e, ɵ-ö, ʉ-ü, i-i, j-y, w-w, ¹ɭ, p-b, p^h-p, t-d, t^h-t, k-g, ɡ-ɡ, k^h-k, ts-z, ts^h-c, tʃ-ž, tʃ^h-č, f-f, s-s, ʃ-š, x-x, m-m, n-n, ɳ-ɳ, ʎ-l, ɭ-lh, r-r.

²The Cyrillic letters were transcribed as follows: а-а, б-б, в-в, г-г, д-д, е-е, ё-ё, ж-ж, з-з, и-и, й-й, к-к, л-л, м-м, н-н, о-о, ө-ө, п-п, р-р, с-с, т-т, у-у, ү-ү, ф-ф, х-х, ц-ц, ч-ч, ш-ш, ь-ь, ы-ы, ь-ь, э-э, ю-ю, я-я.

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stricting Buryat, Oirat, Tuvian and Mongolian Sign Language to private settings. It is used at all levels of administration, education and media. Foreign movies are overdubbed in Mongolian. The assimilation of other dialects has enriched the vocabulary of literary Khalkha, but this is much less notable for the spoken language. Ulaanbaatar Khalkha has developed an urban slang ([Sambuudorž & Ėrdēnēsuvd 2002](#)). The first foreign language learned in school is now English, and previously was Russian. These are also the most important donor languages for recent loanwords, while previously important donor languages include Turkic (neighboring tribes), Tibetan (religion) and Chinese (trade). Emigration is common, with larger communities e.g. in South Korea, the Czech Republic or Sweden (as manual labor force) or in the USA, Germany or China (as students and subsequent employees).

Khalkha Mongolian has the default word order subject-object-predicate. The relative order of subjects and direct objects is relatively loose, and repair strategies allow for arguments (esp. subjects) that follow the predicate. Subordinate clauses precede matrix clauses. Adverbials precede verbs, attributes (except some quantifiers) precede modified nouns, auxiliaries follow main predicates. All non-reduplicative affixing processes are suffixal and obey vowel harmony. Obligatory verbal suffixes yield three different verb form types: CONVERBS form adverbial clauses or connect clauses or verbs; finite uses in ellipsis or afterthought are possible to a limited extent. PARTICIPLES are used as attributes and sentence-finally. Only they and other nominals co-occur with modal particles and postposed negators. FINITE VERBS can only be used sentence-finally or before the quotative verb *ge-*. They are subdivided into declaratives (coding tense and evidentiality) and mood forms (imperatives and hortatives).

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

Standard negation is marked by the postclitic =*güi* (orthographically <*güj*>, realized as [=gwüi], [=gwi:] or [-gü:] / [gü:]), which attaches to participles, but not to finite verbs (an opposition that will be briefly discussed at the end of this section). It also functions as existential negator (see §2.3.2) and privative case (see §3.3.2), functions that are older than its predicate-negating use. As a standard negator, it usually attaches to a verbal predicate, as in (1) and (2). This includes auxiliaries other than the copular auxiliary verb *bai-* which are always connected to the main verb by converbal suffixes, e.g. *üz-ež amž-ax=güi* ‘don’t manage (in time) to see’. The negator =*güi* is classified here as a clitic since it still resists vowel

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harmony quite often (and consistently so in orthography).³ The second reason is that the additive focus clitic =č ‘even, also’ can be used in-between participle and negator as in (3).

- (1) aaa teg-ež ix id-ex=**küü**.
 INJ do.like.that-CVB much eat-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 ‘Well, I won’t / don’t eat that much.’ (SC2: Z01-1)⁴
- (2) öglöön-ii xool id-ee=**güü**.
 morning-GEN meal eat-RES.PTCP=NEG
 ‘[I] haven’t eaten / didn’t eat breakfast.’ (SC2: Z08-7)
- (3) bii bol üz-ež amž-aa=č=**güi**.
 1SG TOP see-CVB succeed(in.time)-RES.PTCP=ADD.FOC=NEG
 ‘I have not even managed to see [that movie].’ (SC2: Z08-5)

The only morphological forms that can be negated by =*güi* as an original existential negator (cf. Veselinova 2014) are nominals. The only class of verbal flexional suffixes that allow for this negator are participial markers. There are four participial forms to which negative markers can attach. The negated non-past participle -*x* attached to activity verbs refers to events that at reference time are not prone to happen, including actions that the speaker doesn’t intend to commit as in (1). With some stative verbs, it refers to the absence of possibility, knowledge etc. as in (4). Verbs in -*x* cannot be used in absolute sentence-final position without any subsequent morphemes. Accordingly, -*x*=*güi* in negative sentences roughly corresponds to the suffix -*n* that expresses potential, sometimes habitually instantiated developments in positive sentences (unless it attaches to the copular auxiliary *bai*-). The negated habitual participle -*dag* in (5) indicates that a certain action does not take place habitually, repeatedly or as a disposition, thus merely negating its positive values. While -*x*=*güi* and -*dag*=*güi* may often replace one another (like -*n* and -*dag* in positives, see Brosig 2015a), they differ in their aspectual perspective, which is a non-occurring habitual development vs. a non-occurring potential development in the present. The negated “resultative participle” -*aa*=*güi* in (2) indicates that an event has not or not yet happened, while the

³ In SC, a majority of critical examples is transcribed as conforming to vowel harmony. However, to ensure that these transcriptions are accurate, one would have to conduct systematic acoustic or perceptual phonetic measurements.

⁴ The cited source only contains the Mongolian example, while its glossing and translation were created specifically for this paper.

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negated “perfect participle” *-saŋ=güi* indicates that the event didn’t happen at a certain point in the past. However, *-aa=güi* has almost turned into a neutral way of negating past events, while *-saŋ=güi* is now largely restricted to contexts in which the event can no longer take place in a way that would still be meaningful to the interlocutors.⁵ In (6), the elderly speaker with four daughters will not try to produce additional children. In (7), the TV anchor is introducing a fully prepared report during broadcasting, so he could no longer meaningfully change his mind about how to prepare it. Only *-aa=güi*, but not *-saŋ=güi* can be used in the scope of *bai-* (e.g. in the immediately perceived negated past *-aa=güi bai-n* in (12) below). In addition, *=güi* also negates the non-aspecto-temporal quasi-participles in *-maar* (intention)/*-xaar* (inclination), as in (8).

- (4) *deegii med-ex=küü.*
 NAME realize+know-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 ‘Deegii doesn’t know.’ (SC2: Z01-1)
- (5) *bii tax¹aan-ii max id-deg=güü.*
 1SG chicken-GEN meat eat-HAB.PTCP=NEG
 ‘I don’t eat chicken.’ (SC2: Z05-1)
- (6) *uulan=č xüü gara-g-č-ii ge-ž*
 actually=ADD.FOC son come.out-CAUS-COMPL-HORT QUOT-CVB
bod-žii-soŋ. gar-saŋ=güi.
 think-PROG-EST.PST come.out-PRF.PTCP=NEG
 ‘Actually, I was also thinking “Let’s get a son.” [But] I didn’t get one.’ (SC1: TH, Parik Jagaa)
- (7) *aa bid büxen bol (...) iŋg-ež beld-ii ge-ž*
 INJ 1PL all TOP (...) do.like.this-CVB prepare-HORT QUOT-CVB
bod-soŋ=guu.
 think-PRF.PTCP=NEG
 ‘[They usually speak in such a manner on TV programs, the TV programs usually prepare (this kind of interviews.)] Ah, as for our team, we didn’t think “Let’s (...) prepare it like this.”’ (SC1: Derik, Yanhan1)
- (8) *bii dax¹-až yum uu-maar=guu bai-n.*
 1SG do.again-CVB thing drink-wish.PTCP=NEG COP-IMM.PRS
 ‘I don’t want to drink more.’ (SC2: Z05-5)

⁵I partially follow Hashimoto (2007). However, he analyzes *-aa=güi* and *-saŋ=güi* as prototypes of equal status, thus failing to recognize their disparity in favor of *-aa=güi*. Several native speakers rejected his (38b) and a few other examples.

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Participles are required for forming negated declarative, attributive and nominalized forms, while positive finite main clauses employ both finite and participial suffixes. For instance, in the past tense there is a distinction (in order of decreasing frequency) between an established past in *-saŋ*, immediate sensory and inferential pasts in *-laa* and *-ž(ee)*, an interrogative-leaning peripheral past in *-w* and a particle-assisted peripheral dubitative past in *-aa* (for which see Brosig 2015a, 2018, Brosig & Skribnik 2018). These distinctions, which among other things relate to evidentiality and time of acquisition, are lost under simple negation and replaced by the two-way distinction between *-aa* or *-saŋ* plus *=güi* that relates to completion. Overall, asymmetric negation in Mongolian entails the common loss of finiteness and TAME distinctions under negation (cf. Miestamo 2005).

Putative correspondences between positive and negative forms get even more complicated for aspectually complex constructions. In these, the copular auxiliary *bai-* follows a converbal or participial form of the main verb. The positive progressive takes the form *-ž bai-n* > *-žai-n* (for an immediately perceived event) or *-ž bai-gaa* > *-žai-gaa* (for an event already known to be taking place) as in (9). But if *=güi* is added directly to this latter form as in (10), the resulting sentence expresses that its subject has never experienced the event in a period that ranges from the past until the time of speech, i.e. a negated experiential perfect. A better candidate for a negated progressive is shown in (11) which expresses either that speaker B has observed the subject for a period of time and seen that s/he doesn't eat or that speaker B is drawing an inference to this effect from currently observable evidence. The marker *-n*, which indicates immediate perception when attached to the copula *bai-*, thus has the negation in its scope. On the other hand, the simple state of not having occurred yet as immediately observed by the speaker would be expressed by the pattern *-aa=güi bai-n* as in (12).⁶

- (9) öröön-d=öö yum id-žai-gaa.
 room-DAT=RPOSS thing eat-PROG-EST.PRS
 'He is eating something in his room.' (SC2: Z04-3)
- (10) xezee=č ard_tümeŋ (...) cad-tal=aa
 when=ADD.FOC people become.satiated-CVB(until)=RPOSS
 id-ež bai-gaa=güi.
 eat-CVB COP-RES.PTCP=NEG
 'Never have the people (...) been eating their fill.' (IC)

⁶In contrast to *-aa=güi bai-* ($n_{IC}=14390$, including false positives and repetitions), forms like *-saŋ=güi bai-* ($n_{IC}=29$) and *-saŋ bai-PTCP=güi* ($n_{IC}=3$ for *bai-gaa=güi* and $n_{IC}=16$ for *bai-dag=güi*) don't play a role in the Khalkha negation system.

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- (11) A: ügü=ee, naa-d=čin xool=oo
 no=EMPH 2PROX.DEM-ATTR=2POSS meal=RPOSS
 B: ugaasaa id-ex=küü bai-n.
 fundamentally eat-NPST.PTCP=NEG COP-IMM.PRS
 ‘No, s/he doesn’t eat her meal at all (these days / as I currently realize).’ [A starts the sentence, B completes it.] (SC2: Z08-7)
- (12) Bi zöw ge-ž xel-ee=güi bai-n=l=daa.
 1SG correct QUOT-CVB say-RES.PTCP=NEG AUX-IMM.PRS=ADD.FOC=DP
 ‘I haven’t said (as you should realize) that it’s right/correct.’ (IC)

The way in which positive and negative TAME forms might, partially, correspond to each other cannot be discussed here in any detail. *Biš* as a negator of main clause predicates is discussed in §4.1, §4.6.2.

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

Among Khalkha non-declaratives, imperatives use distinct negators. Khalkha uses three imperative suffixes: plain -Ø, imploring -*aač*, and politely requesting -*aarai*. These are negated by the preverbal negation particles *bitgii* or rarely *büü*. The patterns in (13) and (14) illustrate simple and aspectually complex negated imperatives, while (15) illustrates their positive counterparts (though the first sentence in (15) actually fulfills a prohibitive function).

- (13) yanz yanz-iij nōx-düüd-iig bitgii aw-aač=ee.
 sort sort-GEN comrade-PL-ACC NEG take-IMP.IMPL=DP
 ‘Don’t bring along all kinds of guys!’ (SC1: Derik, Yanhan3)
- (14) bitgii ineedtei yum yar^l-aad bai-Ø!
 NEG ridiculous thing speak-PFV.CVB COP-IMP
 ‘Don’t keep on talking nonsense!’ (SC1: Derik, Yanhan3)
- (15) aa tenegt-eed bai-Ø! tegeed gudamž-ruu=gaa or-Ø!
 ah behave.stupidly-PFV.CVB COP-IMP then street-ALL=RPOSS enter-IMP
 ‘Ah, [just] keep on talking nonsense (I dare you)! Then get out onto your street!’ (SC2: Z08-1)

Positionally, *bitgii* is placed between the subject, if overt, and the predicate (cf. Yu 1991: 82–84). In (14), it precedes an indefinite direct object, in (13) it follows a specific direct object. Yu (1991: 87–88) claims that prohibitives can be embedded

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if *bitgii* modifies a case-marked participle, but no such examples were found in IC. *Bitgii* and rarely *büü* are also used in connection with the desiderative suffix *-aasai*, e.g. *bitgii exl-eesei* ‘may it not begin’ (IC). First and third person hortatives (*-ii/-y=aa*, *-g*) don’t seem to combine with *bitgii*, but *büü V-ii* occurs in a few rare idioms. The intention of a first person not to commit an action can be expressed by a negated nonpast participle in the scope of *bai-y* as in (16).

- (16) Getel ter=maan genet xoy-uul=aa ger büü
 but that=STC suddenly two-COLL=RPOSS family
 bol-tl=oo seks xii-x=güi bai-y ge-seŋ.
 become-NPST.PTCP=NEG sex do=NPST.PTCP AUX-HORT QUOT-EST.PST
 ‘But suddenly s/he said: “Let’s not have sex until we marry.”’ (IC)

The old imperative negator *büü* is rarely used, occasionally showing up in solemn exhortations like *büü mart-aarai* ‘Don’t forget!’ or *büü ai-Ø* ‘Don’t fear!’. It is the only option in the idiomatic “pseudo prohibitive” pattern *büü med-Ø* ‘no clue’ (cf. Yu 1991: 73–74).

Negated interrogatives, by contrast, are participles modified by negators and question particles, i.e. they use the same type of negator as declaratives. Functionally, negated questions in *=güi=yüü* cover a range from exhortations as in (17) to guesses and rhetorical questions. Questions formed with *biš=üü* ‘isn’t it so that’ (based on the ascriptive negator *biš*) cover a range from guesses as in (18) to rhetorical questions as in (19) (cf. Bjangbasan 2001: 14, 18).

- (17) nem-eed piiw uu-č-x=güi=yüü? aay
 ADD-PFV.CVB beer drink-COMPL-NPST.PTCP=NEG=Q.PL R INJ
 ‘Drink some more beer, won’t you?’ (SC2: Khalkha0018)
- (18) či xar¹aŋ tur-c=iin biš=üü?
 2SG but become.thin-COMPL.EST.PST=ASRT NEG=Q.PL R
 ‘But haven’t you become thinner?’ (SC2: Z08-7)
- (19) en xar¹aŋ goy yum biš=üü?
 this but nice thing/ASRT NEG=Q.PL R
 ‘But ain’t this (a) nice (thing)!’ (SC2: Z08-9)

One common way of forming alternative questions is to combine a regular polar question with (*ü*)*güi*, here still used as a clause-forming negative particle, plus the interrogative clitic *=uu* as in (20). Instead of (*ü*)*güi*, full verbs negated by *=güi* can sometimes be used. *Güi=yüü* is also used when following up a declarative with a tag question as in (21).

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- (20) budaa xii-xžii-n=uu **güi=yüü?**
 rice make-PROSP-IMM.PRS=Q.PLR NEG=Q.PLR
 ‘Are you about to prepare rice or not?’ (SC1: TH, Ganbaatar)
- (21) am^ɪdral saixaŋ bai-n **güi yuu?**
 life beautiful COP-IMM.PRS NEG Q.PLR
 ‘Life is beautiful, isn’t it?’ (SC1: TH, Ganbaatar)

2.3 Negation in stative predications

2.3.1 Ascriptive predications

In stative non-temporal non-verbal ascriptive predications (cf. [Veselinova 2013: 110–111](#), following [Hengeveld 1992](#)), the only negator is *biš* (< ‘other’). It denies nominal predications such as identity in (22) or proper inclusion. In positive predications, *biš* corresponds to zero, see the second sentence of (22). Identity predications occasionally employ the existential-identificational particle *mön* ‘same’ to confirm identity, but this in turn can be denied by *mön biš* ‘not the same’.

- (22) aan, enxbayar **biš**. en pürewžaw.
 ah NAME NEG this NAME
 ‘Ah, [it] is not Enkhbayar. It is Purevjav.’ (SC2: Khalkha0001)

For negating generic or permanent adjectival property predications, *biš* is the most common negator. It denies that a proposition holds, for whatever reason, as in (23). Relatively rarely, *=güi* is used instead of *biš*. It signals that a property is absent or present to a lesser extent ([Saranggüü-a 2007: 43](#)) as in (24). This pattern is skewed heavily towards certain stems, e.g. it is much more frequent with *saiŋ* ‘good’ ($n_{IC}=256$) than with *saixaŋ* ‘beautiful’ ($n_{IC}=8$) or *goi* ‘nice, pretty’ ($n_{IC}=0$).

- (23) BB: ‘Gambling is bad.’
 A: ügü=ee, muu **biš=ee**.
 NEG=EMPH bad NEG=EMPH
 ‘No, it is not bad (at all) [but more exciting].’ (SC2: Khalkha0017)
- (24) man-ai xos bid xoyor bas muu=**güi** šüü.
 1PL-GEN pair 1PL two also bad=NEG DP
 ‘[You think you can take the price?] The two of us are not bad either.’ (IC)

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In predications that overtly specify aspect, tense, time of acquisition or evidentiality, non-verbal predicates are followed by the copular auxiliary verb *bai-*. In this setting, *biš* or (only with adjectives) *=güi* may attach to the nominal, so that a negative state is located in time (or qualified epistemologically) as in (25a). Alternatively, the copula verb can be negated. This is normally done by the standard negator *=güi* as in (25b), claiming that a positive situation did not occur at the specified point in time. Alternatively, negating the copula with *biš* would deny a potential conceptualization of the situation as accurate and point to an alternative as in (25c) (cf. §4.1, §4.6.2).

- (25) a. *Xarʼaŋ bi beleŋ biš bai-saŋ yum.*
 but 1SG ready NEG COP-EST.PST ASRT
 ‘But I was not ready.’ (IC)
- b. *Tüüx-eŋ en öörčölöŋt-öd bidn-ii xeŋ=č beleŋ*
 history-ATTR this change-DAT 1PL-GEN who=ADD.FOC ready
bai-gaa=güi.
 COP-RES.PTCP=NEG
 ‘For this historical change, none of us was ready (yet).’ (IC)
- c. *Odoo-güiŋ-x šig бүх yum beleŋ bai-saŋ biš.*
 now-GEN-NMLZ like all thing ready COP-PRF.PTCP NEG
 ‘[We would write our play. For every role, we would make a picture of the intended clothes and sew it.] It is not that all things were readily available, like it is today.’⁷

2.3.2 Locative, possessive and existential predications

In Khalkha, the locative pattern is also used as the main possessive pattern which is preferably used with topicalized possessa. In (26), both the “existential” ~ inverse locational (cf. Creissels 2014: 1) interpretation in (26a) and the possessive interpretation in (26b) are possible since the dative-marked noun can be interpreted as either a location (a shop as a place) or a possessor (a shop as a corporation). In (27), the spatial demonstrative can only bear locational meaning, while the dative-marked person pronoun in (28) is normally conceptualized as a possessor. In all of these examples, a participial form of the copula *bai-* is negated, the possessed or located entity is in the unmarked nominative, and the possessor/location receives dative-locative case.

⁷Ž. Tujaacécég: Zarimdaa jamar ix tëvčéertéj jum bè gēž boddog. Interview with the wife of the high-ranking politician M. Ènxbold) <http://www.olloo.mn/n/43845.html>, online 2017-6-20, retrieved 2019-3-16

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- (26) Delgüür-t dawsn-aas öör yum **bai-x=güi**...
 shop-DAT salt-ABL other thing COP-HAB.PTCP=NEG
 a. ‘In the shop, there is nothing but salt.’ (IC, decontextualized)
 b. ‘The shop doesn’t have (~sell) anything but salt.’
- (27) Aztaṅ bol-soṅ Xišigsaixaṅ=maan odoo-goor end
 lucky.winner become-PRF.PTCP NAME=1POSS now-INS here
bai-x=güi[.]
 COP-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 [A photo shows a woman around 55 standing in front of a rack with new shoes and holding a paper bag with something inside. The text below reads:] ‘The winner, Khishigsaikhan, is currently not here. [Her mother came and took her present. Congratulations again!],’⁸
- (28) A: čam-d tamag **bai-x=kuu** biz=dee?
 2SG-DAT ace COP-NPST.PTCP=NEG DP=DP
 ‘You don’t have an ace, do you?’
 B: **bai-x=kuu**.
 COP-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 ‘No, I don’t.’ (SC2: Khalkha0018)

Instead of the nonpast participle *baixgüi*, it is also possible to use the young locative-possessive negator *alag* ‘absent/missing’ as in (29). As a predicate, it indicates that an entity is absent despite the speaker’s expectation or wish, that the entity is temporarily absent or that an intention is absent (see the excellent functional account of Umetani 2004, summarized in English in Brosig 2015b: 97–98; for its morphology, see Mönx-Amgalan 1999). The old existential negator *ügüi* is sometimes still used if preceded by the additive focus particle as in (30), but without a clitic, as in (31), this pattern is exceedingly rare. To convey non-existence without regard for location, speakers often add a converbal form of the quotative verb *ge-* in its naming function as in (32). However, this is not required if the non-existing entity is designated by a complex attribute as in (33). The positive equivalents of (26) and (32) would use habitual *bai-dag*, and (27–29) would use established present *bai-gaa*, without *yamar=č* in (29).

⁸<https://www.globuya.com/MN/Dalan-Zadagad/Өмнөговь-”emerald”-Гутлын-Дэлгүүр>, retrieved 2020-2-13

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- (29) nadad yamar=č zaw alac.
1SG.DAT what.kind=ADD.FOC free.time absent
‘I don’t have any time at all.’ (SC1: Derik, Yanhan2)
- (30) ... üül=č ügüi, boroo=č ügüi ...
cloud=ADD.FOC NEG rain=ADD.FOC NEG
‘... there were no clouds and there was no rain ...’ (Bjambasan 2001: 9,
quoting the writer D. Nacagdorž)
- (31) Xorwoo delxii-d tüün-ees=min sain, saixan xün ügüi
(fleeting)world globe-DAT that-ABL-1POSS good beautiful person NEG
bai-san.
COP-EST.PST
‘In the [entire] world, there was no better, more wonderful person than
him/her.’ (IC)
- (32) burxan ge-ž bai-x=güi.
god QUOT-CVB COP-NPST.PTCP=NEG
‘There is no god.’ (lit. ‘What is called “God” is not.’) (IC)
- (33) man-ai dorž-iig güic-ex xün bai-x=gü=ee.
1PL-GEN NAME-ACC match-NPST.PTCP person COP-NPST.PTCP=NEG=EMPH
‘There’s nobody who matches our Dorj [in card games].’ (SC2: Z08-7)

Possession can also be expressed by a construction that uses nominative possessors. Possesseees are marked by either comitative-possessive or privative case as in (34). The use of *alag* in this pattern, which for most speakers requires dative-marked possessors, is apparently non-standard, but not uncommon if a dummy noun *yum* with a preceding participial construction is the possessed, as in (35) (see also Brosig 2015b: 101).

- (34) öör=öö möng=güü, ör-tei yuu ta?
self=RPOSS money-PRIV debt-COM Q.PLR 2SG.HON
‘Are you without money and with debts?’ (SC1: TH, Parik Jagaa)
- (35) tan-ai cai wol ünen-d=ee (.) yarⁱ-ax yum alag
2SG-GEN tea TOP truth-DAT=RPOSS speak-NPST.PTCP thing absent
‘There is truly nothing [bad] to say about your tea.’ (SC1: TH, Ganbaatar)

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

2.4.1 Attributive and argument clauses

In attributive and nominalized clauses, the distinction between the negated incomplete past in *-aa=güi* and the negated completed past in *-saŋ=güi* is lost. Only forms in *-aa=güi* are used as attributes as in (36) or as nominalized argument clauses as in (37). Habitual *-dag=güi*, nonpast *-x=güi*, *-xaar=güi* ‘not likely to’ and nominal attributes in *=güi* are common, too. Contrastive attributes with adjectival, participial etc. predicates negated by *biš* as in (38) are rare, and attributes in *biš* without a contrasting positive form are even less common. For adjectives and nouns, this latter function is sometimes fulfilled by *bus* (see §3.3.1). Direct nominalizations of *biš* as in (39) are very rare.

- (36) tan-ii xairl-aa=**kuu** xüüxed tan-iig ilüü
 2SG.HON-GEN love-RES.PTCP=NEG child 2SG.HON-ACC more
 xairal-žii-n=aa.
 love-PROG-IMM.PRS=HON
 ‘The child that you didn’t love is loving you more [than your other son].’
 (SC2: Z04-2)
- (37) X¹atad-ad bai-dag naiz-uud ir-ee=**güi**-g med-ež
 China-DAT COP-HAB.PTCP friend-PL come-RES.PTCP=NEG-ACC know-CVB
 bai-gaa.
 COP-EST.PRS
 ‘[I] know that the friends who are in China have/did not come.’ (IC)
- (38) Muu **biš**, sain tal-iin šüümžlel erg-eed ür_düng=ee
 bad NEG good side-GEN critique turn-PFV.CVB result=RPOSS
 ög-dög yum bai-n.
 give-HAB.PTCP ASRT COP-IMM.PRS
 ‘Not bad, but good critique gives results in return.’ (IC)
- (39) Bi tiim=č xel am-tai, eldew aaš-tai büsgüi
 1SG such=ADD.FOC tongue mouth-COM various character-COM woman
biš šüü. Xöörxöŋ **biš**-iig ud-ax=güi xar-aarai za.
 NEG DP cute NEG-ACC take.long-NPST.PTCP=NEG see-IMP(HON) TAG
 ‘I’m really not such a gossipy, ill-tempered woman. [But] take a look at
 [the one who] is not pretty [=me] soon, okay?’ (IC)

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2.4.2 Negation in adverbial clauses

Khalkha Mongolian has inherited a large number of converbs. Due to the demise of preverbal negation, these cannot be negated directly, but a number of strategies have evolved that circumvent this issue. Firstly, the converbal suffix may attach to the copula *bai-*, while the negator attaches to the main verb as in (40a), as compared to positive (40b). This entails specific aspectual meaning, namely, reference to an ongoing time period. Secondly, aspectually neutral subordinating conjunctions as in (41) may be used. Conjunctions are preceded by the same set of negated attributive forms that modify nouns (see §2.4.1).⁹ In rare cases that involve conditionals, writers may also choose to retain the old preverbal negator (see discussion on *es* in §3.3.1). Finally, some forms cannot be negated. This includes converbs in *-ŋguut* as in (42) which express that the matrix clause action takes place as soon as the subordinate clause action occurs. The progressive-stative interpretation of using a negated participle with *bai-* is incompatible with its punctual meaning (hence *V-PTCP=*güi bai-ŋguut* is unattested). No conjunctions that involve this medium-frequency suffix seem to have evolved.

- (40) a. *usl-ax-guu* *bai-wal* (...) *ösölt=ön*
 water-NPST.PTCP-NEG COP-COND.CVB growth=3POSS
 zogs-n=oo=doo.
 stop-POT=HON=DP
 ‘If you are not watering it (over a period of time), its growth will stop.’
 (SC1: BTV, 16 nemex)
- b. *usal-ž* *bai-wal*
 water-CVB COP-COND.CVB
 ‘if you are watering it’ (constructed)
- (41) *uulz-ax-guu* *bol al-an* *x¹ad-an.*
 meet-NPST.PTCP-NEG if kill-POT massacre-POT
 ‘If [you] don’t meet up [with us], [we] will kill [you].’ (SC1: Derik, Gazar)
 cf. *uulz-wal* ... ‘if [you] meet up [with us]’ (constructed)
- (42) *utg-ii=n* *ol-onguut=aa* *nad-ad šuud*
 meaning-ACC=3POSS find-CVB(as.soon.as)=RPOSS 1SG-DAT direct
 xel-žai-gaa *baixkuuyuu.*
 say-PROG-EST.PRS DP
 ‘Once [he] understands its meaning, [he] directly tells me, you see.’ (SC2:

⁹Historically, conjunctions evolved from verbs (*bol* ‘if’ < *bol-bol* become-COND.CVB, via haplology), nouns (*učr-aas* ‘because’ < reason-ABL) or are intransparent (*tul* < *tula* ‘because’).

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Z08-7)

There is also a special negative converbal suffix *-lgüi*. Diachronically, it consists of the deverbal noun-forming suffix *-l* (e.g. *medr-* ‘feel’ > *medr-el* ‘perception’) and the standard negator in its (older) use as a privative case =*güi*, but it can be formed from verbs to which simple *-l* does not attach and it cannot be used attributively (Bjambasan 1985). It expresses that one action took place without another action being undertaken as in (43). Its use is partially similar to the negated nonpast participle *-x=güi* in its adverbial use shown in (44) which specifies that the subordinate action was not started throughout the main action. The adverbial status of a predication is sometimes clarified by attaching the instrumental case to participles as in (45), nouns, or even unambiguous converbs in *-lgüi*. The precise circumstances under which participles negated by =*güi* can be used as adverbials are not fully clear.

- (43) *ertn-ii en urlag (...) žinxen utg=aa ald-**algüi** bidn-ii*
 early-GEN this art real meaning=RPOSS lose-NEG.CVB 1PL-GEN
önöö-giin cag-t ulamžl-agd-aŋ ir-seŋ.
 now-GEN time-DAT inherit-PASS-MNR.CVB come-EST.PST
 ‘This old art form has (...) been passed down to us without losing its real meaning.’ (SC1: BTV, 16 nemex)

- (44) *en (...) šön unt-uul-**kuu** uil-aad*
 this night sleep-CAUS-NPST.PTCP.NEG cry-PFV.CVB
bai-x=iin.
 COP-NPST.PTCP=ASRT
 ‘S/he keeps on crying all night without [ever] allowing [you] to sleep.’
 (SC2: Z07-6)

- (45) *Texeer en бүгд-иig xel-**küü-geer** unt-až bol*
 thus this all-ACC say-NPST.PTCP.NEG-INS sleep-CVB TOP
čad-kuu=n bai-n=aa.
 can-NPST.PTCP.NEG COP-IMM.PRS=HON
 ‘Accordingly, I feel that I cannot sleep without telling [you] all this.’ (SC1: TH, Badaruugan)

In a closely related pattern, negated participles collocate with several auxiliary-like matrix verbs, depicting the state of the subject during the passage of time. For resultative participles, the most common of these quasi-auxiliaries is *ud-* ‘take time, endure’ as in (46), for nonpast participles it is *yaw-* ‘go (forth, on etc.)’.

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- (46) *bii yöröösöö uu-gaa-guu ud-žii-n=aa.*
 1SG at.all drink-RES.PTCP-NEG take.time-PROG-IMM.PRS=HON
 ‘I’ve not been drinking at all for a long time.’ (lit. ‘[It] is taking a long time with I not drinking at all.’) (SC2: Z05-3)

Negated (non-clausal) adjectival adverbials seem to be dispreferred, but if they are formed, the negator is mostly =*güi* as in (47) rather than *biš*.

- (47) *Xüite-wter us (...) can-gaa-g muu=güi tail-dag.*
 cold-DIM water thirst-ACC bad=NEG relieve.of-HAB.PTCP
 ‘Coldish water quenches thirst quite well.’ (IC)

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

Among apparent lexicalizations of negative concepts, the only word that does not contain a known negator (besides *alac* ‘absent’, see §2.3.2) is the verb *yad-* ‘be unable to, to bungle something up’ (< ‘be in dire straits’, cf. *yaduu* ‘poor’). However, *yad-* is restricted to a fixed set of collocations, of which only *üz-en yad-* ‘cannot see > hate’ is common. Other collocations such as *tes-č yad-* ‘cannot endure’ or *učr=aa ol-ž yad-* ‘cannot find one’s cause’ are confined to written style.

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative replies

When providing an informative answer to regular open [and, in particular, alternative] questions, it is possible to answer with a verb echoing the question, either in positive or negated form (cf. Guntsetseg 2016: 21–22), and with or without additional arguments. As seen in (48), these answers still function as assertions of their own right, since the addressee is free to switch aspectual forms, in this case answering not that he doesn’t drink habitually, as asked, but that he doesn’t drink at all. Alternatively, positive items such as adjectival *tiim(ee)* and its interjectional forms *te ~ tx* ‘such’ as well as *mxm* (predominantly used for signaling attentiveness) or negative items like the existential adjective into particle (*ü*)*güi* can be used in interjection-type answers, particularly to confirm (Binnick 2011: 94–95) or contradict presumptive questions as in (49) or affirm or reject assertions as in (50). While a proper quantitative comparison of answer strategies in SC cannot be undertaken in this paper, some preliminary checks suggest that interjection-type patterns such as *güü* in (49b) and *ügüü* in (50b) as compared

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to the verb in (48b) are overall more frequent. A similar observation has been offered by Enfield et al. 2019 for most languages of their convenience sample.

- (48) a. ar¹ax uu-dag=uu?
 liquor drink-HAB.PTCP=Q.PLR
 ‘Do you drink liquor?’
 b. uu-x=güi
 drink-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 ‘No.’ (cf. *uu-dag*: ‘Yes.’) (SC1: TH, Ganbaatar)
- (49) a. ter (.) baicaa=n x¹amd-xaŋ bai-dag biz=dee?
 that cabbage=3POSS cheap-DIM AUX-HAB.PTCP MP=DP
 ‘That cabbage is usually cheap, right? [I claim, you will agree.]’
 b. güü, xar¹xaŋ ün-tei wai-n. xil=en dörwöm m¹aŋg.
 no but price-COM AUX-IMM.PRS kg=3POSS four thousand
 ‘No, but [just the opposite], it’s expensive. One kilo of it is 4000.’
 (SC2: Z01-1)
- (50) a. bii kolon bol-on ge-ž yöröösöö
 1SG colony become-POT QUOT-CVB on.the.whole
 yar¹-aa-guu=šdee.
 say-RES.PTCP-NEG=DP
 ‘I didn’t say at all that [Mongolia] would become a colony [then].’
 b. ügüü=šdee. say či tex-s=ii=šd.
 no=DP recently 2SG do.like.that-EST.PST=ASRT=DP
 ‘No, you just said so.’ (SC2: Z08-7)

Orders, requests or suggestions to act can be accepted by *za* ‘well’ (see Pürev-Očir 2009) or declined by (*ü*)*güi* as in (51), and sole *bitgii* as in (52) can be used to prevent the interlocutor from acting. If the goal is to correct the addressee and give an unmediated alternative explanation, *biš* (< ‘other’) can be used instead, as in (53). The interjection used for negative replies and a subsequent negative explication don’t have to use the same form: In (54), the speaker objects to the addressee’s statement using *biš*, but follows it up with an assertion in standard negation.

- (51) a. bii xamt xii-č-ii!
 1SG together do-COMPL-HORT
 ‘I shall prepare it together [with you]!’

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- b. **güi bitgii** xamt xii-Ø!
 no NEG together do-IMP
 ‘No, don’t prepare it together [with me]!’ (SC1: TH, Parik Jagaa)
- (52) **Ügüi**, yaa-ž teg-ež bol-dog yum!? **Bitgii!**
 no do.what-CVB do.like.that-CVB may-HAB.PTCP ASRT NEG
 Či=min^j taiwšir-Ø!
 2SG=1POSS become.calm-IMP
 ‘No, how could one do such a thing!? Don’t! Calm down, my dear!’¹⁰
- (53) a. **nöxör-tei** yum=uu či?
 husband-COM ASRT=Q.PLR 2SG
 ‘Do you [thus] have a husband?’
 b. **biš=ee**, man-ai naiz.
 no=EMPH 1PL-GEN friend
 ‘No, [this is just] my friend.’ (SC1: Derik, Yanhan2)
- (54) BB: ‘Now I can play a five!’
 A: **biš=ee**, iŋg-ež gar-kuu.
 no=EMPH do.like.this-CVB come.out-NPST.PTCP.NEG
 ‘No, you don’t play [your cards] like this.’ (SC2: Khalkha0017)

When answering negative questions, the responder seems to be using different strategies in different communicative situations. In several conversational contexts, the responders match the polarity of the question in their answers. For instance, to a biased question intended to elicit a positive answer, the responder can retain her position via denial using (*ü*)**güi** as in (55) or concede with an answer like *xar^jaŋ teg-seŋ* ‘indeed I did so’. This encompasses negative questions with *biš=üü* ‘isn’t it so that’ as in (56). If the question is meant to suggest a course of action e.g. for a third person, the responder can express disagreement via (*ü*)**güi** or agree by forms like *tii=š=d* ‘precisely’. However, the situation is different if the asker is perplexed between two conflicting pieces of information and uses a more or less open negative question to seek confirmation for the newly acquired position that the event did actually not happen. In this case, the responder may agree with the asker’s underlying negative presupposition by using plain *tiiŋ* ‘yes, in

¹⁰Xolboony surguulijn ulaan dèelt xuv’ zajaagaa urlagtaj xolbosen tüüx (interview with actress Lxamžavyn Dolgor shortly after her 90th birthday by L.Dëmidbaatar) <http://entertainment.mongolnews.mn/Архив/tdq>, published 2012-12-19, retrieved 2019-03-09

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this way’ as in (57), while using (*ü*)*güi* to confirm the negation would be precariously ambiguous, though this could be resolved by adding a negated verb form like *med-küü*. If the responder instead wants to contest the negative proposition of the asker, she can immediately answer with assertive forms like reduplicated *med-n=ee med-en* ‘[they] know it alright’ or *xar¹aŋ med-en* ‘yeah, [they] indeed know it’. If the responder considers the asker’s doubt as unjustified, a sharper, more authoritative answer would be *med-ii=š=d*.

- (55) A: ‘How come you brand people as thieves?’
 B: ‘Brand people as thieves?’
 ta say end-ees xulgai xii-gee=**güi** yuu?
 2SG.HON recently here-ABL theft do-RES.PTCP Q.PLR
 ‘Have you not just stolen [something] from here?’
 A: **gü=ee**, zügeer yum son¹orx-oo=l
 no=EMPH just thing be.interested.in-PFV.CVB=LIM.FOC
 yaw-žii-[n]=šd.
 go-PROG-IMM.PRS=DP
 ‘No, I was just walking around looking at (lit. being interested in) things.’ (SC1: Derik, Narantuul)
- (56) A: I was walking alone.
 B: xoy-uul=aa yaw-žii-s=iin **biš=üü?**
 two=COLL=RPOSS go-PROG-EST.PST=ASRT NEG=Q.PLR
 ‘Wasn’t it rather the case that you were walking as a pair?’
 A: **gü=ee** **güü**.
 no=EMPH no
 ‘No, no.’ (SC1: Derik, Narantuul)
- (57) A: xüŋ med-**küü** yuu?
 person know-NPST.PTCP.NEG Q.PLR
 ‘[So] people don’t know [about this]?’
 B: tiŋ.
 such
 ‘Yes [they don’t know].’ (SC1: Derik, Yanhan1)

Rather than using interjections or negated verbs, a construction that is occasionally used in negative answers is by using the non-reduced form of the old existential negator *ügüi* plus copula as in (58) and (59). These clauses are used to

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state, from immediately accessed evidence, that something is or was not the case, i.e. that a negative state obtains. These small pro-clauses may start with sentence adverbials and end in modal particles, but contain no arguments.

- (58) A: *curl=an tom-d-ood bai-n=uu güi=yüü?*
 flour=3POSS get.too.big-PFV.CVB COP-IMM.PRS=Q.PLR NEG=Q.PLR
 ‘Is the flour getting too big or not?’

B: *ügüi bai-n.*
 NEG COP-IMM.PRS
 ‘It is not.’ (SC2: Z07-5)

- (59) *liŋxüü asuudal šiid-egd-seŋ=üü ge-wel ügüi*
 such problem decide-PASS-EST.PST=Q.PLR QUOT-COND.CVB NEG
bai-n.
 COP-IMM.PRS
 ‘If one were to state whether this question has been decided, it is not the case.’ (IC)

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

Khalkha lacks specific negative indefinites. Positive indefinites are recruited from a few regular nouns (*yum* ‘(some)thing’, cf. (9)) or formed from interrogative pronouns by adding *neg-eŋ* ‘one-ATTR’ (e.g. *xerŋ neg-eŋ* ‘somebody, anybody’) or the additive focus clitic =č ‘even, also’ (*xerŋ=č* ‘anybody’) (cf. Janhunen 2012: 132–133, cf. also 67–68; for =č under negation also see Hashimoto 2009), as in (60). These forms are then used together with a regular verbal negator, as in (61). =č-based indefinites most often occur under negation, while *negeŋ*-based indefinites are more common in positive sentences, but show up in a limited set of negative contexts, particularly when the set of possible referents is restricted and topical as in (62). With quantifiers under negation as in (63), the use of =č is optional.

- (60) *Xii-seŋ xerg=ee xerŋ=č üür-ex yos-toi*
 do-PRF.PTCP deed=RPOSS who=ADD.FOC load-NPST.PTCP custom-COM
biz=dee.
 MP=DP

‘Anyone should take responsibility for what s/he did, right?’ (IC)

- (61) *bidn-ii xerŋ=č orolc-oo=güi*
 1PL-GEN who=ADD.FOC participate-RES.PTCP=NEG
 ‘... none of us has taken part...’ (IC)

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- (62) Gexdee az bol-ž **xen neg-ŋ=en** bertel gemtel
 but luck become-CVB who one-ATTR=3POSS injury damage
 aw-aa=**güi** yum bai-n.
 take-RES.PTCP=NEG ASRT AUX-IMM.PRS
 ‘But fortunately, apparently **none of them** [i.e., the aforementioned
 reporters that were staying at the hotel] got injured [in the course of the
 armed robbery].’ (IC)
- (63) **canc=ač** xanz med-ex=güü bai-ž ...
 single=ADD.FOC hanzi know-NPST.PTCP=NEG COP-CVB
 ‘Not knowing **even a single** Chinese character, ...’ (SC2: Khalkha0001)

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

3.3.1 Negative derivation

There are several lexicalized expressions that involve old or current negators. Most are analytic and contain the old preverbal standard negators *es* and *ül* or the old ascriptive negator *bus*. Some are morphologically derived from or via *ügüi* or from *biš*.

The old imperfective/non-past negator *ül* ($n_{IC} \leq 9121$) is still somewhat common in negative expressions related to willful disregard (e.g. *ül too-* ‘disregard’, *ül xargalzan* ‘without regard for’, *ül xündetg-* / *ül xündl-* ‘disrespect’, cf. also *ül xamaar-* ‘be independent of’) or (often legligent) failure to realize (*ül med-* / *ül medegd-* ‘not realize / not be perceived’, *ül oilg-* / *ül oišoo-* ‘not understand’, *ül tanⁱ-* ‘not recognize’, *ül itg-* ‘disbelieve’, *ül aŋxaar-* ‘not notice’). In addition, it also forms part of the non-inflecting lexicalizations *ül xödlöx* (*ed xöröŋg*) ‘immovable (property)’ and *ül baram* ‘not likely to stop with > not only but also’.

The old perfective/past negator *es* is 3.5 times less frequent ($n_{IC} \leq 2631$), and its distribution appears to be less systematic. Its use in a few verbal expression like *es zöwšöör-* ‘disagree/reject’, phrasal idioms like *tus-iig es ol-* ‘not find help’ or an adverbial like *xüs-seŋ=č es xüs-sen=č* wish-PRF.PTCP+ADD.FOC NEG wish-PRF.PTCP=ADD.FOC ‘nolens volens’ is relatively uncommon, and it is only used in a few fixed legal expressions such as *es üilde-xüi* NEG perform-DVN ‘inaction’ or *šašan šütex*, *es šütex erx* ‘right to worship and not to worship (i.e. freedom of religion)’. However, it is relatively common with petrified conditional converbs in *-wal* (< *-ba=la* -PST=LIM.FOC) turned discourse markers such as the clause-connective *-iig es toocwol* ‘if one discounts that ...’ or the sentence adverbials *es tegwees* / *es tegwel* ‘if one does not do like that’. Conditional negation is the only

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area in which the closely related Oirat variety Kalmyk retained its cognate of *es* in active usage (Baranova 2019: 27–31). This also includes the frequent conjunction *eswel* ~ *esxül* ‘or’ (< ‘if it is not’). This and the existence of the historical unclear form *esex* ‘or not’ in subordinate clauses (see §4.5) suggest a historical verb stem *es-*, but this is probably a fallacy (see Brosig 2015b: 89–90).

The old existential negator *ügüi* is part of several derived or lexicalized forms, e.g. as stem in *ügüi-l-* ‘miss (somebody)’ and *ügüi-sg-* ‘deny’, as independent word in *ügüi bol-* ‘become absent / die’ (cf. *alag bol-* ‘disappear’), or as privative in complex forms such as *ažal-güi-d-el* ‘unemployment’ (cf. the rare *ažal-güi-d-* ‘be unemployed’ etc.), *noir-güi-d-el* ‘sleeplessness’, *ür-güi-d-el* ‘childlessness’ or *büt-el-güi-t-* succeed-V>N-NEG-N>V.INTR- ‘fail’. Forms derived from *biš* such as *biš-d-* ‘go wrong’, by contrast, are relatively rare. The combined *biš-güi* ‘plentiful’ in (64) might originally have been conceptualized from ‘without other’, i.e. without anything comparable [in quantity] (see Bjambasan 2001: 9–10, 14–15 for additional forms derived from *ügüi* and *biš*).

- (64) Ger_bül-d iim margaan **bišgüi** gar-dag.
 family-DAT such quarrel plentiful emerge-HAB.PTCP
 ‘In a family, this kind of quarrel comes up abundantly.’ (IC)

Bus, which is cognate with *biš* (< *busi*), is exceedingly common as a negator in recent official and especially administrative terms in attributive use. In these collocations, the first part is an adjective or noun, either bare or with a case suffix (genitive *-iin*, attributive *-aŋ*, short comitative-possessive *-t*). The modified noun may be fixed as in *tör-iin bus baiguulac* state.power-GEN NEG organization ‘non-governmental organization’ or semantically delimited as in *eelž-et bus xural / xuraldaaŋ / čuulgaŋ / soŋcuul* ‘irregular meeting / gathering / assembly / election’. Some expressions allow for a wider range of modified nouns, e.g. *ašg-iin (tölöö) bus* profit-GEN (for) NEG ‘non-profit’, *xaraa-t bus* ‘independent’ or *xüč-eŋ tögöldör bus* ‘invalid’. There are also some official-sounding, but non-administrative collocations like *šudrag bus* ‘dishonest/unfair’, *erüül bus* ‘unhealthy’ and the highly frequent *todorxoi bus* ‘unclear’. Finally, there are the two colloquial collocations *neg bus udaa* ‘more than once’ and *bas bus* also NEG ‘this and that’. For terms ending in *bus*, predicative uses are highly dispreferred.

3.3.2 Negative case and negative adjectives

In one of its oldest attested functions, *=güi* may function as a privative that marks the absence of an entity. It is used adverbially (65), attributively (66) or sentence-

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finally, namely in the possessive construction discussed in (34). The comitative-possessive case *-tai* is used to create roughly equivalent positive patterns. Adjectives are uncommon with the privative (see the discussion about (24)).

- (65) *ta nar solonġos-ruu wiz=güi yaw-dag yum=uu?*
 2 PL Korea-ALL visa=PRIV go-HAB.PTCP ASRT=Q.PLR
 ‘Can you thus enter Korea without visa?’ (SC2: Khalkha0001)
- (66) *man-ai-x=čan wiz=güi orn-uud-tai, zöndöö=šdee.*
 1PL-GEN-NMLZ=STC visa=PRIV country-PL-COM lots.of=DP
 ‘Ours [=Our people] have visa-free countries, lots of them!’ (SC2: Khalkha0001)

Several nouns that denote concepts like social obligation and inclination can via comitative and privative suffixes be derived into pairs of “modal adjectives”, as shown in (67).

- | | | | | |
|------|-------------------------|---------------|---|--------------------|
| (67) | <i>xereg-tei/güi</i> | ‘necessity’ | > | ‘(not) need to’ |
| | <i>yos-toi/güi</i> | ‘custom’ | > | ‘ought to/mustn’t’ |
| | <i>šaardlac-tai/güi</i> | ‘requirement’ | > | ‘(not) have to’ |
| | <i>bolomž-toi/güi</i> | ‘possibility’ | > | ‘(im)possible’ |
| | <i>dur-tai/güi</i> | ‘desire’ | > | ‘(dis)like to’ |
| | <i>xüsel-tei/güi</i> | ‘wish’ | > | ‘(not) wish to’ |
| | <i>sanaa-tai/güi</i> | ‘intention’ | > | ‘(not) intend to’ |

Modal adjectives are used as regular adjectives (68) or convey modality for a preceding verb in the nonpast participle (69). They can be followed by a copula for additional TAME marking. A few adjective pairs only have adjectival uses, e.g. *ašag-tai/güi* ‘profit’ > ‘(dis)advantageous’ and *xamaa-tai/güi* ‘relevance [only found in existential clauses]’ > ‘(ir)relevant’. The modal adjective *macadgüi* ‘maybe’ (< Classical Mongolian *macad* ‘certain’) doesn’t contrast to a positive form and (in Khalkha dialect) only follows linking converbs in -ž (70).

- (68) *žims bol xereg=güi.*
 fruit TOP necessity=NEG
 ‘As for fruits, we don’t need any.’ (SC2: Khalkha0001)
- (69) *gur¹al aw-ax xereg=güi.*
 flour take-NPST.PTCP necessity=NEG
 ‘We don’t need to import [wheat] flour.’ (SC2: Khalkha0001)

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- (70) *tunḡaa tat-saṅ bai-ž maḡadḡuu.*
 NAME draw-PRF.PTCP COP-CVB maybe
 ‘Tungaa might have smoked [this fag].’ (SC2: Khalkha0001)

The morpheme combination *-š=güi* forms deverbal adjectives which express that the occurrence of the event is unlikely or impossible, e.g. *mart-agd-aš=güi tör-söṅ ödor* ‘unforgettable birthday’ or *sal-š=güi naiz* ‘inseparable friends’. These adjectives are mostly used as attributes and only rarely as predicates. An irregular case is *bolz-oš=güi* ‘unarrangeable’ in (71) which indicates that some adverse action marked by a converb in *-ž* might conceivably happen. It is also common in predicates. A related positive pattern in *-uuš-tai* forms adjectives that denote that the action is worthwhile doing, e.g. *anxaar-uuš-tai züil* ‘an issue worth taking notice of’. While most of these words are lexicalized and do not come in polarity pairs, the patterns retain some limited productivity. The morph *-(uu)š-* always co-occurs with comitative/privative case.

- (71) *yaltaṅ amⁱ=aa xorl-ož bolz-oš=güi bol ...*
 prisoner life=RPOSS harm-CVB arrange-LIKELY=NEG if
 ‘If a prisoner is likely to commit suicide ...’ (IC)

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

The position of a declarative negator within a predicate correlates with its scope. It is subsumed under the scope of all subsequent TAME markers and takes all preceding (necessarily non-finite) TAME markers into its scope. For instance, the negator in *id-ež bai-caa=güi* ‘have not yet been eating’ in (10) takes scope over the progressive, while the copula in *xel-ee=güi bai-n* ‘have not yet said’ in (12) defines a time span during which a certain action is not being performed. If a negator attaches to adjectives as in (24) or (25a), it only affects the adjectival phrase itself. In imperatives (§2.2), the negator precedes and takes scope over the full verbal predicate, sometimes along with some arguments other than the subject.

In Mongolic languages, it is often not possible or feasible to separately negate adjectives used as adverbials to verbal predications (Yu 1991: 156), since *=güi* is uncommon with adjectives (§2.3.1) and *biš* rarely forms adverbials. Instead, standard negation negates these adverbials and their predicates as a whole, as in (72)

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which only denies that the speaker has GOOD knowledge. Since =*güi* entails reduction, *saiŋ* ‘good’ could not readily be replaced with bare *muu* ‘bad’. With the additive focus clitic =*č* (see §3.2), *muu*=*č* could imply that the speaker does not even know the matter badly, but just not at all.

- (72) en-iig bol bii neg saiŋ med-ex=**küü**.
 this-ACC TOP 1SG one good know-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 ‘This I don’t know particularly well.’ (SC1: Derik, Benzin)

To negate an adjunct through its predicate without necessarily reducing or denying the main action, the negator or “焦点調整形式” ‘focus adjustment form’ (Mukai 2001: 75–76) *biš* can be used (Yu 1991: 159–160). *Biš* indicates that something is not correct about the proposition, but does not specify what. For instance, (73) is ambiguous with regard to the negated constituent, while in (74) the context specifies that only the adverbial *xüüxed-tei ge-ed* ‘because I have a child’ is negated by *biš*.

- (73) Oyuun bayan ge-ed Dorž tüün-tei genel-sen **biš**.
 NAME rich QUOT-PFV.CVB NAME that-COM marry-PRF.PTCP NEG
 ‘Dorž didn’t marry Oyuun saying>because *Oyuun* is rich (but he did something else/but he married her for another reason).’ (Yu 1991: 159–160)
- (74) Xüüxed-tei ge-ed yaw-ž čad-ax=*güi*
 child-COM QUOT-PFV.CVB go-CVB can-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 bai-gaa=m **biš** šüü.
 COP-PRS.PTCP=ASRT NEG DP
 ‘It is really not because I have a child that I cannot leave [my husband]. [I have (...) all things necessary to take my child with me.]’ (IC)

Biš most often attaches to predicates, but it is also used for the contrastive negation of constituents such as arguments (75), goal complements (76), and attributes. The denied and affirmed constituent must both be overt (Yu 1991: 123–124), except in some fossilized expressions such as *neg biš udaa* / *neg bus udaa* ‘on not just one occasion’ (cf. §3.3.1).

- (75) Monᠭol-d **biš** xar^j gar^jag-t tör-sön bol saixan
 Mongolia-DAT NEG foreign world-DAT be.born-PRF.PTCP if beautiful
 baixgüiyuu.
 DP
 ‘It is great if you were not born in Mongolia, but in the great wide world, you see.’ (IC)

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- (76) Xudaldaq-ge xož-ogd-ox ge-ž biš xož-ox
 trade-ACC defeat-PASS-NPST.PTCP QUOT-CVB NEG defeat-NPST.PTCP
 ge-ž xii-deg.
 QUOT-CVB do-HAB.PTCP
 ‘One does trade not in order to be defeated, but to defeat.’ (IC)

4.2 Negative polarity

A few semantically general adverbs are confined to negated contexts, including the intensifier *ogt* ‘(not) at all’ in (77), *tödiilön* ‘(not) particularly’ [lit. making it that much], and the concessives *yaawč* / *xerxewč* ‘(not) in any regard’ [lit. in spite of doing what]. The comparative-concessive adverbial *tegtlee* [lit. until doing like that] is restricted to negated and interrogative sentences, and *tödii* ‘(only) that much’ prefers, but does not strictly require negated contexts. Indefinite proforms (see §3.2) are mostly found in negative, interrogative and permissive contexts.

Some adverbs are more common in negative contexts due to their specific meanings. For instance, *xaraaxaŋ* ‘still’ only collocates with predicates that express that something has not yet become ready or not come to a certain point as in (77), which also includes positive sentences containing the word *ert* ‘early’ or its derivations. Similarly, *or tas* ‘completely’ collocates with predicates that denote becoming absent, whether this is achieved lexically or via negators.¹¹

- (77) Gexdee en=en xünj ogt ič-ex yos=güi
 but this=3POSS person entirely feel.ashamed-NPST.PTCP custom=NEG
 ge-seŋ üg xaraaxaŋ biš.
 QUOT-PRF.PTCP word still NEG
 ‘But that does not quite mean that man shouldn’t feel ashamed at all.’ (IC)

4.3 Marking of noun phrases in the scope of negation

Under negation, case marking is left intact, only that comitative case marking in *-tai* is replaced with privative marking in *=güi* if the constituent itself is negated (see §3.3). The use and choice of focus markers is affected by polarity, i.e. additive focus marking is used for ‘[not] even [one/once]’ (cf. (63)), but limitative focus marking in *=l* is used in the corresponding positive statement ‘only [one/once]’.

¹¹All forms discussed in this section were identified by Kim (2016: 109).

4.4 Reinforcing negation

The negative polarity adverb *ogt* ‘(not) at all’ as in (77) reinforces negation. Apart from this, several sentence-final particles are general means for reinforcing positive or negative statements.

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

Mongolian tends to embed preceding clauses into subsequent clauses and thus makes relatively limited use of coordination. Constructions based on *eswel* ‘or’ historically speaking use negation in the scope of conditionality to coordinate constituents (see Brosig 2015b: 89–90). Coordination also plays a role in alternative questions with (*ü*)*güi*=*yüü* (§2.2). In a similar vein, it is possible to coordinate two finitely used predicates at the end of a matrix clause. Most often both of these have the same polarity as in (78), but different forms as in (79) are possible, too. The latter might be seen as a predecessor to negated adverbial clauses (§2.4.2). Contrastive constituents can be coordinated by *biš* (§4.1), antonym compounds use =*güi* (§4.6.3).

- (78) Getel tern-ii aaw=an ir-ž (...), tüün-iig bol
 but that-GEN father=3POSS come=CVB that-ACC TOP
 ömöö-ör=öo=güi bas eež-iig=en bas zagn-aa=güi.
 console-RES.PTCP=NEG also mother-ACC=3POSS also scold-RES.PTCP=NEG
 ‘But her father came (...) but he did not console her, nor did he scold the mother.’ (lit. and also didn’t scold ...) (SC2: Retelling_EO)

- (79) neg xözör gar-g-ax-guu, öng-öör=ön
 one trump exit-CAUS-NPST.PTCP-NEG color-INS=3POSS
 gar-ag-čax-Ø!
 exit-CAUS-COMPL-IMP
 ‘[One] doesn’t play a trump [here; rather] follow suit [lit. ‘by its color’]!’
 (SC2: Khalkha0017)

A specific case between coordination and subordination is the negative nominalizer *esex*. It can follow any nominal predication, but most commonly combines with nonpast participles in -x, as in (80). Structurally, this pattern is reminiscent of the formation of alternative questions in that the negator forms something reminiscent of a negated pro-clause, and the tendency to “coordinate” identical TAME forms (if *esex* is taken to historically end in a nonpast participle) supports this explanation. *Esex* as a nominal element can form argument clauses,

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which would be marked by case suffixes as in (81) or, for subjects, by personal-possessive suffixes (for subjects) as in (80). Alternatively, *esex* can also be used attributively as in (82). It is prevalent in formal written texts and entirely absent from SC.

- (80) Bag=n delxii-ŋ awarg-ad orolc-ox
team=3POSS world-GEN champion-DAT participate-NPST.PTCP
esex=n ergelzee-tei.
or.not=3POSS doubt-COM
'It is doubtful whether the team will participate in the world
champion[ship].' (IC)
- (81) en doloo_xonog-t bagt-aa-ŋ D.Zorjogt said-iig
this week-DAT be.contained-CAUS-CVB NAME minister-ACC
ogcr-uul-ax esex-iig šiidverl-ex yos-toi.
resign-CAUS-NPST.PTCP or.not-ACC decide-NPST.PTCP custom-COM
'[We] should decide within this week whether or not [we] relieve
minister D. Zorigt of his duty.' (IC)
- (82) Erdes_bayalag erčem_xüčn-ii said D.Zorjogt-iig
minerals energy-GEN minister NAME-ACC
ogcr-uul-ax esex asuudl-iig UIX-iig
resign-CAUS-NPST.PTCP or.not problem-ACC Great.State.Assembly-GEN
negd-seŋ čuulgan-aar xel-elc-lee.
unite-PRF.PTCP assembly-INS discuss-RECP-IMM.FH.PST
'[They] discussed the question of whether or not to relieve the minister
for resources and energy, D. Zorigt, of his duty during the plenary
session of the Great State Assembly.' (IC)

The pattern (*ter=ç*) *büü xel-Ø* ‘not to mention’ with the old imperative negator *büü* also fulfills a connective function, as in (83), though in structural terms it seems to be adverbial rather than coordinating.

- (83) Tatwar ge-xeer önöödör biznes erxlegč-d-ees exl-eed žiriij
tax QUOT-CVB today business owner-PL-ABL begin-CVB normal
neg-eŋ irgeŋ Dorž guai xürtel töwögš-öö-ž,
one=ATTR citizen NAME mr/mrs until be.uncomfortable-CAUS-CVB
ter=č **büü xel-Ø** zar¹am=an daramt-and or-ž,
that=ADD.FOC NEG say-IMP some=3POSS pressure-DAT enter-CVB

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stress-t bar¹-agd-san bai-dag.
 stress-DAT catch-PASS-PRF.PTCP COP-HAB.PTCP
 ‘If you speak about taxes, today [people] starting from the business
 owner up to normal citizen Dorj feel uncomfortable. **Not to mention that,**
 some **even** get into pressure and are caught by stress.’ (IC)

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

4.6.1 Negative transport

In many languages, subordinate clause predicates with certain semantic characteristics can be negated via a negation that occurs in the matrix clause (e.g. *I don’t think they sing for I think they don’t sing*). This phenomenon is called negative transport (see Horn 1989: 315). In Mongolian, predicates that entail such implicatures include *bod-* ‘think’ (84) and the somewhat formal *xüs-* ‘wish’ (85). Regardless of whether the matrix predicate or the embedded predicate is negated, the most accessible interpretation is that the speaker seeks to express that the predication in the embedded clause does not obtain.

- (84) a. Bi margaaš togol-ž čad-an ge-ž
 1SG tomorrow play-CVB can-IMM.PRS QUOT-CVB
 bod-ox=güi bai-n.
 think-NPST.PTCP=NEG COP-IMM.PRS
 ‘[I] don’t think I can play tomorrow.’ (IC)
- b. infl¹ac¹-ad tiim=č ix nölöl-öx=güi ge-ž
 inflation-DAT SO=ADD.FOC much influence-NPST.PTCP=NEG QUOT-CVB
 bod-ož bai-n.
 think-CVB COP-IMM.PRS
 ‘[I] think that [this] (...) would not influence inflation that much.’ (IC)
- (85) a. Tiim boloxoor bi itgel ald-ax-iig xüs-ex=güi
 like.that because 1SG belief lose-NPST.PTCP-ACC wish-NPST.PTCP-NEG
 bai-gaa.
 COP-EST.PRS
 ‘Because it is like that, I don’t want to lose trust.’ (IC)
- b. Wirus eswel teknik-iin gemtl-ees bol-ž čuxal
 virus or technic-GEN damage-ABL become-CVB important
 fail-uud=aa ald-ax=güi bai-x-iig xüs-deg.
 file-PL=RPOSS lose-NPST.PTCP-NEG COP-EST.PRS-ACC wish-HAB.PTCP
 ‘We want not to be losing important files because of viruses or

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technical defects.’ (IC)

Structurally, the complement clause in (84) is in the scope of the quotative verb, while in (85) it is nominalized via a case-marked nonpast participle. It is exceedingly rare for negated participles to receive accusative case marking ($n_{IC:xüs-}=8$, i.e. the verb *xüs-* is immediately preceded by $-PTCP=güi=g$ on 8 occasions in the Internet Corpus). So if a verb of cognition requires accusative marking, the case suffix rather attaches to a copula that follows the negated participle ($n_{IC:xüs-}=147$). However, a copula automatically conveys aspect (e.g. progressive in (85b)). If this is to be avoided, the negation has to be placed in the matrix clause ($n_{IC:xüs-}=1917$), as in (85a). In contrast to *bod-* (OPINION) and *xüs-* (INTENTION), negated forms of the verb *san-agd-* miss/think-PASS- ‘seem (to the mind) as if’ (PERCEPTION) only rarely take (positive) participial complements ($n_{IC}=15$) or quoted complement clauses ($n_{IC}=12$). Instead, negation usually takes place within the complement of the positive matrix verb *san-agd-*, e.g. by introducing negated participles by means of the dummy noun *yum* ‘thing’ followed by the similative linker *šig* in a sequence $-PTCP=güi\ yum\ šig\ san-agd$ ($n_{IC}=201$). The option to negate either the main or subordinate clause doesn’t seem to be common for predicates of other semantic classes either. PROBABILITY is commonly expressed by complex predicates or adverbials rather than by main clause predicates. For INTENTION and JUDGMENT/WEAK OBLIGATION, speakers heavily rely on MODAL ADJECTIVES, see (67–70) above. These are inherently marked for polarity by privative or comitative (possessive) case forms, while subordinate forms take bare nonpast participles. Consequently, they are negated in the matrix clause as in (86) ($n_{IC}=575$), while a structure similar to (85b) is strongly dispreferred ($n_{IC}=1$).

- (86) Bi öwöl ger-ees=ee car-ax **dur=güi=ee.**
 1SG winter home-ABL=RPOSS go.out-NPST.PTCP desire-NEG=EMPH
 ‘I won’t like leaving my place during winter.’ (IC)

If this preliminary overall picture is correct, “negative transport” in Khalkha Mongolian appears to be a somewhat restricted phenomenon.

4.6.2 Metalinguistic negation

While regular negation denotes that a proposition does not hold true, metalinguistic negation is used to object to an utterance on any grounds conceivable, including its apparent implicatures, its register, morphology or phonetics (Horn 1989: 363). This usually requires the speaker to explicitly invoke an alternative

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contrastive interpretation, something that the ascriptive negator *biš* (< ‘other’) does by necessity (see §2.3.1). Consequently, it is *biš* that is used for the metalinguistic readjustment of perspective as in (87).

- (87) 2009 on-ii sonġuul¹-d C.Elbegdorž ge-deg ulstörč
 2009 year-GEN election-DAT NAME QUOT-HAB.PTCP politician
 yal-saŋ biš, N.Enġxbayar ge-deg ulstörč
 win-PRF.PTCP NEG NAME QUOT-HAB.PTCP politician
 yal-agd-saŋ yum.
 win-PASS-PRF.PTCP ASRT
 ‘In the election of 2009, it was not the politician Ts. Elbegdorj who won,
 [but rather] the politician N. Enkhbayar who was defeated.’ (IC)

4.6.3 Non-negative uses of negatives

A negated nonpast participle plus optional conditional particle may be followed by a negated nonpast participle of *bol-* ‘may’ as in (88) to indicate necessity. Both negated nonpast participle in *-x=güi* and negative converbs in *-lgüi* can be followed by *yaa-* ‘do what’ as in (89) to indicate a reasonable course of action. Straightforward double negation, yielding a positive statement, is accomplished by *=güi biš*, as in (90). Several rare forms of double negation that are even absent from IC are discussed by Pjurbeev (2015).

- (88) bitmiŋ uu-x-kuu bol bol-kuu.
 vitamin drink-NPST.PTCP if may-NPST.PTCP.NEG
 ‘I (really) need to take vitamins.’ (SC2: Z05-1) (lit. ‘It is not possible if [SUBJECT] doesn’t drink vitamins.’)
- (89) odoo xon-uul-x=güü
 now stay.overnight-CAUS-NPST.PTCP=NEG
 yaa-x=aw=dee.
 do.what-NPST.PTCP=NEG=Q.IFR
 ‘Now what else but to let him stay overnight [now that he’s arrived].’
 (SC1: TH, Ganbaatar)
- (90) A: ‘It seems that this light hasn’t been put in yet.’
 B: güi=ee, čidenġ-gii=n xii-gee=güi biš=ee, en-čen
 no=EMPH light.bulb-ACC=3POSS do-RES.PTCP=NEG NEG=EMPH this-STC

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šat-c=iin.

burn-EST.PST=ASRT

‘No, it’s not that the light bulb hasn’t been put in, it has burnt out.’
(IC)

If attached to a pair of antonyms, =*güi* cancels out the relevance of this distinction for the situation at hand, and both sets are conjoined, as in (91). Most attested antonym collocations are highly conventionalized.

- (91) ödör šön=**güü** gedes güi-lg-eed bai-n.
day night=NEG stomach run-CAUS-PFV.CVB COP-IMM.PRS
‘I’m having diarrhea (without regard for) day and night.’ (SC2: Z05-2)

As discussed in §2.2, negated questions commonly combine a request for information with the speaker’s guess at a positive state. The form *bai-x=güi=yüü*, consisting of the existential/copula verb *bai-* as a negated nonpast participle with question clitic, conveys such a meaning in a locative-possessive construction, as in (92). However, if it follows predicative nominals as in (75) and (93), it functions as a specialized discourse particle. It signals to the addressee that the speaker is quite convinced of the proposition and, given the explanation just presented, the addressee should also accept it. Alternatively, the speaker might use it to remind the addressee of an important factor which the addressee might not have considered earlier. This expression also implies that this factor would enable the addressee to automatically understand the overall situation.

In a sincere or even rhetorical negated verbal question, =*güi*=*yüü* would attach directly to the participle. The semantically similar discourse particle *šüü*, conveying the speaker’s superior authority, might have a similar origin, going back to *biš=üü*.

- (92) čam-d maas **bai-x-kuu=yuu?**
2SG.DAT pair.of.cards be-NPST.PTCP=NEG=Q.PLR
‘Don’t you have any pair of cards?’ (SC2: Khalkha0017)
- (93) ter yag iŋg-ež čimx-deg **baixkuuyuu.**
that precisely do.like.this-CVB pinch-HAB.PTCP MP
‘She pinches the dumplings shut in precisely this [efficient and helpful] way, you see.’ (SC2: Z03-1)

The suffix *-lgüi* (see §2.4.2) forms yet another complex discourse particle, *bai-lgüi=dee*, as in (94). It conveys that the occurrence of the event (at a time specified

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by a preceding participial suffix, mostly in *-x*) is almost automatic and nothing that the addressee should worry about. Since specialized converbs in *-lgüi* can normally not occur in sentence-final position, the construction might have arisen from ellipsis, but native speakers are unable to supply any elided component.

- (94) neg cagaan sar-aas ömön uulz-acgaa-x bai-lguu dee.
 one white month-ABL before meet-PL-NPST.PTCP AUX-NEG.CVB DP
 ‘Before New Year, we shall certainly meet.’ (SC2: Z08-1)

As mentioned for (53) in §2.3.1, the function of *biš* can sometimes be understood in terms of its original meaning ‘other’, and such an interpretation is forced for (95). It thus does not truly instantiate a non-negative usage of a negative, but rather the not-yet negative use of a young negator that has not acquired a negation function in all contexts.

- (95) öör xüüxd-üüd-ees=l asuu-x-aas biš
 other child-PL-ABL=LIM.FOC ask-NPST.PTCP-ABL other
 yaa-x=aw?
 do.what-NPST.PTCP-Q.IFR
 ‘What should you do, except for asking other children?’ (IC)

Finally, the construct in (96) appears to be biclausal and ultimately positive. The nominal clause preceding *biš* seems to express an action that the speaker regrets. The second clause conveys the unexpected and undesired consequence of that action. The habitual *-dag* conveys a surprised pseudo-generalization (Brosig 2015a: esp. 93–96), while *bai-n* signals immediate perception. Alternatively, its predicate could contain the completive *-čix-* indicating lack of speaker control. (96a) is a regular translation and (96b) a hypothetical attempt to translate *biš* as a negator, with elliptic elements that currently cannot be motivated independently.

- (96) Yar'-sarj biš gai bol-dog bai-n.
 speak-PRF.PTCP NEG misfortune become-HAB.PTCP COP-IMM.PRS
 a. ‘I spoke [about it], and now misfortune has come out of it.’
 b. ‘[If] it had not been for [me] speaking, [everything would have been good. But now,] I see, misfortune evolves.’ (D. Guntsetseg, p.c., 2019-04-24)

While *biš* (< ‘other’) might still express its original meaning in connective contexts like (95–96), neither *biš* nor *bus* can express this meaning in regular

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attributive uses. In this regard, they contrast with the fossilized plural adjective form *bus.ad* ‘the other(s)’ which can be used attributively or as a nominalized form but cannot function as a negator.

4.6.4 Diachronic notes and observations

The Middle Mongol (13th-14th century) system was based on several preverbal negators: *ese* for past forms, *ülü* for non-pasts, and *büü* for imperatives. There is defeasible evidence that these were also used for ascriptive negation. *Busi* ‘other’ started to take over ascriptive negation in Late Middle Mongol, while *bü-tügei* ‘desist!’ started its development into an imperative negator even later. The existential negator was *ügei* (back then an adjective-like word with varying forms), which also formed privative adverbials. Non-possession was based on a privative rather than a locative scheme (see Brosig 2015b and references therein).

In the “Negative Existential Cycle” (Croft 1991), synchronically speaking, Middle Mongolian occupies stage B~C (an existential negator making first inroads into verbal negation, still closer to stage B). Its daughter Khalkha Mongolian is harder to locate. On the one hand, it occupies a stage in which the cliticized (or suffixed) form =*güi* of a former negative existential has taken over standard negation including the marking of the positive existential, displacing the particle *ügüi* from nearly all of its former functions (B~C, almost completely attaining C). On the other hand, the pragmatically specific form *alac* ‘absent’ is making first inroads into the domain of possessive (Brosig 2015b: 128-129) and, secondarily and somewhat arguably, existential negation (Veselinova 2013: 137), suggesting stage C~A at a point still very close to C. Between the still poetically or dialectally usable constructions involving existential *ügüi*, the complete reign of =*güi* and the advent of *alac*, one might situate Khalkha at a stage B~C~A, confirming the high stability of transitional stages (Veselinova & Hamari 2022: 13).

5 Summary

We observe several distinct negation strategies in Khalkha Mongolian, summarized in Table 1. The most frequent and multi-functional negator is the clitic =*güi*. Diachronically, it started out as an adjective indicating absence (without reference to a specific location) or possessive negation in predicates, attributes and adverbials. In the course of time, it has taken over standard negation and is currently only marginally used for negation of possession. As a standard negator, =*güi* attaches to participles, thus neutralizing the evidential opposition between different past tense forms. In the new locative-possessive-existential negation

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pattern, *=güi* normally attaches to a participial form of the existential verb *bai-*. Its longer and older form *ügüi*, which would be used on its own, not following the positive existential verb, is only marginally attested. Both *=güi* and *ügüi* are used in negative answers and the second clauses of alternative questions. In the second clauses of embedded alternative propositions, the fossilized negator *esex* can be used. The diachronically new negator *alac* ‘absent’ is used as a pragmatically conditioned alternative to *bai-PTCP=güi* and is mostly found in locative-possessive predications. The converbal suffix *-lgüi* (based on deverbal noun-forming *-l*) marks negative adverbial clauses.

The ascriptive negator *biš* has become the only negator for identity and the most common negator for property predications. It originates from the Middle Mongol word *busi* ‘other’ and, probably due to that, it is the only device for metalinguistic negation. It is also used for the negation of participles and as a short standalone negative answer. *Biš* is mostly used in predicates, while attributive identity negation is primarily encoded by the negator *bus* which also derives from *busi*. In addition to their uses as clausal negators, both *(ü)güi* and *biš* may function as nominal bases for derivation.

For imperatives, the preverbal usage of negators has been retained from Middle Mongol, but the innovative form *bitgii* has reduced the original imperative negator *büü* to a rare stylistic variant. If responding to a proposal that the interlocutor would like to act in a particular way, *bitgii* on its own can be used for prohibition. The old pre-verbal standard negators *ül* (imperfective) and *es* (perfective) have been confined to lexical negation and here combine with particular verb stem classes regardless of tense-aspect marking.

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Table 1: Khalkha Mongolian negators

Negation marker	Functions	Section
V-PTCP= <i>güi</i> , N= <i>güi</i>	negates finite predications negates attributive predications negates adverbial predications negates property predications negates alternative questions negative replies privative case derivational negation	§2.1–§2.2, §4.1 §2.4.1 §2.4.2, §3.3.2 §2.3.1 §2.2 §3.1 §3.3.2 §3.3.1–§3.3.2
(N) <i>bai</i> -PTCP= <i>güi</i> , (N) <i>ügüi</i>	negates locative-possessive-existential predications negates comitative-possessive predications alternative questions negative replies	§2.3.2 §2.3.2 §2.2 §3.1
(N) <i>ügüi</i>	basis for negative derivation	§3.3.1
- <i>lgüi</i>	negates adverbial clauses	§2.4.2
(N) <i>alac</i>	negates locative-possessive-existential predications negates comitative-possessive predications	§2.3.2 §2.3.2
<i>esex</i>	alternative propositions	§4.5
N <i>biš</i>	negates identity / property in finite predicates metalinguistic negation negative replies basis for negative derivation connective 'other'	§2.2–§2.3.1, §4.1, §4.6.2 §4.6.2 §3.1 §3.3.1 §4.6.3
N <i>bus</i>	negates identity / property in attributives	§3.3.1
<i>bitgii</i> V-2IMP, <i>büü</i> V-2IMP <i>bitgii</i>	express prohibition expresses negative replies	§2.2 §3.1
<i>ül</i> V-, <i>es</i> V- <i>es</i> V- <i>wal</i>	derivational negation conditional negation	§3.3.1 §3.3.1

Abbreviations

(.)	short pause	INS	instrumental
1	first person	INTS	intensifier
2	second person	INTR	intransitive
3	third person	INJ	interjection
ABL	ablative	IPFV	imperfective
ACC	accusative	LIM	limitative (focus)
ADD	additive (focus)	LOC	locative
ALL	allative	MNR	manner (converb)
ASRT	assertive (particle)	MP	modal particle
ATTR	attributive	NAME	proper name
AUX	auxiliary	NEG	negation
CAUS	causative	NMLZ	nominalizer
COLL	collective	NPST	nonpast
COM	comitative	PASS	passive
COMPL	completive	PFV	perfective
COND	conditional	PL	plural
COP	copula	PLR	polar (question)
CVB	converb	POSS	possessive
DAT	dative	POT	potential
DIM	diminutive	PRF	perfect
DP	discourse particle	PREP	preparatory
DVN	de-verbal noun	PRIV	privative
EMPH	emphatic	PROG	progressive
EST	established (present, past)	PROX	proximal
EX	existential	PRS	present
F	feminine	PROSP	prospective
FH	firsthand (evidentiality)	PST	past
FOC	focus	PTCP	participle
FUT	future	Q	question marker
GEN	genitive	QUOT	quotative verb
HAB	habitual	RECP	reciprocal
HON	honorific	RES	resultative
HORT	hortative	RPOSS	reflexive possessive
IC	Internet Corpus	SC	Spoken Corpus
IFR	information (question)	SG	singular
IMFR	inferential	STC	stance marker
IMM	immediate (present, past)	TAG	tag (question)
IMP	imperative	TOP	topic
IMPL	implore		

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Chapter 9

Negation in Amri Karbi

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This paper provides a description of the negation system in Amri Karbi. The description is based mainly on data collected by the author during fieldwork. The outline of the description follows the structure of the “Questionnaire for describing the negation system of a language” (Miestamo 2025). The paper starts with a short introduction, then it proceeds with description of standard negation in Amri Karbi that is marked with the negative suffix -Ce. Following this is a discussion of non-clausal negation and the final section of the paper provides description of other aspects of negation, including negative polarity and negation in complex clauses among other topics.

Keywords: Amri Karbi, negation, tibeto-burman, duplifix.

1 Introduction

Amri Karbi (ISO: [ajz](#), Glottocode: [amri1238](#)) is a Tibeto-Burman language spoken in the Kamrup district of Assam and the Ri-Bhoi district of Meghalaya of North East India. Amri Karbis, along with a closely related group Karbis, are an indigenous tribe of North East India. They are mentioned as the Mikir in the Constitution Order of the Government of India. Amri Karbis and Karbis are closely related linguistically and ethnically. Karbis predominantly live in Karbi Anglong district of Assam.

A full description of the Amri Karbi grammar is provided in [Philippova \(2021\)](#). The latest description of the closest related language Karbi can be found in [Konnerth \(2014\)](#).

The Amri Karbi live in scattered villages located either in the plains or the hills; they live among an Assamese speaking population and other tribes that

speak either related languages like Tiwa or genealogically unrelated languages like Khasi (Austro-Asiatic). The *Ethnologue* (Eberhard et al. 2019) mentions 125 000 native speakers of Amri Karbi. The Census of India from 2011 states that there are 511 732 Karbi/Mikir native speakers in Assam and 14 380 Karbi/Mikir speakers in Meghalaya, a total of 528 503 Karbi/Mikir speakers in all India.¹ The number of speakers for Assam includes both Amri Karbi speakers and Karbi speakers of Karbi Anglong. Therefore, the exact number of Amri Karbi speakers is uncertain.

Amri Karbi is a verb final language and TAM distinctions are expressed through verb morphology. Amri Karbi is a synthetic language, with some degree of variation in the form of morphemes and fusion at morpheme boundaries.

Table 1 gives a summary of verbal affixes and their assigned slots.

Table 1: Template of Amri Karbi verb structure

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
<i>nang</i> =	NMLZ <i>ki-</i>	RR <i>chi-</i>	ROOT	PRED.DERIV	RED	NEG - <i>Ce</i>	R - <i>lô</i>	TAG = <i>dik</i>
1 <i>ne</i> =	PST <i>ki-</i>	CAUS <i>pa-</i>		(RED)		IMP - <i>not</i>	HAB - <i>man</i>	ASSUM =hole/=hele
2 <i>nang</i> =				(NEG)		IMP.POL - <i>tha</i>	POT - <i>bô</i>	CONF.Q= <i>bô</i>
1PL.INCL <i>i</i> =						PROH - <i>nek</i>	FUT - <i>ye</i>	OT = <i>ba</i>
1pl.EXCL <i>hali</i> =						HORT - <i>nang</i>	IRR1 - <i>bang</i>	REP = <i>tâng/-tânghò</i>
							NFNL.R - <i>si</i>	Q = <i>ma</i>
							NFNL.IRR - <i>ne</i>	Q2 = <i>te</i>
							yet - <i>lang</i>	ADD = <i>ta</i>
							DEF - <i>po</i>	UNCERT = <i>ne</i>
								may.be = <i>mine</i>
								REPL = <i>to</i>
								INTERACT = <i>hō</i>
								EMPH = <i>he</i>
								SUPP = <i>tema</i>
								DECL = <i>ro</i>
								INDF = <i>bak</i>

Amri Karbi is a tonal language, with three tones, low, medium and high, which exhibit low functional load. In the text examples tone is marked only on those items where the tone category was identified. Since there is a high variability and fluctuation of tone, only underlying tone is marked in the text examples. Tone in the text examples is marked with the diacritics, e.g. *á* ‘High’, *à* ‘Low’, *ā* ‘Mid’.

Most of the linguistic examples given in this paper come from natural data collected by the author during fieldtrips (in the period 2013–2017) as a part of the Amri Karbi grammatical description project (see Philippova 2021). There are two hours and thirty-four minutes of transcribed natural data; there are also several hours of recorded audio and video data that were not transcribed but were used for this paper to supplement the transcribed data. The transcribed data consists of data recorded from thirty speakers. The paper contains some elicited examples

¹<http://censusindia.gov.in/>

that were recorded during the fieldtrips or remotely from language consultants. When a linguistic example in this paper was elicited, it is indicated after the example. There are some examples that come from the New Testament that was translated in 2013; these examples are indicated as (NT).

2 Clausal negation

2.1 Standard negation

Standard negation (Payne 1985, Miestamo 2005) in Amri Karbi is expressed by the negative marker on a verb which is an onset reduplication suffix or a duplifix -Ce. A duplifix is a mixture of an affix and reduplication where an element attached to the base consists of both copied segments and fixed segments (Haspelmath 2002: 24). In Amri Karbi, the copied segment is the onset of the last syllable of the verb stem. The fixed segment is the vowel which is always *e*. For example, the verb *cho* ‘eat’ has an onset *ch*, so the negative suffix for *cho* is *che* and the negative form of the verb is *choche* ‘not eat’. If the last syllable of the verb stem does not have an onset, then the negative suffix starts with the glottal stop; for example, *ùn* ‘be able’ does not have an onset consonant, so the negative suffix for *ùn* is *e* and the negative form of the verb is produced as *ùn’e* ‘not able’.² In the text examples, the negative suffix is written as -Ce on the morpheme line, where C stands for the onset consonant and *e* is the fixed vowel of the negative suffix.

The negative suffix attaches to a verb stem (that may consist of a verb and a predicate derivation suffix) (1), thus appearing between the stem and TAM suffix.

- (1) a. Ne dame.
 ne dam-ye
 1 go-FUT
 ‘I will go.’
 b. Ne damdeye.
 ne dam-Ce-ye
 1 go-NEG-FUT
 ‘I will not go.’ (elicited)

Amri Karbi standard negation is different from the affirmative counterpart in regard to TAM marking, where the basic negated verb stem serves as a general negative form. As is shown in this section, there is a paradigmatic asymmetry (the term adapted from the typology suggested by Miestamo (2005) between

²The negative suffixes starting with the glottal stop are written with the apostrophe, i.e. *un’e* ‘not able’.

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Amri Karbi's affirmative and negative structures with some TAM categories. This asymmetry is exhibited by the tense-aspect distinction in the negative being neutralized. For example, in the habitual there is a constructional asymmetry as the habitual *-man* disappears in the negative (2); in other words, there is a cooccurrence restriction of the negative *-Ce* and the habitual *-man*. There is also a variation in the negative of the future *-ye* (3), with either keeping the future *-ye* in the negative or not. As a result, negative forms of the habitual *-man* and the future *-ye* sometimes are identical, and the formal distinction between these forms is neutralized in the negative, their senses may be inferred though the context.

- (2) a. Ne an choman.
 ne an cho-man
 1 rice eat-HAB
 'I eat rice.'
- b. Ne an choche.
 ne an cho-Ce
 1 rice eat-NEG
 'I do not eat rice.' (elicited)
- (3) a. Ne an choye.
 ne an cho-ye
 1 rice eat-FUT
 'I will eat rice.'
- b. Ne an chocheye.
 ne an cho-Ce-ye
 1 rice eat-NEG-FUT
 'I will not eat rice.'
- c. Ne an choche.
 ne an cho-Ce
 1 rice eat-NEG
 'I will not eat rice.' (elicited)

In the database, the negative and the future *-ye* occurs primarily along with the conditional clauses (4). The general negative form of the verb stem and the negative duplifix is found to have future sense (5).

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- (4) Aro labang hakpo kiphok phoknge putang putene nang eku hlonghleye.
 aro labang hak-po ki-phok phok-ye {putang putene} nang
 and DEM bucket-DEF NMLZ-open open-FUT {then} 2
 eku **hlong-Ce-ye**
 nothing get-NEG-FUT
 ‘And this bucket, if you open then you will not get anything.’ (natural data)
- (5) Tene kaiyokta thanek neta thanthe.
 tene kai=yok=ta than-ek ne-ta **than-Ce**
 then who=NSUBJ=ADD say-PROH 1=ADD say-NEG
 ‘So do not tell anyone and I will not tell (anyone).’ (natural data)

There is a different form of paradigmatic asymmetry between negative and affirmative in the case of the potential *-bo*. The potential *-bo* marks events that are non-asserted or that the speaker considers not to be the case. There is a cooccurrence restriction between the potential *-bo* and the negative marker *-Ce*. The elicited negative form of the potential *-bo* appears as the realis *-lo* or as a basic negative form with the stem and the negative marker (6), as is the case with the negative habitual and future that was shown above. However, the realis *-lo* with the negative suffix yields an emphatic meaning of ‘no more’ or ‘never’, which suggests that it is not an exact negative counterpart of the potential *-bo* which does not have this type of emphatic meaning.³

- (6) a. Ne an chobo.
 ne an cho-bo
 1 rice eat-POT
 ‘I am going to/will eat rice.’
- b. Ne an chochelo.
 ne an cho-Ce-lo
 1 rice eat-NEG-R
 ‘I will not eat rice (any more).’
- c. Ne an choche.

³Note that the construction verb-NEG-*lo* does not need to have the word ‘never’ to produce this meaning, which is different than the construction verb-NEG-NEGEX that is discussed in §3.2, where the adverb *jatsi* ‘never’ is required.

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ne an cho-Ce
 1 rice eat-NEG
 'I will not eat rice.' (elicited)

Since the realis *-lo* produces the future meaning in the negative, one would expect the negative realis to have a different form. The suffix *-lo* has functions that fluctuate between the categories of the realis mood and perfect and perfective. As a mood marker, it has to do with the actuality of a state and in this category, it usually appears with a copular verb or an adjectival verb. As an aspect, it marks action verbs and indicates completed events that involve change (perfect), or it marks actions that are viewed as a single whole (perfective). The negative counterpart of the realis *-lo* has three forms. One is when the negated verb stem is marked with the realis *-lo*. In this case the meaning of the verb has an aspectual meaning of 'no more, never', which is similar to the future meaning of *-lo* 'no more, never' discussed above, but it does not have future meaning (7). Another form consists of the negated verb stem marked with the reduced form of the negative existential *ingyong* i.e. *-yong* (8). The negated verb stem is then marked with *-yong* and may be further marked with the realis *-lo*, but the semantics in this case requires a speaker to provide a reason for the event that did not happen (8). See also Table 2, that illustrates the different negative counterpart constructions of affirmative *-lo*.

- (7) Taramta angpasiselo.
 taram=ta nang=pasi-Ce-lo
 call=ADD CIS=respond-NEG-R
 'Even though (he) called (him), (he) never responded.' (natural data)
- (8) a. Ne an cholo.
 ne an cho-lo
 1 rice eat-R
 'I have eaten rice.'
- b. Ne an chocheyong/chocheyongo.
 ne an cho-Ce-yong/cho-Ce-yong-lo
 1 rice eat-NEG-NEGEX/eat-NEG-NEGEX-R
 'I have not eaten.' / 'I have not eaten (because I was sick).' (elicited)

The irrealis *-bang* marks events that have not happened and are going to happen. There is a nature of intention, desire and necessity in actions marked with *-bang*. The irrealis *-bang* may occur both in the affirmative and negative, but the

Table 2: The negative counterpart constructions of affirmative -lo

affirmative	negative
<i>dam-lo</i>	<i>dam-de-yong</i> <i>dam-de-yong-o</i> <i>dam-de-lo</i> ‘future sense’

senses of *-bang* are not symmetric in the affirmative and negative. In the negative, the intentionality of *-bang* is not negated, the action that it marks is negated and an inference of the expectation of the action is produced (9). In addition, similar to other TAM discussed above (habitual, future and potential), the general negative form with the verb root and the negative suffix may be used and the meaning of *-bang* may be inferred through the context.

- (9) a. Ne hat dambang.
ne hat dam-bang
1 market go-IRR1
‘I am going to the market now.’⁴
- b. Ne hat damdebang.
ne hat dam-Ce-bang
1 market go-NEG-IRR1
‘I am not going to the market now/yet (but I will after sometime).’
- c. Ne hat damde.
ne hat dam-Ce
1 market go-NEG
‘I am not going to the market.’ (elicited)

The elicited negated past tense forms appear symmetrical, where the negative suffix *-Ce* is added to the affirmative past tense e.g. (10). However, in the available natural data, the past tense *ki-* never occurs in the negative. Negatives with past time references in the data have the form involving reduced negative existential copula *-yong/-yong-o*. This is the same negative construction that is used for the negative realis, e.g. (11).

⁴*ne hat dambang* ‘I am going to the market now’ can mean that a person intends to go to the market at the time of speaking or that a person is on the way to the market.

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- (10) a. Kiwang.
 ki-wang
 PST-come
 ‘(I) came.’
 b. Kiwangwe.
 ki-wang-Ce
 PST-come-NEG
 ‘(I) did not come.’ (elicited)
- (11) Chiklo jonni dordelengke anang jangchilangdundeyongo mengsurungpo
 ahem ayok.
 chiklo jon-ni dor-Ce-leng=ke anang
 month CLF:month-two complete-NEG-reach=TOP 3
 nang=chi-lang-dun-Ce-yong-lo mengsurung-po a-hem
 CIS=RR-look-follow-NEG-NEGEX.COP-R fox-DEF POSS-house
 a-yok
 POSS-DIR
 ‘He (the crocodile) did not come to the fox’s house for two months.’
 (natural data)

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

2.2.1 Prohibitive

Second person imperatives or commands are expressed by a bare stem or by one of the imperative suffixes *-not* or *-tha*. The imperative *-tha* is used for plural addressees or in a formal setting, e.g. talking to one’s in-laws. The imperative *-not* is used for plural addressees or also in a formal setting, e.g. talking to strangers, but it is less formal than the imperative *-tha*. The bare stem form is used in informal settings, e.g. talking to friends, siblings, etc. The negative form of an imperative has a dedicated construction, which is the prohibitive suffix *-yek*. The prohibitive suffix *-yek* is used for all three types of imperatives; as a result, the negative of imperative does not distinguish between formal and informal forms, e.g. (12), thus showing paradigmatic asymmetry.

- (12) a. Cho! / Chonot! / Chotha!
 cho / cho-not / cho-tha
 eat / eat-IMP / eat-IMP.POL
 ‘Eat! / Eat! / Eat, please!’

- b. Choyek!
 cho-yek
 eat-PROH
 ‘Do not eat!’ (elicited)

The Amri Karbi prohibitive *-yek* does not occur with the imperative suffixes, which is different from Karbi (see [Konnerth 2014:536](#)) where the Karbi prohibitive suffix *-rī* occurs with the imperative suffixes.

2.2.2 Modals

Some negative non-declarative clause types are expressed with the modal predicate derivational suffixes *-lag(e)* ‘want, should’ and *-un* ‘be able’. In negation of the modal *-lag(e)* there is an asymmetry, as the negative suffix does not attach to *-lag(e)*, but to a different modal suffix *-nang* e.g. (13) (note that in the case of the predicate derivational suffix *-nang* the scope of negation is on the entire predicate). The suffix *-nang* is an older modal that was used both in the affirmative and negative, but nowadays, Amri Karbi speakers prefer to use the Asamese borrowed modal *-lag(e)* in the affirmative. However, the old form *nang* is still used in the negative. Cross-linguistically there is a phenomenon where old elements are sometimes preserved in the negative and Amri Karbi *-lag(e)*, and *nang* are good examples of it. Amri Karbis remember that they previously used modal *nang* in both the affirmative and the negative and it was used in the New Testament translation in the affirmative. This form is still used in the closely related language Karbi ([Konnerth 2014: 356](#)), where the modal *-lag(e)* has not been adopted.

- (13) a. Chobellage.
 chobel-lage
 deceive-need
 ‘You should deceive.’
 b. Chobelnangne.
 chobel-nang-Ce
 deceive-need-NEG
 ‘You should not deceive.’ (elicited)

Non-declarative clauses constructed with the modal *-un* are negated with the negative verbal suffix *-Ce* (14).

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- (14) Nanghem kihlenghlelengke nang labang hakpo phoun'e.
 nang-hēm ki-hlēng-Ce=**lēngke** nang la=bang hak-po
 2-house NMLZ-reach-NEG=until 2 DEM=GNR bucket-DEF
 pho-ùn-Ce
 open-be.able-NEG
 'Before you reach home, you must not open the bucket.' (PM Bilangthe)

2.2.3 Negative questions

Polar questions are constructed with the question particle =*ma* that marks the predicate. In negative polar questions, the verb has the negative suffix -*Ce* and the question particle is the same =*ma* as in the standard negation questions, e.g. (15). However, in negative questions that involve the negative existential *ingyong* the question particle is =*te* instead of =*ma*, e.g. (16). The question particle =*te* is also a dedicated question particle for rhetorical questions and reprimands.

- (15) a. Mohan hat kidamma?
 Mohan hat ki-dam=*ma*
 Mohan market PST-go=Q
 'Did Mohan go to market?'
 b. Mohan hat damdema?
 Mohan hat dam-Ce=*ma*
 Mohan market go-NEG=Q
 'Didn't Mohan go to market?' (elicited)
- (16) a. Mohanpo hem doma?
 Mohan-po hem do=*ma*
 Mohan-M home COP=Q
 'Is Mohan at home?'
 b. Mohan-po hem ingyongte?
 Mohan-po hem ingyong=*te*
 Mohan-M home NEGEX=Q
 'Isn't Mohan at home?' (elicited)

2.3 Negation in stative predications

Stative predications are classified according to [Payne \(1997: 111\)](#) with following types of stative predication clauses: equation, class inclusion, attribution, locative predication, existential predication and possessive predication.

2.3.1 Equative and class inclusion clauses

In equative and class inclusion clauses, nouns function as predicates without any other elements in the present tense. The subject is topicalized and the noun predicate usually carries the definite marker *-po/-pe*. Nominal predicate clauses require a combination of a noun and the copula *do* when the nominal clause is in the past and the copula is marked with the past tense *ki-*. In the future tense, the equative and class inclusion clauses generally use the verb *chiplang* ‘become’ instead of the copula *do*. The negative equative is *kalek*, which is placed at the end of the negative equative and class inclusion clauses. The negative *kalek* does not take TAM markers, but it can be marked with the second syllable of the existential *ingyong*, i.e. *kalekyong*. The negative *kalek* is used in negative present clauses, even though there is no affirmative copula in equative and class inclusion clauses of present tense, e.g. (17–22). The present and past tense negative equative and class inclusion clauses are identical in form and the past tense is inferred though the context e.g. (17–22). The fact that the past tense distinction is eliminated in the negative, makes the pattern to be asymmetric in the past tense. The future negative equative and class inclusion clauses are marked on the verb *chiplang* with the negative duplifix *-Ce* e.g. (17–22).

- (17) a. Anangke neaipe.
 anang=ke ne-ai-pe
 3=TOP 1-mother-F
 ‘She is my mother.’
 b. Anangke neaipe kalek.
 anang=ke ne-ai-pe kalek
 3=TOP 1-mother-F NEG.EQ
 ‘She is not/was not/will not be my mother.’ (elicited)
- (18) a. Anangke neaipe kido.
 anang=ke ne=ai-pe ki-do
 3=TOP 1=mother-F PST-COP
 ‘She was my mother.’
 b. Anangke neaipe kalek.
 anang=ke ne-ai-pe kalek
 3=TOP 1-mother-F NEG.EQ
 ‘She is not/was not/will not be my mother.’ (elicited)

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- (19) a. Anangke necipe chiplangye.
 anang=ke ne=ai-pe chiplang-ye
 3=TOP 1=mother-F become-FUT
 ‘She will become my mother.’
 b. Anangke necipe chiplangpleye.
 anang=ke ne=ai-pe chiplang-ple-ye
 3=TOP 1=mother-F become-NEG-FUT
 ‘She will not become my mother.’ (elicited)
- (20) a. Mohanpoke sikaripo.
 Mohan-po=ke sikari-po
 Mohan-DEF=TOP hunter-DEF
 ‘Mohan is a hunter.’
 b. Mohanpoke sikaripo kalek.
 Mohan-po=ke sikari-po kalek
 Mohan-DEF=TOP hunter-DEF NEG.EQ
 ‘Mohan is not a hunter.’ (elicited)
- (21) a. Mohanpoke sikaripo kido.
 Mohan-po=ke sikari-po ki-do
 Mohan-DEF=TOP hunter-DEF PST-COP
 ‘Mohan was a hunter.’
 b. Mohanpoke sikaripo kalek.
 Mohan-po=ke sikari-po kalek
 Mohan-DEF=TOP hunter-DEF NEG.EQ
 ‘Mohan was not a hunter.’ (elicited)
- (22) a. Mohanpoke sikaripo chiplangye.
 Mohan-po=ke sikari-po chiplang-ye
 Mohan-DEF=TOP hunter-DEF become-FUT
 ‘Mohan will become a hunter.’
 b. Mohanpoke sikaripo chiplangpleye.
 Mohan-po=ke sikari-po chiplang-Ce-ye
 Mohan-DEF=TOP hunter-DEF become-NEG-FUT
 ‘Mohan will not become a hunter.’ (elicited)

2.3.2 Attributive clauses

In Amri Karbi, the attributive function is usually fulfilled by adjectival verbs that are nominalized and usually carry the possessive prefix *a-*. Since adjectival verbs are verbs, the verbal negative suffix *-Ce* is used when attributive clauses are negated, e.g. (23). However, since adjectival verbs are nominalized, nominal predicate negation strategy can also be used to negate adjectival verbs. So, to negate an attributive clause, the negative equational *kalek* can be used, but the negative existential *ingyong* can be used as well. Examples (23) and (24) show an adjectival verb *akime* ‘be.good’ being negated either with the standard negator (23b) or the negative equative *kalek* or the negative existential *ingyong* (20b), the meaning in both cases is the same. There is a symmetry between affirmative and negative attributive clauses in examples (23) and (24).

- (23) a. An akime.
 an a-ki-me
 rice POSS-NMLZ-be.good
 ‘Rice (generally) is good.’
- b. An akimeme.
 an a-ki-me-Ce
 3 POSS-NMLZ-be.good-NEG
 ‘Rice (generally) is not good.’ (elicited)
- (24) a. An akime.
 an a-ki-me
 rice POSS-NMLZ-be.good
 ‘Rice (generally) is good.’
- b. An akime kalek/ingyong.
 an a-ki-me kalek/ingyong
 rice POSS-NMLZ-be.good NEG.EQ/NEGEX
 ‘Rice (generally) is not good.’ (elicited)

When attributive clauses appear with different tenses, the constructions are partially symmetric. In the past tense the affirmative attributive clause involves the copula *do* that inflects for past tense; in the negative, the negative suffix attaches to the copula *do*, thus being symmetric. In the future tense, the adjectival verb itself functions as a verb and inflects for the future tense, while in the negative, the negative verbal suffix attaches to the adjectival verb, but the future tense is lost, thus being asymmetric, e.g. (25).

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- (25) a. An akime kido.
 rice a-ki-me ki-do
 rice POSS-NMLZ-be.good PST-COP
 ‘(The cooked) rice was good.’
- b. An akime kidode.
 an a-ki-me ki-do-Ce
 rice POSS-NMLZ-be.good NMLZ-COP-NEG
 ‘(The cooked) rice was not good.’
- c. An akimeye/meye.
 an a-ki-me-ye/me-ye
 rice POSS-NMLZ-be.good-FUT/be.good-FUT
 ‘(The cooked) rice will be good.’
- d. An akimeme/meme.
 an a-ki-me-Ce/me-Ce
 rice POSS-NMLZ-be.good-NEG/be.good-NEG
 ‘(The cooked) rice will not be good.’ (elicited)

2.3.3 Existential clauses

Existential clauses that usually perform a presentative function are expressed by a combination of a noun and the copula *do* regardless of tense, where the copula *do* occurs clause-finally. The copula *do* may occur without TAM markers and has a present tense meaning and may inflect for TAM. Existential clauses are negated by the negative existentials *ingyong* or *we*, e.g. (26). The negative existentials *ingyong* and *we* may take some TAM markers; both *ingyong* and *we* may be marked with the realis *-lo* for the aspectual meaning, e.g. ‘no more’, and both *ingyong* and *we* may be marked with the future *-ye*, e.g. *weye* ‘will not be’. The negative existential *ingyong* also occurs with the aspect *-lang* ‘yet’, the imperative *-not* and the non-final verbal suffix *-si*. The past tense is not marked on the existential and is inferred through the context, which makes this pattern to be asymmetric. Subject arguments in negative existential clauses are usually definite. Examples (26–28) show an indefinite subject in the positive existential marked with the numeral *isi* ‘one’. If we replace the positive copula *do* with the negative *ingyong* in (26–28) the meaning will be *isi anijom ingyong* ‘one custom is missing’. So, the subject in the negative is identifiable and the numeral *isi* ‘one’ may no longer function as an indefinite marker in (26–28), but as the numeral ‘one’. On the other hand, since the obligatory possessive prefix *a-* is on the word *anijom*, it can also have a third person possessive reading of the existential clause

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‘they do not have a custom/ he or she does not have a custom’. If we look at a noun without the obligatory possessive prefix *a-* (for example *tike* ‘tiger’) in (29), in the negative numeral *i-jon* ‘one-CLF.ANIM’ will again have a numeric meaning rather than indefinite and without the numeral, negation will induce the definite marker *-po* or an information structure topic =*ke*, focus =*si*, additive =*ta* or a plural *-hel/- (po)mar* on the subject, depending on the context.⁵

- (26) a. *Isi anijom do.*
 isi a-nijom do
 one POSS-custom COP
 ‘There is one custom.’
- b. *Anijom(po) ingyong/we.*
 a-nijom(po) ingyong/we
 POSS-custom-(DEF) NEGEX
 ‘There is no/was no/will not be custom.’ / ‘They do not have (the)
 custom.’ (natural data)
- (27) a. *Isi anijom ki-do.*
 isi a-nijom ki-do
 one POSS-custom PST-COP
 ‘There was one custom.’
- b. *Anijom(po) ingyong/we.*
 a-nijom(po) ingyong/we
 POSS-custom-(DEF) NEGEX
 ‘There was no custom.’ (elicited)
- (28) a. *Isi anijom doye.*
 isi a-nijom do-ye
 one POSS-custom COP-FUT
 ‘There will be one custom.’
- b. *Anijom(po) weye.*
 a-nijom(po) we-ye
 POSS-custom-(DEF) NEGEX-FUT
 ‘There will be no custom.’ (elicited)

⁵The negative copular verbs **ingyong* and *we* are generally in free variation. The copula *kangwe*, likely formed by the lexicalization of the nominalized negative copulas *ingyong* and *we* (with the initial vowel of *ingyong* dropped, as typical with the prefix *ing-* in Amri Karbi), is primarily used in possessive clauses, where *we* rarely occurs.

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- (29) a. Tike ijon do.
 tike i-jon do
 tiger one-CLF:ANIM COP
 ‘There is one tiger.’
 b. Tike ijon ingyong.
 tike i-jon ingyong
 tiger one-CLF:ANIM NEGEX
 ‘One tiger is missing.’
 c. Tikepo ingyong.
 tike-po ingyong
 tiger-DEF NEGEX
 ‘There is no tiger.’ (elicited)

2.3.4 Possessive clauses

Amri Karbi possessive clauses employ the existential structure, which is a combination of a noun and a copula regardless of tense and mood. Similarly, to existential clauses, the copula in possessive clauses may inflect for tense and mood and appears clause-finally. Possessive clauses are negated by the negative existential *ingyong* or the negative existential *kangwe* ‘not.exist’, e.g. (30–31). The negative existential *ingyong* may be marked with the realis *-lo* (with the meaning ‘no more’), the future *-ye* and *-lang* ‘yet’; *kangwe* is a nominalized form and does not occur marked with TAM. Negative possessive clauses that appear in past time contexts imply past tense though the context (31). Possessive clauses in future, i.e. ‘I will have a house’ could not be produced.

- (30) a. Nehem do.
 ne-hem do
 1-house COP
 ‘I have a house.’ (lit. ‘My house exists.’)
 b. Nehem ingyong/kangwe.
 ne-hem ingyong/kangwe
 1-house NEGEX/not.exist
 ‘I do not have a house.’ (lit. ‘My house does not exist.’)
 c. Nehem kido.
 ne-hem ki-do
 1-house PST-COP
 ‘I had a house.’ (lit. ‘My house exists.’)

- d. Nehem ingyong/kangwe.
 ne-hem ingyong/kangwe
 1-house NEG.EX/not.exist

‘I did not have a house.’ (lit. ‘My house did not exist.’) (elicited)

- (31) Atomo asarpe himepe ahem kangwe aret kangwe salkam katiki kaita kangwe.

a-tomo a-sar-pe hime-pe a-hem **kangwe** a-ret
 POSS-story POSS-be.old-F widow-F POSS-house not.exist POSS-field
kangwe sal-kam ki-tiki kaita **kangwe**
 not.exist work-work NMLZ-work nobody not.exist

‘A story about an old widow, (she) had no home, no field, nobody to work (with her).’ (natural data)

2.3.5 Locative predicate

Locative predicate clauses also use existential construction and are constructed with the copular verb *do* and one of the locative relator nouns, e.g. *-long* ‘LOC’. The copula *do* inflects for TAM and appears clause-finally. Locative predicates are negated by negative existentials *ingyong* or *we*, that occur clause-finally and may inflect for TAM as in existential clauses, e.g. (32–34). Locative predicate clauses in past time contexts may also infer past tense through the context (35).

- (32) a. Hikpo hem along do.
 hik-po hem a-long do
 dog-DEF house POSS-LOC COP
 ‘The dog is in the house.’
 b. Hikpo hem along ingyong.
 hik-po hem a-long ingyong
 dog-DEF house POSS-LOC NEGEX
 ‘The dog is not in the house.’ (elicited)
- (33) a. Hikpo hem along kido.
 hik-po hem a-long ki-do
 dog-DEF house POSS-LOC PST-COP
 ‘The dog was in the house.’
 b. Hikpo hem along ingyongo.
 hik-po hem a-long ingyong-lo
 dog-DEF house POSS-LOC NEGEX-R
 ‘There was no dog in the house (anymore).’ (elicited)

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- (34) a. Hikpo hem along doye.
hik-po hem a-long do-ye
dog-DEF house POSS-LOC COP-FUT
‘The dog will be in the house.’
b. Hikpo hem along weye.
hik-po hem a-long we-ye
dog-DEF house POSS-LOC NEGEX-FUT
‘The dog will not be in the house.’ (elicited)
- (35) Anangai wang kilang ayokke ososo hemtak along ingyong.
anang-ai wang ki-lang a-yok=ke oso-so hemtak a-long
3-mother come NMLZ-look POSS-PURP=TOP child-DEF hut POSS-LOC
ingyong
NEGEX
‘When his mother came to look, the baby was not in the hut.’ (natural data)

2.3.6 Summary

There are three constructions for stative predications. One is the equative construction that is also used in class inclusion clauses; they are constructed with a nominal predicate in the present tense and involve a copular verb in the past and future. Other stative predicates - existential, possessive and locative - employ one existential construction that involves the copula *do*, which inflects for tense. The negation of stative predications does not involve the negative suffix *-Ce* that is used in standard negation. The equative clauses are negated with the negative equative *kalek* which does not inflect for tense. Negative existential clauses are constructed with the negative existentials *ingyong* and *we* for existential and locative clauses, *ingyong* and *kangwe* for possessive clauses. The negative existentials *ingyong* and *we* may inflect for TAM or may infer the tense through the context. Thus the pattern is asymmetric and possessives and locatives inherit this asymmetry from existentials.

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Subordinate clauses are constructed by the nominalizer *ki-* marking the subordinate verb. Besides nominalization, subordination can also be generated by the realis non-final suffix *-si* or the irrealis *-ne*. The non-final suffix *-si* is used for subordination in declarative clauses and in the realis mood, whereas the non-final

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suffix *-ne* is used for subordination of non-declarative clauses and declarative clauses in the irrealis mood. Nominalized subordinate clauses (36), (38), as well as those that are marked with non-final suffixes *-si/-ne* (37), are negated by the verbal negative suffix *-Ce*. Therefore, subordinate clauses use standard negation in a regular way without the asymmetry that was observed in the main clauses. The affirmative counterparts of the examples (36), (37), and (38) could be constructed by leaving out the negative suffix *-Ce*. The main reason for the symmetry is that there is usually no TAM marking in the subordinate clauses.

- (36) Parake anang bupeke kampihel kikatune ayok hem pademlo.
 parake anang bu-pe=ke kampi-hel **ki-kat-un-Ce**
 then 3 grandmother-FEM=TOP monkey-PL NMLZ-run-be.able-NEG
 a-yok hem padem-lo
 POSS-PURP house repair-R
 ‘And their grandma repaired the house so that monkeys could not run away.’ (natural data)
- (37) Manta phurulpoke chiklangklesi arlengposi kimead arlengposi
 chiklangdungsi wango.
 manta phurul-po=ke **chi-klang-Ce-si** arleng-po=si
 but snake-DEF=TOP RR-show-NEG-NFNL.R man-DEF=FOC
 ki-me-ad arleng-po=si chi-klang-dung-si wang-lo
 NMLZ-be.good-be.much man-m=FOC.R RR-show-near-NFNL.R come-R
 ‘But the snake did not show himself (as a snake) he came out as a handsome man.’ (natural data)
- (38) Lasi labadisi anang damman kihlonghle apor manta aneng arong doman.
 lasi labadi=si anang dam-man **ki-hlong-Ce** a-por manta
 so like.this=FOC.R 3 go-HAB NMLZ-get-NEG POSS-time but
 {aneng arong} do-man
 happy COP-HAB
 ‘So he goes hunting like this, even when he did not get (birds) he was happy.’ (natural data)

The subordinator *=lengke* ‘until’ (which is a negative polarity item, see §4.2) occurs with the negated main clause that marks the punctual ‘until’ for the event in the main clause to happen (40–41). The verb in the subordinate clause marked with *=lengke* is also negated. This phenomenon is called ‘expanded negation’ (Wälchli 2018: 145), where negation in temporal clauses in translation equivalents in many other languages lack negation. An ‘until’ clause in Amri Karbi

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identifies the time when the event in the main clause may happen, happened or will happen. These negated adverbial clauses demonstrate an “extremely close relation between linguistic form and function” (Hetterle 2015: 145–146); in Amri Karbi, if the event in the adverbial clause marked with =*lengke* does not happen, the event in the main clause also does not happen. The ‘until’ clause marked with =*lengke* may also occur with an affirmative main clause (42), where the adverbial clause identifies a point of time until which the event of the main clause may last.

- (39) Lasi bekso niyok panghongtolo apor chokchelang apodsi.
 lasi bek-so ne-yok pa-inghong-tol-lo apor chok-Ce-**lang**
 so little-DIM 1-N.SUBJ CAUS-wait-send-R time finish-NEG-yet
 apod=si
 because=FOC
 ‘So I was asked to wait for sometime because time is not yet finished.’
 (natural data)
- (40) Chiklo jonni dordelengke anang jangchilangdundeyongo mengsurungpo
 ahem ayok.
 chiklo jon-ni dor-Ce=**lengke** anang
 month CLF:month-two complete-NEG=until 3
 nang=chi-làng-dun-Ce-yong-lò mengsurung-po a-hēm
 CIS=RR-look-follow-NEG-NEG.EX.COP-R fox-DEF POSS-house
 a-yok
 POSS-DIR
 ‘He (the crocodile) did not come to check (his children) at the fox’s house
 until two months had passed.’ (natural data)
- (41) Nanghem kihlenghlelengke nang labang hakpo phoun’e.
 nang-hēm ki-hleng-Ce=**lengke** nang la=bang hak-po
 2-house NMLZ-reach-NEG=until 2 DEM=GNR bucket-DEF
 pho-ùn-Ce
 open-be.able-NEG
 ‘Before you reach home, you cannot open the bucket.’ (natural data)
- (42) aro Herodpo thithelengke lalongsi dolo.
 aro Herod-po thi-Ce=**lengke** lalong=si do-lo
 and PN:Herod-M die-NEG=until there=FOC:R stay-R
 ‘and was there until the death of Herod’ (NT)

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

Negative lexicalizations include ‘not yet’, ‘not exist’, ‘not be of identity’, ‘not know’, ‘cannot, not be able to’, ‘not want’, ‘not talk’, ‘not need’, ‘not enough’, ‘not like’, and ‘not see’ (cf. Veselinova 2013a). Some of these lexicalizations are treated in other sections, e.g. ‘not exist’ and ‘not be of identity’ are treated in §2.3, ‘not yet’ in §4.2 and ‘not want/not should’ is treated in §2.2.2.

2.6 Other clausal negation constructions

In Amri Karbi, negation can be also achieved by derivational means. There is at least one predicate derivation *-kel* that yields a negative meaning without the verbal negative suffix. Example (43) shows the verb *arju* ‘hear’ marked with the predicate derivation *-kel* that gives meaning that the action denoted by the verb did not happen. In the example (44) *-kel* occurs with the verb *-hlong* ‘get’. The negative predicate derivation *-kel* is not a productive suffix and occurs mainly with the verbs that denote senses and perceptions.

- (43) Anangaipeke arjukelbakngo sal katiki along.
 anang-ai-pe=ke arju-kel-bak-lo sal ki-tiki a-long
 3-mother-F=TOP hear-NEG.DRV-INDF-R work NMLZ-work POSS-LOC
 ‘Its (baby’s) mother did not hear because of hard work.’ (natural data)
- (44) Arlengpo angsong para wangkisun ayokke bachik isi hlongkelo.
 arleng-po angsong para wang-ki-sun a-yok=ke
 man-DEF underneath para come-NMLZ-come.down POSS-NSUBJ=TOP
 bachik isi hlong-kel-lo
 basket one get-NEG.DRV-R
 ‘When the man came down from the tree (up to where the basket was) and did not get one basket (i.e. ‘one basket got missing’).’ (natural data)

3 Non-clausal negation

3.1 Negative and positive replies

The positive answer to a nominal predicate question is *oik* ‘yes’. The positive answer to a verbal predicate question can either be *oik* ‘yes’ or the verb itself, i.e. the verb is echoed in the answer, e.g. (45) or both *oik* ‘yes’ or the echoed verb. More research is needed to understand the reasons for this variation. Social and

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pragmatic factors, such as the need for clarity, politeness, or emphasis in conversation, may influence the choice of a positive answer in some languages (see [Enfield et al. 2019](#)). The negative answer to a question always corresponds to the type of predication being used in the question. When a predicate in the question is a verb, the negative existentials *ingyong* or *we* are used; with stative questions, the negative equational *kalek* is used. This finding aligns with [Veselinova's](#) (2013b) observation that languages employ specific negative existentials, such as *ingyong* or *we*, for verbal predicates, while using forms like *kalek* to negate stative predicates. [Veselinova's](#) research illustrates how these constructions serve as effective standalone answers, relying on contextual clues to convey their full meaning. This approach underscores the importance of predicate-specific negation for clarity and precision, a pattern also evident in the Amri Karbi language. The predicate in the question can also be negated with the standard negation verbal suffix *-Ce* (46). Positive and negative answers to questions are asymmetrical in a way that there are two negatives used in the answers depending on the type of predicate, and there is only one positive *oik* 'yes' for all predicate types. Besides, in the answers with the echoed verb, the TAM distinction is preserved in the positive replies and is not preserved in the negative replies.

- (45) A: Anangke nangai ma?
 anang=ke nang-ai ma
 3=TOP 2-mother Q
 'Is she your mother?'

B: Oik.
 oik
 yes
 'Yes.' (elicited)

- (46) Q: Hik inguman ma?
 hik ingu-man ma
 dog bark-HAB Q
 'Does a dog bark?'

A: Oik./Inguman.
 oik/ingu-man
 yes/bark-HAB
 'Yes, (it) barks.' (elicited)

- (47) Q: Anangke nangai ma?

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anang=ke nang-ai ma
 3=TOP 2-mother Q
 'Is she your mother?'

A: Kalek.
 kalek
 NEG.EQ
 'No.' (elicited)

(48) Q: Hik inguman ma?
 hik ingu-man ma
 dog bark-HAB Q
 'Does the dog bark?'

A: Ingyong./We./Inguge.
 ingyong/we/ingu-Ce
 NEGEX/NEGEX/bark-NEG
 'No, does not bark.' (elicited)

Negative and positive replies to negative questions are similar to replies to positive questions and a negated predicate is usually repeated, e.g. (49–52).

(49) Q: Anangke nangai kalek ma?
 anang=ke nang-ai kalek ma
 3=TOP 2-mother NEG.EQ Q
 'Isn't she your mother?'

A: Oik.
 oik
 yes
 'Yes.' (elicited)

(50) Q: Hik inguge ma?
 hik ingu-Ce ma
 dog bark-NEG Q
 'Doesn't the dog bark?'

A: Oik./Inguman.
 oik/ingu-man
 yes/bark-HAB
 'Yes/it barks.' (elicited)

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- (51) Q: Anangke nangai kalek ma?
anang=ke nang-ai kalek ma
3=TOP 2-mother NEG.EQ Q
'Isn't she your mother?'
A: Kalek.
kalek
NEG.EQ
'No.' (elicited)
- (52) Q: Hik inguge ma?
hik ingu-Ce ma
dog bark-NEG Q
'Is the dog barking?'
A: Ingyong./We./Inguge.
ingyong/we/ingu-Ce
NEGEX/NEGEX/bark-NEG
'No, not barking.' (elicited)

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

Amri Karbi has three negative indefinites, listed in Table 3 along with the corresponding affirmatives. Out of the three, only *kaita* 'anybody/nobody' occurs in both positive and negative clauses, other indefinites, *iku* 'nothing' and *jat* 'never', occur only in negative clauses. The pronoun *kaita* 'nobody' is the only one that is constructed with the interrogative pronoun *kai* 'who', which is attached with the additive suffix =*ta* to form a universal (or non-specific) pronoun 'anybody'. The other pronouns *iku* 'nothing' and *jat* 'never' have Assamese origin. The pronoun *jat* 'never' may occur with the additive =*ta* sometimes. The pronoun *iku* can cooccur with the negative existential *ingyong*. Negative pronouns are used together with clausal negation, e.g. (53–55).

Table 3: Indefinites and quantifiers

	Negative	Affirmative
Person	<i>kaita</i> 'anybody' / 'nobody'	<i>kaibak/inghonebak</i> 'somebody'
Thing	<i>iku(si)/eku(si)/eko(si)</i> 'nothing'	<i>penebak</i> 'something'
Time	<i>jat/jatsi/jatta</i> 'never'	<i>daknebak/kanebak</i> 'sometime'

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- (53) Kaita thektheto kaita ingyong holek.
 kai=ta thek-Ce-to kai=ta ingyong holek
 who=ADD see-NEG-EMPH who=ADD NEGEX here
 ‘Nobody will see, nobody is here.’ (elicited)
- (54) Ikusi tikikelangta.
 iku=si tiki-Ce-lang=ta
 nothing=FOC:R work-NEG-yet=ADD
 ‘Nothing has been done yet.’ (Mrs & Mrs gathering)
- (55) Israyel adak labadi jatsi thekhlonghleyong.
 israyel a-dak labadi jatsi thék-hlong-Ce-ingyong
 PN:Israel POSS-among like.this never see-get-NEG-NEGEX
 ‘It was never so seen in Israel.’⁶ (NT)

3.3 Negative derivation

There is no dedicated strategy to express the caritive in Amri Karbi. Meanings of ‘without’ / ‘-less’ / ‘un-’ on nouns are expressed with the negative existentials *we* or *kangwe* ‘not.exist’ that follow a noun, e.g. *lang (kang)we* (water NEGEX/not.exist) ‘waterless’ or literally ‘no water’, *perik (kang)we* (clothe NEGEX/not.exist) ‘naked, unclothed’ or literally ‘no clothes’. These nouns can modify other nouns e.g. (56).

On deverbal adjectives that are nominalized, meanings of ‘without’ / ‘-less’ / ‘un-’ are expressed with the negative suffix *-Ce* on a verb, e.g. *ki-krol-kre* NMLZ-believe-NEG ‘faithless’, literally ‘not believing’. These deverbal adjectives also modify nouns, e.g. (57). There is no other way of constructing a caritive from deverbal adjectives, so meanings like ‘unfaithful’ will have a similar form to ‘faithless’, i.e. *kikrolkre*. However, since deverbal adjectives are verbs, they can extend their meaning with the help of predicate derivational suffixes and, depending on the context, can express different meanings of the caritive by the same negative verbal suffix *-Ce* attaching to a predicate derivation suffix. For example, if a modal predicate derivation suffix attaches to a deverbal negative adjective or a caritive, it means ‘the lack of ability’, e.g. *ki-krol-un-e* ‘NMLZ-believe-be.able-NEG’ ‘unfaithful’ / ‘faithless’, literally ‘not being able to believe’.

- (56) Lang kangwe athem.
 lang kangwe a-them
 water nothing POSS-place
 ‘waterless region/place’ (NT)

⁶The construction *jatsi* verb-NEG-NEGEX is found to be used only in the realis mood.

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- (57) Kikrolkre arleng.
 ki-krol-Ce arleng
 NMLZ-believe-NEG man
 ‘unfaithful/faithless man’ (NT)

4 Other aspects of negation

4.1 The scope of negation

Amri Karbi has a large class of semantically rich predicate derivation suffixes that attach to the right of the verbal root in slot 5 of the verbal template. This type of suffix is found in other Tibeto-Burman/Trans-Himalayan languages and has been labeled in a variety of ways (see [Post 2010](#)). I follow [Post \(2010\)](#) in choosing the term *predicate derivation suffixes*. There are about fifty-four predicate derivation suffixes found so far; these can be divided according to their subsequent functions: manner, result, direction, argument structure emphasis, aspect/aktionsart and others. When a verb with a predicate derivation suffix is negated, the negation has scope over either the predicate derivation, e.g. (58), or over the entire predicate, as in, e.g. (59) *thekdunde* ‘I did not know’. Each predicate derivation allows only two options for scope of negation, i.e. either only on the predicate derivation or over the entire verb.

- (58) Borketke.
 bor-ket-Ce
 wrap-tight-NEG
 ‘Wrap but not tightly.’ (elicited)
- (59) potpotbadi chiporhelone ingyongne neke thekdunde potsi chininelo.
 ...pot~pot-badi chi-porhe-lo=ne ingyong=ne ne=ke thek-dun-Ce
 what~what-as RR-learn-R=INDF NEGEX=INDF 1=TOP know-follow-NEG
 potsi chini-Ce-lo
 reason know-NEG-R
 ‘I did not know whether they studied or not, because I do not know (I am uneducated).’ (natural data)

4.2 Negative polarity

Besides the negative polarity items listed in §3.2 there are three more negative polarity items that can be marked on the verb. The first one is the modal predicate derivation suffix *-nang* that occurs only in the negation discussed in §2.2.2.

The second item is the aspect *-lang* ‘yet’ that indicates that something has not happened yet. This aspect occurs only with standard negation, e.g. (39). The third negative polarity item is the subordinator *=lengke* ‘until’, which was discussed in §2.4.

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

It was observed in §2.3.3 that negative existential clauses cannot have unidentifiable subjects and the forms of negative possessive and existential clauses appear to be identical with inalienable subjects.

4.4 Reinforcing negation

Negation can be reinforced with the conjunction *tene* ‘then’. The conjunction *tene* is usually used with conditional clauses in the consequence part. Example (60) contains an equative clause, where the predicate is a nominalized verb *kasuru* ‘crying’ and *tene* is used to reinforce negation and occurs after the negative equational *kalek*.

- (60) Kasuru kalek tene khoi.
 ki-suru kalek tene khoi
 NMLZ-cry NEG.EQ then friend
 ‘This is not crying, friend.’ (natural data)

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

Subordination is usually marked by the nominalizer *ki-* or the non-final suffix *-si*. Complex clauses that have a positive subordinate clause and a negative main clause involve either the additive clitic *=ta* or the topic clitic *=ke* (depending on the intended meaning), marking a subordinate verb instead of the usual nominalization or non-final verb strategy. There is no dedicated coordinator for negative independent clauses which are coordinated by juxtaposition.

Subordinate clauses that can be translated as ‘even though’ are constructed by the additive *=ta*, when *=ta* marks a positive subordinate clause that is followed by a negative clause e.g. (61).

- (61) Aro khoi puta pasiselo.
 aro khoi pu=**ta** pasi-Ce-lo
 and friend say=ADD reply-NEG-R
 ‘Even though, he called him ‘friend!’ he did not reply.’ (natural data)

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The topic =*ke* marks the quotative *pu* instead of the usual non-final suffix -*si* when the quotative *pu* cooccurs with the negation, e.g. (62).

- (62) Manta alang neyok sunnot puke nepupeyong.
 manta alang ne=yok sun-not pu=**ke** ne=pu-Ce-ingyong
 but 3 1=NSUBJ get.out-IMP say=TOP 1=say-NEG-NEGEX
 ‘But he didn’t say to me get out.’ (natural data)

Two or more negative independent clauses are coordinated by juxtaposition. Example (63) shows three independent clauses appearing next to each without any conjunction.

- (63) Atomo asarpe himepe ahem kangwe aret kangwe salkam katiki kaita kangwe.
 a-tomo a-sar-pe hime-pe a-hem kangwe a-ret
 POSS-story POSS-be.old-F widow-F POSS-house not.exist POSS-field
 kangwe salkam ki-tiki kaita kangwe
 not.exist work-work NMLZ-work nobody not.exist
 ‘Long time ago there was a widow, she had no home, no field, nobody to work (with her).’ (natural data)

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

This section deals with miscellaneous aspects of negation. Negative transport (neg-raising), which is when a higher-clause negative is interpreted as negating a lower-clause predicate, does not occur in Amri Karbi.

Metalinguistic negation has not been found in the current Amri Karbi database. Since this type of negation is difficult to elicit, more natural data are needed in order to learn how metalinguistic negation is expressed in Amri Karbi.

Contrastive negation occurs several times in the database and is exemplified in (64). Example (64) shows that the first clause objects the previous utterance, it is negated and the second clause that conveys the correct information follows right after it. The objecting element of the proposition is the O argument of the verb *ap* ‘shoot’, which is marked with topic =*ke* in the objection part and the focus =*si* in the correction part of the proposition.

- (64) We arleng ayokke chiap’e tike ayoksi apmeta.
we arleng a-yok=ke chi-ap-Ce tike a-yok=si
NEGEX man POSS-NSUBJ=TOP RR-shoot-NEG tiger POSS-NSUBJ=FOC
ap-ye=ta
shoot-FUT=ADD
(‘(We) do not shoot people, (we) will shoot tiger only.’ (natural data))

Non-negative uses of negatives and expletive negation have not been attested in Amri Karbi.

5 Conclusion

The negative strategies in Amri Karbi are summarized in Table 4.

Table 4: Summary of the negation strategies in Amri Karbi

Negative markers	Functions
-Ce	general verbal negation suffix: habitual, potential, future, past
PST-V-Ce	past
-Ce-lo	‘no more’
-Ce-bang	‘not now, but after some time’
-nang-Ce	‘should not’
-Ce-lengke	‘not until’
-Ce-lang	‘not yet’
-Ce-te	negative question particle
- Ce-yong	realis negation
- Ce-yong-lo	realis negation
ingyong	existential, locative
we	existential, locative
ingyong-lo	existential ‘no more’
ingyong	possessive
kangwe	possessive
kalek	equational
-yek	prohibitive
-kel	negation of verbs with meaning of sense and perception

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The negative suffix *-Ce* can occur as the only verbal operator, and the stem with the negative suffix can function as a general negative verb form for most TAM. The exception is the realis *-lo*, which requires the reduced negative existential *-yong* to form its negative. Besides, the realis *-lo* may have future meaning in the negative. The habitual *-man* is different from other forms in a way that it has only one negative form option, which is a basic V-NEG form. As a summary, Table 5 provides an overview of the main negative forms with the verb *dam* ‘go’ that has the negative duplifix *-de*.

Table 5: Affirmative and negative paradigm

Affirmative	Negative	Functions
<i>dam-bo</i> ‘will go’	<i>dam-de-lo</i> ‘will go no more’ <i>dam-de</i> ‘not going’	Potential <i>-bo</i>
<i>dame dam-ye</i> ‘will go’	<i>dam-de-ye</i> ‘will not go’ (cooccurrence with conditional clauses) <i>dam-de</i> ‘will not go’	Future <i>-ye</i>
<i>dam-bang</i> ‘going/will go’	<i>dam-de</i> ‘not going’ <i>dam-de-bang</i> ‘not going now, but will go after some time’	Irrealis <i>-bang</i>
<i>dam-lo</i>	<i>dam-de-yong</i> <i>dam-de-yong-o</i> <i>dam-de-lo</i> ‘future sense’	Realis <i>-lo</i>
<i>dam-man</i>	<i>dam-de</i>	Habitual <i>-man</i>
<i>ki-dam</i>	<i>ki-dam-de</i> <i>dam-de</i> <i>dam-de-yong</i>	Past <i>ki-</i>
<i>lag(e)</i> <i>un</i>	<i>nang-ne</i> <i>un-e</i>	Modal <i>nang</i> ‘want, should’; <i>un</i> ‘be.able’
<i>do</i>	<i>ingyong</i> <i>ingyongo</i> ‘no more’ <i>we</i>	Existential
Ø	<i>kalek</i> <i>kaleyong</i>	Equation
<i>cho-not</i>	<i>cho-nek</i>	Command

The negative form of an imperative has a dedicated construction, the prohibitive suffix *-yek*. The prohibitive suffix *-yek* is used for all types of imperatives, as a result the negative of imperative does not distinguish between formal

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vs. informal forms. The modal suffix *-lag*, which is a borrowing, does not occur in the negative, and the older form *-nang* is used in the negative instead. In the negative polar questions, the verb has the negative suffix *-Ce* and the question particle is *=ma* as is in the positive polar questions. However, negative questions that involve the negative existential *ingyong* use the question particle *=te* instead of *=ma*. Equations are negated with the negative equative *kalek* that does not inflect for tense. Other stative predicates - existential, possessive and locative are negated with the negative existential *ingyong* and *we* for existential clauses, *ingyong* and *kangwe* for possessive clauses and *ingyong* and *we* for locative clauses. The negative existential *ingyong* and *we* may inflect for TAM.

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Abbreviations

1	first person	IMP	imperative
2	second person	INCL	inclusive
3	third person	INDF	indefinite
ADD	additive	INTERACT	interactive
ASSUM	assumption	IRR	irrealis
AUG	augmentative	LOC	locative
AUTO	autobenefactive	M	masculine
BEN	benefactive	MAL	malefactive
CAUS	causative	NEG	negation
CIS	cislocative	NFNL	non-final
CLF	classifier	NMLZ	nominalizer
CONF	confirmation	NSUBJ	non-subject
COP	copula	NT	new testament
DECL	declarative	PL	plural
DEF	definite	POL	polite
DEM	demonstrative	POT	potential
DIM	diminutive	PRED.DERIV	predicate derivation
DIR	directive	PROH	prohibitive
DIST	distal demonstrative	PST	past
EE	elaborate expression	Q	question
EMPH	emphatic	QUOT	quotative
EQ	equative, equational	RED	reduplication
EX	existential	REP	reportative
EXCL	exclusive	REPL	reply
F	feminine	R	realis
FOC	focus	RR	reflexive-reciprocal
FUT	future	SG	singular
GNR	generic	SUPP	supposition
HORT	hortative	TAG	tag question
		VB	verb

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Chapter 10

Negation in Geshiza

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This chapter offers a typologically and functionally motivated description of negation in Geshiza, a Horpa language of the Trans-Himalayan (Sino-Tibetan) language family. Geshiza has a wide range of negative morphology and negative constructions, including four distinct negator prefixes and two dedicated negative verbs. Morphologically negation in Geshiza belongs to the realm of verbs, contrasting with nouns and adjectives that lack dedicated means for being negated category-internally. The large inventory of negative morphology and particular constructions, e.g. the linking of negation and controllability, make negation in Geshiza a topic of interest to typologists. At the same time, the conservative negative morphology of Geshiza contributes towards understanding the history of negation in the Trans-Himalayan language family.

Keywords: negation, Geshiza, Horpa, Gyalrongic, languages of China.

1 On Geshiza

Geshiza (Glottocode: [gesh1238](#)) is a Horpa language of the Gyalrongic branch of the Trans-Himalayan/Sino-Tibetan language family (see [Sun 2000a,b](#) for establishing Gyalrongic as a sub-branch of the language family). Geshiza remains understudied, the language being spoken in Danba County of Sichuan Province in the People's Republic of China. In the Horpa language cluster, Geshiza belongs to the Central Horpa branch ([Sun 2019](#)), which makes it closely related to Stau, another partially documented Horpa lect. The language has approximately 8000 speakers who are officially classified as Tibetan by the Chinese State and also self-identify with the label. The Geshiza are predominantly agriculturalists

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who inhabit a mountain valley with prominent altitudinal differences. The geographical features of the homeland are encoded in the Geshiza language, most prominently in the form of “orientational” prefixes in the verbal system.

Geshiza is one of the two main Horpa varieties spoken in Geshiza valley, the other one being Dandong. The two form a dialect continuum with a high degree of mutual comprehensibility. This chapter uses Geshiza as a shorthand for Eastern Geshiza (Glottocode: [east2851](#)) spoken in Balang (Ge. *bāra*) Village at the proximity of Danba County Town. Consequently, it is worth noting that not everything discussed herein necessarily applies to all Geshiza dialects.

When examined against the [UNESCO \(2003\)](#) criteria, Geshiza appears endangered. This change, however, has taken place only recently, at least in its more dramatic forms. The endangerment of Geshiza reflects an ongoing widespread loss of languages in China that is especially happening in the Tibetosphere ([Roche 2017](#): 24). As a result of extensive ongoing language contact with Chinese, Geshiza speakers are increasingly shifting into Mandarin Chinese, a change that is most prominently seen among the young and children. While Sichuanese Mandarin is gaining ground, the use of Standard Mandarin is also expanding due to education and media. In contrast, the Geshiza generally lack knowledge of any Tibetic languages in spoken or written form, even though Tibetic languages, such as a Kham lect known as the “Twenty-four villages’ patois,” are spoken in the immediate neighborhood of the Geshiza homeland.

Grammatically Geshiza exhibits many features known from earlier work on Gyalrongic and more broadly, Qiangic languages, a proposed branch of Trans-Himalayan (see [Chirkova 2012](#) for a critique on Qiangic as a valid genealogical unit). Geshiza has an extensive phoneme inventory comprising 8 full vowel phonemes and 37 full consonant phonemes, but tone plays no distinctive function in the language. While the morphology of nouns and other related word classes relies primarily on enclitics, Geshiza verbs show extensive morphological operations by means of affixation, stem modification, reduplication, and suppletion.

[Honkasalo \(2019\)](#) is a culturally anchored descriptive grammar aiming at sketching Geshiza’s main grammatical features. The present work builds on this grammar, the only work of previous research that extensively discusses negation in a Horpa language. Negation is also briefly mentioned in [Duo’erji \(1998\)](#), a grammatical sketch of Eastern Geshiza written in Chinese. The description and analysis offered here is based on the author’s *in situ* fieldwork among the Geshiza. The source materials include recorded texts from various speech genres, supplemented by monolingual elicitation and overheard examples. The monolingual fieldwork strategies include grammaticality judgements and asking Geshiza speakers to generate examples with selected words and expressions.

From the viewpoint of negation, Geshiza is of interest due to its multitude of negative constructions and rich negative morphology. Also, since the negative morphology is generally conservative, it also contributes towards understanding the history of the Trans-Himalayan language family.

2 Clausal negation

This section discusses clausal negation in Geshiza. Six primary means for clausal negation exist in the language. The inventory includes four negative suffixes and two dedicated negative verbs: the negative copula *m̥pa* ~ *m̥ja* and the negative existential verb *ma*.

2.1 Standard negation

2.1.1 General principles of standard negation

Standard negation, namely the general and productive way(s) of negating verbal declarative main clauses (Miestamo 2005, Payne 1985) is expressed by two verbal prefixes in Geshiza: *mi-* and *m̥-*. Standard negation is paradigmatically symmetric in the language, since all grammatical categories, including evidentiality, also occur in negative contexts.

When both a main verb and an auxiliary verb are present, the negators adjoin the main verb if the auxiliary is bound, and the auxiliary if the auxiliary is independent. To illustrate, with the bound causative auxiliary *-p^hə*, the main verb hosts the negator, as in the example pair (1) and (2). It should be noted that the examples include modal discourse enclitics, also known as “(sentence-)final particles” in the literature, conveying the speaker’s attitude, emotional state, and certainty (see Honkasalo 2019: 574–579 for an overview). Further research is needed to analyze the ways in which the ubiquitous modal discourse enclitics interact with polarity in Geshiza.

- (1) *v̥za=t^hə~t^hə* *jində* *spa-p^hə-ræ=mə*.
warm.season=TOP-RED strongly be.thirsty-CAUS.AUX.NPST.3-SENS=MOD
‘One feels very thirsty in the warm season.’ (elicited)
- (2) *rtso=nə* *mi-spa-p^hə-ræ=je*.
cold.season=TOP.CNTR NEG-be.thirsty-CAUS.AUX.NPST.3-SENS=MOD
‘One does not feel very thirsty in the cold season.’ (elicited)

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In turn, the experiential perfect is a complex aspect formed with a self-standing auxiliary *zda* ‘to have done something’ and a main verb in the perfective aspect, as in (3). The negator attaches to the independent auxiliary when the perfective aspect is negated, as in (4).

- (3) *sop^ho æ-li dæ-ç^hoŋ zda.*
 TOPN one-CLF.time PFV-go.PST.1 AUX.EXP.PERF
 ‘I have been to Suopo once.’ (personal history)
- (4) *sop^ho dæ-ç^hoŋ mi-zda.*
 TOPN PFV-go.PST.1 NEG-AUX.EXP.PERF
 ‘I haven’t been to Suopo.’ (accepted during elicitation; see 3)’

2.1.2 Distribution of the negators in standard negation

To understand the distributional properties of *mi-* and *mε-*, it is helpful to briefly investigate negation in Gyalrongic languages and the tense-aspect system of Geshiza. In East Gyalrongic (also known as Core Gyalrongic) languages, the selection of a standard negator is usually aspectually determined. For instance, [Prins \(2011: 529\)](#) interprets the difference of the negators *ma-* and *ji-* in Jiaomuzu Gyalrong in terms of aspectual contrast in which the former is used for the imperfective and the latter for the perfective aspect. Also, in a recent description of Luhuo Stau, a Horpa language related to Geshiza, [Tunzhi \(2019: 381–385\)](#) argues that the difference between the negators *ma=* and *mi=* is generally determined on the basis of tense, *ma=* appearing in past and *mi=* in non-past constructions. Such aspect and tense based systems are typologically common and widely attested.

The distribution of *mi-* and *mε-* is also aspectually determined, although the distributive conditions differ from other previous descriptions of Gyalrongic languages. The language has three prefixally expressed primary aspects: perfective (*dæ-*), imperfective (*gæ-*), and prospective (*zə-*): *dæ-ŋgu* ‘I ate’, *gæ-ŋgu* ‘I was eating’, *zə-ŋgu* ‘I am about to eat’. In the whole aspectual repertoire, the primary aspects appear most frequently. They are morphologically non-compositional and set the frame for the structurally more complex secondary aspects. Geshiza also has a “binary tense system” ([Comrie 1985: 48–49](#)) comprising the past and non-past tenses expressed through aspiration alternation in the consonants of the verb stem. It should be noted that since not all consonants participate in aspiration alternation, many verbs with no tense distinctions exist in Geshiza. As shown in Table 1, aspect and tense are strongly linked in the language, allowing

no free variation. For instance, the perfective aspect always co-occurs with the past tense. The imperfective aspect also always occurs with the past tense, but as some of the following examples show, its use is not strictly limited to a past time frame. Such scenarios are nevertheless formally marked as being in the past tense.

Table 1: Distribution of standard negation prefixes in Geshiza

Negative prefix	Aspect	Tense
<i>mi-</i>	aspectually neutral	non-past
<i>mε-</i>	prospective	non-past
<i>mε-</i>	imperfective	past
<i>mε-</i>	perfective	past

As Table 1 illustrates, the distribution of the two negators is explainable as follows. The negator *mi-* adjoins predicates that lack primary aspect marking and may thus be considered aspectually neutral. In contrast, the negator *mε-* appears in aspectually marked contexts where one of the primary aspect prefixes is present. Alternative explanations, e.g. in terms of tense, fail to explain the distribution of the negators. Examples (5-8) illustrate the distribution of negators in aspectually unmarked and prospective contexts. In terms of frequency, negated prospective predicates occur only rarely in Geshiza, contrasting with the relatively common negated imperfective and perfective predicates. Examples of standard negation with the imperfective aspects are offered in (9) and (10). The perfective aspect presenting a structural asymmetry is discussed subsequently.

No aspectual marking:

- (5) t^hævære lɣa=ɲə braŋgu dʒi-ræ.
recently child=PL TOPN EXVB.3-SENS
'Recently, (our) children are (living) in Danba County Town.'
(conversation)
- (6) t^hævære lɣa=ɲə braŋgu mi-dʒi-ræ.
recently child=PL TOPN NEG-EXVB.3-SENS
'Recently, (our) children are not (living) in Danba County Town.'
(accepted during elicitation; see 5)

Prospective aspect:

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- (7) t^hævæ=t^hə zə-st^hoŋ=bɔ.
 now=TOP PROSP-finish.NPST.1PL=MOD
 ‘We are about to get finished now.’ (accepted during elicitation; see 8)
- (8) t^hævæ=t^hə zə-mɛ-st^hoŋ=bɔ.
 now=TOP PROSP-ASP.NEG-finish.NPST.1PL=MOD
 ‘We are not about to get finished now.’ (chronicle)

Imperfective aspect:

- (9) t^hævæ=t^hə~t^hə leska=be skəu gæ-rk^ha.
 now=TOP~RED work=too more IPFV-be.hard.PST
 ‘Now, work too is more tiring (than it used to be).’ (accepted during elicitation; see 10)
- (10) t^hævæ=t^hə~t^hə leska=be skəu gæ-mɛ-rk^ha.
 now=TOP~RED work=too more IPFV-ASP.NEG-be.hard.PST
 ‘Now, work too is less tiring (than it used to be).’ (lit. ‘Now, work too is being more non-hard.’) (local history)

2.1.3 Standard negation and symmetry

Negation in Geshiza largely maintains structural symmetry. In other words, the affirmative and the corresponding negative constructions are identical, save the presence of a negator in the latter. This can be seen in examples (11–12) with the imperfective aspect (see also the previous examples above).

- (11) bəvi skɛ gæ-tɕoŋ-s^hə=mde.
 this.year more IPFV-can.PST.1-INFR=MOD
 ‘This year I have been earning more than usual.’ (lit. ‘This year I have been more able.’) (accepted during elicitation; see 12)
- (12) bəvi skɛ gæ-mɛ-tɕoŋ-s^hə=mde.
 this.year more IPFV-ASP.NEG-can.PST.1-INFR=MOD
 ‘This year I have been earning less than usual.’ (lit. ‘This year I have been less able.’) (conversation)

The perfective aspect, however, is exceptional, since asymmetry commonly occurs in this context. The perfective aspect always requires prefixal marking.

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The standard perfective marker *dæ-* is incompatible with the negator *mɛ-*. Consequently, it is deleted in this context, which results in structural asymmetry. In (13), the speaker negates *dæ-v-ɕa* ‘he took’ as *mɛ-v-ɕa* ‘he did not take’, the symmetrical form **dæ-mɛ-v-ɕa* being ungrammatical:

- (13) tɕ^hu æqɛ=ræ wnæ-sq^ha, wnæ-sq^ha-wtɕ^həu ŋuə-ræ. <ləupər>
 so all=LNK two-ten two-ten-six COP.3-SENS shopkeeper
 lməu=t^hə wnæ-sq^ha-wzæ=zɔ dæ-v-ɕa. s^ho k^hrə wne
 3.ERG=TOP two-ten-four=only PFV-INV-take.PST.3 more yuan two
 mɛ-v-ɕa.
 ASP.NEG-INV-take.PST.3.
 ‘(The bill) was 26 yuan. The shopkeeper took only 24 yuan. He did not
 take the two yuan.’ (chronicle)’

As the previous examples have shown, the other two aspects compatible with *mɛ-*, namely the imperfective and prospective, always retain overt aspectual marking in negation. Therefore, the sole appearance of *mɛ-* must always be interpreted as negation of the perfective aspect, not as a neutralization of aspectual distinctions in this context. The reasons behind the phenomenon remain unknown. In the closely related Stau language, perfective negation is achieved symmetrically.

Importantly, in contrast to the default perfective prefix *dæ-*, no asymmetries arise in negation when the perfective aspect is expressed by secondary markers of perfectivity. In addition to the directionally neutral perfective prefix *dæ-*, prefixes with orientational value, such as *rə-* ‘upwards, away from the river’ have a secondary function of marking perfectivity. However, no asymmetry in negations of such instances takes place, as seen in (14) and (15).

- (14) xaræ grə=nɔ rə-v-læ-s^hi ŋuə-mə-ræ.
 CONJ boat=LOC PFV.DIR-INV-let.3-NMLZ COP.3-EP-SENS
 ‘But (the boatman) took them in.’ (accepted during elicitation; see 15)
- (15) xaræ grə=nɔ rə-mɛ-v-læ-s^hi ŋuə-mə-ræ.
 CONJ boat=LOC PFV.DIR-ASP.NEG-INV-let.3-NMLZ COP.3-EP-SENS
 ‘But (the boatman) did not take them in.’ (mythical local history)

2.1.4 Controllability and deviation from standard negation

In aspectually neutral negation, a negator *mə-* surfaces in 18 identified cases where *mi-* would be expected (see Table 2 for a list).¹ In the context of *mε-*, the set of these 18 verbs behaves regularly. As shown in the pair (16) and (17), the aspectually neutral negation of the verb *v-se* ‘to know’ always takes the form *mə-*, *mi-* being ungrammatical.

Table 2: List of verbs negated with the negator *mə-*

Modal verbs	Other verbs of low controllability
<i>mə-grə</i> ‘to not be able’	<i>dzo</i> ‘to fit in’
<i>mpə</i> ‘to be able’	<i>dzo</i> ‘to bear, able to put up with’
<i>ŋi</i> ‘to be fine, all right’	<i>mə-k^{he}</i> ‘to envy’
<i>sko</i> ‘to manage, be able’	<i>mnæ</i> ‘to (be able) to reach’
<i>snə</i> ‘to dare’	<i>v-ri</i> ‘to find’
<i>tɕ^ha</i> ‘to be able’	<i>v-se</i> ‘to know’
<i>vɕe</i> ‘to need, have to’	<i>st^hæ</i> ‘to finish’
<i>mə-ske</i> ‘should not’	<i>tɕɔ</i> ‘to feel comfortable’
Opportunistic perception verbs	
<i>nt^hje</i> ‘to hear’	
<i>vdo</i> ‘to see’	

- (16) *dæ-lmu-s^{hi}* *tɕ^hu æqe mə-səu=mɔ.*
PFV-forget.1SG-INFR so all MOD.NEG-know.NPST.1SG=MOD
‘I have forgotten, so I don’t know all of it.’ (conversation)
- (17) * *dæ-lmu-s^{hi}* *tɕ^hu æqe mi-səu=mɔ.*
PFV-forget.1SG-INFR so all NEG-know.NPST.1SG=MOD
Intended meaning: ‘I have forgotten, so I don’t know all of it.’ (rejected during elicitation)

Since the distribution of *mə-* cannot be explained as an automatic phonological process, the subset of 18 verbs requires explaining.

¹In the table, verbs that are included with the negator *mə-* attached can only occur in a negative form while the rest can be used both with or without the negative prefix.

The negator occurs together with modal verbs (*snə* ‘to dare’, *tɕʰa* ‘to be able’), OPPORTUNISTIC PERCEPTION VERBS (*ntʰje* ‘to hear’, *vdo* ‘to see’; see [Honkasalo 2019](#): 647 for details), and several other verbs (*v-se* ‘to know’, *tɕə* ‘to be, feel comfortable’). This distribution is hardly accidental. Rather, all three groups denote low level of control by the subject. Consequently, *mə-* appears as a negator of modal verbs and several verbs of uncontrollable action. As a shorthand it is glossed as MOD.NEG ‘negator of modal verbs’ here. Previous studies on Trans-Himalayan languages, such as [Sandman \(2016\)](#) on Wutun, have shown that controllability is sometimes embedded into the grammatical systems of these languages. In a similar fashion, Geshiza negation reflects this as well. The existing forms may be remnants of a more productive historical pattern that has largely disappeared from the language.

A formally and functionally identical cognate of *mə-* may also exist in some dialects of the closely related Stau language, although vowel harmony that operates in the language and thus alters the surface level realizations of vowels presents some challenges for confirming this (personal fieldwork on the Poxiu dialect, possibly 15 identified cases of verbs negated with *mə-*). The sets of verbs using *mə-* in both languages largely overlap. In addition, a cognate is attested in the extinct Tangut language where [Jacques \(2011\)](#) reports *mji*¹ ‘negation of modal verbs’ formally resembling *mji*¹ with the function of ‘basic negation’. East Gyalrongic languages, however, lack a corresponding phenomenon. The modal negator consequently constitutes another feature highlighting the closeness of Tangut to West Gyalrongic languages, an ongoing topic of Gyalrongic research.

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

Negation of non-declaratives in Geshiza is determined by the reality status of the underlying mood. Reality status is coded in the language’s grammar where two main categories, namely irrealis and realis moods, are identified. Except for the imperative that uses the same prefixes as the indicative, individual moods are in turn marked by vowel prefixes that fuse with the multifunctional “directional” prefixes of verbs. Realis moods consist of indicative, non-actual realis, and interrogative. Non-actual realis is a term for a Geshiza realis mood referring to habitual action or planned non-initiated action in the future (see [Honkasalo 2019](#): 563–564 for more). In turn, imperative and optative are classified under irrealis. The irrealis moods have a dedicated structure different from standard negation.

Like many languages of the region, Geshiza general imperatives use a multifunctional verbal prefix that marks orientation, aspect, and mood, as illustrated

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in (18). Prohibitives (i.e., negative imperatives) cannot be formed with the standard negation strategy, as illustrated in the pair (19) and (20). Instead, the construction requires the irrealis negator *di-* ~ *dzi-* that occurs paradigmatically in the same slot with the other negators in the Geshiza verbal template. Note that as illustrated in the examples, the preferred prefix in general imperatives and prohibitives may also differ, a topic that needs further research.

- (18) dʒa wə-t^{hi}.
tea IMP-drink.NPST.2SG
'Have some tea!' (addressing the author)
- (19) ɕ^hældæn noŋ tɕ^hæra mi-ndzə. dæ-di-t^{hi}.
bottle inside thing NEG-EXVB.3 IMP-IRR.NEG-drink.NPST.2SG
'There is nothing inside the bottle. Don't drink from it!' (overheard)
- (20) *ɕ^hældæn noŋ tɕ^hæra mi-ndzə. dæ-mi-t^{hi}.
bottle inside thing NEG-EXVB.3 IMP-NEG-drink.NPST.2SG
Intended meaning: 'There is nothing inside the bottle. Don't drink from it!' (rejected during elicitation; see 19)

From a formal viewpoint, the prohibitive exhibits lack of parallelism vis-à-vis the other negative prefixes. Unlike all other negative prefixes that share the initial *m* and vary in their vowels, the irrealis negator has a different initial and maintains the vowel *i* constantly. Seen from a semantic perspective, the prohibitive is generally restricted to negate actions and processes that can be controlled by a sentient being capable of changing its behavior. Consequently, stative verbs, such as *nəu* 'to be deep' and *p^hru* 'to be white', are usually not negated with the prohibitive.

Finally, examined against the typology of [van der Auwera & Lejeune \(with Valentin Goussev\) \(2013\)](#), Geshiza belongs to type 2, namely "the verbal construction of the second singular imperative and a sentential negative strategy not found in (indicative) declaratives." This cross-linguistically most common type is typical for languages of East and Southeast Asia.

Optatives, another irrealis mood, are formed with the prefix *-a-* fusing with a verbal multifunctional prefix. Semantically the optative carries cupitive and prescriptive tones, the former illustrated in (21). Optatives in Geshiza are frequently used in what [Aikhenvald \(2010\)](#) calls non-canonical imperatives, namely commands and requests to someone other than the addressee. Like the imperative, optatives must be negated with the irrealis negator (22), since the standard negation is deemed ungrammatical, as in (23).

- (21) n-a-mdær
 PFX-OPT-bite
 ‘Let (the hornet) bite you!’ (addressing the author, joke)
- (22) n-a-di-mdær
 PFX-OPT-IRR.NEG-bite
 ‘Let (the hornet) not bite you!’ (accepted during elicitation; see 21)
- (23) * n-a-mi-mdær
 PFX-OPT-NEG-bite
 Intended meaning: ‘Let (the hornet) not bite you!’ (rejected during elicitation; see 22)

Cognates for the Geshiza irrealis negator *di-* ~ *dzi-* are widely attested in Trans-Himalayan languages where the proto-form is usually reconstructed as *ta ~ da and labeled as prohibitive (see Matisoff 2003: 586). The prohibitive function has been inherited into many modern Trans-Himalayan languages as well. In Geshiza, analyzing *di-* ~ *dzi-* as a dedicated prohibitive marker would be somewhat misleading. First, as shown above, the suffix is required by all irrealis moods, including the optative. Second, it also appears in counterfactual irrealis scenarios where no other formal markers of irrealis status are present, as shown in (24). For this reason, I analyze it more broadly as an irrealis marker, rather than as a dedicated prohibitive. If more languages having reflexes of *ta ~ da behaving similar to Geshiza are documented, it will be possible to postulate that even in the proto-language, a primary irrealis function likely existed. At the current stage of research the analysis remains inconclusive.

- (24) æpa=ke bɔ dæ-dzi-jon=ræ dæ-dzi-əməmoŋ=ræ
 father=DAT thus PFX-IRR.NEG-say.1=LNK PFX-IRR.NEG-discuss.1=LNK
 mə-ŋi-ræ=gæ. ŋɛ væ ŋuə tɕʰu jon-mə.
 MOD.NEG-be.allright-SENS=MOD 1SG.GEN dad COP.3 DM say.1-EP
 ‘It is not fine for me not to tell thus (e.g. all these things) to my father and discuss (them with him). He is my dad, I am saying!’ (conversation)

As discussed above, questions in Geshiza are realis, with the result that they are negated with the standard negation prefixes in the limited contexts where this is allowed. Negative questions are never used as a strategy for gaining information, shown in the pair (25) and (26).

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- (25) g-i-vjin.
 IPFV-Q-be.hungry.2
 ‘Are you hungry?’ (overheard, addressing the author, multiple occurrences)
- (26) *g-i-mε-vjin.
 IPFV-Q-ASP.NEG-be.hungry.2
 Intended meaning: ‘Are you not hungry?’ (rejected during elicitation; see 25)

Rather, negative questions occur in the pragmatic context of rhetorical questioning and “auto-interrogation” (‘I wonder’). This is illustrated in (27) that would be rendered ungrammatical if the auto-interrogation enclitic =goŋ was absent.

- (27) <tsope> mε-stəu tɕ^hu <ləusə>=wo
 homework ASP.NEG-finish.PST.1SG so teacher=ERG
 æ-mi-v-dæ=goŋ.
 Q-NEG-INV-punish.3=Q
 ‘I haven’t finished the homework, so I wonder if my teacher will (lit. won’t) punish me.’ (elicited)

2.3 Negation in stative predications

Geshiza existential and copular predications use both standard negation and dedicated expressions. Copular predications in the language contain a copula together with a copular subject and a copular complement. Their functional range covers identity or (in)equation, group (dis)membership or inclusion/exclusion, and attribution. The copula *ηuə* ‘to be’ conjugates like an ordinary verb and has a dedicated negative counterpart *mɲa* ~ *mja* ‘not to be’. As shown in the example set (28–30), the negative copula cannot be replaced by standard negation in Geshiza.

- (28) bɔ gæ-tɕ^hæ ŋoŋ-ræ=gæ.
 thus ADJZ-big COP.1-SENS=MOD
 ‘We are that big.’ (conversation)
- (29) bɔ gæ-tɕ^hæ mŋoŋ-ræ=gæ.
 thus ADJZ-big NEG.COP.1-SENS=MOD
 ‘We aren’t that big.’ (accepted during elicitation; see 28)

- (30) * bɔ̌ gæ-tɕ^hæ mi-ŋoŋ-ræ=gæ.
thus ADJZ-big NEG-COP.1-SENS=MOD
Intended meaning: ‘We aren’t that big.’ (rejected during elicitation; see 29)

While synchronically non-analytical, the Geshiza negative copula possibly originates from a coalescence of a standard negation marker attaching the affirmative copula: *mV-ŋV (here V represents unclear exact vowel values of the reconstructed forms). The recently sketched Lamo language related to Geshiza and other Gyalrongic languages shows that in some related languages, standard negation can be applied to the copula. Nevertheless, if the fusional hypothesis has historical validity, its future elaborations should offer an explanation for the somewhat unexpected phonological outcomes of the fusion.

Existential and locative verbs abound in languages of Southwestern China (Sun 2001: 170). Their inventory in Geshiza includes six verbs, the selection of which depends on several factors, such as the animacy of the referent (animate, inanimate); locus of existence (containment, attachment, etc.); and alienability (alienable, inalienable). Table 3 summarizes the attested existential and locative verbs together with their negations and basic properties.

Table 3: Existential and locative verbs and their properties in Geshiza

Verb	Negation	Animacy	Locus	Alienability
<i>də</i>	<i>ma</i>	inanimate	general	not relevant
<i>wi</i>	<i>mi-wi</i>	inanimate	attachment	inalienable
<i>ndzə</i>	<i>mi-ndzə</i>	not relevant	container	not relevant
<i>dzi</i>	<i>mi-dzi</i>	animate	general	not relevant
<i>mdzi</i>	<i>mi-mdzi</i>	animate	group	not relevant

As can be seen, negative existential and locative predications are largely formed analytically by means of standard negation. To illustrate, standard negation applies to the existential-locative verb *dzi* in (31).

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- (31) e bændi-næmk^ha=t^hə mi-dzi-ræ t^hə p^he æ-yi=t^hə
 INJ PN-PN=TOP NEG-EXVB.3-SENS DEM other one-CLF.person=TOP
 dzi.
 EXVB.3
 ‘Bændi-næmk^ha is not (at home), but another person (of his family) is.’
 (chronicle)

In contrast, the general inanimate existential-locative verb *də* cannot be negated with standard negation (**mi-də*), but has a dedicated non-analytic negative counterpart *ma*, illustrated in (32) and (33). As discussed in Veselinova (2013b), this conforms to a general cross-linguistic tendency of applying a special negation strategy for negative existentials.

- (32) vdzi æ-yi=je rjəu æ-vtɕa bɔt^hə=t^hə ɲɛdɔlu
 man one-CLF.person=GEN wife one-CLF.pair like.that=TOP custom
 də-ræ.
 EXVB-SENS
 ‘There is a custom of a man marrying two women.’ (ethnographic explanation)
- (33) vdzi æ-yi=je rjəu æ-vtɕa bɔt^hə=t^hə ɲɛdɔlu
 man one-CLF.person=MOD wife one-CLF.pair like.that=TOP custom
 ma-ræ.
 NEGEX-SENS
 ‘There is no custom of a man marrying two women.’ (accepted during elicitation; see 32)

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Non-main clauses in Geshiza use standard negation, and the language shows no dedicated negative constructions in this context. Three main subordinate clause types exist in the language: adverbial, complement, and relative clauses. Syntactically, subordinate clauses precede main clauses. Both finite and non-finite subordinate clauses are attested, depending on the construction. Negation in such complex clauses frequently appears in the main clause, rather than in a subordinate clause, such as ‘I saw that she’s not coming’. In reported speech, however, a subtype of complementation with verbs of speech and cognition as the main clause predicates, the subordinate clause commonly appears as negated, as in (34).

- (34) *bran̩gu mi-ɕon̩=bo də-joŋ.*
 TOPN NEG-go.NPST.1=MOD PFV-say.1
 ‘I said that I am not going to Danba County Town.’ (chronicle)

Negative relative clauses frequently appear in a double negative construction discussed in §4.6.1.

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

Geshiza has relatively few negative lexicalizations, such as *mk^huə* ‘to lack’. Most prominently, the affirmative copula *ɲuə* has a negative counterpart *m̩ɲa* ~ *m̩ja*. In a similar fashion, the language has a dedicated negative existential verb *ma* that corresponds to the affirmative inanimate existential verb *də*. These two negative lexicalizations are discussed in detail in §2.3. The lexicon of the language also includes three identified verbs that must always be negated and can thus be seen as borderline cases of negative lexicalizations (see §4.6.2).

The modal auxiliary verb *vɕe* ‘to want, need’ has an irregular stem in aspectually neutral negation where *mə-ɕe* in lieu of **mə-vɕe* appears, as in example (35). In aspectual negation, the fully regular form *mɛ-vɕ^he* is used, as shown in (36).

- (35) *stɕæn mən-ɕe.*
 be.afraid.NPST.2 MOD.NEG-need-NPST
 ‘You need not be afraid.’ (folktale)
- (36) *lmæ=ɲə=ke k^hon̩ mɛ-vɕ^he tɕ^ha s^ho*
 3=PL=DAT give.NPST.1PL ASP.NEG-need.PST COND more
ru-ræ=gæ.
 find.1SG-SENS=MOD
 ‘If we didn’t have to give them (a part of the earnings), I would earn even more.’ (conversation)

The irregular negative form of the modal auxiliary cannot be explained as a result of morphophonemics. Rather, it is better viewed as an irregular quasi-fusional form that has some properties of negative lexicalizations. Typologically, negative lexicalizations frequently develop from fusional negated forms. As a well known example, the Latin verb *nolō* ‘to wish not, not want’ originates from the negation of *volō* ‘wish, want’ (Walde & Hofmann 1938: 829). Geshiza *mə(-)ɕe* is similar to this. Finally, Veselinova (2013a) shows that negative lexicalizations are not random, but surface in limited semantic domains. ‘To not want’ discussed above is one such domain, and Geshiza thus reflects this typological tendency.

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3 Non-clausal negation

This section addresses non-clausal negation in Geshiza. Most negative morphology in the language pertains to the domain of verbs. Save one exceptional case, no dedicated negative indefinites and quantifiers have been identified. Also, non-verbal word classes cannot be morphologically negated, except when individual lexical items derive from verbs.

3.1 Negative replies

Geshiza has a negative interjection *ʔǎxǎ* used for forming negative replies to polar questions. The language nevertheless prefers a verb-echo (repetition-type) strategy (see [Holmberg 2015](#)), namely echoing the verb of the question, either in affirmative or negative form. With a sample of 14 languages, [Enfield et al. \(2019\)](#) show all of the analyzed languages allowed both interjection-type answers and repetition-type answers to polar questions, but showed different frequencies for the two. To illustrate the repetition-strategy more common in the source materials collected from Geshiza, the question in (37) that serves as a conventional greeting among the Geshiza in the evening when people return home from work is answered both in the affirmative (38) and in the negative (39) by echoing the stative verb *rka* 'to be tired':

- (37) d-i-rk^ha.
 PFX-Q-be.tired.PST
 'Are you tired?' (lit. 'Did you get tired?') (overheard)
- (38) æ-nts^hæ rka-ræ=bɔ.
 one-CLF.little.bit be.tired.NPST-SENS=MOD
 'I am a little bit tired.' (addressing the author, notice also how the answer is in the non-past tense)
- (39) mɛ-rk^ha.
 ASP.NEG-be.tired.PST
 'I'm not tired.' (lit. 'I did not get tired.') (overheard)

As mentioned previously, Geshiza never uses negative questions to elicit information. Consequently, in the language it cannot be determined whether negative replies negate the proposition or disagree with the polarity of the question.

3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

Geshiza has few if any dedicated indefinites and quantifiers. Most basic, i.e. non-derived, interrogative pro-forms of Geshiza also carry an indefinite function, a typologically well-known tendency (see Dixon 2012: 401, Haspelmath 1997: 170–179, Kahrel 1996). They are further compatible with negative predicates, but must be accompanied with the contrastive topic marker (40–41).

- (40) *ni s^hədə rə-tjin.*
 2SG when DIR-come.NPST.2
 ‘When are you coming?’ (elicited)
- (41) *s^hədə=nə rə-mi-tjan=bə.*
 when=TOP.CNTR DIR-NEG-come.NPST.1=MOD
 ‘I will never come!’ (elicited)

The echo-like partially reduplicated *s^hədəs^həpəu* ‘never’ derives from *s^hədə* ‘when’ and requires a negative predicate. Exceptionally, *s^hədəs^həpəu* is the only attested negative indefinite pronoun, other interrogative pronouns lacking corresponding derivations. Example (42) semantically corresponds to (41).

- (42) *s^hədəs^həpəu rə-mi-tjan=bə.*
 never DIR-NEG-come.NPST.1=MOD
 ‘I will never come!’ (elicited)

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

Geshiza uses case enclitics for coding semantic roles. The grammar of the language lacks dedicated cases for expressing the absence of something, such as the Finnish Abessive *-tta* in *ongelmitta* ‘without problems’. Equally, a without-postposition does not exist in the repertoire of postpositions in Geshiza.

Nouns and adjectives cannot be negated category-internally in Geshiza. Only adjectives and nouns that are derivations rarely appear with negation in the language. In other words, negating the source category, namely verbs, offers the only pathway for deriving negative nouns and adjectives. The process is consequently represented as verb > negated verb > nominalization or adjectivization, as in (43). The nominalizer is almost always the productive agentive nominalizer *-me*, the rare agentive nominalizer *-pa* occurring only in few non-productive instances, such as in *mi-ntc^ho-pa*, an alternative to *mi-ntc^ho-me* ‘poor person’.

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- (43) *ntc^ho* > *mi-ntc^ho* > *mi-ntc^ho-me*
 have > NEG-have > NEG-have-NMLZ
 ‘to have’ (verb) > ‘not to have’ (negated verb) > ‘poor person’
 (nominalization of the negated verb)

The derivation of negative adjectives is subject to more restrictions. Like other Horpa languages of which research exists, Geshiza has three types of adjectives: prefixed (*gæ-tc^hæ* ‘big’), reduplicated (*dəu~dəu* ‘small’), and non-marked (*ɾɲoŋba* ‘old’). Of these, the prefixed and reduplicated adjectives derive from verbs. Only the prefixed adjectives appear with a negator in negative adjectivizations (44). Similar formations from reduplicated and non-marked adjectives are deemed ungrammatical, with the result that they can only be negated with the negative copula (see §2.3), a strategy equally applicable to prefixed adjectives as well.

- (44) *mdze* > *mi-mdze* > *gæ-mi-mdze*
 be.beautiful > NEG-be.beautiful > ADJZ-NEG-be.beautiful
 ‘to be beautiful’ (verb) > ‘not to be beautiful’ (negated verb) >
 ‘non-beautiful’ (adjectivalization of the negated verb)

4 Other aspects of negation

This section discusses major phenomena that occur in connection with negation in Geshiza. Several of such phenomena rely on pragmatic factors coded by information structure enclitics.

4.1 The scope of negation

The scope of negation in Geshiza is manipulated by the use of the information structure enclitics, which often leads into contrastive interpretations, as in (45) with the topic enclitic =*t^hə*.

- (45) *goŋma=t^hə mɲa-ræ. p^he ɶpən, t^hə ɶpən ŋuə-ræ.*
 emperor=TOP NEG.COP.3-SENS other leader DEM leader COP.3-SENS
 ‘He is not an emperor. (He is) a different leader. He is a leader.’ (local history)

4.2 Negative polarity

Negative polarity refers to expressions attested only in the negative context. In addition to *s^hədəs^həɲəu* ‘never’ discussed in §3.2, the Geshiza source materials

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contain only one negative polarity item, namely the discourse intensifier *=m(d)e* ‘only, no more/other than, apart from, besides’ that requires a negated predicate (46–47).

- (46) bjəwa æ-lə=je ts^hetsæ=mde mi-ntɕ^ho-ræ=mɔ.
 mouse one-CLF.INDF=GEN life.span=only NEG-have.NPST.3-SENS=MOD
 ‘He only has the life span of a mouse.’ (i.e., ‘He will die very soon.’)
 (folktale)
- (47) t^həvæ=t^hə <sents^həntui> ws^hu=mde mɛ-stoŋ=wo
 now=TOP production.unit three=only ASP.NEG-finish.PST.1PL=cause
 s^ho s^ho <sents^həntui> æ-vtɕa ntɕ^hoŋ=mɔ.
 more more production.unit one-CLF.pairs have.NPST.1PL=MOD
 ‘Because we have finished only three production units, we still have two
 more production units (to finish).’ (procedure)

In some languages, such as Japanese with *sika* and Tibetan with *ma gtogs*, the morpheme ‘only’ is compulsorily accompanied by a negator, and Geshiza follows this pattern. An interpretation of *=mde* as an intensifier ‘even’, as in ‘He doesn’t even have the life span of a mouse’ for (46) cannot be justified. In (48), the speaker narrates his daily activities when the author was visiting his village. Since the day had been busy for both, there was time to eat cup noodles only, unlike the more elaborate meals that the Geshiza frequently enjoy. Consequently, the speaker conveys the message that no other kind of food was available. Examples like this strongly support the semantic interpretation of ‘only’ for *=m(d)e*.

- (48) bəsni=t^hə mdzo=ke <fənbɛænmiæn>=mde mɛ-ŋgoŋ-s^hə-mə.
 today=TOP lunch=DAT cup.noodles=only ASP.NEG-eat.1PL-INFR-EP
 ‘Today we had only cup noodles for lunch.’ (chronicle)

4.3 Marking of NP in the scope of negation

As mentioned previously, negation does not affect case marking in Geshiza. In terms of information structure enclitics, however, negation commonly cooccurs with noun phrases marked with the contrastive topic marker *=nɔ* (see §3.2, §4.4).

4.4 Reinforcing negation

Negation in Geshiza is frequently reinforced with two main strategies: the use of an adverb and a versatile discourse enclitic. Geshiza has an inherently redupli-

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cated adverb *kəŋkən* that together with a negative predicate conveys the meaning ‘at all’, as in (49).

- (49) *kəŋkən lməu rejuɕəmæ mi-stɕʰə-mə-ræ-jə.*
 ADV 3.ERG front.teeth NEG-show.NPST.3-EP-SENS-REP
 ‘It is said that she does not show her front teeth at all.’ (folktale)

While frequently appearing paired with a negative predicate, *kəŋkən* is not a negative polarity item. In interrogative contexts, the adverb expresses the notion of ‘on earth’, illustrated in (50). In positive polarity contexts, it conveys the notion of ‘fully, completely’, as in (51).

- (50) *ni kʰə kəŋkən sʰə=ke=kʰa stɕæn jə.*
 2SG INJ ADV who=DAT=about fear.NPST.2 say.3
 ‘“Who on earth are you afraid of?” he said.’ (joke)

- (51) *e sme kəŋkən=tʰə wɰərja=zə də-tʰje-sʰi*
 DEM woman ADV=TOP hair=only PFV-become.PST.3-NMLZ
ŋuə-ræ=bə, æ-ŋuə-ræ.
 COP.3-SENS=MOD Q-COP.3-SENS
 ‘That lady had become completely covered with hair (because of living in isolation away from other human beings and civilization), right?’
 (folktale)

In addition, the information structure enclitic *=nə* is frequently used to reinforce negation. The enclitic covers a wide semantic range, but I analyze the marking of contrastive topic as the central function. To illustrate, in (52) involving a conversation of two participants, *=nə* indicates that while the speaker finds Balang Village close to Danba County Town pleasant to live in, other villages further away from the County Town are less so in his opinion.

- (52) *bəra=nə tɕə-re. pʰe tɕædzi*
 TOPN=TOP.CNTR be.pleasant.NPST-SENS.MOD other distant
mə-tɕə-ræ.
 MOD.NEG-be.pleasant.NPST-SENS
 ‘Balang is pleasant! Other (villages) far away aren’t pleasant.’
 (conversation)

The enclitic is frequently found adjoining the constituent preceding the predicate verb, as in (53) where it emphasizes *æ-ntsʰæ* ‘a little bit’:

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- (53) $\eta a=t^h\grave{a}$ $\grave{a}-nts^h\grave{a}=n\grave{o}$ $m\epsilon-vdo=je$.
 1SG=TOP one-CLF.little.bit=TOP.CNTR ASP.NEG-see.1SG=MOD
 ‘I haven’t seen him around at all!’ (conversation)

When putting emphasis on the predicate verb itself, the verb must be repeated, as illustrated in (54).

- (54) $y\grave{a}-\eta gu\grave{a}$ $lxua=n\grave{o}$ $mi-lxua-r\grave{a}$.
 ten-five appear.3=TOP.CNTR NEG-appear.3-SENS
 ‘There is no way I will get 150,000 yuan!’ (conversation; 15 refers to units of 10,000)

Finally, a clitic may attach directly to a negator, in which case it is detached from the predicate and also replicated in its canonical position as a verbal prefix (55).

- (55) $t^h\grave{a}$ $\eta\grave{a}=\eta u$ $t\check{c}^h\grave{a}s^h\grave{o}$ $m\grave{a}=n\grave{o}$ $m\grave{a}-san$.
 DEM 1=PL.ERG DM MOD.NEG=TOP.CNTR MOD.NEG-know.NPST.1PL
 ‘We (the younger generations) have no idea at all about that.’ (local history)

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

Negation does not affect coordination in Geshiza (56).

- (56) $d\grave{a}u\sim d\grave{a}u$ $t^h u$ $\grave{a}-li$ $d-\grave{a}-v-d\grave{a}$ $\grave{a}-li$
 RED.ADJZ~small DEM.ERG one-CLF.time PFX-NACTL-INV-do.3 one-CLF.time
 $d-\grave{a}-mi-v-d\grave{a}$.
 PFX-NACTL-NEG-INV-do.3
 ‘The small one (i.e. younger brother) carried out the tasks sometimes and sometimes he did not.’ (folktale)

Geshiza lacks any dedicated negative coordinators. The conjunction $m\epsilon-mja \sim m\epsilon-mja$ ‘either...or’ is etymologically related to the negated negative copula. Like all double negation in Geshiza, it follows the general principle of *duplex negatio affirmat* (57).

- (57) $\langle xoko \rangle$, $m\epsilon mja \langle xoko \rangle$ $\eta g\grave{a}$ $d-\grave{a}-\check{c}o\eta$. $m\epsilon mja$
 hot.pot either hot.pot eat.INF PFX-NACTL-go.NPST.1 either
 $\langle t\check{s}^hu\grave{a}nt\check{s}^hu\grave{a}nt\check{c}an \rangle$ $\eta g\grave{a}$ $\check{c}o\eta$.
 meat.skewers eat.INF go.NPST.1
 ‘Let’s go to eat Chinese hotpot or Sichuanese style meat skewers.’
 (conversation)

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4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

4.6.1 Double negation

Geshiza frequently applies double negation that follows the principle *duplex negatio affirmat*, viz. double negations always carry positive semantics, rather than its logical opposite *duplex negatio negat*. It commonly surfaces in a strong necessitative construction. Geshiza forms a permissive construction with the non-argument nominaliser *-rgui* ‘permission’ and the existential verb *də* (see §2.3), as in (58). This in turn is subject to negation, illustrated in (59). Finally, as shown in (60), changing the polarity value of the nominalization results in a strong necessitative, literally ‘there is no permission not to V’. Necessitative parallels to the Geshiza double negation construction exist in other Asian languages, e.g. the Chinese *bùdé bù V* ‘to have to V’ and the Japanese *V-nakereba naranai* ‘to have to V’.

- (58) <ʈʂʰetsə> mdzə-rgui də-ræ=gæ.
 car change-NMLZ:permission EXVB-SENS=MOD
 ‘Changing the car is allowed!’ (conversation)
- (59) <ʈʂʰetsə> mdzə-rgui ma-ræ=gæ.
 car change-NMLZ:permission NEGEX-SENS=MOD
 ‘Changing the car isn’t allowed!’ (accepted; see 58)
- (60) <ʈʂʰetsə> mi-mdzə-rgui ma-ræ=gæ.
 car NEG-change-NMLZ:permission NEGEX-SENS=MOD
 ‘We really need to change the car!’ (accepted; see 58)

While double negation is commonly attested with such nominalizations, finite verbs also follow the same principle of double negation yielding affirmative semantics (61). This reflects a pattern attested in some Trans-Himalayan languages whereby a negated verb appears together with a negated modal verb with a resulting affirmative meaning.

- (61) ŋa ʌsu=læ mə-tɕʰan tɕʰu ŋa=læ xo ŋɛ
 1SG rear.INF=FOC MOD.NEG-can.NPST.2 so 1SG=FOC DEM.LOC 1.SG.GEN
 stʰi rə-di-ɕoŋ mə-ŋi-ræ [...]
 place DIR-IRR.NEG-go.NPST.1 MOD.NEG-be.all.right-SENS [...]
 ‘You cannot take care of me, so I really need to go back to my place.’ (lit.
 ‘You cannot take care of me, so if I do not go back to my place, things will
 not be fine.’) (folktale)

4.6.2 Verbs with compulsory negation

The source materials include three Geshiza verb stems that always occur with a negative prefix: *mə-grə* ‘to be unable’, *mə-ske* ‘should not’, *mə-k^he* ‘to envy’ (meaning of the morpheme *k^he* remains unclear). These can be interpreted as borderline cases of negative lexicalizations (see §2.5). To illustrate, (62) and (63) show that *mə-ske* ‘should not’ cannot appear without the negative prefix.

- (62) sponqæal s^hæ mə-ske=mɔ.
 frog kill.INF MOD.NEG-should=MOD
 ‘One should not kill frogs.’ (conversation)

- (63) * sponqæal s^hæ ske=mɔ.
 frog kill.INF should=MOD
 Intended meaning: ‘One should kill frogs.’ (rejected during elicitation;
 see 62)

4.6.3 Disagreement and self-repair

The pragmatic functions of expressing disagreement and repairing one’s utterance during conversation are achieved by means of the negative copula *mpa* ~ *mja*. In (64), the husband in an elderly couple is narrating a folktale. His wife interrupts him, since she disagrees with her husband concerning the correct plot of the folktale.

- (64) A: ts^honpən=ke oja ji rji də-ɲuə-s^hi tɕ^hu xaræ
 merchant=DAT INJ 2SG.GEN horse PFV-COP.3-INFR SO CONJ
 k^huæn=bɔ. də-v-tɕ^hi=ræ də-ɕ^hə-s^hə-mə-ræ.
 give.NPST.2=MOD PFV-INV-ride.PST.3=LNK PFV-go.PST.3-INFR-EP-SENS
 ‘He (A *khu ston pa*) said to the merchant: “Yes, it is your horse, so I
 will give it (back) to you,” and he rode the horse, going away.’
 B: mpa. rə-zə-s^hə-mə-ræ.
 NEG.COP.3 PFV.DIR-come.3-EP-EP-SENS
 ‘No. He came back (to the merchant).’ (folktale mixed with
 conversation)

In a closely related fashion, the negative copula *mpa* ~ *mja* carries the pragmatic function of self repair when speakers change their minds, modify, or even negate their previous statement. In (65), the speaker suddenly realizes his mistake in identifying a person as a lama, immediately followed by the negative copula and self-repair.

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- (65) t^ho næmk^hæ jə-me æ-lə dæ-dzi-s^{hi}, læma.
DEM.LOC PN say-NMLZ one-CLF.INDF PFV-EXVB.3-SENS lama
mja. læma=t^hə mja-ræ=bə.
NEG.COP.3 lama=TOP NEG.COP.3=MOD
‘There was a certain person called *Næmk^hæ*, a lama, there. No. He is not a lama.’ (personal history)

5 Conclusion

This chapter introduced the principal morphology and constructions pertaining to negation in Geshiza. The findings concerning negative morphology and negative verbs are summarized in Table 4 below.

Table 4: Negative morphology in Geshiza

Domain	Type	Form	Description
verbal	<i>mi-</i>	prefix	aspectually neutral standard negator
verbal	<i>mɛ-</i>	prefix	aspectual standard negator
verbal	<i>mə-</i>	prefix	unproductive aspectually neutral negator
verbal	<i>di- ~ dzi-</i>	prefix	irrealis negator
existential	<i>ma</i>	verb	negative inanimate existential verb
copular	<i>mja ~ mja</i>	verb	negative copula
nominal	<i>mi-, mə-</i>	prefix	verbal negators present in nominalizations
adjectival	<i>mi-, mə-</i>	prefix	verbal negators present in adjectivalizations

Negation in Geshiza strictly pertains to the domain of verbs, which means that nouns and adjectives are only subject to negation when they derive from verbs and have already been negated in that word class prior to derivation. The language deviates from other described Gyalrongic languages in terms how aspect and negation interact. Geshiza includes an unproductive negator *mə-* that is used for modal verbs and several other verbs denoting non-controllable action. Additionally, the language includes a dedicated negative prefix *di- ~ dzi-* for irrealis scenarios, such as the prohibitive.

Abbreviations

The glossing of examples uses abbreviations from the Leipzig Glossing rules. New abbreviations for categories not included in the rules have been adopted.

In all, the abbreviations used are listed below. To ease their identification, recent Chinese loanwords are placed inside angle brackets: <loanword>. Omissions are indicated with [...].

1	first person	INV	inverse
2	second person	IPFV	imperfective
3	third person	IRR	irrealis
ADJZ	adjectivizer	LNK	linker
ADV	adverb	LOC	locative
ASP	aspectual	MOD	modal
AUX	auxiliary	NACTL	nonactual, realis mood
CNTR	contrastive	NEG	negation
CAUS	causative	NEGEX	negative existential
CLF	classifier	NMLZ	nominalizer
COND	conditional	NPST	non-past
CONJ	conjunction	OPT	optative
COP	copula	PERF	perfect
DAT	dative	PFV	perfective
DEM	demonstrative	PL	plural
DIR	direction, orientation	PN	personal name
DM	discourse marker	PFX	multifunctional verbal prefix
EP	epistemic suffix	PROSP	prospective
ERG	ergative	PST	past
EXP	experiential	Q	interrogative
EXVB	existential verb	RED	reduplication
FOC	focus	REP	reportative
GEN	genitive	SENS	sensory
INFR	inferential	SG	singular
IMP	imperative	TOP	topic
INDF	indefinite	TOPN	toponym
INF	infinitive		
INJ	interjection		

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Chapter 11

Negation in Rumai Palaung

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In Rumai, a variety of Palaung (Palaungic, Austroasiatic), negation is dependent on the clause type. While the negative morphemes *ʔa:w-* ‘NEG’, *bu:-* ‘NEG’, *-maʔ* ‘NEG’ and *pjɛm* ‘not yet’ can be used in independent clauses, dependent clauses are restricted to *bu:-* and *pjɛm*. This is probably due to the constituent order change from VAP to AVP in the Rumai independent clauses. Additionally, there are the prohibitives *kʰu:-* and *maj-*. The aim of this chapter is to describe and to analyze the means of negation in Rumai. It follows the “Questionnaire for describing the negation system of a language” by Miestamo (2025).

Keywords: Austroasiatic, Palaung, Rumai, negation, Jespersen Cycle.

1 Introduction

Rumai Palaung (ISO: **rbb**, Glottocode: **ruma1248**), an Austroasiatic language of the western Palaungic branch, is one of three varieties of Palaung (Ta’ang) so far mentioned in the linguistic literature, the other two being Shwe Palaung and Ruching Palaung. The three varieties (called in the following simply Rumai, Shwe and Ruching) differ to a considerable extent in the grammatical morphemes, and somewhat less in the lexicon.

Rumai, with a population of approximately 140 000, is mainly spoken in Myanmar in the townships Nam Hkam and Man Ton in Northern Shan State and Mogok in Mandalay Region, but also in adjacent regions of the Chinese province Yunnan. For a long time, Shan (Tai-Kadai) has been the main contact language, but with the introduction of the public school system after the independence of Myanmar in 1948, Burmese (Tibeto-Burman) gained more influence. This means, today the sociolinguistic hierarchy in the region is Burmese > Shan > Rumai. In

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Northern Shan State, the Rumai live in villages scattered over ridges and slopes of the mountains. The Rumai speakers in the villages of the same valley have relatively easy contact to each other, but this is not the case for villages of different valleys. This results in several dialects, which slightly diverge in phonology, lexicon, and syntax. The present study is based on fieldwork by the author mainly conducted in Mandalay, between 2013 and 2020, with consultants from Nam Hkam and Man Ton townships, in a village in Nam Hkam township and in Lashio, the informal capital of Northern Shan State. The corpus includes elicited sentences from several questionnaires, interviews, conversations, picture stories, and published texts from a phrasebook, journals, and a booklet with short stories. The references to the sources are explained in the appendix at the end of the chapter.

The Palaung have their own script, which was invented in 1972 by the Ta'ang Literature and Culture Committee and in 2012, a dictionary Burmese-Shwe-Rumai-Ruching appeared. There is also a dictionary Rumai-English-Burmese from 2011. The script is based on Burmese script with some additions from Shan script. However, as teaching (and even speaking) of ethnic languages in public schools was forbidden for a long time, literacy in Palaung is still low and a real standardization of the script has not taken place. Moreover, Ruching communities in Southern Shan State use Khün script, a script which is mainly used for Tai languages in this region.

Rumai constituent order is mainly SV/AVP in main clauses while dependent clauses have predominantly VS/VAP order. Multi-verbal predicates are common, and although the language is mainly analytic, there are verbal affixes expressing aspect, modality, and negation. The multi-verbal predicates include preverbal and postverbal secondary verbs expressing several grammatical categories which partly coincide with the functions of the verbal prefixes.¹

2 Clausal negation

The way clausal negation is expressed in Rumai is partly connected to constituent order. Negation is predominantly preverbal, but there is also the postverbal negator *-ma?*, which occurs only in independent declarative (SV/AVP) clauses. This conforms to the findings of [Dryer \(1988: 97\)](#) that postverbal negation in verb initial languages is highly unusual. It was originally a reinforcement of negation, but today it also occurs as the sole negator of a verb.²

¹For the affixes and secondary verbs in Rumai see [Weymuth 2018](#) and [2023](#).

²See §4.6.2 for Jespersen Cycle.

2.1 Standard negation

The negators used in Rumai standard negation are the prefixes *ʔa:w-* and *bu:-*, the suffix *-maʔ*, and the preverbal negative particle *ɲʌm* ‘not yet’. *ɲʌm* is not an affix like the other negators, but a free morpheme as it can be used alone in the negative answer to a polar question (§3.1).³ *ʔa:w-* and *-maʔ* only occur in independent clauses while *bu:-* and *ɲʌm* are also used in dependent ones.

In independent clauses, the preverbal affixes usually occur together with the suffix *-maʔ* (1b⁴, 3b), but there are also examples where the prefixes are the only negator (2b⁵, 4b).

- (1) a. pi ʔʌw təkjeət pʌʔ sɔŋfāj
 elder.sibling 1SG tidy.up LOC kitchen
 ‘My sister cleans up in the kitchen.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_115)
- b. pi ʔʌw ʔa:w-təkjeət-maʔ pʌʔ sɔŋfāj
 elder.sibling 1SG NEG-tidy.up-NEG LOC kitchen
 ‘My sister does not clean up in the kitchen.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_117)
- (2) a. ʔʌw jêəw təpâ:w pʌŋ dʌh mâj
 1SG see listen REL say 2SG
 ‘I hear what you say.’ (pc_3)
- b. ʔʌw ʔa:w-jêəw təpâ:w pʌŋ dʌh mâj
 1SG NEG-see listen REL say 2SG
 ‘I don’t hear what you say.’ (EQB_17_M_3_023)

bu:- is the main negator in dependent clauses (§2.4), but it is also used in independent ones (3) and (4).

- (3) a. pa:t bʌ:n ʔʌw hâ:w jangû:n
 week back 1SG go Yangon
 ‘Next week I will go to Yangon.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_040)
- b. pa:t bʌ:n ʔʌw bu:-hâ:w-maʔ jangû:n
 week back 1SG NEG-go-NEG Yangon
 ‘Next week I will not go to Yangon.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_041)

³Due to the lack of data, *ɲʌm* was analyzed as a prefix in Weymuth (2018).

⁴The transcription *eə* in words like *təkjeət* ‘tidy up’ in example (1) does not represent a diphthong in Rumai, but a vowel between /e/ and /ɛ/.

⁵In the paper about secondary verbs in Rumai (Weymuth 2023), *pʌŋ* is glossed as a nominalizer. However, to analyze *pʌŋ* as a relativizer is more compatible with the structure of the language.

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- (4) a. ʔê nà ʔu kê dih
 1PL.INCL know name 3PL DISC
 ‘We know their names.’ (pc_3)
 b. ʔê bu:-nà ʔu kê dih
 1PL.INCL NEG-know name 3PL DISC
 ‘We don’t know their names.’ (C3_17_MS_9_107)

Besides its function as a neutral negation marker in independent clauses, *bu:-*, in contrary to *ʔa:w-*, may also mean ‘no longer, no more, not anymore’, dependent on the context or the intention of the speaker. Here, the negative suffix *-maʔ* is always present (5).

- (5) ʔân bu:-deəh-maʔ dih
 3SG NEG-come-NEG DISC
 ‘He won’t come anymore.’ (EQB_17_M_3_006)

ʔa:w- and *bu:-* (as a neutral negation marker) are sometimes freely interchangeable. However, dependent on the intention of the speaker, there may also be the connotation of ‘not anymore, no longer’ in (6b), but not in (6a).

- (6) a. māj ʔa:w-bŷn-maʔ ʔak
 2SG NEG-get-NEG sit
 ‘You may not sit here.’ (EGGD_16_L_6_142)
 b. māj bu:-bŷn-maʔ ʔak
 2SG NEG-get-NEG sit
 ‘You may not sit here (anymore).’ (EGGD_16_M_1_141)

The suffix *-maʔ*, in combination with the negative prefixes, probably originally had a reinforcing function, but today it is very frequent in negative declarative clauses, so that it is now rather a neutral negation marker. Sometimes it also occurs as the sole negator in a clause (7b).⁶

- (7) a. ʔāw hā:w pāʔ jangû:n
 1SG go LOC Yangon
 ‘I go to Yangon.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_034)
 b. ʔāw hā:w-maʔ pāʔ jangû:n
 1SG go-NEG LOC Yangon
 ‘I don’t go to Yangon.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_035)

⁶See §4.6.2 for Jespersen Cycle.

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The three Palaung varieties have a common preverbal negative marker with the meaning ‘not yet’, namely Rumai *ɲjɔm*, Shwe *hɲem* (Milne 1921: 176) and Ruching *hɲam* (Deepadung et al. 2015:1078). In the Burmese-Palaung dictionary (Unknown 2012: 131), the Shwe and the Ruching expressions are cited as verbs with the meaning ‘dilatory, stiff’ (the corresponding Rumai verb in the dictionary is *moj*). This suggests that a former common verb of the three Palaung varieties is the source of the Rumai negation marker *ɲjɔm*. Clauses containing the prefix *hɔj-* ‘NSIT’ (8a, 9b), the secondary verb *hɔj* ‘finish’ (9a), or both (10a) are usually negated by *ɲjɔm*.⁷

The prefix and the secondary verb are aspectual markers which denote a new (and usually expected) situation after the transgression of a limit (Jenny 2001: 125). Both may be translated by ‘already’ (8a, 10a), but they do not have to be translated at all (9). In negative clauses, they are always omitted.

Furthermore, as illustrated in the following negative clauses, *ɲjɔm* is always used together with the negative suffix *-maʔ* in declarative verbal main clauses.

- (8) a. ʔân hɔj-tʰiʷ cəʔuʔ
3SG NSIT-give book
‘He has already given back the book.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_019)
- b. ʔân ɲjɔm tʰiʷ-maʔ cəʔuʔ
3SG not.yet give-NEG book
‘He has not yet given back the book.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_020)

The secondary verb *hɔj* (9a) and the prefix *hɔj-* (9b) are freely interchangeable, the negated clause (9c) is the same for both (9a) and (9b).

- (9) a. ʔâw ʃɰh hɔj
1SG buy finish
‘I have bought it.’ (pc_3)
- b. ʔâw hɔj-ʃɰh
1SG NSIT-buy
‘I have bought it.’ (pc_3)
- c. ʔâw ɲjɔm ʃɰh-maʔ
1SG not.yet buy-NEG
‘I haven’t bought it yet.’ (pc_3)

⁷For more details about the verbal affixes see Weymuth (2018), and for the secondary verbs see Weymuth (2023).

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In (10a), the prefix as well as the secondary verb are used while in the negative clause (10b) both are omitted. When both grammatical markers are used in a positive clause, one probably emphasizes the other, but it is not yet clear which is the emphasizing one.

- (10) a. ʔâw hɔj-ʃvʰ hɔ:j tɛw.hlâ
1SG NSIT-buy finish vegetable
‘I have already bought vegetables.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_059)
- b. ʔâw ɲjɔm ʃvʰ-maʔ tɛw.hlâ
1SG not.yet buy-NEG vegetable
‘I have not yet bought vegetables.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_060)

The replacement of the new situation markers by the negator *ɲjɔm* ‘not yet’ indicates a constructional asymmetry (Miestamo 2005: 52). And as the asymmetry concerns a grammatical category of the aspectual domain, it belongs to Miestamo’s asymmetry type A/Cat/TAM⁸ (Miestamo 2005: 116).

In Rumai, the lexical verbs in a clause belong to one of two functional categories: semantically primary verbs (main verbs) or semantic secondary verbs (secondary verbs). The secondary verbs (V2) can be divided into two sub-categories, namely preverbal and postverbal secondary verbs. The preverbal secondary verbs are always the syntactic primary verbs that means, they take the verbal affixes and the postverbal secondary verbs. The postverbal secondary verbs never have syntactic priority. In Table 1, the possible combinations of main verbs and secondary verbs are given.

Table 1: Semantic and syntactic priority of the Rumai lexical verbs

	preverbal V2	+	main verb	main verb	(+ postverbal V2)
semantic priority	–		+	+	–
syntactic priority	+		–	+	–

This categorization is important for negation because it is always the syntactic primary verb in a clause which takes the negation markers (as well as the other verbal prefixes and the postverbal secondary verbs) and is therefore in the scope of negation. As it is shown in Table 1, in absence of a preverbal secondary verb, the syntactic primary verb is the main verb, otherwise it is the preverbal

⁸Asymmetry that affects the grammatical categories tense, aspect and/or mood.

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secondary verb. The most common preverbal secondary verbs are listed in Table 2.⁹

Table 2: The most common preverbal secondary verbs in Rumai

Verb	Lexical meaning	Function	Domain
<i>lo</i>	‘need’	obligation	modality
<i>bɛ</i>	‘can’	possibility, inherent ability	modality
<i>səmâ</i>	‘know’	acquired ability	modality
<i>bɿn</i>	‘get’	possibility, permission	modality
<i>dɛh / tʰiʷ</i>	‘give’	causative	valency

Examples (11–15) show that the means of negation with preverbal secondary verbs are the same as with main verbs.

- (11) a. *pi jê lo rêən sɔ:ŋfâj*
 elder.sibling 1PL.EXCL need do kitchen
 ‘Our elder sister has to clean the kitchen.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_114)
- b. *pi jê ʔa:w-lo rêən sɔ:ŋfâj*
 elder.sibling 1PL.EXCL NEG-need do kitchen
 ‘Our elder sister does not have to clean the kitchen.’
 (ENEG_13_M_1/2_116)
- (12) *ma ʔaw bu:-lo-ma? rêən ʃuŋ kjâ:m*
 mother 1SG NEG-need-NEG do work rough
 ‘My mother doesn’t have to do rough work anymore.’ (WA_15_M_3_038)
- (13) *kê ɲjam bɛ-ma? lɔ? vɿh dih*
 3PL not.yet can-NEG COMP open DISC
 ‘They cannot yet open (school).’ (C3_17_MS_9_022)
- (14) *mâj ʔa:w-bɿn-ma? dɛəh hla pɔ? ʃuŋ*
 2SG NEG-get-NEG come late LOC work
 ‘You shouldn’t come late to work.’ (WPKT_14_L_097)

⁹The analysis of Rumai is a work in progress, and there may be more marginally used preverbal secondary verbs. The same holds for the postverbal secondary verbs and the verbal affixes.

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- (15) ma ʔâw siŋ-**dəh-maʔ** kô:n ʔân hâ:w pɔʔ rangun
 mother 1SG DES-give-NEG child 3SG go LOC Yangon
 ‘My mother does not want to let her children go to Yangon.’
 (EMR_19_M_3_090)

Except for the negative constructions with *njɔm* (A/Cat/TAM), the examples so far given suggest that negation in declarative verbal main clauses is symmetric. However, there is a certain paradigmatic asymmetry (Miestamo 2005: 52) regarding some verbal prefixes and postverbal secondary verbs. These grammatical markers are not generally incompatible with negation, but they are often omitted in negative clauses. Although Miestamo (2005: 58) includes only fully grammaticalized, obligatory asymmetries in his study, this partial asymmetry is mentioned here as the tendency to omit certain grammatical markers is very strong. Like the asymmetry with *njɔm*, this asymmetry can be classified as type A/Cat/TAM. Of the verbal affixes, the imperfective marker *gi:j-* and the irrealis marker *nɔŋ-* are most often affected. The feature is shown in example (16).

- (16) a. ʔân diŋ cəʔuʔ
 3SG read book
 ‘He reads a book.’
 b. ʔân **nɔŋ**-diŋ cəʔuʔ
 3SG IRR-read book
 ‘He will read a book.’
 c. ʔân **gi:j**-diŋ cəʔuʔ
 3SG IPFV-read book
 ‘He is reading a book.’
 d. ʔân (**ʔa:w-**)diŋ-**maʔ** cəʔuʔ
 3SG NEG-read-NEG book
 ‘He doesn’t/will not read/isn’t reading a book.’ (pc_3)

While in the affirmative clauses (16b, 16c) the affixes are used to indicate modality and aspect, the negative clause (16d) is underspecified and may therefore be read in different ways. However, when the function of the prefix is emphasized, it is also maintained under negation (17).

- (17) a. ʔân **gi:j**-diŋ cəʔuʔ dɿ
 3SG IPFV-read book ANA
 ‘She is still reading that book.’

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- b. ʔân ʔa:w-gi:j-dih-maʔ cəʔuʔ dɿ
 3SG NEG-IPFV-read-NEG book ANA
 ‘She is still not reading that book.’ (pc_3)

Of the post-verbal secondary verbs, ʔû:n ‘keep’ is the one that is most often omitted in negative clauses. The basic function of this aspectual marker is to express duration without emphasizing initial or final boundaries, although they may be present implicitly. This includes ongoing actions or situations, but also general truths. Especially the general truths convey certainty of the situation or event, and therefore the durative marker may additionally have developed into an emphasis marker which conveys more certainty. This is probably the case in (18a). In the negative clause (18b), the secondary verb is omitted, but the negative suffix *-maʔ* is used which, in combination with the preverbal negative marker *ʔa:w-* may have an emphasizing function. As there are only a few examples of this pattern in the data, it is not clear at this point whether the correspondence is regular.

- (18) a. ʔân jêəw ʔû:n baw.pʰûŋ ʔân
 3SG see keep friend 3SG
 ‘He has (definitely) met his friend.’ (ENEG_14_M_028)
 b. ʔân ʔa:w-jêəw-maʔ baw.pʰûŋ ʔân
 3SG NEG-see-NEG friend 3SG
 ‘He did not meet his friend.’ (ENEG_14_M_029)

Other secondary verbs like *deəh* ‘come’ are usually retained in negative clauses (19). The function of *deəh* is to express a motion towards the center of interest (Jenny 2005: 173).

- (19) səŋâj tənɿŋla pa:t bân mʌ kê ɲjʌm vî deəh-maʔ
 sun Monday week back RESTR 3PL not.yet return come-NEG
 ‘By next Monday they won’t have returned yet.’ (EGGD_16_M_3_158)

Some pronouns merge with the negative prefix *ʔa:w-*, like ʔêw- ‘1PL.INCL.NEG’ (20) from ʔê ‘1PL.INCL’ and *kêw-* ‘3PL.NEG’ (21) from *kê* ‘3PL’.

- (20) ʔêw-nʌ pʌŋ nʌŋ-rêəŋ tɛ hɔm
 1PL.INCL.NEG-know REL IRR-do begin eat
 ‘We don’t know what we should do for eating.’ (N2_17_MS_7_012)

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- (21) kê nî mΛ kêw-meəh-ma? lΛ? jλ:j rêən hōm si? pΛŋ
3PL PROX RESTR 3PL.NEG-exist-NEG COMP rise do eat something REL
hâj
other
'They don't have to do something else for living.' (N2_17_MS_7_007)

These are the only two mergers between a pronoun and *ʔa:w-* that occur in the corpus. Table 3 contains the personal pronouns of Rumai.

Table 3: The Rumai personal pronouns

		Singular	Dual	Plural
1	Inclusive	ʔâw	ʔâ:j	ʔê
	Exclusive		jâ:j	jê
2		mâj	pâ:j	pê
3		ʔân	kâ:j	kê

The phonological shape of the pronouns seems to be a factor in whether merger occurs. While a merger with pronouns ending in a vowel is possible, due to phonotactics it is unlikely with those ending in a consonant.

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

Non-declaratives in Rumai are imperative and interrogative clauses. Both have several means of expressing negation, which will be described in the following sections.

2.2.1 Imperative clauses

Imperative clauses in Rumai are usually negated by the prohibitive marker *k^hu:-* (22).

- (22) a. hâ:w pΛ? kəlah
go LOC market
'Go to the market!' (ENEG_13_M_1/2_249)
b. k^hu:-hâ:w pΛ? kəlah
PROH-go LOC market
'Don't go to the market!' (ENEG_13_M_1/2_234)

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Sometimes the prohibitive marker *maj-* is used. This seems to be only possible if a corresponding positive imperative does not make sense like in (23). So, it may rather express a well-meaning advice.

- (23) *maj-bī* *teəh cə:ŋ*
 PROH-forget take umbrella
 ‘Don’t forget to take an umbrella!’ (WPKT_14_L_194)

So far negation of imperatives is symmetric, but there are two features which can trigger an asymmetry. On the one hand, the second person pronoun may be used in prohibitive clauses for emphasis like *mâj* ‘2SG’ in (24). According to the data, this seems impossible in positive imperatives.

- (24) *paŋtâ:j ciʔ dɿh mâj kʰu:-leəp*
 rabbit TCL say 2SG PROH-enter
 ‘The rabbit said: “Don’t enter!”’ (PCHT_16_L_6_035)

On the other hand, for more politeness, the polite marker *kʰɿŋ* can be used in positive imperatives (25). This is not possible in negative ones (26).

- (25) *vɿh kʰɿŋ mòj ploɰ dī*
 open POL mouth door MED
 ‘Please open the door!’ (WPKT_14_L_148)

- (26) *kʰu:-vɿh (*kʰɿŋ) mòj ploɰ dī*
 PROH-open POL mouth door MED
 ‘Don’t open the door!’ (pc_3)

In their analysis of the prohibitive, *van der Auwera et al. (2013)* propose a four-way distinction which pays attention to the similarity between the verbal constructions of the prohibitive and the imperative, and to the similarity between the negative strategy used for prohibitives and for declaratives.

2.2.2 Interrogative clauses

Rumai interrogative clauses include polar questions and content questions. The negators which are used in standard negation are also used in negative interrogatives.

The polar questions mostly contain an interrogative particle, which is *lɿh* in positive questions (27a, 28a), while *huh* is usually used in negative ones (27b,

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(28b). All the interrogative particles directly follow the verb complex. In example (27b), the negator *maʔ* is used, and in (28b) it is *ʔa:w-*. This choice is probably due to the intention of the speakers.

- (27) a. *mâj hâ:w lah pʔ ʃûŋ*
 2SG go Q LOC work
 ‘Do you go to work?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_235)
- b. *mâj hâ:w-maʔ huʰh pʔ ʃûŋ*
 2SG go-NEG Q LOC work
 ‘Don’t you go to work?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_238)
- (28) a. *mâj dih lah bèəh tō:n səŋâj*
 2SG read Q text every sun
 ‘Do you read the newspaper every day?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_245)
- b. *mâj ʔa:w-dih huʰh bèəh tō:n səŋâj*
 2SG NEG-read Q text every sun
 ‘Don’t you read the newspaper every day?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_246)

Neither the positive nor the negative question in (29) contain a question marker, and the clauses are identical to the corresponding declarative clauses. Here, only the intonation allows the hearer to distinguish between the clause types. In declarative clauses and in questions including a question particle the intonation is falling towards the end; in interrogative clauses without a question marker, it is rising. Example (29b) contains the common negative markers *bu:-* and *-maʔ* to express the meaning ‘not anymore’.

- (29) a. *ʔân nʌŋ-hâ:w tʰéŋ bō pʔ rangŋ*
 3SG IRR-go repeat fill LOC Yangon
 ‘He will go to Yangon again.’
 ‘Will he go to Yangon again?’
- b. *ʔân nʌŋ-bu:-hâ:w tʰéŋ-maʔ pʔ rangŋ*
 3SG IRR-NEG-go repeat-NEG LOC Yangon
 ‘He won’t go to Yangon anymore.’
 ‘Won’t he go to Yangon anymore?’ (pc_3)

Additionally, the particle *hʌʔ* can be used as a question marker. Example (30) shows an affirmative clause that includes the secondary verb *hə:j*, which is usually translated as ‘already’.

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- (30) ʔân ʃɤh hò:j kâ
 3SG buy finish car
 ‘He already bought the car.’ (pc_3)

In the corresponding question (31), the secondary verb *hò:j* is replaced by the particle *hʌ?*, but it can also be maintained to emphasize the meaning ‘already’ (31a). In the negative question (31b), *ɲjʌm* ‘not yet’ replaces *hò:j*, and *jêw* ‘perceive’, a secondary verb with a function that is not yet clear, follows the main verb.

- (31) a. ʔân ʃɤh (hò:j) hʌ? kâ
 3SG buy finish PTCL car
 ‘Did he already buy the car?’
 b. ʔân ɲjʌm ʃɤh jêw kâ
 3SG not.yet buy perceive car
 ‘Hasn’t he bought the car yet?’ (pc_3)

According to native speakers, *hʌ?* means ‘to stop’ or ‘be all’. This and the form of the particle are hints that *hʌ?* may be derived from the verb *hò:j* ‘finish’. However, the postverbal position of *hʌ?* in interrogative clauses implies a derivation from the postverbal secondary verb *hò:j*. This would be unusual as *hʌ?* is an independent morpheme while *hò:j* in this function is not.

There do not seem to be any means to express an expectation for a positive or negative answer in polar questions.

Content questions can be expressed with (32, 33b) or without (33a, 34) interrogative particles.

- (32) a. sim.ba:j mâj sʌm gi:j-dih lʌh bèə
 why 2SG CONC IPFV-read Q text
 ‘Why are you reading?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_208)
 b. sim.ba:j mâj sʌm bu:-dih lʌh bèə
 why 2SG CONC NEG-read Q text
 ‘Why are you not reading?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_209)
- (33) a. cʰi gô:j deəh pʌ? dī
 who stay come LOC MED
 ‘Who was there?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_222)
 b. cʰi ʔa:w-gô:j deəh huɰh pʌ? dī
 who NEG-stay come Q LOC MED
 ‘Who was not there?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_223)

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- (34) a. si mâj ʃʏh deəh
 what 2SG buy come
 ‘What did you buy?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_219)
- b. si mâj bu:-ʃʏh deəh
 what 2SG NEG-buy come
 ‘What did you not buy?’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_220)

Negative questions introduced by *sim.baj* ‘why’ (32b) are always negated by the prefix *bu:-* and the question particle *lɔh* follows the verb instead of *huuh*, which is usually used in negative questions. The use of *bu:-* here and in (34b) may be due to a possible reading as ‘not anymore’ while in (33b) this is less plausible. However, the use of the negative markers is flexible and different consultants may give different translations of the sentences.

The examples in this section show that negation in questions is usually asymmetric, only (34b) is symmetric. But here also, translations given by other consultants may differ.

2.3 Negation in stative predications

In Rumai, stative predications are verbal, and negation is expressed by standard negation. This means, that the usual negation strategies are used. These are *ʔa:w-V-ma?* ‘not’, *ɲjam V-ma?* ‘not yet’ and *bu:-V-ma?* ‘not anymore’. The type of negation that seems impossible is negation by a simple preverbal or postverbal negator.

Negation in stative predications is symmetric unless aspectual markers are involved. While clauses expressing “already” include the prefix *hɔj-* ‘NSIT’ and/or the postverbal secondary verb *hɔj* ‘finish’, these aspectual markers are substituted by *ɲjam* ‘not.yet’ in the corresponding negative clauses, as illustrated for *hɔj* in (36d). Other aspectual markers like *gi:j-* ‘IPFV’ are mostly omitted in negative clauses (36f, 38e). For *ʔuN-* ‘DUR’ see §2.3.5.

2.3.1 Equation

Equation uses the verb *moh* ‘be so’ that is negated regularly (35).¹⁰

¹⁰The Rumai verbs are so far divided into primary and secondary verbs dependent on their function in a clause (§2.1, Table 1). Whether *moh* ‘be so’ can be assigned to one of these categories, or whether it is appropriate to introduce an additional category like “auxiliary”, or “copula” is not yet clear. The research for the syntactic constructions in which *moh* is used will give more insight.

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- (35) a. ʔân moh ma ʔâw
3SG be.so mother 1SG
'She is my mother.'
- b. ʔân ʔa:w-moh-maʔ ma ʔâw
3SG NEG-be.so-NEG mother 1SG
'She is not my mother.' (pc_3)

2.3.2 Proper inclusion

Also, in proper inclusion, the verb *moh* is used and is negated regularly as shown in (36).

- (36) a. ʔân moh kəŋjâ nâ
3SG be.so owner field
'He is a farmer.'
- b. ʔân ʔa:w-moh-maʔ kəŋjâ nâ
3SG NEG-be.so-NEG owner field
'He isn't a farmer.'
- c. ʔân moh hò:j kəŋjâ nâ
3SG be.so finish owner field
'He is already a farmer.'
- d. ʔân ɲɰam moh-maʔ kəŋjâ nâ
3SG not.yet be.so-NEG owner field
'He is not yet a farmer.'
- e. ʔân gi:j-moh kəŋjâ nâ
3SG IPFV-be.so owner field
'He is still a farmer.'
- f. ʔân bu:-moh-maʔ kəŋjâ nâ
3SG NEG-be.so-NEG owner field
'He isn't a farmer anymore.' (pc_3)

In proper inclusion, sentences with a generic subject (37) do not differ from sentences with specific subjects (36).

- (37) a. ʔəpɛw moh to.sət
cat be.so animal
'Cats are animals.'

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- b. ʔəpɛw ʔa:w-moh-maʔ to.sɔt
 cat NEG-be.SO-NEG animal
 ‘Cats are not animals.’ (pc_3)

2.3.3 Attribution

Attribution is expressed by stative verbs (38) that behave like intransitive active verbs (39). This means, they directly follow the subject and are within the scope of negation. Here also, the regular means of negation are used.

- (38) a. ʔân pjɔ
 3SG happy
 ‘She is happy.’
 b. ʔân ʔa:w-pjɔ-maʔ
 3SG NEG-happy-NEG
 ‘She is not happy.’
 c. ʔân ɲjam pjɔ-maʔ
 3SG not.yet happy-NEG
 ‘She isn’t happy yet.’
 d. ʔân gi:j-pjɔ
 3SG IPFV-happy
 ‘She is still happy.’
 e. ʔân bu:-pjɔ-maʔ
 3SG NEG-happy-NEG
 ‘She isn’t happy anymore.’ (pc_3)
- (39) a. ʔân kəɲjah
 3SG laugh
 ‘He laughs.’
 b. ʔân ʔa:w-kəɲjah-maʔ
 3SG NEG-laugh-NEG
 ‘He doesn’t laugh.’
 c. ʔân ɲjam kəɲjah-maʔ
 3SG not.yet laugh-NEG
 ‘He doesn’t laugh yet.’
 d. ʔân bu:-kəɲjah-maʔ
 3SG NEG-laugh-NEG
 ‘He doesn’t laugh anymore.’ (pc_3)

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There is no difference in negation between temporary (38) and permanent (40) property assignment.

- (40) a. k^həleəp nî dâ:ŋ
house PROX big
'This house is big.' (ENEG_13_M_1/2_188)
- b. k^həleəp nî ʔa:w-dâ:ŋ-maʔ
house PROX NEG-big-NEG
'This house is not big.' (ENEG_13_M_1/2_189)

2.3.4 Locative predication

Locative predication is expressed by the verb *gô:j* 'stay' (41) which also means 'live' (42). Negation is regular.

- (41) a. ʔəpɛw gô:j tēəŋ ku:.ʔiʔ
cat stay on bed
'The cat is on the bed.'
- b. ʔəpɛw ʔa:w-gô:j-maʔ tēəŋ ku:.ʔiʔ
cat NEG-stay-NEG on bed
'The cat is not on the bed.'
- c. ʔəpɛw ɲɿɿm gô:j-maʔ tēəŋ ku:.ʔiʔ
cat not.yet stay-NEG on bed
'The cat isn't on the bed yet.'
- d. ʔəpɛw bu:-gô:j-maʔ tēəŋ ku:.ʔiʔ
cat NEG-stay-NEG on bed
'The cat isn't on the bed anymore.' (pc_3)
- (42) ʔɿw gô:j pɿʔ ʔuɿ.ʔuh p^hədən
1SG stay LOC village PN
'I live in Pha Den village.' (WPKT_14_L_008)

2.3.5 Existential predication

For existential predications, the verb *meəh* 'exist' is used (43). Existential clauses are always verb initial. For locative-presentative constructions (Veselinova 2013: 108), a locative adverbial can be added to the existential clause without any other changes. Existential predications show asymmetry. This is due to the durative

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prefix *ʔuN-*, which describes a situation in which the boundaries are not known or are not of any importance. The negative clauses (43b) and (43d) both show this feature, but only in (43d) is *ʔuN-* used. The reason for its presence in this clause is not yet clear, and more research is needed. In (43c), there is a boundary as *ɲɟɒm* ‘not.yet’ also means “not until now”.

- (43) a. (k^hêəŋ bjâj) **ʔuɒm**-mɛəh sâ:ŋ
in forest DUR-exist elephant
‘There are elephants (in the forest).’
b. (k^hêəŋ bjâj) **ʔa:w**-mɛəh-**maʔ** sâ:ŋ
in forest NEG-exist-NEG elephant
‘There are no elephants (in the forest).’
c. (k^hêəŋ bjâj) **ɲɟɒm** mɛəh-**maʔ** sâ:ŋ
in forest not.yet exist-NEG elephant
‘There aren’t elephants (in the forest) yet.’
d. (k^hêəŋ bjâj) **ʔuɒm-bu:**-mɛəh-**maʔ** sâ:ŋ
in forest DUR-NEG-exist-NEG elephant
‘There aren’t elephants (in the forest) anymore.’ (pc_3)

2.3.6 Possessive predication

The verb *mɛəh* ‘exist’ also has the sense ‘have’ in Rumai and is therefore used in possessive predication (44). Negation is regular.

- (44) a. ʔân mɛəh k^həleəp
3SG exist house
‘He has a house.’
b. ʔân **ʔa:w**-mɛəh-**maʔ** k^həleəp
3SG NEG-exist-NEG house
‘He doesn’t have a house.’
c. ʔân **ɲɟɒm** mɛəh-**maʔ** k^həleəp
3SG not.yet exist-NEG house
‘He doesn’t have a house yet.’
d. ʔân **bu:**-mɛəh-**maʔ** k^həleəp
3SG NEG-exist-NEG house
‘He doesn’t have a house anymore.’ (pc_3)

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

Rumai dependent clauses are mainly verb-initial, and they are always negated by *bu:-* ‘NEG’ or *njam* ‘not yet’. This means that the negators *ʔa:w-* and *-maʔ* are never used in dependent clauses. Concerning the postverbal *-maʔ*, its absence in dependent clauses is probably due to the tendency to avoid postverbal negators in verb-initial languages as observed by Dryer (1988) in his study about negative position (Dryer 1988: 97). Although the basic word order in Rumai is verb-medial today, one can assume that it was generally verb-initial as dependent clauses are believed to be more conservative than independent ones (Bybee 2001). The following examples include relative clauses, temporal clauses, complement clauses and conditional clauses. These constructions are also representative of the other dependent clauses like causal and concessive clauses.

Relative clauses are usually introduced by the relativizers *ʔi* for persons (45) and *pʌŋ* for things (46).¹¹

- (45) a. ʔi.mâ:j dɛʔ cʰeh [ʔi diɰ bə̀əh] nʌŋ-ʔɔ:ŋ bə̀əh
 man small CLF REL read text IRR-pass text
 ‘The boy who learns the text will pass the exam.’ (ENEG_14_M_007)
- b. ʔi.mâ:j dɛʔ cʰeh [ʔi bu:-diɰ bə̀əh] nʌŋ-ʔa:w-ʔɔ:ŋ-maʔ bə̀əh
 man small CLF REL NEG-read text IRR-NEG-pass-NEG text
 ‘The boy who does not learn the text will not pass the exam.’
 (ENEG_14_M_008)
- (46) kiʔ nî moh doʔ [pʌŋ njʌm diɰ ʔʌw]
 NMLZ PROX be.so exhausted REL not.yet read 1SG
 ‘These are the ones I have not read yet.’ (EMSR_19_M_3_059)

Relative clauses can include verbal affixes like the irrealis *nʌŋ-* in (47). Here, the irrealis marker is maintained in the negative clause.

- (47) a. ʔuŋ.hmêəw ʔʌw jêəw bʌw.pʰuŋ cʰeh [ʔi nʌŋ-ʔoh kʰə̀lə̀əp]
 yesterday 1SG see friend CLF REL IRR-buy house
 ‘Yesterday, I met the friend who will buy a house.’
- b. ʔuŋ.hmêəw ʔʌw jêəw bʌw.pʰuŋ cʰeh [ʔi nʌŋ-bu:-ʔoh kʰə̀lə̀əp]
 yesterday 1SG see friend CLF REL IRR-NEG-buy house
 ‘Yesterday, I met the friend who will not buy a house.’ (pc_3)

¹¹This is only a general distinction. Animals, for example, can be relativized by *ʔi* or *pʌŋ*, depending on the intention of the speaker.

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Temporal clauses are introduced by *ʔəkʰjuŋ* ‘time’ (48) which can be interpreted as the relative construction ‘the time when’, or by a conjunction like *ʔà:j* ‘before’ (49).

- (48) [*ʔəkʰjuŋ bu:-deəh pi ʔλw pλʔ kʰəleəp*] *ʔλw nɔh.hɲjap-maʔ*
 time NEG-come elder.sibling 1SG LOC house 1SG worried-NEG
 ‘When my brother did not come home, I was not worried.’
 (ENEG_13_M_1/2_167)

- (49) a. [*ʔà:j teəh māj tλʔ ʃûŋ təmâ:j dʃ*] *hmò māj kû:n māj*
 before take 2SG OBL work new ANA ask 2SG father 2SG
 ‘Before you accept that new job, ask your father.’
 b. [*ʔà:j ɲjλm teəh māj tλʔ ʃûŋ təmâ:j dʃ*] *hmò māj kû:n māj*
 before not.yet take 2SG OBL work new ANA ask 2SG father 2SG
 ‘Before you don’t accept that new job, ask your father.’ (pc_3)

In (49b), the negator *ɲjλm* ‘not yet’ is used, but neither the prefix *hɔj-* ‘NSIT’ nor the secondary verb *hò:j* occur in the positive clause (49a). That means, *ɲjλm* is not triggered by the aspectual markers, but its use depends on the intention of the speaker.

For the complements in (50), an English translation with a finite as well as a non-finite verb is possible.

- (50) a. *ʔλw jêəw ʔû:n [hôm ʔân]*
 1SG see keep eat 3SG
 ‘I saw that she was eating.’
 ‘I saw her eat.’
 b. *ʔλw jêəw ʔû:n [bu:-hôm ʔân]*
 1SG see keep NEG-eat 3SG
 ‘I saw that she was not eating.’
 ‘I saw her not eat.’ (pc_3)

This brings up the question about finiteness in Rumai. Bisang (2001) discusses this feature from different views. These are finiteness as a scalar phenomenon and finiteness due to morphological or syntactical reasons. Rumai lexical verbs are invariable in their form, but there are the aspectual affixes and postverbal secondary verbs. If there are clause types, where some of these markers are excluded, or at least very uncommon, one could say that these clauses are less finite. However, this needs more research.

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Complement clauses following verbs of thinking (51) and saying (52) are constructed like main clauses. This means that they are verb medial, and they use the negators of main clauses. The suffix *-ma?* is possible, but not frequent in these complement clauses.

- (51) a. $\text{ʔ}\lambda\text{w } t^h\text{a}\eta$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}$]
 1SG think 3SG IRR-come
 ‘I think he will come.’
 b. $\text{ʔ}\lambda\text{w } t^h\text{a}\eta$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-ʔa:w-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}(-\text{ma?})$]
 1SG think 3SG IRR-NEG-come-NEG
 ‘I think he will not come.’
 c. $\text{ʔ}\lambda\text{w } \text{ʔa:w-}t^h\text{a}\eta\text{-ma?}$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}$]
 1SG NEG-think-NEG 3SG IRR-come
 ‘I don’t think he will come.’
 d. $\text{ʔ}\lambda\text{w } \text{ʔa:w-}t^h\text{a}\eta\text{-ma?}$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-ʔa:w-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}(-\text{ma?})$]
 1SG NEG-think-NEG 3SG IRR-NEG-come-NEG
 ‘I don’t think he will not come.’ (pc_3)
- (52) a. $\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } d\Lambda\text{h}$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}$]
 3SG say 3SG IRR-come
 ‘He said that he will come.’
 b. $\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } d\Lambda\text{h}$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-ʔa:w-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}(-\text{ma?})$]
 3SG say 3SG IRR-NEG-come-NEG
 ‘He said that he will not come.’
 c. $\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } \text{ʔa:w-d}\Lambda\text{h-ma?}$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}$]
 3SG NEG-say-NEG 3SG IRR-come
 ‘He didn’t say that he will come.’
 d. $\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } \text{ʔa:w-d}\Lambda\text{h-ma?}$ [$\text{ʔ}\hat{\text{a}}\text{n } n\Lambda\eta\text{-ʔa:w-de}\hat{\text{a}}\text{h}(-\text{ma?})$]
 3SG NEG-say-NEG 3SG IRR-NEG-come-NEG
 ‘He didn’t say that he will not come.’ (pc_3)

Conditional clauses are verb-medial, nevertheless, like other dependent clauses, the negators are limited to *bu:-* (53) and *ɲjɿm* (54).

- (53) [$s\Lambda$ $m\hat{\text{a}}j$ $\text{bu:-t}\hat{\text{ə}}\text{p}\hat{\text{a}}\text{:w}$] $m\Lambda\eta\text{-j}\hat{\text{o}}\text{h}$ $\eta\hat{\text{ə}}\text{r}\hat{\text{a}}\text{:j}$
 COND 2SG NEG-listen 2SG.IRR-fall hell
 ‘If you don’t listen, you will fall to hell.’ (WPKT_14_L_082)

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- (54) a. [k^hΛ māj hɔj-teəh hâ:j] pù ɲâj
COND 2SG NSIT-take wood blow fire
‘If you have brought the wood already, make a fire.’
b. [k^hΛ māj **ɲjam** teəh hâ:j] teəh cɒŋ.naj
COND 2SG not.yet take wood take now
‘If you haven’t brought the wood yet, bring it now.’ (pc_3)

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

In Rumai, there are no negative lexicalizations. The only negative marker that comes close to them is *ɲjam* ‘not yet’. It is probably derived from a former verb with the meaning ‘dilatory’ or ‘stiff’. However, as it usually replaces the new situation prefix *hɔj-* and/or the secondary verb *hâ:j* ‘finish’ of the positive clause, it is part of the Rumai aspect system, and is therefore treated in the section about standard negation (§2.1).

3 Non-clausal negation

Non-clausal negation is rare in Rumai. The only examples which have been found so far are answers to questions that include ‘already’ in the translation. The features of the other structures intended in this section will be described in as much detail as possible.

3.1 Negative replies

Example (55) shows a positive and a negative question, and (56) shows the corresponding answers.

- (55) a. sɒw bjɔh lɒh
dog bark Q
‘Is the dog barking?’
b. sɒw ʔa:w-bjɔh hɒh
dog NEG-bark Q
‘Is the dog not barking?’ (pc_3)

The answers to both questions are clausal, and they are the same. This means that the positive answer *bjɔh* ‘bark’ does not agree with the polarity of the neg-

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ative question and the negative answer ('not bark') not with the polarity of the positive question.¹²

- (56) a. *bjɔh* (ʔɣ)
bark ASRT
'Yes.' (the dog is barking)
b. *ʔa:w-bjɔh-maʔ*
NEG-bark-NEG
'No.' (the dog is not barking) (pc_3)

The assertive marker *ʔɣ* is not obligatory, and so negation in the answers is symmetric.

Questions including *hɔʔ* (57) which is usually translated by 'already' (see also §2.2.2) can be answered in two ways. The first answers are clausal (57b and 57c), and the second ones are not (57d and 57e).

- (57) a. *mâj ʃɣh hɔʔ kâ*
2SG buy PTCL car
'Did you already buy the car?'
b. *ʃɣh hò:j*
buy finish
'Yes.'
c. *ɲjɔm ʃɣh-maʔ*
not.yet buy-NEG
'No.'
d. *hɔʔ*
PTCL
'Yes.'
e. *ɲjɔm*
not.yet
'No.' (pc_3)

These answers, which are a simple *hɔʔ* for the positive one and *ɲjɔm* 'not yet' for the negative one, are the only non-clausal answers so far detected in Rumai.

¹²Several studies propose different categories of polar answers. However, the sample of Rumai answers is too small to draw a conclusion in this respect. For more information about polar answers see for example Moser (2018) and Enfield et al. (2019).

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3.2 Negative indefinites and quantifiers

There are five indefinites in Rumai that are also used in negative clauses. Three of them are derived from interrogatives, namely *hmeəʔ* ‘any’ from *hmeə* ‘which, when’, *c^hiʔ* ‘anyone’ from *c^hi* ‘who’ and *siʔ* ‘something, anything’ from *si* ‘what’. Additionally, there are the indefinite pronoun *ʔi* ‘others’ and the experiential prefix *təm-* ‘ever’. All the clauses that include indefinites are negated by means of standard negation.

The use of the indefinite *hmeəʔ* ‘any’ in negative clauses is shown in (58) and (59).

- (58) *cəʔuʔ ʔa:w-məəh pʌʔ hmeəʔ*
 book NEG-exist LOC any
 ‘The book is nowhere.’ (pc_3)

- (59) *bun hmeəʔ mʌ ʔʌw bu:-bî māj*
 time any RESTR 1SG NEG-forget 2SG
 ‘I will never forget you.’ (WPKT_14_L_077)

Examples (60) and (61) illustrate *c^hiʔ* ‘anyone’ in a positive and a negative clause.

- (60) *c^hiʔ sʌ jʌŋ hŋja lûjʌbùj nʌŋ-kəŋâ tʌm jʌ:m*
 anyone COND sell tobacco white IRR-come.across punishment death
 ‘Anyone, if he sells heroin, will be punished with the death penalty.’
 (WPKT_14_L_096)

- (61) *pʌŋ səmâ jê c^hiʔ mʌ ʔa:w-bɛ-maʔ lʌʔ deəh bjâ bɣn*
 REL know 1PL.EXCL anyone RESTR NEG-can-NEG COMP come steal get
 ‘Nobody can steal what we know.’ (W1_025)

siʔ ‘something, anything’ is also used in positive (62) and in negative (63) clauses.

- (62) *kap lo cʌm rɛən siʔ mʌ jʌw ʔun.sətà dih*
 tight need INCL do anything RESTR fear heat DISC
 ‘Although there was something to do, we feared the heat.’
 (C3_17_MS_9_057)

- (63) *ʔʌn ʔa:w-kəsòj dʌh-maʔ siʔ*
 3SG NEG-respond say-NEG anything
 ‘He doesn’t respond to anything.’ (WPKT_14_L_271)

The indefinite pronoun *ʔi* ‘others’ is shown in (64) and (65). The semantics of this pronoun suggest that the speaker is excluded, but this is still to be clarified.

- (64) *pjatəna nî ʔi bɛ lʔ p^hje*
 problem PROX others can COMP answer
 ‘Anyone can solve this problem.’ (pc_3)

- (65) *ʔa:w-meəh-maʔ ʔi nʌ ʔəp^hje*
 NEG-exist-NEG others know answer
 ‘Nobody knows the answer.’ (pc_3)

Examples (66) and (67) show the use of the experiential prefix *tʌm-*.

- (66) *ʔà:j nî māj tʌm-cʌ:m lʌh kũŋ korijâ*
 before PROX 2SG EXP-reach Q state Korea
 ‘Have you ever been in Korea before?’ (WPKT_14_L_044)
- (67) *ʔʌw ʔa:w-tʌm-cʌ:m-maʔ*
 1SG NEG-EXP-reach-NEG
 ‘I have never been there.’ (WPKT_14_L_045)

3.3 Negative derivation and case marking

There are no special expressions for meanings like absence, opposition or antonymy in Rumai. Instead, these meanings are expressed by common lexical and syntactical means. Examples (68–70) show some of these constructions.

- (68) a. *pen dâ*
 good use
 ‘useful’
 b. *bu:-pen dâ*
 NEG-good use
 ‘useless’ (pc_3)
- (69) *c^hiʔ ɲjʌm dih-maʔ bəəh nî*
 anyone not.yet read-NEG text PROX
 ‘This text is unread.’ (lit. ‘No one has read this text so far.’) (pc_3)
- (70) *c^hiʔ bu:-bɛ-maʔ lʔ dih bəəh nî*
 anyone NEG-can-NEG COMP read text PROX
 ‘This text is unreadable.’ (lit. ‘No one can read this text.’) (pc_3)

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4 Other aspects of negation

The phenomena discussed in this section are not negative constructions or expressions themselves but occur in connection with negation.

4.1 The scope of negation

In Rumai, the scope of negation is dependent on the context. This means, the negator(s) keep their usual position and there are no scope-indicating morphemes. In (71), the scope is on the object and in (72) it is on the whole clause.

- (71) ʔλw dih-maʔ cəʔuʔ ʔλw dih bèə
 1SG read-NEG book 1SG read text
 ‘I am not reading a book but a letter.’ (pc_1)
- (72) buɲ hmeəʔ mλ ʔλw tλm-gô:j-maʔ mandale
 time any RESTR 1SG EXP-stay-NEG Mandalay
 ‘I have never lived in Mandalay.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_051)

Not much about the scope of negation in Rumai is known so far, and more research is needed.

4.2 Negative polarity

No negative polarity items have been found in research on the language so far.

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation.

Negation does not affect the marking of noun phrases in Rumai.

4.4 Reinforcing negation

The negative suffix *-maʔ* that was originally the means for reinforcing negation is pragmatically bleached today as it is used very frequently, and it may also be the sole negator in a clause (73).¹³

- (73) kê nλ-maʔ ʔuɲ.dλ:n hméə kê nλŋ-hâ:w
 3PL know-NEG way which 3PL IRR-go
 ‘They don’t know which way they have to go.’ (EMR_19_M_3_026)

Whether prosody plays a role in reinforcing negation is not yet clear.

¹³See also §2.1., especially the comment after example (6), and §4.6.2 for Jespersen Cycle.

4.5 Negation, coordination and complex clauses

According to the present database, there are no special coordinators, constructions for contrastive negation, or negative conjunctions in dependent clauses in Rumai.

For example, “neither...nor” constructions are expressed by a simple juxtaposition of two clauses (74), or the coordination of objects (75), showing standard negation. Whether the choice of the negators, namely *-maʔ* in (74), and *ʔa:w-...-maʔ* in (75) is mandatory in these constructions is still to be clarified.

- (74) ʔʌw dih-**maʔ** cəʔuʔ ʔʌw dih-**maʔ** bèəh
 1SG read-NEG book 1SG read-NEG text
 ‘I am neither reading a book nor a letter.’ (ENEG_13_M_1/2_004)

- (75) ʔʌn ʔa:w-ʔyh-**maʔ** səkjɛ tu klô:j
 3SG NEG-buy-NEG cucumber and banana
 ‘He buys neither a cucumber nor a banana.’ (pc_3)

tu ‘and’ is not very frequent in the corpus, but it is also used in positive clauses, so that the meaning ‘nor’ can be excluded.

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

In this section, negative transport (§4.6.1) and diachronic observations (§4.6.2) are discussed.

4.6.1 Negative transport

By negative transport, the negation of an independent clause is interpreted as the negation of the predicate of a dependent clause (Miestamo 2009: 223). In such a reading, in sentences like (76c) and (77c), not the thinking would be negated but the coming, and the sentences would be nearly synonymous with (76b) and (77b), respectively. However, in Rumai there is no evidence for this phenomenon. The two clauses in the corresponding Rumai sentences (76, here repeated from 51) and (77) have both AVP word order as it is usual in independent clauses, and like in other independent clauses, they can be negated by *ʔa:w-* and *-maʔ*, the negators that never occur in dependent ones. So, in these Rumai sentences there is rather coordination than subordination. Furthermore, the sentences can be translated by using different negators, as it is shown in (76) and (77). The translations are from the same consultant but elicited independently at different times.

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- (76) a. ʔλw t^haŋ ʔân nΛŋ-deəh
1SG think 3SG IRR-come
'I think he will come.'
- b. ʔλw t^haŋ ʔân nΛŋ-ʔa:w-deəh(-maʔ)
1SG think 3SG IRR-NEG-come-NEG
'I think he will not come.'
- c. ʔλw ʔa:w-t^haŋ-maʔ ʔân nΛŋ-deəh
1SG NEG-think-NEG 3SG IRR-come
'I don't think he will come.'
- d. ʔλw ʔa:w-t^haŋ-maʔ ʔân nΛŋ-ʔa:w-deəh(-maʔ)
1SG NEG-think-NEG 3SG IRR-NEG-come-NEG
'I don't think he will not come.' (pc_3)
- (77) a. ʔλw t^haŋ ʔân nΛŋ-deəh
1SG think 3SG IRR-come
'I think that he will come.'
- b. ʔλw t^haŋ ʔân nΛŋ-bu:-deəh-maʔ
1SG think 3SG IRR-NEG-come-NEG
'I think that he will not come (anymore).'
- c. ʔλw t^haŋ-maʔ ʔân nΛŋ-deəh
1SG think-NEG 3SG IRR-come
'I don't think that he will come.'
- d. ʔλw t^haŋ-maʔ ʔân nΛŋ-bu:-deəh
1SG think-NEG 3SG IRR-NEG-come
'I don't think that he will not come.' (pc_3)

4.6.2 Diachronic notes and observations

The introduction of *-maʔ* was probably due to reinforcement of the negation and there might be a Jespersen Cycle, as it is known in other languages and shown for French by van der *van der Auwera* (2010: 78–79). The possible stages for Palaung are shown in Table 4, which follows van der *van der Auwera* (2010: 79).

However, there is a difference between dependent and independent clauses. While the dependent clauses still stay on Stage 1, the independent ones are on Stage 3. As already mentioned, most of the dependent clauses are verb initial, and a postverbal negator in verb-initial languages is highly unusual, as *Dryer*'s (1988) study shows.

Table 4: Stages of negation in Rumai

Stage 1	→	Stage 2	→	Stage 3	→	Stage 4	→	Stage 5
<i>bu:-</i>		<i>bu:-</i>		<i>bu:-</i>		<i>bu:- -ma?</i>		<i>-ma?</i>
		<i>bu:- -ma?</i>		<i>bu:- -ma?</i>		<i>-ma?</i>		
				<i>-ma?</i>				

Dependent clauses are, as described by Bybee (2001), more conservative than independent ones. Therefore, the original general constituent order in Palaung was probably VS/VAP. Then, one can assume that the general negator in Rumai was originally *bu:-*. Only after the constituent order in independent clauses completely changed to AVP, was the postverbal *-ma?* introduced. (Weymuth 2014)

5 Conclusion

In Rumai, the expression of negation is dependent on the clause type. While the negative morphemes *ʔa:w-* ‘NEG’, *bu:-* ‘NEG’, *-ma?* ‘NEG’ and *ɲɲam* ‘not yet’ can all be used in independent clauses, the use is restricted to *bu:-* and *ɲɲam* in dependent ones. The constituent order change from VAP to AVP in the Rumai independent clauses is probably the reason for this feature, because postverbal negators are very unusual in verb initial languages. Additionally, there are the prohibitives *k^hu:-* and *maj-*. The latter seems only to be used, when a corresponding positive imperative clause does not make sense and therefore, it may rather express a well-meaning advice. The negative suffix *-ma?* was originally a means for reinforcing the negation but today it is widespread, and it can also be used alone, so that it is rather a neutral negator now. There might be a Jespersen Cycle with only *bu:-* on stage 1, resulting in *-ma?* as the only negator on stage 5. However, the dependent clauses are still on stage 1, and the independent ones are on stage 3, where the two negators can either be used alone or together. Furthermore, the construction *bu:-V-ma?* often expresses the meaning of ‘not anymore’ in independent clauses. Several aspects of negation in Rumai, like the scope of negation, are still unclear and need more research. Table 5 summarizes the Rumai morphemes connected to negation and their functions.

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Table 5: Rumai morphemes connected to negation

Morpheme	Function
<i>bu:-</i>	Main negator in dependent clauses In independent clauses, in combination with <i>-ma?</i> , implicitly or explicitly ‘not anymore’
<i>ʔa:w-</i>	Main negator in independent clauses
<i>-ma?</i>	In combination with <i>bu:-</i> , <i>ʔa:w-</i> and <i>ɲjɒm</i> , sometimes reinforcement of negation
<i>ɲjɒm</i>	Negator in absence of another negator ‘not yet’
<i>k^hu:-</i>	Prohibitive
<i>maj-</i>	Prohibitive
<i>huuh</i>	Question particle used in negative questions, but not itself negative

Abbreviations

1	first person	LOC	locative
2	second person	MED	medial
3	third person	NEG	negative
ANA	anaphoric demonstrative	NMLZ	nominalizer
ASRT	assertive	NSIT	new situation
CLF	classifier	OBL	oblique
COMP	complementizer	PL	plural
CONC	concessive	PN	proper name
COND	conditional	POL	polite
DES	desiderative	PROH	prohibitive
DISC	discourse marker	PROX	proximal
DUR	durative	PTCL	particle
EXCL	exclusive	Q	question marker
EXP	experiential	REL	relativizer
INCL	inclusive	RESTR	restrictive
IPFV	imperfective	SG	singular
IRR	irrealis	TCL	topic-comment linker

6 Appendix

Structure of the data labels

- 1. Short name: shortcut_year_place of recording/edition
- 2. _consultant(s)/author_example in toolbox
- 3. pc_X: personal conversation with consultant X

First letter of the shortcuts:	Places:
C conversation	M Mandalay
E elicitation	MS Man Sat (Nam Hkam township)
N narrative	L Lashio
P picture story	
W written text	

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Sources of the examples

Short name	Description
C3_17_MS	Conversation about the life in a village
EGGD_16_M	Questionnaire about the use of “give” and “get” and about ditransitive constructions, English
ENEG_13_M	Questionnaire about negation, Burmese/English
ENEG_14_M	Questionnaire about negation, Burmese
EQB_17_M	Questionnaire about Burmese constructions, Burmese/English
EMR_19_M	Questionnaire resumptive pronoun, Burmese
EMSR_19_M	Questionnaire subordinate clauses, Burmese/English
N2_17_MS	About green tea cultivation in a village
PCHT_16_L	Picture story: The chicken thief. Béatrice Rodriguez. 2008. <i>Der Hühnerdieb</i> . Wuppertal: Peter Hammer Verlag.
WA_15_M	Sentences containing aspectual markers from: Sa Pe. 2015. <i>bjat gôj k^hêṇ bèə</i> [Being clever with texts]. Mandalay: Self-publishing.
WPKT_14_L	Phrase book Rumai – Shwe – Burmese – English. 2014. Lashio: Ta’ang Students and Youth Union.
W1	Story in <i>Our Ta’ang magazine</i>

Consultants

Nr.	Gender	Y.o.b.	Origin	Education	Occupation	Languages
1	f	1996	Na Aw Gyi village, Man Ton township		bachelor student	Rumai, Burmese, English
2	m	1994	Man Ton township		bachelor student, novice monk	Rumai, Burmese, English
3	m	1988	Man Sat village, Nam Hkam township	Bachelor diploma	monk	Rumai, Burmese, English, Pali
6	m	1993	Sar Lu village, Nam Hkam township		student	Rumai, Burmese
7	f	1959	Man Sat village, Nam Hkam township	Public school in Shan	housewife, farmer	Rumai, Shan, (Burmese)
9	f	1998	Pha Daen village, Nam Hkam township	Public school in Burmese	housewife, farmer	Rumai, Burmese, (English)

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Chapter 12

Negation in Nivkh

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Nivkh has a full spectrum of lexical and grammatical devices for expressing clausal negation. These devices are located at different points on the scale of grammaticalization and some of them are the result of grammatical reanalysis and areal contacts. This chapter discusses various aspects of the Nivkh system of negation both from synchronic and diachronic perspectives. A clear border is drawn between the expression of negation in declarative and non-declarative clauses. Except for this distinction, negation of all types of clauses in Nivkh follows common rules and uses basically the same devices. The discussion covers negation strategies in declarative, prohibitive and apprehensive clauses, negation in stative predications, coordinated and subordinate clauses, negative lexicalizations, negative replies, negative emphatics and indefinites, as well as the means of rendering caritive semantics and antonymic low-level negation. The material represents several different Nivkh varieties, which display a considerable variation, and comes from personal field data as well as from other extant sources, including collections of folklore texts.

Keywords: Nivkh, Nivhng, clausal negation, low-level negation, prohibitive, apprehensive.

1 The language

Nivkh (Gilyak, Ghilyak. ISO: [niv](#), Glottocode: [gily1242](#), [sakh1247](#)) is a language isolate spoken on Sakhalin Island and in the Amur region of Russia.¹ The language is traditionally classified as “Paleosiberian”, or “Paleoasiatic”, together with a number of other languages of Siberia and the Russian Far East. As a result of

¹The first version of this article was written in 2019, when Maksim Fedotov was affiliated with the Institute for Linguistic Studies, Russian Academy of Sciences.

historical expansion from a homeland in central Manchuria to the Lower Amur and further to Sakhalin, Nivkh has been formed as a continuum of several distinct idioms with the major split between Amur (Nivkh proper, [gily1242](#)) and Sakhalin (Nighvng, [sakh1247](#)) varieties, which, in fact, fulfill the criteria for separate languages and are mutually hardly comprehensible. The Amur Nivkh comprises Amur (A), West Sakhalin (WS) and North Sakhalin (NS) varieties, whereas the Sakhalin Nighvng consists of East Sakhalin (ES), Central Sakhalin (CS) and South Sakhalin (SS, extinct) varieties. The Amur variety is spoken along the Lower Amur on the continent, while the other varieties are used on the Sakhalin Island. Two other varieties covered in this paper are represented by the ES variety, which essentially differs from the A variety, and the WS variety, which can be seen as a transitional variety displaying a mixture of features typical of other varieties. Some of the given varieties can be further divided into several local variants. For this paper, the most essential division is between the Tymovsk (ES^T) and Nyivo (ES^N) variants of the East Sakhalin variety.

For a long historical period, Nivkh has been in close contact with the Tungusic languages both in the Amur area and on Sakhalin, as well as with Ainu (isolate) on Sakhalin. One may assume that during more distant historical times, Nivkh was also influenced by other, already extinct, local languages. More recent historical ties with Japanese and Russian languages date back to the mid-19th century, when the Russians began to settle in the Far East of Russia and on Sakhalin.

At the moment, Nivkh is a heavily endangered language, since the entire Nivkh population has switched to Russian. The current (2022) number of fluent Nivkh speakers, who are all bilingual, is hardly more than 50, with less than 25 for the Lower Amur, Amur Liman and West Sakhalin varieties, only 2 for the North Sakhalin variety, and less than 25 for the East Sakhalin variety.

The paper is based on personal field data collected during the period of 1989–2021 in the Amur area and on Sakhalin Island (also online),² as well as on other extant sources, including collections of folklore texts in different varieties. In most cases, the examples are given in their original transcription, but with an additional morphological segmentation and glossing. Throughout the paper, field examples are marked with an “FM” (= field materials), cf. “(Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:11)”; “(Fedotov FM2013)”.

Typologically, Nivkh is a (poly)synthetic language with a rather complex phonology and predominant suffixation. Possessor and object (including reflexive) markers are prefixed (or rather cliticized) to nouns and transitive verbs. Nivkh is well-known by its root/morpheme-initial consonant alternations, which take place at

²We are extremely grateful to all our consultants for their help in collecting the data on different Nivkh varieties.

morpheme boundaries and within noun and verb phrases.³ Nivkh phonological system has been undergoing various historical changes, the most prominent one being the loss of nasals in stem-final position.

Nivkh noun morphology distinguishes two numbers (singular vs. plural), as well as eight cases in the Amur varieties and seven cases in the Sakhalin varieties. The verbs are characterized by several aspects and moods and two tenses (non-future and future). Contemporary indicative finite forms are historically nominalizations, which explains the fact that these forms (optionally) agree with the subject only in number. The full differentiation of person and number is found only in imperative (hortative, jussive) forms. There are no adjectives that would be morphologically distinct from verbs, but practically all verbal stems irrespective of their meaning may function as adnominal modifiers (= participles) that occur in preposition to the head nominal.

At the level of the simple clause Nivkh displays some features of isolating structure, especially with respect to core arguments, which are typically unmarked. Nivkh has accusative alignment. The canonic word order (for transitive clauses) is [(TOPIC) (SUBJECT) OBJECT PREDICATE] (SOV). All modifiers, except for numeral / quantifier constituent, precede the head nominal. Adverbial clauses are formed by converbs (= dependent forms) of different origins and are arranged in chains concluded by the main clause. The latter, in turn, is built around the clause-final finite (= independent) form. Converbs render various interclausal relations, with the finest differentiation being made within the temporal converbs. Some converbs agree with the subject in person and number similarly to aforementioned finite forms.

Nivkh has a full spectrum of lexical and grammatical devices for expressing clausal negation. These devices are located at different points on the scale of grammaticalization and some of them are the result of grammatical reanalysis and areal contacts. There is also a considerable dialectal variation, which reflects historical developments and calls for diachronic explanations. A clear border is drawn between the expression of negation in declarative and non-declarative (prohibitive and apprehensive) clauses. Besides that, negation of all types of clauses in Nivkh follows some general rules and uses more or less the same devices.

³The words entering the complexes that are subject to morphological alternations are separated in the examples by “+”. For more details on Nivkh polysynthesis see (Mattissen 2003). The rules of morphophonological alternations are not discussed in this paper.

2 Clausal negation

This section discusses various devices for expressing clausal negation in declarative clauses (§2.1) and non-declarative (prohibitive and apprehensive) clauses (§2.2).

2.1 Standard negation

Standard negation, which is understood as negation in a simple declarative clause containing a verb (Miestamo 2005), is rendered in Nivkh by various synthetic and analytic verb forms with different history and degree of productivity. We will discuss the basic synthetic negative forms in §2.1.1 and the basic analytic negative forms in §2.1.2. As will be shown, each dialectal variety shows a clear tendency towards employing one or another type. A special synthetic negative habitual form will be discussed in §2.1.3.

2.1.1 Synthetic forms

Synthetic forms are formed by one of the following ways: (i) compounding of the lexical verb with the negative verb *ɣavr*- ‘not exist’, (ii) compounding of the lexical verb with the negative verb *lɔɣə*- ‘not have’, or (iii) suffixation.

In contemporary ES, basic negative synthetic forms are derived by compounding two verbal elements. The resulting complex verb behaves like a regular verb and may undergo subsequent inflection. The first element is the nominalized form of the negated lexical verb, which historically ends in the nominalizer *-ŋ*. Note that nominalizations together with a negative lexicalized verb are very frequent in the negative existential cycle, see Veselinova 2014. In many cases this unstable nasal has been lost in the speech of modern speakers; however, it still determines the quality of the initial consonant of the following element, namely the root of the negative verb *ɣavr*- ‘not exist’. Following the rules of morphophonological alternations, the bound form of this verb, which is used in the synthetic form, has the shape *-ɣavr*-. The negative verb root is synchronically perceived as a negative suffix, though its connection with the free negative verb is rather transparent (see §2.3 and §4.6.1, cf. (1)).⁴ This type of negative construction can be seen as symmetrical to the affirmative one, since the negated verb retains all

⁴Throughout the paper, the examples are given in (quasi)phonemic transcription, made with the International Phonetic Alphabet symbols. This transcription, however, is partly conventional. First, it does not reflect dialectal differences in the phonetic realization of cognate phonemes (such as /ɣ/). Second, in case of the examples taken from other authors — especially (Kreinovich Ms.), it is rather a transliteration from their Cyrillic notation into its rough IPA correspondence.

its categories, including finiteness/non-finiteness. The markers of various verbal categories follow the complex verb stem, as, for example, the future tense suffix *-i* in *vi-gavr-i-d=ra* ‘[I] won’t go’ in (2),⁵ or the iterative suffix *-t^ha* in *vi-gavr-t^ha-d-γun* ‘[usually we] don’t go’ in (3).

- (1) a. *Ni ra-d.*
1SG drink-IND
‘I drink / drank.’
b. *Ni ra-gavr-d.*
1SG drink-NEG-IND
‘I don’t / didn’t drink.’ [ES]
- (2) *N-əmk qo-gu-t ni klub-roχ vi-gavr-i-d=ra.*
1SG-mother be_ill-CAUS-CVB.NARR.1PL 1SG club-DAT go-NEG-FUT-IND=FOC
‘Because my mother is ill, I won’t go to the club.’ (Gruzdeva FM 1991)
[ES^T]
- (3) *Kə-χajnapə c^hχar+mi-roχ vi-j-d-γun. Ajv=at*
rain-CVB.CONC tree+inside-DAT go-FUT-IND-PL usually=FOC
vi-gavr-t^ha-d-γun.
go-NEG-ITER.1PL-IND-PL
‘Despite the rain, [we]’ll go to the forest. Usually we don’t go.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:141) [ES^T]

In the Amur varieties, standard negation is normally expressed by an analytic construction. However, in the future tense, the WS variety and seemingly some other Amur varieties utilize a similar synthetic strategy as in the ES variety, viz. compounding of lexical and negative verb stems, cf. (4) and (5). Note that in contrast to the ES example (2), where the future suffix *-i* is placed after the negative verb root, in these WS examples (from Panfilov 1965), the future suffix *-nə* precedes the negative verb root. This fact also defines the use of the allomorph *-gavr-*, which in this case follows the vowel.

- (4) a. *Qan p^hrə-ʃ.*
dog come-IND
‘The dog comes / came.’

⁵The causative suffix adds the causal meaning to the narrative converb and serves as a switch-reference marker.

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b. Qan p^hrə-nə-ɣavr-ʃ.

dog come-FUT-NEG-IND

‘The dog won’t come.’ [WS]

(5) Hə+umguola ʃatx=hagin vi-gu-nə-ɣavr-ʃ.

that+girl where=EMPH go-CAUS-FUT-NEG-IND

‘[He] won’t let the girl go anywhere.’ (Panfilov 1965: 160) [A]

Another synthetic negative form exists only in A and employs the negative possessive verb *ləɣə-* ‘not have’ (§2.3.2). This verb synthesizes with the stem of the lexical verb which is followed by the emphatic suffix *-Tə⁶* (§4.6.2). In this form, *ləɣə-* is fully grammaticalized as a pure negative marker and does not bear any possessive meaning. The whole construction can be seen as symmetrical to its affirmative counterpart, cf. (6). This synthetic construction is much rarer than the analytic form discussed below.

(6) If p^hrə-ivi-də-ləɣə-ʃ=ravej.

3SG come-PROG-EMPH-NEG-IND=FOC_EMPH

‘He’s not coming all the same.’ (Panfilov 1965: 160) [A]

2.1.2 Analytic forms

In various Nivkh varieties there are altogether three negative analytic constructions, all of which contain a nominalized form of a negated lexical verb and a negative verb. The corresponding lexical verb can be synchronically zero-nominalized, nominalized with the suffix ES *-(n)d* or the suffix *-k*.

In WS and A, standard negation is typically expressed by an analytic construction comprising a synchronically zero-nominalized lexical verb, which is marked by the dative suffix *-Toχ⁷*.⁷ Historically, this verb form ended in a nasal, which makes *-doχ* the correct allomorph in this context, according to the morphophonological rules. The resulting form is immediately followed by the negative verb *q^haw-* ‘not exist’, cf. (7–8):

(7) a. If p^hrə-ʃ.

3SG come-IND

‘S/he came.’

⁶The suffix has variants *-tə*, *-rə*, *-də*.

⁷The dative suffix has the variants *-toχ*, *-roχ*, *-doχ*. In some works on Nivkh, the final fricative of the dative suffix is transcribed as velar: *-tox*, *-rox*, *-dox*.

- b. If **p^hrə-dox q^haw-ʃ**.
 3SG come-DAT NEG-IND
 ‘S/he didn’t come.’ [WS]

- (8) If **p^h-ətək nəmɾ mu-jnə-ʃ+xrərə imŋ-dox p^hrə-dox q^hau-ʃ**.
 3SG REFL-father yesterday die-DES-NMLZ+because_of 3PL-DAT come-DAT
 NEG-IND
 ‘He didn’t come to their place (lit. ‘to them’) because of his father’s
 having fallen ill the day before.’ (Nedjalkov & Otaina 2013: 66) [A]

The negative form can be also derived from an ideophone. In example (9), it consists of the ideophone *poj* describing the visual image of smoke, the nominalized form of the auxiliary verb *ha-* ‘be / do so’, and the negative verb.

- (9) **T^huf poj ha-dox q^hau-ʃ**.
 smoke curl do_SO-DAT NEG-IND
 ‘The smoke doesn’t curl.’ (Panfilov 1965: 222) [A]

As can be seen from examples (7–9), in declarative epistemically neutral sentences the negative verb *q^haw-* is typically used in the indicative mood, which is marked by the suffix A *-ʃ* or *-c*. In the same context, the negative verb can also be used in the nominalized form in *-k* (an agentive nominalizer), cf. (10).

- (10) **Mu+bəvə-də-ləyət nən vi-nə-dox q^hau-k=ra**.
 boat+repair-EMPH-not_have-CVB.NARR.1PL 1PL.EXCL go-FUT-DAT
 NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC
 ‘Without repairing the boat, we won’t go.’ (Panfilov 1965: 160) [A]

In the speech of the modern speakers of the LA and WS varieties, the negative analytic construction has undergone further changes, so that the dative suffix is nowadays pronounced as *-to* or *-ta* or even *-tə* rather than *-dox*. The *-d > -t* change is in line with the general process of devoicing of plosives, which is attested in these varieties, whereas the loss of final *χ* and the *o > a* change are connected with the reduction that takes place in word-final unstressed syllables. As a result of these processes, the connection of this marker to the dative suffix is weakening and the whole construction is becoming further grammaticalized, cf. (11):

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- (11) a. Həj məkr-ʃ=ra.
that be_right-IND=FOC
'This is right.'
- b. Həj məkr-ta q^haw-ʃ.
that be_right-DAT NEG-IND
'This isn't right.' (Jushkina 2019) [AL]

The negative analytic complex displays regular inflection: aspect and modality are marked on the lexical verb, tense can be marked either on the lexical verb, as in (10) and (12a), or on the negative verb, as in (12b), whereas mood and finiteness / non-finiteness are marked exclusively on the negative verb, cf. the finite form of the negative verb in the adversative mood in (13):

- (12) a. Tə+als-ku pəpi-nə-dox q^haw-ʃ.
this+berry-PL be_sweet-FUT-DAT NEG-IND
'These berries won't be sweet.'
- b. Tə+als-ku pəpi-dox q^haw-nə-ʃ.
this+berry-PL be_sweet-DAT NEG-FUT-IND
'These berries won't be sweet.' [A]
- (13) Ni c^h-sa-dox q^hau-bənevo-ʒar.
1SG 2SG-beat-DAT NEG-PROB-ADVS
'It seems [that] I didn't beat you.' (Kreinovich 1934: 213) [A]

Synchronically, the entire analytic construction of negation is asymmetrical to the affirmative one, since the lexical verb loses its finiteness and is deverbalized (type A/Fin/(NegVerb) in Miestamo's (2005) classification).

Another analytic construction seems to be used only in ES and is attested only in Kreinovich Ms.⁸ It is not known to the contemporary speakers. This construction comprises the lexical verb in the nominalized form with the suffix *-(n)d*, which functions as an object to the negative verb *ɣavr*.⁹ Note that in the finite

⁸We refer to the unpublished Nivkh texts that had been collected by E. A. Kreinovich on Sakhalin in 1926–1928 (Kreinovich Ms.). Copies of these documents from the E. A. Kreinovich Fund in Sakhalin Regional Museum had been kindly provided to us by A. B. Ostrovskii (part of them were discovered by the Museum and part by A. B. Ostrovskii himself). Russian translations of these texts were made in 2012–2013 by N. Ja. Tanzina, V. N. Sachgun and G. I. Paklina in collaboration with A. B. Ostrovskii and were published separately in (Ostrovskii 2016, Kreinovich 2016). The authors are grateful to A. B. Ostrovskii, M. M. Prokofiev, and Sakhalin Regional Museum for the opportunity to use these data.

⁹In the texts this verb is recorded as *xovr*- or *xavr*- with the initial velar voiceless fricative.

predicative form the suffix *-(n)d* was reanalyzed as an indicative mood marker. In example (14a), one can see the nominalized form *lu-nd* ‘singing’ and the finite form of the negative verb *xovr-nd*. The contemporary synthetic variant of the same construction is given in (14b).

- (14) a. Ni vuu-nd. Ni **lu-nd+xovr-nd**.
 1SG cry-IND 1SG sing-NMLZ+NEG-IND
 ‘I’m crying, I’m not singing.’ (Kreinovich Ms. : D824:12v–15, «Indən. Təlgund») [ES]
- b. Ni vuw-d. Ni **lu-gavr-d**.
 1SG cry-IND 1SG sing-NEG-IND
 ‘I’m crying, I’m not singing.’ (an adaptation of the same text into modern ES by G. I. Paklina) [ES]

Furthermore, Kreinovich’s texts contain examples of one more negative construction with the negative verb *kau-* (= *q^haw-*). Here, the nominalized lexical verb in the form of *-(n)d* apparently functions as a finite verb form, whereas the negative verb, which is also nominalized, forms an additional one-word clause, cf. *vi-i-nd=ra kau-k=re* ‘[I] won’t go’ in (15), in which one person quotes two different people.

- (15) J-aki. C^h-ingrə-i-nd=ra.
 3SG-elder_brother 2SG-go_together-FUT-IND=FOC
 ‘His elder brother [said]: I’ll go with you.’
- Ugrər **vi-i-nd=ra** **kau-k=re**.
 together go-FUT-IND=FOC NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC_EMPH
 ‘[The other person said:] [I] won’t go together [with you].’
- Niyəvəŋ+to-inə-tla agu-nd=ra[.] Park vi-inə-nd=ra.
 man+help-DES-ASRT.1SG not_want-IND=FOC only go-DES-IND=FOC
 ‘[I] don’t want to help the man. [I]’ll go myself.’ (Kreinovich Ms. : D363:1–13, «Pal təlgund») [ES]

An alternative negation strategy, which is used by some modern speakers of ES, can be seen as an extension of the basic synthetic form. It is formed through the following steps: First, according to the general rule, the negative verb *gavr-* combines with a lexical verb root. Then, the resulting negative stem is nominalized by the suffix *-k*, cf. *orbot-gavr-k* ‘a not working one’ in (16). The full form is ultimately created by the auxiliary verb *ha-* ‘be / do so’, which takes all verbal

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markers, including non-finite ones, cf. (16). Synchronically, this construction is structurally not symmetrical to the positive one, but it is likely that a parallel affirmative analytic construction once existed in ES, since the verb *ha-* ‘be / do so’ is widely used in this variety for deriving analytic forms.

- (16) *N-ətk orbot-cavr-k ha-ŋa eɣlŋ-gun+ŋrə~ŋrə-d.*
 1SG-father work-NEG-NMLZ.AGT do_SO-CVB.SIM child-PL+look~PLAC-IND
 ‘When my father didn’t work, he looked after the children.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 7) [ES]

2.1.3 Negative habitual form

Nivkh has also a specific negative habitual form that refers to a characteristic situation that does not hold at all times.¹⁰ Note that there are no positive habitual forms in Nivkh. This form is derived by the suffix *-Ksu*¹¹, which historically comes back to the negative verb ES *j-ayzu-*, A *j-ayzu-* ‘not know’ (§2.5), cf. (17–18):

- (17) *Jaŋ arak+ra-ysu-nt.*
 3SG vodka+drink-HAB.NEG-IND
 ‘He (usually) doesn’t drink vodka.’ [ES]
- (18) *C^haj+χav-u-t ra-ysu-ta.*
 tea+be_hot-TR-CVB.NARR.3PL drink-HAB.NEG-COORD.3PL
Civla+c^hax=park+ta~ra-ta.
 cold+water=only+drink~PLAC-COORD.3PL
 ‘[They] don’t drink hot tea (lit. [they] tea heating, don’t drink [it]), [they] drink only cold water.’ (Panfilov 1965: 161) [WS]

Like in other cases, in the A variety, the stem of the lexical verb can be followed by the emphatic suffix *-Tə*, cf. (19):

- (19) *C^hi ɲəŋ-dox p^hrə-də-ksu-ŋ.*
 2SG 1PL.EXCL-DAT come-EMPH-HAB.NEG-IND
 ‘You don’t [even] come to our [place].’ (Panfilov 1965: 161) [A]

2.2 Negation in non-declaratives

There are two types of non-declarative sentences that express negation either directly or intrinsically: prohibitives (§2.2.1) and apprehensives (§2.2.2).

¹⁰Cf. the definition of habitual aspect in (Comrie 1976: 27).

¹¹The negative habitual suffix has the variants *-ksu*, *-ysu*.

2.2.1 Prohibitives

Imperative (hortative, jussive) forms are the only forms in Nivkh that display a full differentiation of person and number. They are formed by attaching the suffixes listed in Table 1 to a verbal stem.

Table 1: Imperative suffixes in Nivkh

(a) Amur variety				(b) East Sakhalin variety			
	Singular	Dual	Plural		Singular	Dual	Plural
1	<i>-nəkta, -nəxta</i>	<i>-n(ə)te</i>	<i>-da</i>	1	<i>-</i>	<i>-nate</i>	<i>-da</i>
2	<i>-ja</i>	<i>-ve</i>	<i>-ve</i>	2	<i>-ja</i>	<i>-ve</i>	<i>-ve</i>
3	<i>-vazo</i>	<i>-vazo</i>	<i>-vazo</i>	3	<i>-varo</i>	<i>-varv(a)ro</i>	<i>-varv(a)ro</i>

In all varieties, the prohibitive meaning can be expressed by a dedicated prohibitive construction with the special negator *t^ha* which precedes, directly or non-directly, the corresponding positive imperative form. Prohibitive constructions are therefore completely symmetrical to the affirmative ones, cf. (20–22):

- (20) a. *P^hrə-ja.*
come-IMP.2SG
‘Come!’
b. *T^ha p^hrə-ja.*
NEG come-IMP.2SG
‘Don’t come!’ [ES]
- (21) *T^ha tus+p^hi-r̥ kəpr-ja.*
NEG here+be_situated-CVB.NARR.2SG stand-IMP.2SG
‘Don’t stand here!’ [ES]
- (22) *Ni i-xez-t it-c. T^ha valc-ja.*
1SG 3SG-tell-CVB.NARR.1SG say-IND NEG lie-IMP.2SG
‘I told him: “Don’t lie!”’ (Jushkina 2019) [AL]

Furthermore, the ES variety makes use of an alternative prohibitive strategy, which is identical to standard negation. In that case the negative verb *vavr-* synthesizes with the lexical verb and the yielded complex verb appears in the corresponding imperative form. Again, the negative form is symmetrical to the affirmative one, cf. (23–24):

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- (23) a. P^hṛə-ja.
come-IMP.2SG
'Come!'
b. P^hṛə-gavr-ja.
come-NEG-IMP.2SG
'Don't come!' [ES]
- (24) C^ho k^he+mi+si-n¹² huji-gavr-ve
fish fishing_net+inside+put-CVB.NARR.2PL.IMP leave-NEG-IMP.2PL
qanṇ-gun i-n-ṣar-i-d-yun.
dog-PL 3SG-eat-COMPL-FUT-IND-PL
'Don't [pl.] leave fish in the fishing nets, [otherwise] the dogs will eat it.'
(Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:38:316) [ES^T]

2.2.2 Apprehensives

Apprehensives¹³ are used when a speaker attempts to prevent undesirable consequences of the situation by means of appealing to the addressee (see e.g. [Lichtenberk 1995](#)). These forms can be seen as intrinsically negative. In Nivkh, there are special apprehensive forms, which contrast two evidential meanings (cf. [Kreinovich 1979](#): 316), specifying the source of fear. Basing on this parameter, one can distinguish: (i) direct (visual) apprehensives and (ii) inferential apprehensives.¹⁴

Visual apprehensive is issued in the situation when the speaker directly observes the situation that may lead to undesirable consequences. In the A variety, it is marked by the complex marker *-nəra* that comprises the future tense suffix *-nə* and the emphatic/direct evidential suffix *-ra* which is apparently used irrespective of the number of addressees and the person-number of the subject. The resulting meaning can be literally analyzed as 'be aware that sb. is going to do sth.!', cf. *vi-nəra* in (25):

¹²The suffix *-n* is a variant of the converbal suffix *-ŋ*, which is used when the finite verb occurs in the future or imperative forms.

¹³The corresponding forms in other languages are alternatively called 'lest' forms, timitives, evitatives, avoiditives, admonitives, preventives, dubitatives, precautionary imperatives, etc.

¹⁴This distinction seems to be typologically unusual. One example of a similar evidential contrast in apprehensive markers is found in Tariana, which has a visual and a non-visual apprehensive clitics ([Aikhenvald 2003](#): 384–387). We are grateful to an anonymous reviewer for this observation and for the reference.

- (25) Əlc-yo ɛŋgut oz-ve q^hotr vi-nəra.
 servant-VOC.PL quickly.2PL get_up-IMP.2PL bear go-APPR.VIS
 ‘Servants, get up quickly! [Otherwise] the bear will go away!’ (Panfilov 1965: 118) [A]

In the ES variety, there are two corresponding apprehensive markers differentiated by the number of addressees: *-inəŋra* for singular and *-inəŋta* for plural. Both markers contain (at least historically) the desiderative/intentional suffix *-inə* and the nominalizer *-ŋ*. The final segments *-ra* and *-ta* are the singular and plural variants of the emphatic/ direct evidential suffix that are used according to the number of the subject, as presented in Table 2. The resulting meaning is: ‘Be aware that sb. is going to do sth.!’ For instance, when the addressee(s) is/are going along a slippery road, the speaker may warn him/her/them, cf. (26–28).

- (26) a. Kuc-**inəŋra**.
 fall_down-APPR.VIS.2SG
 ‘[Careful,] don’t fall down!’
 b. Kuc-**inəŋta**.
 fall_down-APPR.VIS.2PL
 ‘Don’t [pl.] fall down!’ [ES]
- (27) Laṛk+vaχc-u-**jəŋra**.
 dress+burst-TR-APPR.VIS.2SG
 ‘Don’t tear your dress!’ (Gruzdeva FM1989: 3:13) [ES^T]
- (28) P^hŋafq^hŋafq+aɣaɣ-**inəŋta**.
 each_other+disturb-APPR.VIS.2PL
 ‘Don’t [pl.] disturb each other!’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:36) [ES^T]

Inferential apprehensives are used when the speaker foresees undesirable consequences basing not on direct evidence, but on previous experience. These forms seem to be very rare in the A variety. They are mentioned in (Kreinovich 1979: 316) in connection with the following example. Giving away a fragile object for a temporary use, the speaker is warning the addressee: *zosq-ijra* [break-APPR.INFR] ‘don’t break [it]!’. The inferential apprehensive marker *-ijra* or *-əjra* consists of the emphatic/evidential suffix *-ra* and the segment *-ij* or *-əj* with an unknown origin, cf. (29):

- (29) Ola atak+vapak c^hi zosq-əjra.
 child.voc grandfather+toy 2SG break-APPR.INFR
 ‘Child, don’t break grandfather’s toy!’ (Panfilov 1965: 224) [A]

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The corresponding forms also exist in the ES variety, where there are two inferential apprehensive markers opposed by number of the addressees: *-jaŋra* for singular and *-jaŋta* for plural. Both variants comprise the same component *-ja*, which can be probably connected with the 2SG imperative marker *-ja*, and the nominalizer *-ŋ*. The final components, i.e. *-ra* in the singular and *-ta* in the plural are of the same origin as the corresponding components of the visual apprehensive markers discussed above, cf. (30):

- (30) a. **Zosq-jaŋra.**
break-APPR.INFR.2SG
'Don't break [it]!'
b. **Zosq-jaŋta.**
break-APPR.INFR.2PL
'Don't [pl.] break [it]!' [ES]

Table 2: Distribution of common elements of suffixes of the apprehensive forms and the negative purposive converb

	Singular	Dual	Plural
first person	<i>t</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>t</i>
second person	<i>r</i>	-	<i>t</i>
third person	<i>r</i>	-	<i>t</i>

2.3 Negation in stative predications

Existential (§2.3.1), possessive (§2.3.2) and locative (§2.3.3) predications are verbal both in the affirmative and the negative and have a similar structure. Affirmative existential and locative clauses are differentiated by verbal predicates employed in the predicative position, but this differentiation is absent in the negative constructions. Due to the lack of adjectives as a separate part-of-speech category, there are no special attributive predications. Equative clauses (§2.3.4) are built only with nominal predications, whereas ascriptive clauses (§2.3.5) contain either nominal or nominalized predicates, following a well-known cross-linguistic tendency (Veselinova 2013b). The most versatile negators for all stative predications are the negative verbs ES, WS *qavr-* (intransitive), *bavr-* (transitive), WS, A *q^haw-* (intransitive) 'not exist'. All three verbs are diachronically connected to each other (§4.6.1).

2.3.1 Negation of existential predications

Affirmative existential clauses are formed with the clause-final verb *jiv-* ‘exist, have’ and have the structure [EXISTEE NP (subject, unmarked) EXISTENTIAL/POSSESSIVE V (predicate)], cf. (31). In case the clause contains a NP indicating location, the latter is typically case-marked with the locative (in A) or the ablative (in WS and ES) or is followed by a locative postposition and occupies the topical clause-initial position. The structure of the clause is then [LOCATIVE NP (topic, marked) EXISTEE NP (subject, unmarked) EXISTENTIAL/POSSESSIVE V (predicate)], cf. (31–32). In colloquial speech, especially in dialogues, the existential/possessive verb can be omitted, cf. (33).

- (31) Q^ho-ror t^hət oz-ŋan v-emaŋax
 sleep-CVB.DIST morning get_up-CVB.SIM 3SG-old_woman
 ily+ha:s+imə-ŋ. Na+sŋaj jiv-ra
 made_of_deerskin+clothes+give-IND beast+image exist-COORD.3SG
 c^ho+sŋaj jiv-ra.
 fish+image exist-COORD.3SG
 ‘When, after sleeping, [he] got up, his old woman gives him clothes made
 of deerskin. There was an image of a beast, there was an image of a fish.’
 (Panfilov 1965: 226) [A]
- (32) Mulk+mi-x als jiv-ŋ.
 birch_bark_basket+inside-ABL berry exist-IND
 ‘There are berries in the birch bark basket.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 2) [WS]
- (33) Q: Təf+mi-x aŋ?
 house+inside-ABL who
 ‘Who’s in the house?’
 A: Təf+mi-x ɲ-əmək.
 house+inside-ABL 1SG-mother
 ‘My mother is in the house.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 2) [WS]

Existential predications can be negated in several ways. Folklore texts in the various dialectal varieties contain clauses with the general negator *q^haw*, which occurs in the predicative position without any derivational or inflectional markers. The negated structure is [EXISTEE NP (subject, unmarked) NEGATOR (predicate)], which is similar to the affirmative one, except that the predicate, which completes the clause, is non-verbal, cf. (34–35):

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- (34) Niyəvəŋ **kxáu**:¹⁵ puiŋa **kxáu** mifŋa **kxáu** c^ho **kxáu** tol'ŋa
 man NEG bird NEG land_animal NEG fish NEG sea_animal
kxáu:.
 NEG

‘There are no men, no birds, no land animals, no fish, no sea animals.’
 (Kreinovich Ms. D540:7–15+22–24v, «Nuyə k^hen jaqr... [1]») [ES]

- (35) Hə+pət aŋcəj ivŋ+ŋarmu-j. Napa **q^hau**.
 that+tomorrow again 3PL+wait-IND still NEG
 ‘Tomorrow [he] waits for them again. [They’re] still not [here].’ (Panfilov 1965: 248) [A]

Another type of negative existential clauses has a symmetrical structure to the affirmative one, i.e. [EXISTEE NP (subject, unmarked) NEGATIVE V (predicate)], and can be further extended by the locative NP. In the ES variety, the predicate is the intransitive negative verb *qavr-*, cf. (36), which in the A variety has the form *q^haw-* ‘not exist’. In the WS variety, the negative verb is attested in both forms, cf. (37). Constructions with the intransitive negative verb are also used for negation of locative predications (§2.3.3).

- (36) Ni c^hma-t pɾə-nd=ra. Min+ŋaŋk
 1SG visit-CVB.NARR.1SG come-IND=FOC 1PL.INCL+friend
 c^h-wo+ker-i-d=lo. Keɾ **kxavr-d=ra**...
 2SG-settlement+tell-FUT-IND=Q news NEG-IND=FOC
 ‘I came to visit. Our friend [says]: “Will you tell about your village?” –
 “There’s no news...”’ (Kreinovich Ms. D536b:13–14v, «Pilan tav jakr...») [ES]

- (37) Kulu-ɾ t^hər-ŋan i-t^həmɾ **q^hau-γət-c**.
 open_eyes-CVB.NARR.3SG look-CVB.SIM 3SG-polecat NEG-COMPL-IND
 ‘When, opening [his] eyes, he looked, his polecat wasn’t there.’ (lit.
 ‘There was no his polecat.’) (Panfilov 1965: 248) [WS]

In the ES variety, there is an alternative way to encode negative existence with the negator *ujye* ‘not be’, which goes back to the nominal/verbal root *ujyi-* ‘[be] a sin’. In the A variety, this item is still used almost exclusively in its original lexical meaning, cf. (38). The negator can be used in the predicative position as it

¹⁵ *kxáu* corresponds to *q^hau-*.

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is, cf. (39), or it can function as a verbal stem *ujyi-* taking various types of suffixes, cf. (40).

- (38) Mackə+oʁla-gu huŋrə-ʃ+vo-ʃ **uiy-ʃ=ra.**
 be_small+child-PL be_like_that-NMLZ+take-NMLZ be_sin-IND=FOC
 ‘It’s a sin for small children to take [something] like that.’ (Panfilov 1965: 225) [A]
- (39) Pax=paŋk ʁə+kuʦi **uigé.**
 stone=only door+hole NEG
 ‘There’s no opening for a door [made] of stone.’ (Pilsudski Ms., text 3) [ES]
- (40) Nin+du cʰo sik **ujyi-ʁar-d.**
 1PL.EXCL+lake fish all NEG-COMPL-IND
 ‘There’s no fish in our lake.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:12) [ES^N]

The following text passage (41) illustrates various devices for expressing negative existence in the ES variety:

- (41) Əyɾəŋəfk mɾolv+əɾŋ-ux nud=ziŋ **qavr-ʁar-d.**
 long_time_ago be_ancient+time-ABL what=EMPH NEG-COMPL-IND
 Nud+mif=ciŋ nud+niyʋŋ=ʃiŋ nud=ziŋ moŋka-k
 what+land=EMPH what+man=EMPH what=EMPH be_alive-NMLZ.AGT
qavr-d. Nud+ŋa=ziŋ cʰo=ziŋ **ujyi-d.** Cʰxul cʰaχ=pəŋk.
 NEG-IND what+beast=EMPH fish=EMPH NEG-IND completely water=only
 Tʰas=ciŋ tʰas=ciŋ nud=ziŋ tʰmərmə=ʃiŋ **ujyi-d.**
 where=EMPH where=EMPH what=EMPH move=EMPH NEG-IND
 ‘Long time ago, at ancient times, there was nothing. No land, no man, nothing alive. There were no animals, no fish. Only water. Nowhere, nowhere, there was no one moving.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000/2013: 8) [ES^N]

In the WS variety, existentials can be also negated with the verb *ləyə-* ‘not have’, which is otherwise utilized for possessive negation (§2.3.2) or as a basic negator within a synthetic negative form (§2.1). This verb is usually transitive, but it is not completely clear how it behaves in existential predications. One of the WS speakers notes that, in contrast to the neutral negative verb *qʰaw-*, the verb *ləyə-* brings up a connotation of unexpectedness (= mirativity), cf. (42). It may also have a rather abstract negative meaning, cf. (43):

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- (42) Ni məy-t j-ama-ba
 1SG come_down-CVB.NARR.1SG 3SG-look-CVB.IMM
 c^h-mu+ləyə-ta.
 2SG-boat+not_have-EVID.DIR.1SG
 ‘When I came down [to the shore], when [I] looked, your boat wasn’t there (unexpectedly).’ (lit. “there was no your boat”) (Gruzdeva FM2019: 11) [WS]
- (43) Ni morqa-nə-j=lu ləyə-nə-j=lu?
 1SG be_alive-FUT-IND=Q not_have-FUT-IND=Q
 ‘Will I be alive or not?’ (Panfilov 1965: 160–161) [A]

2.3.2 Negation of possessive predication

Possessive clauses (which involve indefinite possesses) are also formed by the existential/possessive verb *jiv*- ‘exist, have’, but it is additionally required to make a reference to the possessor. The structure of a possessive clause depends on the dialectal variety.

In the ES variety, possessive predication is built on the model of a transitive clause, so that the verb *jiv*- takes the possessee NP as an object: [POSSESSOR NP (subject, unmarked) POSSESSEE NP (object, unmarked) + EXISTENTIAL/POSSESSIVE V (predicate, transitive)]. As a result, the verb drops its initial *j*-, which is typical of Nivkh transitive verbs that bear the 3SG object marker, cf. (44a) and (49a). In colloquial speech, the existential/possessive verb can also be omitted, cf. (45).

- (44) a. Ni c^hχa+iv-d.
 1SG money+exist-IND
 ‘I have money.’
 b. Ni c^hχa+iv-gavr-d.
 1SG money+exist-NEG-IND
 ‘I don’t have money.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:42) [ES^N]
- (45) Ni eylɿ+me-nɿ.
 1SG child+two-CLF.HUM
 ‘I have two children.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:48) [ES^N]

In the WS and A varieties, the possessive clause employs the same verb *jiv*- ‘exist, have’, but the structure of the clause is different. It is intransitive, maintains the structure of the existential clause and forms a construction of the “Topic

Possessive” type in terms of (Stassen 2009: 58): [POSSESSOR NP (topic, unmarked) POSSESSEE NP (subject, unmarked) EXISTENTIAL/POSSESSIVE V (predicate, intransitive)]. The possessee NP functions as a subject, whereas the possessor NP functions as a topical clause-initial element. The corresponding clause can be literally translated as ‘As for POSSESSOR NP, POSSESSEE NP exists’. The intransitivity of the verb is confirmed by the fact that the verb *jiv-* does not drop its initial *j*, which is illustrated by examples (46) and (47). Alternatively, especially in the modern language, the possessor can be expressed by the locative case, cf. (48), resulting in a construction belonging to Stassen’s “Locational Possessive” type.

- (46) If mu+me-kr jiv-ra.
 3SG boat+two-CLF.GNR exist-EVID.DIR.3SG
 ‘He has two boats.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 10) [WS]
- (47) T^hayrp^hik oŋla+ŋe-n=pak jiv-ra...
 middle_one child+one-CLF.HUM=only exist-COORD.3SG
 ‘The middle [brother] has one child...’ (Panfilov 1965: 160) [A]
- (48) C^h-ujn c^ho jiv-bara.
 2SG-LOC fish exist-ADVS
 ‘You certainly have fish.’ (Panfilov 1965: 121) [A]

In the ES variety, possessive clause is often negated in adherence to the standard negation strategy by synthesizing the negative verb *ɣavr-* with the existential/possessive verb *j-iv-* cf. (44b) and (49b). The resulting construction is symmetrical to the corresponding affirmative one. Note that this strategy is not used for negating existential clauses.

- (49) a. Xevgun mam+iv-d.
 Xevgun old_woman+exist-IND
 ‘Xevgun has a wife.’
- b. Xevgun mam+iv-ɣavr-d.
 Xevgun old_woman+exist-NEG-IND
 ‘Xevgun doesn’t have a wife.’
- c. Xevgun mam+ɣavr-d.
 Xevgun old_woman+NEG-IND
 ‘Xevgun doesn’t have a wife.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:44) [ES^N]

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In addition, possessive negation can be rendered by placing the standard negative verb in the predicative position. In the ES variety and occasionally in the WS variety the transitive verb *Ɂavr*-takes the possessee NP as an object, so that the structure of the clause is symmetrical to the affirmative one [POSSESSOR NP (subject, unmarked) POSSESSEE NP (object, unmarked) + NEGATIVE V (predicate, transitive)], cf. (49c), (50), and (51):

- (50) Jaŋ nud=ziŋ+**Ɂavr-Ɂar-d**.
3SG what=EMPH+NEG-COMPL-IND
'He doesn't have anything.' [ES]
- (51) Hə+haɁs c^hup-xiŋ c^hŋaj+**Ɂavr-ɟ**.
that+clothing at_all-INS image+NEG-IND
'These clothes don't have any images at all.' (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1) [WS]

In the A and WS varieties, it is the intransitive negative verb *q^haw-* that takes the predicative position in a negative possessive clause, so that the resulting structure is also symmetrical to the affirmative one: [POSSESSOR NP (topic, unmarked) POSSESSEE NP (subject, unmarked) NEGATIVE V (predicate, intransitive)], cf. (52–53). In such constructions, the topical element can also be case-marked with the locative, cf. (54).

- (52) Əŋrəkon+ŋivŋ-gu pila+vəŋ q^hau-ɟ.
ancient+man-PL be_big+cauldron NEG-IND
'Ancient people didn't have big cauldrons.' (Panfilov 1965: 160) [A]
- (53) Aŋ=hakisk q^haw-ɟ.
who=EMPH NEG-IND
'There's nobody.' (Gruzdeva FM2019: 2) [WS]
- (54) N-ujn c^ho q^haw-ɟ=ra.
1SG-LOC fish NEG-IND=FOC
'I don't have fish.' (Panfilov 1965: 121) [A]

Alternatively, possessive negation can be rendered by inherently negative possessive verbs. In the ES variety, it is the transitive verb *avli-* 'not have', cf. (55):

- (55) Jaŋ nanq-Ɂainapə ŋawɁk+**avli-d**.
3SG elder_sister-CVB.CONC brain+not_have-IND
'Though she's an elder sister, [she] lacks the brain.' (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:32) [ES^T]

For the same purpose the WS and A varieties use another transitive verb *ləʔə-* ‘not have’, cf. (56). The subject of *ləʔə-* is often followed by the emphatic clitic *=Tə*:

- (56) *Нокә әкәҭ umgu jiv-ra. Hangr toҭ*
 then older_brother woman exist-COORD.3SG then middle_brother
umgu=də+ləʔə-ra.
 woman=EMPH+not_have-COORD.3SG
 ‘Then the older brother had a wife. Then the middle-brother didn’t have a wife.’ (Panfilov 1965: 160) [A]

2.3.3 Negation of locative predications

There are several constructions with locative predications that differ by their structure and the verbs used in the predicative position. The first construction is built on the model [LOCATEE NP (subject, unmarked) LOCATIVE NP (marked) LOCATIVE V (predicate)] and comprises the intransitive verb ES *hunv-*, WS/A *hum-* ‘be, live’. The topical clause-initial position is taken by NP indicating the locatee, whereas the referent of locative NP is conceived as a new information. This is the typical pragmatic structure of locative clauses that usually differentiates them from existential ones. However, in Nivkh, this model works rather straightforwardly only for elicited examples, whereas in narratives, the locative clause may have a structure similar to that of the existential one with the locative NP in the clause-initial position: [LOCATIVE NP (marked) LOCATEE NP (subject, unmarked) LOCATIVE V]. Furthermore, in an appropriate context a reference neither to the location nor to the located entity is obligatory. In the ES and WS varieties, the verb *hunv-*, *hum-* can be used only with animate referents, cf. (57–58), whereas in the A variety, *hum-* occurs with any referent irrespective of its animacy/inanimacy, cf. (59). As a predicate of locative clauses, the verb retains its locative meaning, but it has also been completely grammaticalized as a marker of continuative in other contexts, cf. the second verb *hum-* in (58).

- (57) *Tuҭ+hajmҭaҭ ҭe-ҭҭ=bəҭk tav-ux hunv-d.*
 this+old_man one-CLF.HUM=only house-ABL be-IND
 ‘This old man is/lives in the house alone.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:76) [ES^N]

- (58) Ni təf-toχ təvba-ŋan aŋ=hakisk ʁavɾ-γəɾ-c.
 1SG house-DAT come_in-CVB.SIM who=EMPH NEG-COMPL-IND
 Umgu-o:la=bə:k hum-ɾ hum-ɾ.
 woman-child=only be-CVB.NARR.3SG be-IND
 ‘When I came into the house, there was nobody [there], only a girl was there.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 3) [WS]
- (59) Siɟ=agin q^hau-ra paχ+ɲa-qɾ p^hal-uin hum-ra.
 what=EMPH NEG-COORD.3SG stone+one-CLF.GNR floor-LOC be-COORD.3SG
 ‘There’s nothing, there’s only a stone on the floor.’ (Panfilov 1965: 226) [A]

Another locative verb *Xu-* ‘be located [swh.]’ is used in all varieties only with inanimate referents and obligatorily requires a reference to the location. In all varieties, it functions as a transitive verb and takes a locative NP as an object, so that the clause structure is [LOCATEE NP (subject, unmarked) LOCATIVE NP (object, unmarked) + LOCATIVE V], cf. (60–61).

- (60) Pityaŋ ostol+vaj+xu-d.
 book table+under+be_located-IND
 ‘The book is under the table.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:18) [ES^N]
- (61) Umgu zu+ɲir-gu tər+t^hxə+xu-ɾ.
 woman wash+bowl-PL table+on+be_located-IND
 ‘The bowls (which) the woman had washed are on the table.’ (Nedjalkov & Otaina 2013: 280) [A]

One more type of locative predications can be formed by the transitive verb *Fi-*¹⁶ ‘be situated (swh.)’, which in all varieties takes a locative NP as an object. The construction with this verb has the structure [LOCATEE NP (subject, unmarked) LOCATIVE NP (object, unmarked) + LOCATIVE V], cf. (62–63).

- (62) Liɣɾ-kun tuŋ+p^hxi+fi-d-γun=la?
 wolf-PL this+forest+be_situated-PL=Q
 ‘Are there wolves in this forest?’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:16) [ES^N]

¹⁶The verb *fi-* has the bound variant *-p^hi-*.

- (63) Naf ɲ-umgu t^hama-r təf+p^hi-r
 now 1SG-woman not_do-CVB.NARR.3SG house+be_situated-CVB.NARR.3SG
 o:la-gu+t^hof-c.
 child-PL+take_care-IND
 ‘Now my wife, not doing [anything], staying at home, takes care of
 children.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 3) [WS]

Locative predications are negated in the ES variety with the transitive negative verb *ɬavr-*, so that the negative construction has the structure symmetrical to the affirmative one [LOCATEE NP (subject, unmarked) LOCATIVE NP (object, unmarked) + NEGATIVE V], cf. (64). This construction is different from the intransitive negative existential one (§2.3.1).

- (64) Mu muspi+ɬavr-d. Mu taf+lef+k^hu-d.
 boat shore+NEG-IND boat house+near+be_located-IND
 ‘The boat is not on the shore. The boat is near the house.’ (Gruzdeva FM2021: Mess.) [ES^T]

In the WS and A varieties, negation of locative predications is built according to the same model as negative existence and is expressed by the intransitive negative verb *q^haw-* ‘not exist’, cf. (65–66):

- (65) Mu co-wx q^haw-ɟ. Mu taf+laya hunɣum-ɟ.
 boat shore-ABL NEG-IND boat house+near be-IND
 ‘The boat is not on the shore. The boat is near the house.’ (Gruzdeva FM2020: Mess.) [WS]
- (66) Vi-ke p^h-ɣəf-tox vi-ra nanak q^hau-ra.
 go-CVB.DUR REFL-house-DAT go-COORD.3SG older_sister NEG-COORD.3SG
 ‘Going for a long time, [he] came to his house, [his] older sister wasn’t there [in the house].’ (lit. “there was no [his] older sister”) (Panfilov 1965: 225) [A]

2.3.4 Equative negation

Equative (or identificational) clauses equate the referents of the subject and the nominal predicate. The predicate of an equative clause is typically a regular noun phrase, which in all varieties takes the focus clitic =*Ta*,¹⁷ cf. (67a) and other examples below. No copula is needed in the non-future indicative, though in the

¹⁷The focus clitic has the variants =*ta*, =*ra*, =*da*.

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future the verb *mu-* ‘become’ must be used, cf. (70b). Equative clauses are negated in one of the following ways.

In the ES variety, the predicative position of the negative equative clause is typically occupied by the nominalized form of the negative verb *Ɂavr-*, in which case the negated NP seems to function as its attribute, cf. (67b).

- (67) a. *Tu+ɲiɣvɲ ɲ-χalɲ=da.*
 this+man 1SG-clan=FOC
 ‘This person is my relative.’
 b. *Tu+ɲiɣvɲ ɲ-χalɲ+Ɂavr-k.*
 this+man 1SG-clan+NEG-NMLZ.AGT
 ‘This person is not my relative.’ [Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:23] [ES]

In the A and WS varieties, equative negative predicates are formed by three elements: negated NP, the dative form of the nominalized auxiliary verb *ha-* ‘be / do so’ and the negative verb, which in (68b) occurs in the finite indicative form, which is historically also a nominalization. In example (69), which illustrates the contrastive negation, the negative verb is used in a nominalized form:

- (68) a. *Təʃ ɲ-axmalk=ra.*
 this_one 1SG-father_in_law=FOC
 ‘This one’s my father-in-law.’
 b. *Təʃ ɲ-axmalk ha-to q^haw-j=ra.*
 this_one 1SG-father_in_law do_so-DAT NEG-IND=FOC
 ‘This one’s not my father-in-law.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:11) [WS]
- (69) *Təʃ+ɲivx umgu=da utku ha-dox q^hau-k=ra.*
 this+man woman=FOC man do_so-DAT NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC
 ‘This person is a woman, not a man.’ (Panfilov 1965: 158) [A]

As can be seen from the following WS examples, in the future, the negative verb *q^haw-* can synthesize with the verb *mu-* ‘become’. Note that in the resulting form the place of the future marker may vary, cf. (70c) and (70d). Equative clauses seem to be the only type of clauses in which the negative verb *q^haw-* can be used as a part of a synthetic form in a similar way to the verb *Ɂavr-*.

- (70) a. *Təʃ+ɲivx ɲ-axmalk=ra.*
 this+man 1SG-father_in_law=FOC
 ‘This man is my son-in-law.’

- b. Tə+ɲivx ɲ-axmalk mu-nə-ʃ=ra.
 this+man 1SG-father_in_law become-FUT-IND=FOC
 ‘This man will be my father-in-law.’
- c. Tə+ɲivx ɲ-axmalk mu-nə-q^haw-ʃ=ra.
 this+man 1SG-father_in_law become-FUT-NEG-IND=FOC
 ‘This man won’t be my father-in-law.’
- d. Tə+ɲivx ɲ-axmalk mu-q^haw-nə-ʃ=ra.
 this+man 1SG-father_in_law become-NEG-FUT-IND=FOC
 ‘This man won’t be my father-in-law.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:11) [WS]

2.3.5 Ascriptive negation

Ascriptive clauses assign a certain property to the referents of their subjects. The predicate is either a full noun phrase, cf. (71), or a nominalized verb form, cf. (72a). The latter is derived from a verbal stem with the nominalizer *-k*. As with equative clauses, no copula is needed in the non-future. Negation of ascriptive clauses is done in the standard way. In case the predicate of an affirmative equative clause is itself a nominalized verb form, the negative verb ES/WS *ɣavr-* synthesizes with it, cf. (72b). WS and A make use of the standard analytic negative construction, cf. (73).

- (71) Liys umla+ɲa.
 wolf angry+beast
 ‘A wolf is an angry beast.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:26) [ES^N]
- (72) a. N-eylɲ mraɲi-k.
 1SG-child be_lazy-NMLZ.AGT
 ‘My child is a lazy one.’
 b. N-eylɲ mraɲi-ɣavr-k.
 1SG-child be_lazy-NEG-NMLZ.AGT
 ‘My child is not a lazy one.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:22) [ES^N]
- (73) N-oyla mraɲi-to q^haw-k. If mu-jvi-ʃ.
 1SG-child be_lazy-DAT NEG-NMLZ.AGT 3SG die-PROG-IND
 ‘My child is not lazy, he’s ill.’ (Gruzdeva FM2020: Mess.) [WS]

2.4 Negation in non-main clauses

In a complex sentence with subordinated clause(s), the main clause typically occurs sentence-finally and is built around a clause-final finite (= independent) form. Subordinate clauses are represented by complement, relative or adverbial clauses.

Complement clauses function as sentential complements to main clauses containing verbs of perception. The predicate of the complement clause is marked by the nominalizer ES *-(n)d/-t*, WS/A *-j/-c*, which synchronically also functions as the indicative marker in the finite verb form. Both clauses have the same structure and can be negated in the same way, cf. (74):

- (74) N-aki-rox jan janʃ p^h-rau-gavr-d+otot-ba
 1SG-older_brother-DAT 3SG why:3SG REFL-study-NEG-IND+ask-CVB.IMM
 jan p^he-kan cafrer-vuʃ it-t.
 3SG REFL-REP be_busy-CVB.REP.1SG say-IND
 ‘When [someone] asks my older brother, why he doesn’t study, he says [that] he’s busy.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:18) [ES^N]

Relative clauses are headed by noun-modifying participles and embedded into the main clause. They can also be negated with the standard negators without any restrictions, cf. (75–76):

- (75) Iosif mu+jivʏ-gu+ɲav+pos c^hka-viʃ ye-ʃ. Hoqororʃ
 Joseph boat+man-PL+wrap+cloth money-INS take-IND then
 krest-ux Iisus+ʁoc-ʃ pos-kiʃ ɲav-roʃ
 cross-ABL Jesus+take_off-CVB.NARR.3SG cloth-INS wrap-CVB.DIST.3SG
 aɲ=hakisk napa huŋk vaks-ta q^hau+huʃkif+si-ʃ.
 who=EMPH yet there bury-DAT NEG+cave+put-IND
 ‘Joseph bought the cloth in which dead bodies are wrapped, then [he] took Jesus’s body off the cross, wrapped [it] in the cloth and put it into the cave, where nobody was buried yet.’ (Stories 2017: 156) [WS]
- (76) Pil-də-ləʏə+dəf pal-uin hum-ʃ.
 be_big-EMPH-not_have+house forest_hill-LOC be-IND
 ‘A small house is situated on the forest hill.’ (Panfilov 1965: 160) [A]

Adverbial clauses are formed by converbs (= dependent forms) of different origin and are arranged in chains which end with the main clause. Converbs

Nivkh has a special negative purposive converb in ES *-lakr̥/-lakrt*, WS/A *-ləkrr̥/-ləkrt* with a complex marker which consists of the bound form of the lexical verb ES *lakr-*, WS/A *ləkr-* ‘fear’ and the suffix of the narrative converb ES *-r̥ : -t*, WS/A *-r : -t*. The converb agrees in person and number not with its own subject, but rather with the subject of the finite (= independent) verb, following the pattern in Table 2, cf. (77) and (78):

- All other converbs are negated according to the standard negation strategies used in one or another variety, cf. narrative converbs in (79–82), a simultaneous/anterior verb in (83), and conditional converbs in (84–85):

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- (80) Slovar-ux mer+dif-ku mək-r-da q^haw-gu-t
 dictionary-ABL 1PL.INCL+word-PL be_right-DAT NEG-CAUS-CVB.NARR.3PL
 raju-j-yu.¹⁸
 write-IND-PL
 ‘In the dictionary, [they] wrote our words wrong.’ (Jushkina 2019) [A]
- (81) Məx-ke i-ndə-ləyə-r
 come_down-CVB.DUR 3SG-look-not_have-CVB.NARR.3SG
 məy-r i-conr-tox pol-ra
 come_down-CVB.NARR.3SG 3SG-head-DAT fall_down-COORD.3SG
 mulk cosq-xət-ra.
 birch_bark_basket break-COMPL-COORD.3SG
 ‘When [he] was coming down, [he] didn’t look [around], [he] fell down
 on his head, the birch basket broke.’ (Panfilov 1965: 227) [A]
- (82) To-jrucez-r p^her-r q^ho-j.
 cry-be_unable-CVB.NARR.3SG be_tired-CVB.NARR.3SG sleep-IND
 ‘Not being able to cry [anymore], being tired, [he] fell asleep.’ (Panfilov
 1965: 248) [WS]
- (83) N-ətk cik p^hrə-ŋ-gavr-ŋa sikm
 1SG-father for_a_long_time come-NMLZ-NEG-CVB.SIM all
 xurŋuftu-d-yun.
 worry-IND-PL
 ‘When my father didn’t come for a long time, everyone worried.’
 (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:14) [ES^N]
- (84) C^hi tə+jus+ni-də-ləyə-ɬaj c^hi-y-nə-j=ra.
 2SG this+meat+eat-EMPH-not_have-CVB.COND 2SG-kill-FUT-IND=FOC
 ‘If you don’t eat this meat, [I]’ll kill you.’ (Panfilov 1965: 229) [A]
- (85) Məkr-gut nivɣjif+raju-da q^haw-ɬa
 correctly:3PL Nivkh_language+write-DAT NEG-CVB.COND
 mək-r-la+nivɣjif+bəzk-nə-j=ra.
 be_correct-QUAL+Nivkh_language+lose-FUT-IND=FOC
 ‘If [they] doesn’t write correctly in Nivkh, [they]’ll lose Nivkh. (Jushkina
 2019: 227) [A]

¹⁸The sentence can be literally translated as ‘In the dictionary, our words making wrong, [they] write.’

2.5 Negative lexicalizations

There is a whole inventory of lexical/lexicalized negative verbs, some of which have been already discussed in connection with stative predications (§2.3). Here we will examine negative verbs and some other lexemes that denote lack of desire, knowledge, attraction, physical ability, as well as some other negative meanings. Most of them fall in line with what Zeshan (2004) and Veselinova (2013a) identified for sign and spoken languages, respectively. The inherently negative verbs often (but not always) form semantic pairs with their positive counterparts. They do not require any explicit negators but in some exceptional cases can combine with them. In general, using a standard negator with an inherently negative lexeme is perceived by the speakers as ungrammatical. Some of the lexicalized negative verbs can be used both independently and as a part of the synthetic negative form, whereas the others are synchronically attested only in synthetic negative forms. In the latter case, the root of a lexicalized modal negative verb synthesizes with the root of a lexical verb. The resulting forms behave as a single verb and can be used both in finite and non-finite functions. Synthetic modal negative forms express two meanings: non-desire and non-ability.

2.5.1 Non-desire

Desire vs. non-desire is indicated by the pair of verbs ES *j-ayni*, cf. (86), WS/A *j-ayn-*, cf. (87), ‘want’ vs. ES *ayu-*, WS/A *ayi-* ‘not want’. In ES, the negative verb *ayu-* displays variation with respect to transitivity. This can be illustrated by example (88), where it occurs as a predicate of the main clause with a dislocated complement clause, and example (89), where it takes an oblique verbal complement formed by the locative nominalizer *-f* and the dative suffix. These negative verbs are often used in the beginning of imperative (hortative, jussive) sentences in the form of a bare stem ES *ayo*, cf. (90), and WS/A *ayi*, cf. (91), or in the imperative form, cf. (92) and *ay-ja* [not_want-IMP.2SG] with the meaning ‘Don’t do it!’, which is close to the prohibitive meaning (2.2.1). In the WS and A varieties, the corresponding verb *ayi-* is always transitive and takes a verbal complement derived by the nominalizer *-j/-c*, cf. (93). In all attested WS examples, the verbal complement contains the future suffix. Panfilov (1965: 163) notes that the verb *ayi-* is used rather rarely.

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- (86) C^{hi} p^h-əmk-aχ qo-ŋ-gavr-gu-jn-ayni-ɣaj
 2SG REFL-mother-ACC be_sick-NMLZ-NEG-CAUS-DES-want-CVB.COND
 jaŋ-aχ oχt+ra-gu-ja.
 3SG-ACC medicine+drink-CAUS-IMP.2SG
 ‘If you want your mother not to be sick, make her drink the medicine.’
 (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:152) [ES^T]
- (87) C^{hi} siʃ+ayp-j=ŋa?
 2SG what+want-IND=Q
 ‘What do you want?’ (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 494) [A]
- (88) Ni ayu-d=ra nin nud+xeraj-d-yun jaŋ-aχ
 1SG not_want-IND=FOC 1PL.EXCL what+say-IND-PL 3SG-ACC
 j-ajm-gavr-gu-jnə-d.
 3SG-know-NEG-CAUS-DES-NMLZ
 ‘I don’t want him to know what we said.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:10a) [ES^T]
- (89) Ni vi-jnə-f-toχ ayu-d.
 1SG go-DES-NMLZ.LOC-DAT not_want-IND
 ‘I don’t want to go.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:23, 193) [ES^T]
- (90) Huŋ+uniɾk it-t. ayo jan ətk+χa-jnə-d...
 that+cannibal say-IND not_want why.2SG father+shoot-DES-IND
 ‘This cannibal says: “Don’t do [that]! Why are you going to shoot at the father...”’ (Kreinovich Ms. D824:12v–15, «Indən. T^həlgur») (an adaptation of an old text into modern ES by G. I. Paklina) [ES]
- (91) Əyi huk-toχ vi-to q^haw-ja.
 not_want there-DAT go-DAT NEG-IMP.2SG
 ‘Don’t do that! Don’t go there!’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:24) [WS]
- (92) Nirəvun-kun polax-ŋa. axgu-ja
 man-PL cry-CVB.SIM not_want-IMP.2SG
 iz^hn+aprej-kun+var-kov-r morxov-ja.
 3PL+wife-PL+rot-NEG-CVB.NARR.2SG be_alive-IMP.2SG
 ‘People crying: “Don’t do [that]! Leave their wives alive!”’ (Kreinovich Ms. D824:12v–15, «Indən. Təlgund») [ES]

- (93) Хоҥоҥан j-acik
 then 3SG-younger_brother
 i-n-nə-j=ri+əyi-j=ra.
 3SG-eat-FUT-NMLZ=EMPH+not_want-IND=FOC
 ‘Then her younger brother didn’t want to eat.’ (Panfilov 1965: 163) [WS]

In all varieties, there is also another lexicalized intransitive negative verb *ker-* with a slightly different meaning ‘not want, refuse’. Due to scarcity of examples of its use, the syntactic behavior of *ker-* is not completely clear. Thus, in ES example (94), *ker-d=ra* behaves as the predicate of a separate clause, whereas in A example (95), *ker-j* takes oblique complements in the dative case:

- (94) Ni c^hi+lu-d ker-d=ra.
 1SG 2SG+sing-NMLZ/IND not_want-IND=FOC
 ‘I don’t want you to sing.’ (Kreinovich Ms. D824:12v–15, «Indən. T^həlguṛ») (an adaptation of an old text into modern ES by G. I. Paklina) [ES]
- (95) Ni c^hax+ta-inə-dox ker-j.
 1SG water+drink-DES-DAT not_want-IND
 ‘I don’t want to drink water.’ (Panfilov 1965: 162) [A]

The corresponding transitive form of *ker-* would be *yer-*, which, however, is not attested in its free form, but which must be the source of the bound root *-ger-* with a similar meaning. The latter is used in a synthetic modal negative form in which *-ger-* is synthesized with a nominalized lexical verb, as in *it-ŋ-ger-d* ‘refused to say’, cf. (96). This construction forms a parallel to the basic synthetic forms with the verb *ɣavr-* (see 2.1.1). In the A variety, the root of the negative verb is often preceded by the epenthetic vowel /i/, cf. (97), or by an emphatic element *-Ci*¹⁹ or *-Ta*, cf. (98).

- (96) Ja-mam j-otot-χajnapə jaŋ
 3SG-old_woman 3SG-ask-CVB.CONC 3SG
 nud=ziŋ+it-ŋ-ger-d.
 what=EMPH+say-NMLZ-not_want-IND
 ‘Though his wife asked [him], he refused to say anything.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:33:274) [ES^T]

¹⁹This emphatic element has the variants *-ci*, *-zi*, *-ji*.

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- (97) K^he vər̥k-ku-i-ger-t
 fishing_net be_spoiled-CAUS-EP-not_want-CVB.NARR.3PL
 se-u-t^ha-ʃ.
 dry-TR-ITER.3PL-IND
 ‘(They) dry fishing nets (because they) don’t want to spoil them.’
 (Panfilov 1965: 162) [A]
- (98) Hemaɲax ɲ-ax k^hrəu-gu-ʃi-ger-ʃ=ra.
 old_woman 1SG-ACC rest-CAUS-EMPH-not_want-IND=FOC
 ‘The old woman doesn’t want to let me rest.’ (Panfilov 1965: 162) [A]

A similar meaning of non-desire is expressed in the A variety by the synchronically bound verb *-mol(o)-*, cf. (99):

- (99) V-aɲχ j-oc-ɲar ici-mol-ra.
 3SG-wife 3SG-ask-CVB.SBJV answer-not_want-EVID.DIR
 ‘Though his wife asked, (he) didn’t want to answer.’ (Panfilov 1965: 162)
 [A]

2.5.2 Non-knowledgeability

Knowledgeability versus non-knowledgeability is most commonly expressed by the pair of transitive verbs ES *j-ajm-*, cf. (100), WS/A *j-ajm-/həjm-* ‘know [sb./sth.]’, cf. (101), vs. ES *j-ayzu-*, cf. (102), WS *j-ayzə-*, A *j-ayzu-*, cf. (103), ‘not know [sb./sth.]’. The negative verb obviously gave rise to the negative habitual suffix -*Ksu* (see §2.1.3). The verbs take either a nominal, cf. (103) or a clausal complement, cf. (104). The WS folklore texts demonstrate that the corresponding lexical meaning can be expressed by a bare verb stem, which retains its transitivity feature, cf. *ayzu* in (104).

- (100) Niyvɲ-gun j-ajm-d-ɣun t^həl̥v-ux u-xmu-d-ɣun.
 man-PL 3SG-know-IND-PL far_away-ABL RECP-fight-NMLZ-PL
 ‘People knew [that] [they] fought far away.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:2)
 [ES^N]
- (101) Nuknuko c^h-o:la paɲd-r pil-ɲan
 stop 2SG-child grow_up-CVB.NARR.3SG be_big-CVB.SIM
 c^hi+həjm-ʃ=ra.
 2SG+know-IND=FOC
 ‘Wait, when your child growing up will become big, [he]’ll get to know you.’ (Panfilov 1965: 228) [A]

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- (102) Ni j-ayzu-d=ra jaŋ hotoŋ-ux nud+ɣxop-d=lo.
 1SG 3SG-not_know-IND=FOC 3SG city-ABL what+do-NMLZ=Q
 ‘I don’t know what he is doing in the city.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:2a) [ES^T]
- (103) Hə+ɲivx p^h-oɣla+ayzu-ɣət-ra oɣla
 that+man REFL-child+not_know-COMPL-COORD.3SG child
 p^h-ətək+ayzu-ɣət-ra.
 REFL-father+not_know-COMPL-COORD.3SG
 ‘This man doesn’t know his son at all. The child doesn’t know his father at all.’ (Panfilov 1965: 161) [WS]
- (104) Lumɣ+c^həuɣ i-z-nə-j+ayzu.
 sable+take_out 3SG-skin-FUT-NMLZ+not_know
 ‘Taking out a sable [from a trap], [he] doesn’t know how to skin it.’
 (Panfilov 1965: 248) [WS]

The ES variety has yet another negative verb *qobr-* ‘not know’, which appears rarely, though it is attested in several elicited examples, cf. (105):

- (105) N=at qobr-d=ra naf t^hak-toχ vi-j-d=lo.
 1SG=FOC not_know-IND=FOC now where-DAT go-FUT-NMLZ=Q
 ‘I don’t know where to go now.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:118) [ES^T]

The verb WS *laja-*, A *laji-*²⁰, whose meaning also refers to the sphere of non-knowledgeability, implies less categorical negation and rather infers doubt than a complete lack of knowledge, cf. (106):

- (106) T^hajɣo-ra laja-j=ra.
 not_know-EVID.DIR doubt-IND=FOC
 ‘[I] don’t know, [I] doubt.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 4) [WS]

Additionally, there is a negative verb ES, A *t^hajɣo-* ‘not know’ (which can appear in the form *t^haj*). It is typically used as a one-word clause either in a sentence-final, cf. (107), or sentence-initial position, cf. (106) and (108). In the latter case it is typically used in a direct evidential form and is followed by another more explicit negative clause, or alone as an answer to a question.

²⁰The negative verb A *laji-* ‘not know’ is mentioned only in Panfilov (1965: 161) without any examples.

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- (107) P^{hi} t^hanx vəkz-d=zin t^hajxo-Ɂar-d=la?
REFL where lose-NMLZ=EMPH not_know-COMPL-IND=Q
‘Don’t you know at all where you lost [it]?’ (FM2000: 5:60) [ES^N]
- (108) T^hajxo-ŋra jaŋ p^h-ət+k+voci-d=lu.
not_know-EVID.DIR 3SG REFL-father+resemble-IND=Q
‘I don’t know [if] he resembles his father.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:10) [ES^N]

The word A *p^hanpara* is a bare stem of the verb, which is often translated as ‘not know’ or ‘not understand’. It seems to be impossible to find any examples of its use in the inflected form, besides a dictionary entry in (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 282), where it is represented in the indicative form *p^hanpara-j*. In all attested examples, the verb occurs sentence-finally and behaves as an extra-sentence one-word clause, cf. (109–110):

- (109) Hoŋguɾ ɾak-tox vi-ʃ=lu p^hanpara.
thus.3SG where-DAT go-IND=Q not_know
‘Thus, [he] doesn’t know where to go.’ (Panfilov 1965: 244) [WS]
- (110) I-z-nə-ʃ+əyzu jaŋgu-nə-ʃ p^hanpara.
3SG-skin-FUT-NMLZ+not_know how_do-FUT-IND not_know
‘[He] doesn’t know how to skin [it], doesn’t know how to do it.’
(Panfilov 1965: 248) [WS]

2.5.3 Non-attraction

Attraction vs. non-attraction is expressed in all varieties by the pair of transitive verbs *e-zmu-* ‘like’, cf. (111), vs. *e-sqa-* ‘not like’, cf. (112):

- (111) Andɣ-kun p^hrə-ba ɲi e-zmu-t^ha-ʃ.
guest-PL come-CVB.IMM 1SG 3SG-like-ITER.1SG-IND
‘I like when the guests come.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:122) [ES^T]
- (112) C^{hi} e-sqa-Ɂaj ɲi=pəɾk i-ɲ-i-d=ra.
2SG 3SG-not_like-CVB.COND 1SG=only 3SG-eat-FUT-IND=FOC
‘If you don’t want to eat, I’ll eat myself.’ (Kreinovich Ms. D824:12v–15,
«Indən. T^həlguɾ») (an adaptation of an old text into modern ES by G. I. Paklina) [ES]

2.5.4 Non-ability

Negative lexicalized verbs that covertly express the meaning of non-ability can be used independently only in the Amur varieties. The verb A *j-iki-* ‘be unable’ is also used predominantly in the bound form, but there are still a few examples of its independent use, cf. (113). When synthesizing with the lexical verb, *j-iki-* loses the initial *j* which marks transitivity, cf. (114):²¹

- (113) Ola ni p^her-j=ra. C^he-rka j-iki-j=ra.
son.VOC 1SG be_tired-IND=FOC 2SG-DEST 3SG-be_unable-IND=FOC
‘Son! I’m tired. I can’t cope with you.’ (Panfilov 1965: 225) [A]
- (114) Hə+baχ per-ka ni xici-j-iki-nə-j=ra.
that+stone be_heavy-CVB.COND 1SG lift-EP-be_unable-FUT-IND=FOC
‘If this stone is heavy, I won’t be able to lift it.’ (Panfilov 1965: 162) [A]

The verb ES/A *j-ali-* with a similar meaning is, on the contrary, used only as a full free transitive verb, cf. (115), which can take a clausal complement, cf. (116).

- (115) Ketv-r t^həŋrəŋa-j. Hoŋke j-ali-j.
stick-CVB.NARR.3SG not_move-IND so 3SG-be_unable-IND
‘Having stuck [it] doesn’t move. So [he] wasn’t able [to move] it.’
(Panfilov 1965: 226) [A]
- (116) If toŋa+mu+lət-c+ali-j.
3SG be_like_this+boat+make-NMLZ+be_unable-IND
‘He wasn’t able to make such a boat.’ (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 497) [A]

In the ES variety, the meaning of non-ability can be expressed by synthetic negative forms with the bound form of the verb *-rer-* ‘be unable’, cf. (117). This verb has an intransitive counterpart *ter-* with the meaning ‘be weak’.

- (117) Urgur q^ho-jnə-ŋa q^ho-rer-d.
well.3SG sleep-DES-CVB.SIM sleep-be_unable-IND
‘When [she] wanted to sleep well, [she] couldn’t sleep.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:14a) [ES^T]

A similar meaning ‘not achieve’ is rendered by the synchronically bound element ES *-(i)roter-*, A *-(i)rucez-*. This marker goes back to the converb suffix *-iro* marking an interrupted action and the modal verb ES *ter-*, A *cez-* ‘be weak’ (Panfilov 1965: 163), cf. (118–119):

²¹The *j* seen in this example is an epenthesis and not the 3sg marker.

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- (118) **Tlo-jroter-t.**
 run-not_achieve-IND
 ‘[He] couldn’t run.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:13) [ES^T]
- (119) **K^hlə-rx p^hu-ŋ vuu-ŋ. Vuu-rucez-ŋ=ra.**
 outside-DAT go_out-CVB.NARR.3SG cry-IND cry-not_achieve-IND=FOC
 ‘Going out (he) shouted. (He) didn’t get the answer.’ (Panfilov 1965: 163)
 [A]

2.5.5 Other negative lexicalizations

The motion intransitive negative verb *A t^həŋŋəŋa-* ‘not move’ has been exemplified by (115).

The verb ES *amtrer-*, *A amcez-* has the meaning ‘not have time, be late’ and is possibly connected, again, with the modal verb ES *ter-*, *A cez-* ‘be weak’ (Panfilov 1965: 163), cf. (120):

- (120) **Новаҥан hə+ŋivɣ+erq-ux oz-r q^haχ-kir**
 then that+man+side-ABL get_up-CVB.NARR.3SG spear-INS
e-sp-inə-ke amcez-ŋ.
 3SG-stab-DES-CVB.DUR not_have_time-IND
 ‘When that man getting up wanted to stab him with a spear, [he] didn’t have time.’ (Panfilov 1965: 163) [A]

One should also mention the WS/A pair *naw-* ‘be enough’, cf. (121), and *roj-* ‘not be enough’, cf. (122):

- (121) **Ni c^hχa+vo-ŋ. Ne-rχ naw-ŋ.**
 1SG money+get-IND 1SG-DAT be_enough-IND
 ‘I got money. I have enough.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:7) [WS]
- (122) **Jeski-ŋan maŋɣu əs roi-ŋ. Uski**
 sell-CVB.SIM Chinese money not_be_enough-IND payment
roi-ŋ.
 not_be_enough-IND
 ‘When [he] was selling, the Chinese didn’t have enough money. [There] was not enough payment. (Panfilov 1965: 250) [WS]

There are also verbs ES *j-akru-*, *A j-əkru-* ‘not believe’, cf. (123), and ES *j-axraw-* ‘not trust’, cf. (124):

- (123) Ni p^hi-də-gavr-χaj ena-gun+akru-j-d.
 1SG REFL-see-NEG-CVB.COND be_another-PL+not_believe-FUT-IND
 ‘If I hadn’t seen myself, I wouldn’t believe the others.’ (Gruzdeva
 FM2000: 4:18) [ES^T]
- (124) Ni c^h-axraw-d=ra.
 1SG 2SG-not_trust-IND=FOC
 ‘I don’t trust you.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:43) [ES^T]

3 Non-clausal negation

This section deals with negative replies (§3.1), negative emphatics and indefinites (§3.2), and the ways of expressing caritive semantics and antonymic low-level negation (§3.3).

3.1 Negative replies

In negative replies to polar questions, *q^hawk* or *q^hawkra* ‘no’ is used as the negative counterpart to *hə* or *həja* ‘yes’. The same negative word is used as a reaction to some proposal or in another appropriate context, cf. (125–127), but it cannot be used as a reply to content questions. Interestingly, this negative reply, which represents a nominalized form of the negative verb *q^haw-*, is used in all Nivkh varieties, including those in which the negative verb is used only in the form of *qavr-*. Most likely, it has been a secondary borrowing from A varieties to the Sakhalin ones. As a result of monophthongization, in the WS variety, this word is currently pronounced as *qa:k*. Besides the neutral focus clitic =*ra*, it can attach the emphatic focus clitic =*rej*, as in (127) in which one speaker quotes two other people. As one can see, Nivkh follows the general tendency to use a negative existential marker as a standalone negative answer (Veselinova 2013b)

- (125) Q: C^hi p^h-romsk c^hχa+ro-l?
 2SG REFL-together money+carry-Q
 ‘Do you have money on you?’
- A: Q^haw-k.
 NEG-NMLZ.AGT
 ‘No.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 1:43) [ES^N]

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- (126) Но́ваҗан if it-c. Q^hau-k=ra ni c^həŋ-doχ
 then 3SG say-IND NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC 1SG 2PL-DAT
 ler-inə-t p^hrə-ʃ=ra.
 play-DES-CVB.NARR.1SG come-IND=FOC
 ‘Then he said: “No, I came to compete with you.”’ (Panfilov 1965: 229) [A]
- (127) Хаҗа naf as^ʃxa җамгур it-nd. Hala vi-nate.
 then now younger_brother tit say-IND well go-IMP.1DU
 ‘Then the younger brother tit said: Well, let’s go!’
- Kau-k=rej[,] ni ʃas-to vi-i-ra[,] tund
 NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC_EMPH 1SG where-DAT go-FUT-EVID.DIR this_one
 ʃ-raf=ta[.]
 1SG-house=FOC
 ‘[The bird-woman said:] No, I won’t go anywhere. This is my house.’
- Vi-i-nd+agu-kaј ni c^h-xe-i-nd=ra.
 go-FUT-NMLZ+not_want-CVB.COND 1SG 2SG-take-FUT-IND=FOC
 ‘[The younger brother said:] If [you] don’t want to go, I’ll take you.’
- Kau-k=ra[,] təŋ+keŋ morxa-ra[,] loŋ
 NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC this+sun be_alive-COORD.3SG moon
 morxa-ra[,] ni vi-n-tox kau-k=ra[,] Ni
 be_alive-COORD.3SG 1SG go-NMLZ-DAT NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC 1SG
 əziŋ+iv-nd=ra[.]
 master+exist-IND=FOC
 ‘No, this sun is alive, the moon is alive, I won’t go. I have a master,’
- Ni cangi+iv-nd=ra[,] aјzi-ŋ+c^hevr^ʃkx+ʃanx it-nd.
 1SG boss+exist-IND=FOC be_golden-NMLZ+bird+woman say-IND
 ‘I have a boss, the golden bird-woman said.’ (Kreinovich Ms.
 D540:7–15+22–24v, «Nuyə k^hen ɲaqr... [1]») [ES]

3.2 Negative indefinites

Nivkh does not have inherently negative proforms, since those proforms which are used in the scope of negation may also occur in non-negative contexts. In all varieties, they are based on interrogatives, but rely on different clitics that are attached to the derivational base.

In the ES variety, proforms which are used in negative predications are essentially emphatics, cf. (128), and are formed from interrogatives with the emphatic

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clitic =*Ciŋ*, which is otherwise used for reinforcing negation (§4.4), cf. *naŋ* ‘who’ > *naŋ=ciŋ* ‘who (exactly), nobody’, cf. (129), *t^hawd* ‘which one’ > *t^hawd=ziŋ* ‘which one (exactly), no-one’, cf. (130), *nud* ‘what’ > *nud=ziŋ* ‘what (exactly), nothing’, cf. (131), *t^hanx* ‘where (non-precisely)’ > *t^hanx=ciŋ* ‘where (non-precisely, exactly), nowhere’, cf. (132), *t^has* ‘where (precisely)’ > *t^has=ciŋ* ‘where (precisely, exactly), nowhere’, cf. (41), ES^T *aŋŋ*, ES^N *əŋŋ* ‘when’ > ES^T *aŋŋ=ciŋ*, cf. (133), ES^N *əŋŋ=ciŋ*, cf. (134), ‘when (exactly), never’, *t^hans* ‘how many’ > *t^hans=ciŋ* ‘how many (exactly), none’, etc. All inflectional markers that are taken by a proform come before the emphatic clitic.

- (128) It-ja **aŋŋ=ciŋ** p^hŋə-j-d.
say-IMP.2SG when=EMPH come-FUT-IND
‘Tell [me], when [exactly] you’ll come.’ [ES]
- (129) Tu+daf **naŋ=ciŋ+iv-gavr-d**.
this+house who=EMPH+exist-NEG-IND
‘There’s nobody in this house.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:9) [ES^T]
- (130) Toqroq-ŋ-gavr-ve. Sikm oz-ŋar-d-ŋun=da. C^hin
sneak_up-NMLZ-NEG-IMP.2PL all get_up-COMPL-IND-PL=FOC 2PL
t^hawd=ziŋ+oz-u-gavr-i-d-ŋun=da.
which=EMPH+get_up-TR-NEG-FUT-IND-PL=FOC
‘Don’t sneak up! Everyone [has] got up. You won’t wake up anyone.’
(Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:40) [ES^T]
- (131) **Nud=ziŋ** huŋ+vo-wx **uŋŋi-d**.
what=EMPH that+settlement-ABL not_be-IND
‘There was nothing in that village.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:43:360) [ES^T]
- (132) Huz urla-ŋ+iv-v-ux c^ho-ŋun qavr-χaj
that_place be_good-NMLZ+exist-NMLZ.LOC-ABL fish-PL NEG-CVB.COND
t^hanx=ciŋ qavr-χar-i-d.
where=EMPH NEG-COMPL-FUT-IND
‘If there’s no fish in this good place, there’ll be no [fish] anywhere.’
(Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:98) [ES^T]

- (133) Nin exkun hoton-dox vi-j-ɤaj ni aɣɣ=ciŋ
 1PL.EXCL soon city-DAT go-FUT-CVB.COND 1SG when=EMPH
 huŋ+ɣaŋgeɤlŋ+ɣɣə-gavr-i-d.
 that+girl+see-NEG-FUT-IND
 ‘If we soon go to the city, I’ll never see that girl.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:1a)
 [ES^T]

- (134) Naɣ=ciŋ əɣɣ=ciŋ ɲ-zaxo-gavr-i-d.
 who=EMPH when=EMPH 1SG-deceive-NEG-FUT-IND
 ‘Nobody never will deceive me.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:13) [ES^N]

In other varieties, proforms which are used in negative predications have the same form as free-choice indefinites, cf. (135). Free-choice indefinites are themselves derivations from interrogatives. The corresponding interrogative attaches the zero-nominalized form of the auxiliary verb *ha-* in the instrumental case. The initial fricative of the auxiliary can be omitted, and the resulting form depends on the shape of the instrumental suffix, which is used in one or another variety, cf. WS/A *aŋ* ‘who’ > WS *aŋ=ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A *aŋ=ha-gin/-girn* ‘anybody, everybody, nobody’, cf. (136), WS/A *ɣaɣ* ‘which one’ > WS *ɣaɣ=ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A *ɣaɣ=ha-gin/-girn* ‘anybody, everyone, no-one’, cf. (137), WS/A *siɣ* ‘what’ > WS *siɣ=ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A *siɣ=ha-gin/-girn* ‘anything, everything, nothing’, cf. (138), WS/A *ɣatx* ‘where’ > WS *ɣatx=ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A *ɣatx=ha-gin/-girn* ‘anywhere, everywhere, nowhere’, cf. (139), WS/A *əɣɣ* ‘when’ > WS *əɣɣ=ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A *əɣɣ=ha-gin/-girn* ‘whenever, never’, cf. (140), WS/A *ɣaŋs* ‘how many’ > WS *ɣaŋs=ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A *ɣaŋs=ha-gin/-girn* ‘however many, none’, cf. (141), etc. All inflectional markers come before the clitic, cf. *ɣak-tox=hagirn* ‘to nowhere’. The elements WS *=ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A *=ha-gin/-girn* can be attached to other nominals to reinforce negation (§4.4).

- (135) Chⁱ aŋ=hakisk+oz-u-toɣ q^haw-nə-ɣ=ra.
 2SG who=EMPH+get_up-TR-DAT NEG-FUT-IND=FOC
 ‘You won’t wake up anyone.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:7) [WS]

- (136) Təɣ aŋ=hagin lət-nə-ɤavr-ɣ.
 this_one who=EMPH do-FUT-NEG-IND
 ‘Nobody will do this.’ (Panfilov 1965: 165) [A]

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- (137) Imŋ-ux ɾaʃ=hagin togut nə-nə-xavr-ʃ.
3PL-ABL which=EMPH in_such_way:3PL do-FUT-NEG-IND
'None of them will do so.' (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 319) [A]
- (138) Siʃ=akirk ivŋ+ar-xsu-ʃ.
what=EMPH 3PL+feed-HAB_NEG-IND
'They don't feed them with anything.' (Panfilov 1965: 247) [WS]
- (139) Ni ɾatx=hagin vi-nə-xavr-ʃ=ra.
1SG where=EMPH go-FUT-NEG-IND=FOC
'I won't go anywhere.' (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 321) [A]
- (140) Ni əʏr=hakisk vi-nə-xavr-ʃ.
1SG when=EMPH go-FUT-NEG-IND
'I'll never go [there].' (Gruzdeva FM2019: 7) [WS]
- (141) Raŋs=hagin+c^hχa q^hau-ʃ.
how_many=EMPH+money NEG-IND
'There's no money.' (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 320) [A]

In the early-20th-century folklore texts recorded by Kreinovich from presumably ES speakers, one can find proforms that are derived according to the WS and A model, cf. *rund* 'what' > *rund=ha-n-kir* [what=do_so-NMLZ-INS] 'anything, everything, nothing' in (142), *əʏr* 'when' > *əgr=a-n-kis^hk* [when=do_so-NMLZ-INS] 'whenever, never' in (143).

- (142) Ni rund=hankir it-n-tox kau-k=ra.
1SG what=EMPH say-NMLZ-DAT NEG-NMLZ.AGT=FOC
'I can't say anything.' (Kreinovich Ms. D536b:13–14v, «Pilan tav pakr...») [ES]
- (143) Əgr=ankis^hk i-ndə-n+xavr-n+ɲigəvən-kun xavru.
when=EMPH 3SG-see-NMLZ+NEG-NMLZ+man-PL NEG
'We never saw people.'²² (Kreinovich Ms. D546:21–22, «Təlgund [6]») [ES]

²²This sentence can be literally translated as 'Never people [that] we didn't see [there] were not.'

- (149) Ni ətək=rə+ləyǝ-t pan-j=ra.
 1SG father=EMPH+not_have-CVB.NARR.1SG grow-IND=FOC
 ‘I grew without a father.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:18) [WS]
- (150) Nəŋ vulvula+lep+romsk seta-də+ləyǝ ɛŋgut
 1PL.EXCL be_black+bread+with sugar-EMPH+without quickly:1PL
 cʰaj+ra-ta.
 tea+drink-COORD.1PL
 ‘We quickly drank tea with black bread and without sugar.’ (Panfilov 1965: 161) [A]

Antonymic (privative) low-level negation, corresponding to English *unkind* or Russian *nekrasivyy* ‘not beautiful’, has no special markers in Nivkh either. It is expressed as normal negation in a subordinate clause by a negative verb in a dependent form attached to the verb expressing the quality, cf. (151):

- (151) Vew-gavr-ŋ+du kəŋ-d.
 deep-NEG-NMLZ+lake freeze-IND
 ‘[There are two lakes, a deep one and a shallow one.] The shallow (lit. not deep) lake has frozen’. (Fedotov FM2013) [ES^T]

4 Other aspects of negation

This section provides information on the scope of negation (§4.1), negative polarity (§4.2), marking of NPs in the scope of negation (§4.3), reinforcing negation (§4.4), negation in coordinated and subordinated clauses (§4.5), and some diachronic observations (§4.6).

4.1 The scope of negation

In Nivkh, the scope of negation is the whole clause, since negation can be marked only on the predicate. There are no negative markers that would allow narrowing of the scope to a specific constituent. All attempts to elicit the relevant examples ended in producing standard negative constructions. On the other hand, virtually any constituent can be emphasized as being in the focus of negation with the emphatic clitic, without a special intonation and without changing the word order (§4.4).

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4.2 Negative polarity

Basically, Nivkh does not distinguish positive and negative polarity items. The only possible exception is represented by the negative emphatics in the ES variety, which seem to be gradually shifting from the affirmative to the negative domain (§3.2, §4.6.2).

4.3 Marking of NPs in the scope of negation

Case marking is not affected by negation in Nivkh.

4.4 Reinforcing negation

Negation can be reinforced by the emphatic clitics, which are attached to various constituents in the clause.

The clitics WS =*ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A =*ha-gin/-girn* function as scalar focus markers with the meaning ‘even’, cf. (Haspelmath 1997: 158) and example (152):

- (152) **If=hagin p^hrə-dox q^hau-j.**
 3SG=EMPH come-DAT NEG-IND
 ‘Even he didn’t come.’ (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 421) [A]

Another way to emphasize a single constituent, is to use the structure [interrogative + XP=EMPH], which is similar to the structure of proforms used in negative predications (§3.2). In the ES variety, the yielded form has just an emphatic reading both with and without negation, whereas in the WS and A varieties in the affirmative context it has a free-choice meaning ‘every XP’, cf. *siʃ + zir=hagin* ‘every tree’ in (153). In the scope of negation this meaning is understood as ‘no XP (whatsoever)’, cf. *nud + ox̣t=ziŋ* [what + medicine=EMPH] ‘no medicine’ in (154), and *siʃ + mu=hagin* ‘no boat’ in (155). The ES variety makes use of the emphatic clitic =*Ciŋ*, whereas in the WS and A varieties, the emphatic clitic has the form WS =*ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A =*ha-gin/-girn*.

- (153) **Siʃ+zir=hagin tuin pan-d ur-j.**
 what+tree=EMPH here grow-NMLZ be_good-IND
 ‘Every tree grows here well.’ (Panfilov 1965: 165) [WS]

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- (154) N-aki əki-q^hatn-d. Nud+oχt=ziŋ
 1SG-older_brother be_bad-AUG-IND what+medicine=EMPH
 ro-ŋ-gavr-i-d.
 help-NMLZ-NEG-FUT-IND
 ‘My older brother [feels] very bad. No medicine will help him.’
 (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:26) [ES]
- (155) Siŋ+mu=hagin kerq+tozu-nə-gavr-ŋ.
 what+boat=EMPH sea+CROSS-FUT-NEG-IND
 ‘No boat will cross the sea.’ (Panfilov 1965: 165) [WS]

Coordinated constituents can be also emphasized by emphatic clitics. In case of the ES variety, it is the clitic =Ciŋ, which can be used both in affirmative, cf. (156), and in negative predications, cf. (157–158). In the WS and A varieties, there are two possibilities. The first one is to use the clitic =Tə, cf. (159), which have been discussed in other sections, especially with regard to negative synthetic forms (2.1). Alternatively, one can utilize the clitic WS =ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk, A =ha-gin/-girn. This clitic can be also used both for positive, cf. (160), and negative, cf. (161–162), emphasis with the preference for the latter.

- (156) Ni ək=ziŋ muŋf=ciŋ orbot-i-d=ra pərk
 1SG night=EMPH day=EMPH work-FUT-IND=FOC oneself
 p^h-rau-jnəftoχ.
 REFL-study-CVB.PURP
 ‘I’ll work day and night in order to study.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:154)
 [ES^T]
- (157) Huŋ+c^hχar+mi-x milkmla=ziŋ alŋ=ciŋ pan-gavr-d.
 that+tree+inside-ABL mushroom=EMPH berry=EMPH grow-NEG-IND
 ‘Neither mushrooms, nor berries grow in that forest.’ (Gruzdeva FM1991: 3:15) [ES^T]
- (158) C^hi taf=ciŋ mam=ziŋ+gavr-ŋar-d.
 2SG house=EMPH wife=EMPH+NEG-COMPL-IND
 ‘You have neither a house, nor a wife.’ (Gruzdeva FM2000: 4:13) [ES^T]

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- (159) Tə+ap̃ ɲəɲ cʰo=rə+ɲəɲ-ysu-ta
 this+year 1PL_EXCL fish=EMPH+look_for-HAB.NEG-COORD.1PL
 ɲa=rə+ɲəɲ-ysu-ta ha-ʃ.
 beast=EMPH+look_for-HAB.NEG-COORD.1PL do_SO-IND
 ‘This year we didn’t fish [and] didn’t hunt.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:10)
 [WS]
- (160) Tunx sək malyo-ʃ. Als=hakisk puk=hakisk melʒa-ʃ.
 here all be_a_lot-IND berry=EMPH mushroom=EMPH be_full-IND
 ‘Here there’s a lot of everything. [The place] is full of berries and
 mushrooms.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:9) [WS]
- (161) Puk=hakisk als=hakisk tunx pan-də-xsu-ʃ.
 mushroom=EMPH berry=EMPH here grow-EMPH-HAB_NEG-IND
 ‘Neither mushrooms, no berries grow here.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:9) [WS]
- (162) If təf=hakisk+ɲavr-ra umgu=hakisk+ɲavr-ra
 3SG house=EMPH+NEG-COORD.3SG woman=EMPH+NEG-COORD.3SG
 ha-ʃ.
 do_SO-IND
 ‘He has neither a house, nor a wife.’ (Gruzdeva FM2019: 1:8) [WS]

4.5 Negation in coordinated and subordinate clauses

Nivkh has several types of complex sentences, in which clauses can be combined either by coordination or by subordination. There are no special negative coordinators or conjunctions. All clauses can be negated separately or together with the standard strategy. For negation in subordinate clauses, see §2.4.

Coordinated clauses are formed by chained finite forms with the suffix ES *-ra* : *-ta* : *-na*, WS/A *-ra* : *-ta*, optionally followed by the auxiliary verb *ha-* ‘be/do so’ in the appropriate morphological form. The following example (163) comprises a chain of possessive clauses, of which the first one contains the negative verb *ləyə-* ‘not have’.

- (163) Cij qʰola-f=tə+ləyə-ta kʰəs
 also be_ill-NMLZ.LOC=EMPH+not_have-COORD.2PL happiness
 jiv-ta sək-ujn pilagut amr-ta
 exist-COORD.2PL all-LOC a_lot_of.2PL have_time-COORD.2PL

ha-ve.

do_so-IMP.2PL

‘Also, don’t be ill, be happy, have a lot of success in everything.’

(Jushkina 2019) [A]

4.6 Miscellaneous aspects of negation

This section will focus on diachronic observations. There are several phenomena in the realm of negation that are of interest from diachronic perspective. This section presents a more detailed discussion of the negative verbs (§4.6.1) and emphatic clitics (§4.6.2).

4.6.1 Negative verbs

As has been noted, in the ES variety there are two negative verbs, of which *qavr-* (with initial plosive) is intransitive and *ɬavr-* (with initial fricative in its free form) is transitive. Without going into further diachronic explanations, let us note that this opposition of initial plosives vs. fricatives is typical of Nivkh verbs in all varieties. The verb *qavr-* is used exclusively in existential predications, whereas *ɬavr-* in its free form is employed in possessive and equative predications and in its bound form in most other types of predications. In the A varieties, the corresponding verb *q^haw-* is intransitive, it is used independently with existential predications and forms a part of analytic negative construction with other predications. The origin of this analytic construction should probably be searched in the contacts with the neighboring Tungusic languages, which have similar negative constructions and have influenced mainly the A varieties of Nivkh. Interestingly, in the A varieties there are no traces of the negative transitive verb, which would have an initial fricative in contrast to intransitive *q^haw-*, which begins with a plosive. It seems that synchronically *q^haw-* can be transitivized by the causative suffix *-gu/-ku*, cf. (80) and the following example from (Saveljeva & Taksami 1970: 148): *Taj q^hau-gu-ʃ* <spot NEG-CAUS-IND> ‘[She] eliminated the spot’. All this suggests that the rise of the transitive verb in the ES varieties may have taken place after the split of these two variants.

As for the phonological shape of the negative verb, it may be assumed that its protoform was **qawr-*, which subsequently developed into ES *qavr-* and A *q^haw-*, respectively. In the ES variety, in this particular word, a non-syllabic labial glide *w* underwent a development to labiodental *ɱ*, which is a different phoneme. As a result, the verb has acquired its current ES form: **qawr-* > *qavr-*. As for the A variety, the negative verb has retained the glide *w* in its original shape, but

has lost the trill *r*, which, again, is in line with the general process of loss of fricatives and trills in this variety: **qawr-* > *qaw-*. According to this diachronic scenario, the initial consonant of the negative verb in the Amur variety should not be aspirated. However, since this postvelar stop is almost always spirantized, it is perceived and pronounced by the speakers as aspirated: *q^haw-*.

Apart from the historical changes affecting its phonological shape, **qawr-* has acquired verbal morphological features and developed an opposition of the intransitive (*qavr-*) and transitive (*ɤavr-*) forms that are now present in the ES and WS varieties. The formation of negative transitive forms led to the creation of complex synthetic negative forms and gradual grammaticalization of the negative verb into a suffixal marker. This model was later extended to the imperative (hortative, jussive) sentences. The process of compounding has spread also to inherently negative verbs, many of which followed the same grammaticalization path. The negative habitual suffix, which comes back to the full lexical verb ‘not know’, can be seen as an example of a final stage of such a process.

Due to the longstanding contacts with the Tungusic languages, the situation in the Amur variety has been developing differently. Here, **qawr-* has functioned as an intransitive verb *q^haw-*, which, besides its independent function in stative predications, is used to head an analytic negative construction with a nominalized lexical verb. In this regard, it may be noted that the structure of this construction goes against the common tendency of placing negative markers before the elements they negate, cf. (Dryer 2013). This construction has undergone further changes in its phonological structure, which could potentially lead to the development of new synthetic forms – if the language had a chance to develop further.

4.6.2 Emphatic clitics

As has been shown in §4.4, there are several emphatic clitics that occur in the negative context, whose properties differ in different Nivkh varieties. Also, each of the clitics has been developing historically in an idiosyncratic way.

The clitic *=Cij* is attested primarily in the ES variety and can be used both with affirmative and negative predicates for general emphasis of a certain constituent and for deriving emphatic proforms, which are also used in negative predications. Lately, its use in the affirmative context has become extremely rare, which means that this emphatic clitic is following the so-called *Jespersen Cycle* (see e.g. van der Auwera 2009) and is on the way to be reanalyzed as a true negative marker. In this connection, let us recall the apprehensive forms, which are also built with the emphatic/evidential suffix.

The clitic WS =*ha-kisk/-gisk/-kirk*, A =*ha-gin/-girn* is derived from the nominalized form of the auxiliary verb *ha-* ‘be / do so’ with the instrumental suffix. In negative clauses, this clitic co-occurs with the clausal negator in the same way as ES =*Cin*. However, in the affirmative clauses, its function is different, as it is employed for deriving free-choice indefinites and providing the free-choice reading of other constituents to which it is attached. As a result, the clitic retains its affirmative status and is not embraced by the *Jespersen Cycle*.

The emphatic clitic =*Tə* comes back to the general focus clitic =*Ta*, making use of a process known as “*a*-raising” for emphasis. Also, the clitic can be attached to nominalized verbal complements, which has determined its fate as a suffixalized and desemanticized element within synthetic negative forms.

5 Conclusion

As may be concluded from the previous discussion, the Nivkh system of negation was originally formed on the basis of a fundamental opposition between declarative and imperative clauses. This opposition was apparently relevant even before the language diversified into the different dialectal varieties. Formally, the opposition was built upon two main elements: (i) the clause-final element **qawr-*, which marked negation in the declarative sentences, and (ii) the clause-initial element *t^ha*, which was used to mark negation in prohibitive sentences, and which remained intact through the history of the language. The existence of special negative marking in prohibitives conforms to a general typological tendency mentioned in (van der Auwera & Lejeune (with Valentin Goussev) 2013). Except for this distinction, negation of all types of clauses in Nivkh follows common rules and uses basically the same devices.

As we have seen, in the realm of negation, Nivkh also displays many other interesting historical processes, which involve the transition or expansion of clitics and forms from the positive sphere to the negative. Apprehensives have developed an inherently negative meaning on the basis of affirmative emphatic/evidential forms, and the same process is observed for emphatic clitics.

Among other features, one should mention the relatively large amount of negative lexicalizations and an elaborate system of proforms that co-occur with the negative predicates. Table 3 sums up the main negation strategies in the East Sakhalin and Amur varieties of Nivkh.

Table 3: Summary of negation strategies in Nivkh

Negation strategy	Function(s)	Section(s)
(-ŋ)- <i>cavr</i> - (ES)	standard negation	§2.1.1
	prohibitive (with imperative)	§2.2.1
	negative ascriptive	§2.3.5
<i>qavr</i> - (ES)	negative existential	§2.3.1
<i>j-iv(-ŋ)-cavr</i> - (ES)	negative possessive	§2.3.2
<i>ɤavr</i> - (ES)	negative possessive	§2.3.2
	negative locative	§2.3.3
<i>ɤavr-k</i> (ES)	negative equative	§2.3.4
<i>q^haw</i> - (A)	negative existential	§2.3.1
	negative possessive	§2.3.2
	negative locative	§2.3.3
<i>q^haw-k(=ra)</i> (ES/A)	negative reply	§3.1
<i>-Toχ q^haw</i> - (A)	standard negation	§2.1.2
	negative ascriptive	§2.3.5
<i>ha-To(χ) q^haw-ɤ=ra</i> (A)	negative equative	§2.3.4
<i>ha-To(χ) q^haw-k</i> (A)	negative equative	§2.3.4
<i>-Ksu</i> - (ES/A)	negative habitual	§2.1.3
<i>t^ha -IMP</i> (ES/A)	prohibitive	§2.2.1
<i>-inəŋra : -inəŋta</i> (ES) / <i>-nəra</i> (A)	apprehensive (visual)	§2.2.2
<i>-jaŋra : -jaŋra</i> (ES) / <i>-ijra</i> (A)	apprehensive (inferential)	§2.2.2
<i>ujye / ujyi</i> - (ES)	negative existential	§2.3.1
<i>avli</i> - (ES)	negative possessive	§2.3.2
<i>ləyə</i> - (A)	negative possessive	§2.3.2
<i>ləyə</i> (A)	caritive	§3.3
<i>-lakrɤ : -lakrt</i> (ES) / <i>-ləkrr : -ləkrt</i> (A)	negative purposive converb	§2.4
interrogative= <i>EMPH</i> (ES)	negative proforms	§3.2
interrogative= <i>ha-INSTR</i> (A)	negative proforms	§3.2
interrogative XP= <i>EMPH</i> (ES)	forms reinforcing negation	§4.4
interrogative XP= <i>ha-INSTR</i> (A)	forms reinforcing negation	§4.4
XP= <i>ha-INSTR</i> (A)	forms reinforcing negation	§4.4
XP= <i>Ci(ŋ)</i> (ES)	forms reinforcing negation	§4.4
XP= <i>Tə</i> (A)	forms reinforcing negation	§4.4

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Abbreviations

1	first person	FUT	future
2	second person	GNR	generic
3	third person	HAB	habitual
A	Amur (Lower/Liman) varieties	HUM	human
ABL	ablative	IMM	immediate
ACC	accusative	IMP	imperative
ADVS	adversative	INCL	inclusive
AGT	agentive	IND	indicative
APPR	apprehensive	INFR	inferential
ASRT	assertive	INS	instrumental
AUG	augmentative (verbal)	ITER	iterative
CAUS	causative	LOC	locative
CLF	classifier	NEG	negation
COMPL	completive	NARR	narrative
COORD	coordinating verb form	NMLZ	nominalization
CONC	concessive	NP	noun phrase
COND	conditional	NS	North Sakhalin variety
CS	Central Sakhalin variety	PL	plural
CVB	converb	PLAC	pluractional reduplication
DAT	dative	PROB	probabilitive
DES	desiderative	PROG	progressive
DEST	destinative	PURP	purposive
DIR	direct	Q	interrogative
DIR	direct	QUAL	qualitative
DIST	distal	RECP	reciprocal
DU	dual	REFL	reflexive
DUR	durative	REP	reportative
EMPH	emphatic	SBJV	subjunctive
EP	epenthesis	SG	singular
ES	East Sakhalin variety	SIM	simultaneous/anterior
ES ^N	Nyivo variant of the East Sakhalin variety	SS	South Sakhalin variety
ES ^T	Tymovsk variant of the East Sakhalin variety	TR	transitivizer
EVID	evidentiality	V	(lexical) verb
EXCL	exclusive	VIS	visual
FOC	focus	VOC	vocative
FM	field materials	WS	West Sakhalin variety
		XP	any syntactic phrase

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